Superzero

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra never cared much about Bright Moon's local superheroes until She-ra rescues her from an attack by the latest would-be supervillain the Horde spat out. She has been lonely ever since the fight that finally ended her and Adora's friendship, but she didn't expect She-ra to be too. For some reason, though, she keeps coming around.
Adora knows it's masochistic to try to befriend Catra the only way she's allowed to be close to her anymore, but when the stress of her secret identity already broke them apart, it might be the only thing that could bring them together again now.
(The Secret Superhero AU)

Chapter 1: Chance Encounter

Chapter Notes

> You can pick it up where relevant, but a brief rundown for clarity: Everybody *mostly* has their canon powers, though they all have the additional power of "transformation" which just takes them from their regular modern clothes to their canon appearances, plus a mask (with She-ra's dramatic transformation an exception). Codenames correspond to their runestones. Bright Moon and the Fright Zone are two boroughs in the same city separated by Bright Moon Bay.
> She-ra's mask reference!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's walk to work is interrupted by a calamitous noise in the distance followed by screams. Actually, to say she was interrupted implies it stops her, but all she does is sigh and tilt her head back, swiveling her ears around trying to pinpoint the direction of the noise.

"Hey! Can you tell where that is?" Catra looks across the street to see the only other person on the street, a human, has stopped and has his hands cupped around his mouth, calling in her direction. He's already relying on her superior hearing, so he should know that he doesn't have to do that, but she just rolls her eyes and jerks a thumb over her shoulder.

"Same way you're walking," she calls back, already continuing on her walk.

"Shit," he says, turning to look down the street with apprehension. See, no help required, he didn't even shout that one. Catra reaches the corner just as the walk light turns red. She pulls out her phone, passing the time by pulling up Twitter and checking the Fright Zone's local trending feed.

It's a Horde bot rampage in the closest thing they have to a fiscal center with Bright Moon and its bigwigs just across the bay. She doesn't really feel bad about that one and the bots aren't likely to make it all the way to her neighborhood. She's probably fine to go to work. There won't be many customers, so tips won't be good, but at least she'll get paid. She taps through the tweets and finds the local news promising they'll have a camera out in ten minutes.

By the time she reaches work, there's already video of the Alliance descending on the area. She-ra is leading the charge. Catra is pretty sure she's the one who cracked Shadow Weaver's mask over the summer and no one has seen a whisper of the sorceress's shadows since. This will be dealt with in no time.

Damn. She was kind of hoping for an excuse to go home. She shoves her phone in her pocket and waves to Linda as she slips into the tea shop and heads for the employees only area to get

her apron.

Just another day in the Fright Zone.

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Catra honestly kind of admires the Horde's tenacity. She knows they're supervillains and they destroy the city on a regular basis, but she's impressed that they even try when most of them don't have powers. The Alliance only has one regular human on its roster, and who knows, maybe that guy has secret healing powers or something that just aren't public knowledge because he isn't one of the princesses. The Horde, as far as she can tell, just has one sorceress and some kind of tech genius that makes all their lasers.

If they were smart they would just use *guns*, the lasers honestly don't seem that effective, but whatever, Catra's not here to give supervillains advice, even if the *super* part of it is a bit questionable. There's so few magic-users running around, though, that seeing some ostensibly normal people go up against them and survive kind of feels reassuring, especially since they never win so she doesn't have to feel bad about wanting to know their local superheroes aren't completely invincible.

Maybe she just has a big problem with authority. Sue her. The Alliance is the closest thing to officially sanctioned a vigilante can get, which basically makes them cops, so she isn't going to worship the ground they walk on even if there is a literal goddess – and a hot one at that – amongst their ranks. That would go against her principles. Their habit of showing up just a little too late when she needs them is unrelated.

She never thought she would find herself cowering under a library table – what do supervillains even *want* with a university is her question – while the occasional laser fires off overhead and she waits for an opportunity to run, but this is what she gets for agreeing to study group, she guesses. She wonders if Adora even checks the Fright Zone news anymore and if she's worried about Catra the same way Catra was about her when Bright Moon University became the subject of an attack.

Probably not. After all, she *forgot* to tell Catra she was alive then, why would she remember to even check on her now? Being bitter is a great way to pass the time as the library wall explodes. Catra feels disoriented from all the loud sounds and the dust settling over the whole scene isn't helping as it makes her eyes burn and her lungs clog, but she refuses to sneeze and draw attention to herself, no matter how much it feels like thorns in her nose-

She sneezes and, despite the tiny sound, immediately hears heavy boots whipping around, followed by the distinct sound of a laser priming. *Fuck*.

Catra bolts just in time for the table to explode behind her. She hisses, pain from her leg registering in the back of her mind but adrenaline running too strong to linger on it as she sprints on all fours. There are tables and shelves to duck behind, but the Force Captain of the

week is tracking her with their shoulder cannon. The second she stops, that thing is going to give her third degree burns, if it doesn't stop her heart outright.

Bullets would be more effective, but that doesn't mean the lasers don't *fucking suck*. Her only chance is to escape from the hole blasted in the wall. She can see lasers and magic shooting around outside, so there's a chance of getting lost in the action as long as someone else doesn't start targeting her out there. She runs for the closest wall, using it as leverage to leap and change direction just as the Force Captain fires off their laser.

Another sting on her tail. Yeah, that singed her at best. She doesn't have time to worry about *at worst*, head and heart pounding as she sprints straight at the Force Captain. They're wearing a helmet, so she can't see their expression, but they fumble with the cannon as they aim it at her again, so they're probably thrown off by the charge. Probably because it's a monumentally stupid thing to do and she can vaguely hear a librarian crying out in shock – everyone else was smart enough to stay hidden, so at least she only has one witness to this suicide play – but the Force Captain is standing between her and the hole they blasted into the building with.

Two more grunts step through the hole and the priming noise is back. Fuck. Catra makes a desperate dodge that is a bit too early, but the Force Captain is a bit too *shitty* to adjust their aim in time and she's able to sprint past another burn mark and leap around them, just barely ducking one of the grunts trying to hit her with a stun baton. She's lucky, then – they're planning to take hostages.

Leaping through the wall leaves her in the blinding sunlight, and between the time her twilight-adapted eyes need to adjust and the disorientation from all the noise and adrenaline, she doesn't notice the next grunt until it's too late. A baton gets her in the shoulder and she cries out, seizing mid-run and rolling several feet across the sidewalk until she hits the lawn, every part of her body either numb or screaming.

"*No*!" a multi-layered voice shouts, a chorus protesting as one. Oh, it's not good when one of the princesses sounds anguished. Catra whimpers, trying to move, but the best her body will do is some pathetic twitching. She manages to open her eyes, but all she has a view of is grass and Horde boots walking towards her. Now she's made herself a problem hostage, the Force Captain with the twitchy trigger finger is probably going to put her down. Hopefully it's just for a burn-assisted nap and not permanent. Then again, the laser did explode a table.

She wouldn't say her life flashes before her eyes as the boots approach her, but suddenly she wishes Adora was in her life again and someone was petting her ears, which really shows how much fear has managed to leak into the adrenaline rush. Just before the grunt reaches her, there's a cry and they disappear. She just blinks and they're gone. She stares at nothing, trying to regain control of her body, but it's still twitching unreliably. Maybe the teleporter is here? She probably wouldn't be able to hear Moonstone popping in and out over all the screaming.

Suddenly hands are on her and Catra is being thrown over a shoulder in a firemen's carry. A muscled back greets her, decorated in white and gold. Catra breathes a sigh of relief as She-ra *jumps*. All that relaxation immediately disappears as she watches the ground grow small beneath them. It's replaced by concrete as a jolt of impact runs through She-ra and jostles

Catra on her shoulder, but She-ra must absorb the force somehow because it really isn't bad. That would explain how she jumps buildings on a regular basis.

She-ra puts her down and Catra finds herself on her back, blinking up at a gold mask with sparking blue pouring out of where eyeholes should be.

"I'll be back for you, just recover," the goddess says to her, the voice of every past She-ra stretching back to the dawn of history layered beneath her own. Somehow, the chorus has enough voices in it to sound familiar, but Catra is still reeling from being fucking tazed, so she just manages a twitch that she thinks comes across as a jerky nod and She-ra seems to accept it, placing what is probably supposed to be an assuring hand on her cheek for a second before standing. Her jaw sets in stone and she turns, leaping right off the roof.

Well. Fuck.

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Catra likes to think she's good under pressure, but she's probably going to be processing today for the next week. Her entire body hurts as she shakes off the last of the involuntary twitches, though her ankle and tail are definitely the *loudest* about it. She can see blood dripping down her ankle, probably from shrapnel when the table exploded, but it's not much, so she's putting off worrying about that until she knows the danger is over. She's slowly regaining her orientation, but sirens have replaced the sounds of lasers and destruction now, which isn't helping her head. She cautiously crawls to the edge of the roof, gravel digging into her knees and palms as she peeks over the lip.

It doesn't look like anyone is fighting anymore, but it's kind of hard to tell with emergency services and the odd princess swarming the quad, plus all the vines sprouted out of the ground restraining Horde members. It has to be close enough because Catra has run out of adrenaline. She goes limp, one arm draped over the edge of the building and her cheek resting on the hot concrete of the roof edge. Her tail files a few more complaints as she slumps awkwardly. She needs to pass out for two days at this point and maybe when she wakes up the pain will be gone and she will have processed the jumble of emotions that passed through her when the stun baton took her down.

She has her eyes closed, just trying to focus on the fact that she's *alive*, when she hears sparkling and wind. Catra opens her eyes to see something sailing over her head. She jerks up, twitching around to watch She-ra hit the roof in a roll, popping up on her feet in a controlled slide a few feet from Catra. Despite the regular attempts by the Horde to bring Bright Moon to its knees or whatever they want, this is the first time Catra has been in the line of fire before, and thus her first time in the presence of one of the princesses of old.

There's an aura that radiates from She-ra and makes Catra's fur fluff up. She-ra is glowing as she turns around and spots Catra, the confidence with which she landed immediately replaced with anxiety. Catra is a little speechless as She-ra hurries over to her, reaching down and

picking her up without so much as *hello*. Catra yelps, trying to scramble for purchase, but that fucking *hurts*, so she stops fighting She-ra as she turns them away from the edge and sets Catra back down on her feet with her body between her and the drop. Catra's ankle immediately buckles and she groans in pain, grabbing at She-ra to stay upright.

"What the fuck?" she demands, annoyance unaffected by how there was no way She-ra could have known about her ankle. Everything hurts and snapping at someone feels good. She-ra seems to decide that she can't be trusted and just lifts her up in a princess carry. Catra's stomach flips as she blinks up at the golden hero, her ears twitching. Warm magic radiates from her arms and surrounds her. She isn't sure if it's soothing or unnerving.

"What are you doing so close to the edge *injured*? I told you to wait!" She-ra reprimands. It's weird hearing anxiety in a dozen voices at once and even weirder that this stranger who deals with peril every day cares, but Catra can easily ignore whatever her stomach is doing right now and scowl up at the goddess. She should have known She-ra would be one of those types who thinks she knows best.

"I was trying to see if the coast was clear yet and make sure I didn't get forgotten and *stranded* up here," she shoots back, crossing her arms and glaring. It's probably not good to snipe at the person who saved you and that you still need, but Catra has never been known for her restraint. She shouldn't have moved to cross her arms, though; she feels like she just ran a marathon and then got hit by a Vespa.

"I never would have forgotten you," She-ra's voice is soft, oddly sincere, and has Catra blinking at her, but She-ra doesn't give her time to examine it. "Where are you hurt?" Catra immediately bristles again. Yeah, like she's going to admit that. She glares to demonstrate how totally not in pain she is.

"I'm fine, being tazed just sucks. If you get me to the ground, I can walk," Catra grits back, daring She-ra to question her. She-ra's mouth presses into a line, but that's about all the reaction Catra gets with most of her face obscured by smooth gold. She doesn't even have visible eyes beneath her mask, just beaming blue light. At least they aren't sparking anymore as she turns her head and seemingly glances down the length of Catra's body.

"You're hurt," She-ra insists. Catra opens her mouth. "You're *bleeding* and you can't stand on your own, cut the shit," She-ra challenges. Catra snaps her mouth shut. She wasn't expecting profanity from the stupid Power Princess or whatever it is. It's kind of hot. She-ra looks away from her, glancing down over the edge.

"The ambulance is here. Hang on tight. You can use your claws," She-ra says, already shifting into a ready stance. Catra scrambles, latching on even as she hisses a reprimand.

"No! I don't need it and I don't have health insurance anyway. You'll be hurting more than you're helping," Catra cuts her off, glancing down to the lawn where EMS personnel swarm. Normally she wouldn't blurt out that much, but she really doesn't want go to the ambulance and it's the first thing her mind tells her might work. She looks back to She-ra to find her jaw clenched.

“I live close by and I have a first-aid kit. I can limp there and take care of it. I’ll be *fine*. I’ve had worse,” Catra tries, apparently fucking negotiating with a superhero to walk away on her own. She-ra’s grip on her was strong to start with, but now it flexes, holding Catra tightly for several long seconds before She-ra releases a breath and relaxes – some.

“Okay, fine. I’ll take you home so you can take care of it. Where do you live?” she asks, and Catra’s pretty sure she’s making eye contact even if she can’t see shit. There’s just this *intense* feeling as blue bores into her.

Today is fucking *insane*. She-re wants to, what, carry her home like a fucking damsel?

“Yeah, uh, *no*. Stranger danger or whatever. I’m not showing you where I live,” Catra says. She isn’t actually sure how the hell she’s going to make the walk, but she’s hoping to limp around the corner and then sit on the sidewalk and recover before going to the rest of the way.

“I’m a superhero. I literally save the people who don’t follow stranger danger,” She-ra doesn’t sound impressed.

“Then you know how important it is. Lead by example. Put me down now, thanks.” Catra pointedly wiggles in her arms, which turns She-ra’s biceps into rocks as she suddenly flexes and traps her there. Catra flushes and glances away, immediately greeted with how large the drop from the roof is. Okay, maybe holding onto her is warranted.

“You’re impossible,” She-ra concludes, just like all the people who meet Catra eventually do. She got there fast, though. Catra’s kind of proud of herself.

“You can let me take you home or you can sit through an ambulance inspection. Your choice,” She-ra finally proposes in a tone that leaves no room for negotiation. Catra has a few suggestions for how she’d rather She-ra *take her home*, but no matter how many dirty thoughts biceps like hers can fuel, Catra has learned her lesson about pining for the unattainable. What she is allowed to want couldn’t get any fucking clearer than Adora never showing up for what was supposed to be their first actual date. Catra scoffs, but the arms flexing around her aren’t exactly easy to argue with, nor is the pain radiating through her.

“Fine,” she grits out. She-ra brightens like a puppy hearing the word *walk*, immediately smiling.

“Great! Which direction is it?” she asks. Catra, trying very hard to not let that affect her, reluctantly points towards the river, ignoring Bright Moon proper looming in the distance.

“I need to grab my backpack from the library first, it has my keys-” She-ra doesn’t wait for her to finish, immediately crouching and leaping down to the lawn below. Catra screams as the air rushes around them, digging her claws into She-ra.

Oh, she should have just taken the ridiculous hospital bill.

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She-ra sets her on the lawn while she goes searching for her backpack inside the library, giving Catra an opportunity to prod at her ankle and then bite her tongue to keep from crying out, but She-ra doesn't take long to grab it. Catra is sure they look a sight, this golden, radiant giant with a beat-up backpack on her shoulder and an even more battered magicat in her arms, but She-ra does her the decency of jumping a row of buildings to shorten the journey. It scares the *shit* out of Catra, but hey, it convinces her to just be grateful it's over by the time they arrive and She-ra carries her into her apartment.

"Any roommates?" She-ra asks as she carefully sets Catra down on her couch in what passes for a living room in her small studio. The question is kind of ridiculous unless She-ra somehow thinks the closet is a door into a secret bedroom or they're sharing the bed tucked in the corner.

"Nope. If you want to murder me, now's your chance," Catra grunts, sinking back into the couch and grimacing when her tail starts to curl and her burn decides to remind her of its presence. She swears she sees a smile pull at the corner of She-ra's mouth, but she doesn't rise to the bait.

"First-aid kit?" she asks, glancing around the room. Catra rolls her eyes, reaching for her tail so she can straighten it between her hands and inspect it. She doesn't know why She-ra is going to this much trouble – or in her *living room*.

"On top of the cabinets, by the fridge. Just bring it over," she instructs, squinting at her oozing burn and feeling her stomach turn. She mostly wants to be alone to curl up and whimper until everything stops hurting, but She-ra is offering some help, so she will reluctantly deal with the wound before giving in to her mature instinct to ball up and hide.

She-ra disappears from her line of sight to fetch it and returns a moment later. She sets the first-aid kit on the couch and then drops to a knee beside her. Catra stares at her, glancing between She-ra and her tail. The last half hour feels like a fever dream. The realization is dawning on her that the burned fur on her tail might not regrow, her ankle is really fucked up, and there's a goddess in her shitty living room to top it all off, unpacking medical supplies.

"Not that I don't appreciate the assist or whatever, but you can go," Catra says when she notices She-ra opening a wipe and cleaning off her hands. She doesn't know how to handle this kind of interaction at all. It's easier if She-ra just leaves her to suffer.

She-re looks up at her and seems to hold her eyes, but whatever look she is trying to give her is lost beneath the mask.

"I have more medical training and you shouldn't have to," she responds, her tone unimpressed. She returns to the kit. Catra glares at her, the base of her tail twitching as it tries to lash with half of it trapped in her hands.

"You don't know that. I could be a nurse," Catra shoots back. She isn't, but that won't stop her from pretending until She-ra calls her on it. She-ra pauses for just a moment before she

opens the disinfectant and carefully applies it. Catra hisses, but the sting isn't any worse than the burn, it's just a *different* kind of pain.

"You're a college student. Even if you're pre-med, I know I have more training in field care," She-ra returns, her voice even. Catra scowls. Sure, she's right, but that doesn't mean Catra wants to admit it. She gets distracted by a jolt of pain as She-ra wipes off her tail, growling loudly like that will make a difference.

"Shh, it's okay. I'm almost done with this part," She-ra murmurs, her voice surprisingly soft as she reaches for a bandage. Catra feels her face flush. Oh, no. She is *not* finding out she has a thing for being comforted like this. She's supposed to be tough and shit. It's just that it's She-ra, that has to be it. Who wouldn't swoon when they have, like, the hottest woman ever gently wrapping a bandage around them.

Okay, fine, She-ra can patch her up, but only because Catra doesn't trust herself not to say something embarrassing if she tries to speak right now. She settles for looking grumpy and flicking the tip of her tail where she isn't holding it. Unfortunately, She-ra just seems amused by that.

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Splinters of shrapnel are embedded in Catra's inner ankle, where the burst from the table caught her. She loses all composure as She-ra picks them out, closing her eyes and whimpering through it. Removing them doesn't hurt any more than leaving them, it just freaks her out. She-ra is stupidly attentive, assuring her quietly and telling her when she finishes with the tweezers because Catra isn't opening her eyes to see it. Something big must have hit her because a bruise is already forming beside the knob of her ankle. Even just ruffling her fur to clean it makes the hair follicles hurt. She-ra wraps it carefully and gives her care instructions for both wounds, but Catra is at the end of her rope and laughs bitterly when She-ra tells her to stay off of it until the pain stops.

"Yeah, sure, I'll try," she says, her tone dark. She-ra doesn't deserve it, probably, but Catra wants her to push just so she has an excuse to snap back. The pain has only mildly improved and she wants to lash out. She-ra is hard to read between her obscured face and obscured *voice*, but she looks kind of upset. Probably annoyed. That makes more sense.

"I'm not convinced there isn't something bad going on to make it bruise so fast. You need to stay off of it and see a doctor if it gets any worse," She-ra returns, voice low and serious. The very idea of something being that messed up makes Catra's stomach churn – just because it would be expensive, not because she's scared of doctors, of course – so she relents just to steer the conversation away. She-ra has already proven she won't let things go. Maybe if Catra agrees she'll finally fucking *leave*.

"I'll get a crutch or something," she acquiesces, glaring at She-ra to make it clear she isn't pushing her any further. She-ra's hand, which is just resting on Catra's uninjured calf for

some reason now that she's done, squeezes her for several long moments as they glare at each other.

Okay, maybe She-ra isn't glaring back, because after an extended stare-down she releases a sigh and hangs her head.

"Fine. Just, please, look after it. Do you need me to bring you anything?" she asks, looking back up at Catra. Catra feels *weird*, mostly because She-ra sounds sad and she can't figure that out, but she decides to write it off as some strange side effect of the *multiple voices* thing because she doesn't want to deal with it. She wants to curl up and *sleep*.

"No. I'm probably going to watch TV while I wait to find out if my study group survived. You can go," she says, pointedly gesturing to the remote just a few inches away. She-ra looks at it, and then back to her.

"There were no casualties," she finally says, an edge of exasperation in her voice.

"Damn, that means I'm going to have to go to class on Monday," Catra returns, pointedly looking towards the door now instead. She-ra chuckles, but she finally takes the hint and stands. Catra immediately changes her mind about *everything* once She-ra is towering over her. She has a view up from the plane of her abs to the swell of her chest and suddenly she is feeling the last ten months alone. Not that her and Adora even *kissed*, but she has had no object to latch her desires onto for months.

She was too heartbroken to pursue someone new, so apparently fate decided to hand deliver her next six months of fantasies to her in exchange for a limp. She swears She-ra was created to be a lesbian's wet dream. She's all muscle, glowing and seven feet tall, and her skintight outfit shows off her strong thighs and curves. Catra isn't really a hair person, but she would *love* to use that ponytail like a handle as her thighs frame She-ra's ears. Her mask helpfully stops just past her cheekbones, leaving her mouth free.

Maybe She-ra picks up on her lustful staring, because she lingers for a long moment. Catra comes to her senses and darts her gaze away, focusing on her closet door instead. The irony almost makes her look away again, but that would make her more obvious. She forces her ears not to twitch and give away her embarrassment. She-ra's shoulders fall a little – relaxing, not disappointment, *obviously* – and she bends to close the first-aid kit, moving it over to the coffee table.

"Change the bandage once a day and be careful," she reminds. When Catra only nods and doesn't otherwise acknowledge her, she gets the message and crosses over to the door. Now no longer being watched, Catra looks back to She-ra.

The half-skirt thing just isn't fair. Catra should get to see her ass as a consolation prize for her leaving. She-ra opens the door and pauses.

"Your friends will want you healthy. Give it time to heal," she adds, her voice soft, and then she closes the door behind her. Catra's ears pin back and she hisses into her empty living room when her tail starts flicking and makes the burn sting.

She flops back against the couch, staring at the ceiling and trying to process the last half hour. It's harder to reconcile She-ra taking her home than the hostage thing, honestly. Adora would be so fucking jealous if she knew. She always admired the Alliance.

At least Catra has something other than Adora to dream about tonight. It was getting fucking old.

Chapter End Notes

Lasers are like, an objectively terrible weapon IRL, so I'm kind of going halfsies on it for this AU. It also lets there be supervillains without staggering body counts, though shit like destroying a building (even partially), which undoubtedly has some people inside, means there's blood on the Horde's hands even without lasers being an insta-vaporize.
Despite this first chapter and the premise, this isn't really going to be an action-focused fic. POV is mostly Catra, but also whatever the story needs, whenever.

Chapter 2: Mask

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It took Adora a while to learn to read her friend's expressions through their masks, but the look Glimmer gives her when she calls for a pickup outside Catra's apartment block could strip paint. She thankfully saves the lecture until after she has brought them back to the Alliance sanctum. Adora took long enough taking care of Catra that the rest of the team is there already, only Bow still in uniform, but he's also the only one who has to physically put on and take off his. Everybody else has dropped their disguises.

Adora almost considers staying as She-ra for the plausible deniability of the mask, but when Glimmer turns to her and drops her own transformation, her uniform fading into pink sparkles to reveal the purple dress she was wearing earlier, Adora reluctantly drops her own. At least she's wearing her Harbor Community College hoodie so she can stuff her hands in the pocket and slouch beneath Glimmer's gaze.

"That was Catra," Glimmer says, because yeah, she definitely saw who Adora was helping even if Adora only said it was a "civilian" when she used her comm in the library to warn them that she was splitting off. Glimmer only met Catra a handful of times and Catra looked pretty different with all her hair cut off and business wear on, but magicats with heterochromia aren't exactly *common* and Adora left her on the lawn in full view when she went for her backpack.

"She goes to Harbor University," Adora reasons, sending a desperate glance towards Bow, but he's out of earshot as he slips from the main chamber to go change. The rest of their team is either distracted or listening but not going to be helpful. Maybe Perfuma, actually, she looks vaguely concerned.

"What were you doing? I know you miss her, but you can't let her figure out who you are," Glimmer asks. Adora shrinks as more of the team clues in to the conversation. This is worse than the lecture she thought she was getting, actually.

"I know. Her leg was hurt and she's scared of doctors, okay? She told me – *She-ra* – that she doesn't have health insurance, so I offered to carry her home and treat her with a first-aid kit. That's it. At most she was annoyed with me for daring to exist near her when she was hurt. She didn't figure anything out," Adora assures. It wasn't even an excuse to get Catra's new address. She definitely noted it, but she knows Catra would have tried to stubbornly limp off on her own if she hadn't intervened and her ankle couldn't have taken that. She's really grateful that she relented and let Adora treat it.

Glimmer eyes her, but she looks a lot less suspicious now.

"I heard you when she got hit," Perfuma adds, her voice kind, as she steps in behind Glimmer. Adora would be grateful for the change of direction if she didn't hate the new direction. She maturely flips her hood up to hide under it.

“She’s okay now,” she murmurs, mostly to herself, gaze fixed on her sneakers. Her heart *stopped* when she saw Catra get hit. She knew it was her the moment she saw a magicat running through the chaos on all fours, even with the differences in her appearance. She hated just leaving her on the roof while they finished the fight. At least she got to punch the Force Captain targeting her. She isn’t sure which grunt it was that tazed her, he just faded in with all the other identical uniforms, but she blasted him with the sword runestone to get him away from her, so he felt She-ra’s wrath too.

“It’s okay if it still affected you,” Perfuma replies. Adora glances up, trying to throw Perfuma a smile she hopes comes across as appreciative. She mostly wants this conversation to be over. She needs to lie facedown on her bed and resist the urge to call Catra. She brought her home. She treated her ankle herself. She *knows* she’s okay. It would be suspicious to randomly call right now-

Actually…

“I’ve got class,” Adora mutters, glancing back over her shoulder to see Bow walking back in wearing what passes as regular clothes for him, his brow furrowed as he takes in the scene.

“Not for another hour. Come on, Perfuma has a point. I know you need to talk about it,” Glimmer says. Perfuma brightens, giving Glimmer a gracious nod that Adora is certain she hasn’t earned. Their goals for this conversation might line up, but she knows their *intentions* don’t. Adora sighs, reaching a hand up to push her hair out of her face. For some reason, she has difficulty maintaining her ponytails when she drops out of the transformation.

“What do you want me to say? That the first time I saw her in ten months could have been to watch her fucking *die*? That I can’t even be there to take care of her now because all this-” she gestures violently around her at the stone sanctum, ceiling vaulted like a chapel and reflecting her voice back at her as it rises in volume and hysteria, “-got in the way and convinced her that I don’t love her? That I want to go so I can cry until class starts? That I can’t even call her now because that will make her ‘*suspicious*’ and keeping She-ra’s new identity secret is more important than anything I w-”

She cuts herself off, turning away and ducking her head to disappear beneath her hood. What she wants doesn’t matter. There’s only one She-ra. She has to fulfill her duties. There’s no one else who can. This outburst has been building for ten long months, but she has to push her emotions aside.

Moments like this make her wish she never even applied to the masters program at BMU. She would still be back in the Fright Zone if she hadn’t, far from any of the magic destiny stuff that overtook her life since crossing the bay to Bright Moon. She and Catra would be sharing an apartment, both of them settled into mid-level careers, and Adora would have no idea she’s a fucking goddess. They would be happy.

She loves being She-ra and getting to help people, and most days she is happy, but she misses Catra with all her heart. The only thing keeping her steady right now is the thought of what would have happened if She-ra *hadn’t* been there. She would rather Catra was alive and not in her arms than going through whatever that grunt would have done to her if he had grabbed her. Every person she saves is a Catra to *someone*. She can’t just abandon the city.

“Take me home,” she finally mutters into the shocked silence. She could walk it, but it’s kind of a long trip from the secret sanctum under the university to the dorm she’s sharing with Glimmer. She’s not sure she could keep from crying long enough to make it.

“Adora…” Bow and Perfuma both take pity on her, but Adora hunches her shoulders and ignores them, turning to make eye contact with Glimmer. She looks concerned, but she’s less inclined to “healthily processing emotions” than Bow and Perfuma are. She might break, especially if she feels guilty for triggering the outburst. Adora is just lucky Netossa and Spinnerella were at work. Neither of them would let her walk away from something like this.

Glimmer glances to Bow and then she steps forward, offering Adora her hand. Adora lets out a shaking breath and takes it, relieved as the world dissolves in pink sparkles and they rematerialize in the dark dorm, blinds perpetually drawn to avoid anyone seeing them pop into existence through the window. Adora drops Glimmer’s hand, turning on the light for an excuse to look away.

“I want to be alone,” she murmurs as she flicks it on and then remains staring at the wall. In the corner of her eye, she can see Glimmer’s reflection in the mirror on the back of the door. Glimmer is hovering, but there’s a resigned sadness there that Bow or Perfuma never would have given her. They all know how Adora has struggled during her last year and a half as She-ra, but Glimmer is the one who has had a front row seat to it as her roommate. She knows there’s no helping it, not if something doesn’t change, and nothing *can*.

Not for the better, at least.

“Are you sure?” Glimmer asks, her voice soft as she crosses over to Adora and puts a hand on her shoulder. Adora closes her eyes and takes a deep breath, taking a second to appreciate the warmth of the touch and remind herself that her friend’s care about her, even when she’s being difficult. As long as she puts back on She-ra’s mask at the end of the day, she can have her occasional fit to cope.

“Yeah. I just need to process it,” she replies, voice low and rough. Glimmer’s hand leaves her.

“Okay. I’ll come check before class starts to make sure you don’t miss it,” Glimmer tells her, taking a step back. She disappears in a shower of sparkles.

Adora takes a deep breath that doesn’t immediately turn into a sob when she releases it, so she’s doing great, really. Gold star. She toes off her shoes and crosses to her bed, flopping down on it and burying her face into the pillow.

She just wants to *hold* Catra, but Catra doesn’t even want to talk to her after all the times she bailed on her with a shit excuse to deal with whatever disaster was threatening Bright Moon or the FZ that afternoon. Catra could never accept being Adora’s last priority, and she swears she *wasn’t*, but she knows that’s how it felt when they went weeks without seeing each other and barely talked between the demands of Adora’s accelerated masters program and the Alliance.

Catra was always the one reaching out and being met with rejection or *nothing* and now Adora has been swallowing her own bitter medicine for months as Catra ignores her calls and

texts. Adora is pretty sure Catra has her entirely muted at this point. Calling probably wouldn't even do anything.

She's going to do it, though. She lied to the group. After a few minutes of steadying her breathing, she pulls out her phone and checks social media. Yep, posts about the attack. That's all she needs to justify this.

--

Catra's phone buzzes incessantly in her backpack, but she ignores it, remaining stretched out on the couch with her foot propped up. It's probably some emergency alert from the university system or something. If it's Linda calling to ask her to work another shift, she can fuck off. Catra isn't moving for the next forty-eight hours. If class isn't canceled tomorrow, she's sure her professor will accept the fact she was fucking *held hostage* a few hours ago and can't walk.

Her ankle actually hurts a lot. She told She-ra she would get a crutch mostly to satisfy her, but she probably does need one if she doesn't want to spend the next two weeks in cabs. She doesn't have that kind of money. Reluctantly, she twists around and reaches for her backpack, digging around for her phone as every inch of her body screams in time with the sirens on the TV, playing footage from the scene of the attack.

Any thoughts of texting Scorpia for help leave her head when she sees who's calling. Static fills her ears as she glances between the caller ID and the news report. Adora is probably watching the same one right now.

Well, she still checks the news. Catra swallows as she declines the call. She has let all of Adora's other calls ring and ignored the voicemails, but this is the compromise she gives her: an early hang-up so she knows she saw and rejected it. She's still alive, but she's not fucking talking to her.

It's more courtesy than Adora showed her.

--

Adora closes her eyes and feels a tear run from the corner of her eye into her hair when the call cuts to voicemail mid-ring. She tries to control her breathing as she waits for the opportunity to leave her message, tilting her head back on the pillow as if stretching out her neck will make her throat feel less tight.

Beep.

“Hey, Catra,” her voice is shaky. She swallows, trying to project more strength into it when she starts again, “I saw the news. I was calling to make sure you were okay. Not that I don’t want to call when you *aren’t* in danger, I just… thought this might be the one time you pick up.” That’s a bad idea. That sounds like Catra owes her the call when the hammer that prepped the final nail for their coffin was Adora never checking in after BMU was attacked last spring. She was busy fending it off as She-ra and then helping clear the destruction afterwards, but she couldn’t tell Catra that when she was furious over Adora ignoring her and letting her worry.

She had to admit everything Catra meant to her just to assure her that she cared. She had always been scared to do it, afraid of rejection or ruining what they had, but she didn’t know how assure Catra that she cared at that point without letting it slip. Everything was slipping through her fingers anyway. She was going to lose Catra if she didn’t do something, but Catra took her implications well. It seemed like everything was going to be okay between them.

The nail was delivered when another emergency made her miss their make-up date.

“What I mean is, I hope you’re okay, and if you need anything – *anything* – just call me. I want to hear from you, even if it’s just to complain about what losers the Horde are for interrupting class. Or who knows, maybe that makes them cool in your casebook.” The joke is weak and her throat works soundlessly as she tries to come up with anything else to say. For several seconds, the silence stretches on.

“I’m sorry. I miss you. I keep thinking about what you’re going to do after graduation. I hope you’re excited for it,” she admits, and then she hits *end call*. For a moment, everything is silent, and then the tears hit her along with images of Catra’s body sprawling lifeless across the lawn.

Catra’s fine. Stop it, *she’s fine*.

But Adora isn’t.

--

Eventually, Catra always listens to the voicemails. Occasionally she manages to delete them in a fit of rage, but that was mostly at the very beginning. For the first few weeks, Adora tried to beg for her back. She only showed up at the apartment once, and when that blew up catastrophically in her face, she switched to calls. Right around the time Catra’s desperation for acknowledgement grew stronger than her anger, Adora backed off and switched to just the occasional text. She still sends them every few weeks, usually wishing her well and telling her she misses her, but occasionally she’ll bust out a voicemail again.

The last one was during Winterfest. Catra read the auto-generated transcript instead of listening to it because she knew that she was at risk of breaking and calling back if Adora still sounded as broken up on it as she did back in the first few. Given the time of year, it seemed

likely. Catra *still* almost broke and called back, but even she doesn't hate herself that much. Being meaningless to Adora hurt more than missing her does. At least, she's pretty sure it did.

It's been a long time since she felt anything but loneliness.

She listens to the voicemail. Her suspicions were correct. Adora sounds upset but like she's trying to hold it together. She scowls when Adora mentions her picking up. Fat fucking chance. Maybe Adora finally realizes what she put Catra through almost a year ago now, and that was only a fraction of their problems.

If Catra didn't know better, she would have thought Adora was cheating on her with the way she suddenly started dodging her, but she knows that, despite everything, Adora could never do that to someone, and besides, they weren't actually *together*. Adora only implied finally starting a relationship as a last-ditch effort to get Catra to stick around, but she couldn't even stomach showing up for the date.

She deletes the voicemail when Adora starts lying that she misses her. She drops the phone on her stomach, glaring up at the ceiling and trying to swallow down the turmoil in her throat.

Adora doesn't care about her. She needs to remember that. If Catra called her back right now, she probably wouldn't even show. If she did, it would be her one gesture to try to get Catra back in her life so she can feel good about fixing the bridge she burned. Nothing would change.

Catra digs the heels of her palms into her eyes, gritting her teeth. She *knows all of this*, so why does she wish Adora was here right now for her to curl into, gentle hands petting her ears and as she promises everything is going to be okay?

--

Adora gets it – relatively – back together and goes about her life, but in her down time she can't stop thinking about the whimpers Catra made as she bandaged her ankle. Catra never lets herself be vulnerable like that in front of strangers. Adora is pretty confident she is the only person who has ever seen Catra like that, and yeah, she still is, but *Catra* doesn't know that.

She preps her story – for her friends and for Catra – and takes the train across the harbor. She grew up in the Fright Zone and she knows it like the back of her hand, even if she's never been to the neighborhood where Catra now lives before. It isn't hard to find, nor is a corner to duck into and quietly transform. There's not much she can do about the flash of light, but when she checks if the coast is clear, it doesn't seem to have drawn anybody over.

Catra's building isn't nice enough to have a working lock on the lobby or a receptionist. Adora mercifully doesn't run into anybody as she makes her way up to apartment 306. She knocks and holds her breath, resisting the urge to bounce on her feet. She does that a lot. Catra might recognize it – if she's even home. Adora has no way to know, really, but she's probably going to hang out in the area for as long as she can get away with it and keep checking if Catra doesn't answer.

She does, though. The lock scrapes and Adora finds herself blinking down at a Catra clearly in the middle of processing. She looks a lot more like the version of her best friend Adora used to know than she did during the attack. Her hair is still short, obviously, but it's scruffy with a kind of wild abandon that fits her rather than slicked back and mussed by destruction. The slacks and button-down from before are gone. She's wearing a loose black t-shirt and ripped leggings, much more in-line with her personal style.

Unfortunately, her ankle and tail are still wrapped and she is leaning on a crutch. At least she got one. Adora was pretty sure she was lying to get her to leave, before.

"What are you doing here?" Catra says, bluntly, but she mostly sounds confused. She squints at her, and sure, her gaze is suspicious, but Catra is just like that. Adora is really grateful for the mask obscuring her facial expressions. There's some kind of subtle glamor – as Glimmer puts it – that makes it harder for people to recognize them even without things like their masks and the voices of previous princesses layered beneath theirs, but the mask also helps to keep her reactions from being too obvious.

Confidence, Adora. Being She-ra usually gives it to her, and she needs to project it if she's going to sell this.

"I wanted to check on you," she explains, pointedly looking down towards her ankle. Catra shifts her weight on her crutch, her gaze darting away to glance down the hall.

"Well, I'm alive. And definitely weirded out that you wrote down my address," she points out, gesturing at herself to prove the point and then focusing a suspicious gaze on her again. Adora rolls her eyes. It's stupid how endearing some simple petulance is after this long.

"I had to note it so Moonstone could come pick me up. I just wanted to come back and check your ankle to make sure everything looks like it's healing on time," she clarifies. Catra narrows her eyes at her for a long moment, but Adora holds her gaze back even though she knows it doesn't really matter. Shockingly, Catra breaks first.

"Fine. Come in before someone sees you," she grits out, glancing down the hall again before she maneuvers away from the door to give Adora room to come in. Adora hurries inside and closes the door behind her before Catra can change her mind. Catra side-eyes her as she makes her way over to her kitchen, a small space tucked to the left of the front door. It seems like Catra has decided to keep the first-aid kit on the counter for now instead of trying to climb up to put it back.

"I've been changing it once a day after washing and drying it like you said. I can follow simple instructions," Catra says, her tone dry as she stops in front of the kit and turns to eye

Adora. Adora follows her, glancing at the wrap on her tail and foot, both new and clearly storebought.

“It’s not that. You said you don’t have health insurance. I just want to make sure it isn’t getting inflamed or showing signs of something like an underlying fracture. I know it’s easy to ignore something until it gets really bad when it will cost you a lot of money to be told that it’s actually healing as normal,” Adora explains. She doesn’t actually know if Catra was lying to She-ra before, but it’s as good of an excuse to come see her as any. She has been worrying about Catra constantly for the last few days.

Catra pauses, her tail swinging in slow, considering arcs as she looks at She-ra, appraising. After a moment, she lets out a long-suffering sigh that hasn’t been earned and steps over to the empty space on the counter beside the kit, hopping up and setting her crutch down so it is leaning next to her.

“Fine. I didn’t know She-ra made house calls. You do this for everybody you pull out of laser tag?” Catra asks, tone sarcastic and gaze wary as Adora steps closer and reaches for her tail. Adora elects not to answer that question, but she can’t help the smile tugging at her lips as she works on slipping off the tail sock Catra has covered her burn with.

“Just want to make sure you’re taken care of,” she settles on.

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Catra wasn’t expecting She-ra to reappear and she feels like she’s lagging two steps behind as a result. If she were on top of things, she might have slammed the door in her face for being a creep who remembered where she lived, but somehow she’s now sitting on her counter and letting She-ra approach. She has no idea why She-ra cares, especially since she *dodged the question*, but somehow she has walked right into one of Catra’s glaring weak points.

She thinks if a stranger – even a fucking superhero – tried to approach her like this a year ago, she would have spit teeth at them until they left her alone. She’s damaged, but she’s not as fragile and angry as Adora left her then. Over time she has just become numb and lonely. If a room is only warm when She-ra is in it because of the magic dancing across her skin, what does it matter? Catra would kind of like someone to fucking care about her, so she’ll take those words from She-ra no matter how meaningless they really are as she gently unwraps her tail sock. Catra definitely doesn’t want to go to a doctor. If nothing else, it will be nice to get the assurance something horrible isn’t happening with her ankle.

It’s really sad when even she can tell she’s justifying things to herself, but she’s just tired. She fought with Scorpia yesterday when she insisted on bringing soup over as if that would help her injuries. She has exactly two friendships left in her life and one of them is driving her up the wall. She’ll take a few moments of kindness. From a superhero, she actually believes that she wants to help, regardless of what her underlying motivations for being altruistic are. She

assumes superheroes are mostly boring moral stuck-ups or overgrown jocks who happened to get powers and like showing them off.

She-ra is unreadable as she washes her hands and inspects the burn, but she doesn't visibly wince, so it's probably fine. No matter how perfectly it heals Catra won't *feel* fine about it when she is pretty sure the fur is never growing back – she hates the idea of having a bald spot – but at least she isn't losing the rest of her tail to infection. Her ears pin back as She-ra ghosts a thumb over the edge of the area. She quickly looks away, fixing her gaze on the sunset out her window.

"I do actually have health insurance, it's just shit," she volunteers just to fill the air. Maybe it will convince She-ra that she doesn't need to be babied, too. She sees her head tilt up to glance at her before she returns to checking her tail. "It's the minimum insurance the university requires for students. I'd be fucked if I went to the hospital, but if something starts looking bad, I can manage a regular doctor," she elaborates. She-ra kind of saved her life, so she doesn't want her to think she was lying to her, even if she normally she holds no reservations about doing it to strangers. It was simplification, if anything.

"*Would* you go?" She-ra asks as she places one last soothing pet down the uninjured tip of her tail and shifts her attention. The corner of Catra's lips quirks up. That's probably earned, but she refuses to confirm She-ra's suspicions.

"I'm going to leave that open for a minute so it can get air. That's important too. Are you okay with me touching your ankle?" She-ra asks, apparently sure enough that she doesn't need a response. Catra's ears immediately pin back. She-ra places a light hand on her knee. It shouldn't make Catra want to meet her eyes so much, but again, *lonely*. She reluctantly looks over. It doesn't really help. She-ra has little expression to speak of aside from a slight smile that is probably supposed to be encouraging. The warmth of her fingertips on Catra's thigh is doing more than a third of her face ever could.

"I'll be gentle," She-ra promises. Well, *fuck*. Catra looks away with a scoff and hopes She-ra doesn't know enough about magicat body language to pick up on what her ears twitching means. She probably glows enough that she can't even tell Catra is blushing. It's fine.

"Fine," Catra agrees, looking back out the window. She grips the edge of the counter and tries to focus on anything but She-ra kneeling before her.

Bad thought. Catra presses her knees together without thinking. She-ra's hand ghosts over the edge of her ankle wrap, but it's bound on the inside and she pauses.

"Can you spread your legs so I can remove this?" she asks. Catra manages not to choke on her own tongue, but the tip of her tail wags because it's a fucking traitor.

"That's my line," she jokes quietly as she shifts her knees apart and gives She-ra access to her inner ankle. She just needs to say something before She-ra reads too much into the tail thing. It seems to work. She-ra snorts softly as she sets to removing the wrap.

"Are you trying to imply you're a top?" she responds. Catra gapes down at her. She-ra glances up to flash her a smirk before she returns to her ankle.

“Are you trying to imply I’m *not*?” she asks, offended, and then immediately hisses when She-ra pulls the rest of the wrap away and pain flares up her leg. She-ra looks up and this time Catra is pretty sure she holds her eyes for a moment. Catra narrows her eyes at her, trying to convey the message that she can *hurry up and finish* while also staring her down to show how totally in control she is.

She-ra looks back to her ankle with a smile quirking her lips.

“I had you pegged for brat, actually,” she hums as she inspects Catra’s ankle, her touch just as gentle as she promised it would be. Catra’s face feels hot. Well, it’s nice to know She-ra is probably gay even if the brat thing is fucking offensive. She’s right, but that’s not relevant.

“You wish,” she scoffs back. She then immediately hisses when She-ra places a light finger beneath the bruised and maybe-swollen part of her ankle and presses carefully. The conversation is actually a decent distraction from how ugly and mottled the bruise is.

“You did complain a *lot*,” She-ra comments. She lightly strokes her calf as she turns Catra’s leg to inspect it. Catra manages to not react to the twinges of pain her ankle gives as gravity causes her foot to shift.

“Is this about the ambulance? I stand by that. I could have taken care of it myself, and they probably weren’t going to do anything you didn’t without charging me a hundred dollars for a band-aid,” she returns. She-ra laughs softly. Surprisingly, the chorus of voices running beneath her own quiets some, almost like a few of those past She-ras never laughed before and can’t add their voice.

That’s a depressing thought. She hopes that’s not how it works.

“That’s part of it,” She-ra agrees as she sets to carefully rewrapping Catra’s ankle. It hurts, but Catra is too busy narrowing her eyes at the top of She-ra’s head to focus on it.

“Part of it,” she reiterates. The corner of She-ra’s lips pulls up. She pauses in the middle of wrapping Catra to reach over to her tail. She looks up, boring blue into Catra’s gaze as she carefully but firmly pets her tail, pulling her hand away before it can cross the injured part each time. She only needs to do it twice for Catra’s tail to start drumming a painful beat against the cabinet. Catra quickly looks away, her fur feeling hot not just beneath She-ra’s touch, but all over her body – where she would also like She-ra’s hands to be. Dammit. She-ra hums as she returns to the wrap.

“You want to do everything yourself and it’s impressive, but it’s okay to like when someone takes care of you, too,” She-ra says, diplomatically, like she isn’t laying Catra bare after, what, half an hour of knowing her total? Granted, a very vulnerable half hour, but what the *fuck*, how did she pick all that up? This isn’t what Catra expected when she let She-ra inside. Sure, she ogled She-ra when she was here before, but with a body like that she assumes that’s standard for any interaction she has. She didn’t expect her to *flirt with her*.

She is flirting, right? Or is she just joking around? Is gaydar and kink prediction one of her lesser-known superpowers? Despite She-ra’s “neutral” tone, Catra can *feel* her satisfaction as she finishes with the wrap and stands, reaching for a wipe from the kit. She-ra’s hand on her

tail is solid but gentle as she cleans off the burn and then begins to rewrap it. Her grip is firm because it *has* to be with how Catra's tail is trying to twitch.

"I don't need help. You're just projecting," Catra accuses, like that will cover up what her tail is doing. She-ra is *holding* it. It's comically hopeless, but Catra will cling to her denial until her last breath. She isn't expecting the grin that spreads across She-ra's face as she finally finishes with the bandage but *doesn't pull back*, instead looking up and focusing all her attention on Catra's face.

"I'm not a tamer, but that doesn't mean I can't handle it when I need to," she replies. Catra's mouth falls open. She isn't a total stranger to getting flirted with, usually by straight guys while she's working, but she isn't used to actually caring about the attention. She-ra's grin is cocky, the exact kind that Catra always wanted to kiss on another face, and she's standing there all hot and *perfect* in her kitchen after going out of her way to make sure Catra is okay. She might as well be the whole package if it weren't for that pesky *secret identity* thing, not to mention Catra spending the last year making life decisions purely centered around spiting Adora.

Maybe this is good, actually. Maybe this is what she needs. Meaningless flirting, maybe meaningless *more*, just something to focus on other than being unlovable. As she is slowly coming to that conclusion, though, She-ra's smile dims. She leans back, stepping away. It's surprisingly cold without the warm glow of her aura, something Catra hardly noticed until its absence leaves her cold.

"Sorry. You're fun to rile up, but I didn't want to make you uncomfortable. I really did just come here to make sure you were okay," She-ra says, her voice low and softly apologetic. Yeah, that is so far from how Catra was feeling it's laughable. She casts her gaze aside and lounges back on the counter, projecting just how unbothered she is.

"It takes more than that to rile me up," she dismisses, letting her fangs flash in a hint of a sideways smile. She-ra is hard to read, but her breath just might hitch. Catra's smirk solidifies.

"Noted." It's not quite a reaction, but a smile is playing at She-ra's lips, and anything stronger would probably undermine her promise of pure intentions. Catra doesn't *doubt* that promise, but there's already a part of her mind spinning off the fantasy that maybe She-ra isn't used to the people she rescues being mouthy and Catra intrigued her, altruism aside. She's not really one for the brat taming thing, but for She-ra – or just for a bit of fun – she might try. Nothing could prove her worth more than She-ra being interested in her.

It's a stupid fantasy to have considering She-ra's a fucking goddess and she's just *Catra*, but Catra has never cared about that shit. She's not going to worship She-ra any day, so she indulges in the thoughts as she tilts her head back to meet She-ra's eyes where she thinks she is holding hers.

Oh. A slight shiver runs through her. No, she wasn't before, but she *definitely* is now. The whole magic eyes thing is new, and maybe it should be concerning, but Catra has shit judgement when it comes to self-preservation and right now she just finds the feeling exciting. Things haven't been exciting for a long time. She-ra steps closer and Catra's body is

immediately at attention, but She-ra just reaches past her and closes the first-aid kit. Catra tries not to let her disappointment show as She-ra steps back.

“Everything looks okay. It’s not getting worse, but I am a worried that your ankle is a little swollen. If it gets worse, see a doctor, but keep up what you’re doing for now,” She-ra says, her tone weirdly kind, like she knows she’s letting Catra down but doesn’t want to. Catra slouches where she sits.

“Yeah, sure,” she agrees, totally neutral and composed. She-ra looks at her for a long moment.

“Be careful and keep it elevated,” she adds, voice soft. Catra’s tail gives a pointless, hopeful twitch, but she ignores it.

“I don’t really have any other choice. It hurts too much to stand on it a lot,” she returns. She-ra doesn’t seem happy with that, but neither is Catra. She watches her head tilt down, as if focusing on her foot again, but Catra can only feel her eyes when they’re meeting her own, so she could be secretly looking up and staring at her tits for all she knows.

“I’m sorry,” she says, startling Catra.

“What for?” Catra asks with a little too much bite for the question. She’s caught off-guard and she doesn’t like it, especially when she’s still swallowing down disappointment.

“She-ra is supposed to have healing abilities, but I’m still learning a new power once a month and I can’t help like I’m supposed to,” She-ra explains, gesturing vaguely towards Catra’s ankle with her free hand. Both of Catra’s ears twitch as she blinks at the – she cannot state this enough – *fucking goddess* in her tiny kitchen. She was caught off-guard because the apology apparently *makes no sense*.

She had no idea that was how She-ra’s powers worked, and she kind of wonders how many people not in the Alliance do, but then again She-ra just blurted it out to her, so maybe she says this to all the strangers she rescues.

“Okay, so that makes you just like the rest of us without magic bullshit powers to kiss the pain away. Big whoop. I have an excuse to take a lot of naps for the next week, you’re fine,” Catra returns, rolling her eyes. She knows she isn’t really good at the whole *assurance* thing with strangers – ordinarily she wouldn’t even try – nor is she inclined to it, but She-ra did save her life. She-ra releases a soft breath and chuckles, so maybe it was good enough.

“Thanks, that’s actually comforting,” she says, taking a step back but tilting her head up to meet Catra’s eyes again. An electric spark immediately dances over her skin. She-ra smiles, small but somehow so important.

“I need to get back. If you want me try the kiss thing, though, just flag me down,” she says, smile growing as Catra’s ears quiver and her tail turns her cabinets into a marching drum. Luckily it *hurts*, which helps her contain her reaction, even if it requires subtly shifting her hand over to hold her tail down on the counter and mute its movements.

“What’s the queer bat signal? A rainbow spotlight?” she asks, cool and composed. She-ra laughs, layers falling away from the chorus again to give a better glimpse at a single voice, a single person beneath the glow and mystique. It’s kind of beautiful.

“You don’t have to go that far to get my attention,” she assures, reaching for Catra’s crutch and handing it off to her. Catra takes it reluctantly, hopping off the counter. She-ra turns to the door and Catra tries to brainstorm a response that doesn’t come across as *desperate* for all of the five steps to the door. When She-ra opens it and turns, Catra realizes she is still smiling.

“You’re going to be back, aren’t you,” she says, the knowledge immediately hitting her. She-ra pauses, flashing her a satisfied smile, and then she steps through the doorway.

“It was good seeing you again,” is all she says, and then she closes the door behind her so Catra doesn’t have to maneuver around her crutch. Catra isn’t so pathetic that she rushes to watch her go through the peephole, but she swears she can feel the subtle aura of magic move away for a few moments before even she can’t delude herself that she can pick it up anymore.

Well. That was.

What?

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Being She-ra gives Adora confidence. It has never been hard to get her cocky, but she feels a lot less socially awkward as She-ra. It might be because she knows exactly what people want and expect from She-ra, but that doesn’t explain it giving her the guts to flirt with Catra when Catra hates her. The real her, anyway. It felt so good to be talking to Catra easily again that she kind of forgot that they were – to Catra, at least – strangers.

Having a secret identity *sucks*. Catra is still so vibrant that even the simplest acts are endearing. Just petting her tail again felt like a revelation, though it left her bizarrely jealous for herself. *Adora* wants to be the person to touch Catra like that, and in the space of two afternoons she has let She-ra surprisingly close to the carefully guarded core that used to be Adora’s sole domain.

She wants to be around Catra more than she wants to selfishly guard what used to just be theirs, and somehow She-ra allows her to do that. It has been a long time since Catra was hers and clearly her interest has moved on. Adora doesn’t even blame her after all the ways she failed Catra those last few months together. This could just be a fleeting moment, but Adora can’t let it go. She never wanted to lose Catra. She knows it is going to hurt eventually, but Catra asks if she’s coming back and Adora already knows the answer.

It will be a while before her ankle is healed, right? All of the Alliance has gone through some medical training to help during emergencies. She can do this for her, at least until Catra is healed and pointedly tells her that she doesn’t need She-ra coming around anymore.

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They’re being hunted. As careful as their pursuers are, they know something is wrong as they trace familiar paths through the city streets and find them defiled with dark traces. No one should know to do that. The attack slipped by them at first, but it doesn’t take long for them to put together the knowledge tucked into the university archives and the disturbance in their trails.

Something powerful is tracking them. They have to stay hidden. They don’t want to know what it will do with them when it catches up.

Chapter End Notes

I told you the POV was whoever I needed uwu

Chapter 3: Overworked

Chapter Notes

> I'm trying to update this fic every 2-3 days. The chapters are a bit longer than in AMLAIT so we'll see where things end up. I just had to completely throw out 1.2k and start again later on in the fic, so when rewrites like that happen it's especially likely to be three days.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra spends the first hour after She-ra leaves processing. She then spends the next hour doing things that are exactly no one's business unless She-ra wants to *make* them her business, at which point Catra is sure they could work something out.

She spends the rest of the evening kind of freaking out over what she just fantasized about, not because she's ashamed of her desires or anything, but because they're so unattainable and foreign to her. Catra isn't a puritan, she has fantasized about plenty of people over the years – especially in the *last* year when she has spitefully been trying and failing to cleanse Adora from her system – but the savior of the damn city is a pretty lofty target.

It was probably some harmless flirting that Catra immediately got way too invested in, which is about half the reason she's freaking out. Getting invested is dangerous, but it's not like she's lying to herself that She-ra is *actually* interested in something. She's just having fun, flirting mindlessly, and if there's any intent behind that, well, Catra isn't lying to herself that either of them is looking for anything deeper than a one-night stand. She has realistic expectations about what she's allowed to have, ranging from nothing to something shallow and quick but at least fun.

She isn't about to back down, regardless of which direction She-ra takes this. It felt nice in a way that no one's attention has since Adora left her shaken and confused. It's validating, too. If She-ra of all people can want her, then clearly there isn't something horribly wrong with her that Adora just couldn't stomach anymore after swallowing down for years. She still doesn't know why Adora turned cold on her and why she tried to *lie* about it, still stringing her along when she reaches out even now, but at least someone can want her. She doesn't need to be loved, she needs to just not be *lonely*.

That's the problem with her expectations, though. There is still a way She-ra can let her down: she can just not show up again.

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Adora almost talks herself out of going back. Well, she tries to at least, but she doesn't think she comes anywhere close to succeeding. Since the breakup she has barely been able to push through even school, unable to picture a future anymore when Catra was always supposed to be a part of it. There are so many reasons why this is a bad idea, but after a year of struggling on her own, she can't make any of them matter to her more than the promise in Catra's smirk as she sat on the counter.

Catra would feel so betrayed if she knew, but Adora has already lost her. There's really nowhere worse they can go from here. Maybe as She-ra she can somehow fix the mess she made as Adora. It's a vain hope, but either she clings to it or she falls into a depression about how there was the distinct possibility that Catra could have *died* without her ever knowing. She holds out for a few days before she has an opportunity to hop over to the Fright Zone unnoticed while Glimmer is spending the night with Bow's family to celebrate one of his bothers being in town.

It's just past sundown when she arrives, maybe a little too late for common courtesy but far from late for Catra, so hopefully she doesn't find it presumptuous. She basically invited Adora back when she asked if she was coming and said nothing to discourage her. Adora hangs onto that as she knocks, feeling out of place as She-ra in the hallway, like she always does when she's transformed indoors.

Her knock is met with a growl from inside, immediately having Adora doubting herself, but when the lock scrapes and Catra opens the door, she looks as surprised as she is disheveled, like she really didn't think Adora was coming back.

She looks- Well- She-

She could have been working late or having hard sex and those are pretty much the only reasons Adora can come up with for her appearance. She was probably dressed in a suit earlier, either for business or a date, but the blazer is gone now and the top several buttons of her dress shirt are undone. Her sleeves are rolled back and buttoned at the elbow, her hair is a bit wild, and she looks tired.

"Is this… a bad time?" Adora asks, noticing a bit belatedly Catra isn't using her crutch even if her foot and tail are still wrapped. Catra blinks at her, seeming a bit dazed, and then shakes her head, half-stepping and half-hopping aside, clearly trying not to put too much weight on her ankle.

"Just come inside," she says, her voice gruff. Adora hurries to follow instructions, sending a glance around the room to survey the scene as Catra closes the door behind her and leans on it. Adora is relieved to find the explanation to her state is firmly *working late*, her coffee table and couch covered in papers and books, all radiating out from the clear spot in the center where she was sitting. Catra's crutch is leaning up against the side of the couch and Adora hurries to grab it, bringing it back to her at the door. Catra, still leaned against it with her eyes closed and taking a deep breath, slits her eyes open slowly.

Her eyes start on Adora's hands and then drag up slowly, tracing up the line of her arm and shoulder before she finally meets Adora's gaze. Her lips pull in a lazy, uneven smile, revealing just a peek of her fangs. Adora was just hoping Catra wouldn't be insulted by the

attempt to help, but this is so, so much more than she would have dared to want. It's the kind of smile that threatens to eat her alive.

Adora is *so* lucky it's not really visible when She-ra blushes, if she can do it at all.

"Thanks," Catra says, her voice rough and as lazy as her smile. She takes the crutch and pushes off the door reluctantly, tucking it under her arm. She brushes past Adora as she makes her way back to the couch. "It's getting better and the crutch is fucking with my back, so I haven't been using it when I'm at home, but-" she cuts off, clearly in pain from the silence required to keep herself from groaning as she puts weight on her foot to sink down on the couch, "-it still sucks," she finishes, slumping back against the couch and immediately folding into a pretzel, leaving her injured leg draping over the side almost as if she is sitting normally and then slouching and twisting the rest of her until she is settled in a position that looks so unnatural it makes Adora's shoulders ache to be popped.

"You sure it's the crutch doing that?" she asks even though she knows Catra can sit and sleep in pretty much any position she wants and never suffer any consequences from it except maybe mussing her hair. It's annoying how impervious she is that way. Catra's head lolls back and she throws Adora another one of those grins that sends a shiver through her. Catra has to be exhausted. She's smiling too much, too easily, and she looks like a sneeze could knock her out.

"Hey, this position has been scientifically proven to increase legalese absorption," Catra throws back as Adora makes her way over. She hovers for a moment before deciding that the least awkward place she can be is sitting on the ground. Between She-ra's height and the knot Catra has worked herself into, they're basically at eye-level as Adora sits crisscross and eyes the papers around her.

"Has it now?" she can't help but ask, smiling to herself at Catra's organized chaos. Catra's eyes slip closed as she hums and Adora seriously considers the possibility that they won't open again and Catra will fall asleep right there, but then they *do* and they're burning as they hold her gaze, the colors seeming especially vibrant set into Catra's half-shadowed features.

"I've got the A's from last semester to prove it," she assures. Adora can't help it – pride immediately swells in her heart.

"Good job. I know that had to take a lot of work. Law stuff is really hard," Adora says. To her surprise, Catra's eyes slip closed as she trills. This time she doesn't open her eyes, but the way her ears and tail are twitching give away that she isn't tired but *embarrassed*. Adora is left too breathless to rib her. She wouldn't anyway, not when Catra is apparently so affected by such simple praise.

"It's hard, but being a magicat helps. We've got good memories," Catra mumbles, turning her head and rubbing her cheek against the back of her couch. Adora can't imagine Catra is randomly feeling possessive of the couch, which means she's scent marking just because she's happy. If Adora needed any extra motivation to keep visiting Catra, this would crack any resolve left otherwise. Catra always reacted to Adora praising her, and maybe it's just especially strong with her tired like this, but a year ago Adora never could have imagined

Catra reacting like this to a stranger's compliments. She *needs* this. She might not have been getting it at all since Adora left her life.

"Still impressive. Even being able to sort that kind of information during a test has to be hard," Adora returns. Catra's purr is soft, but Adora has spent her entire life attuned to that vibration and she wouldn't – *couldn't* – ever miss it. It's a good thing Catra still has her eye closed because Adora can't stop her smile as she roams her eyes over Catra, relaxed and probably comfortable despite her contorted position.

"You sure you should be trying to study when you're this tired?" Adora asks, watching the subtle rise and fall of Catra's chest through her splayed open shirt buttons. Catra slits her eyes so thinly it takes Adora a minute to realize they're open and it looks like Adora is just staring at her cleavage. She snaps her eyes back up to meet Catra's, apologies already half-formed in her mind before she remembers Catra probably can't tell where she's looking beneath the mask.

"You don't get to be a lawyer by napping all day. I have a big-" Catra yawns and waves her hand weakly, barely lifting her arm, "-thing at the end of the week. Need to be ready," she explains, apparently too tired to find the right words. Adora blinks at her.

"You're studying to be a lawyer?" she asks, all her thoughts focusing on the one word. Catra sends her a vague look, caught somewhere between confusion, exasperation, and of course exhaustion.

"Not a lot of other reasons to be taking law classes," she points out.

"You could be studying to be a paralegal. Or an activist! Lobbyists, and stuff," Adora returns, realizing her mistake immediately and stumbling to come up with any other options that aren't what she knew to be the *right* one until this moment. Her tone sounds hurried to her own ears, but Catra is either too tired to care or too thrown off by the undercurrent of voices beneath Adora's own to pick up on it, because she just rolls her eyes.

"I got a community college degree so I could be a paralegal, but that's just a fallback. I'm almost done with undergrad and I'm moving to Bright Moon next semester to start my J.D," Catra explains, which fills in several gaps for Adora, including ones in her *heart*.

There are, maybe, other universities in Bright Moon that could offer law degrees, but the only one Adora knows of is BMU. Catra is going to be there with her, a grad student just like Adora will kinda, sort of be once she's on year three of her accelerated master's program.

She thought Catra hated all of that. They were supposed to just go to community college together on free foster kid tuition and leave as a paralegal and vet tech. When Adora found out about the new aid program, she insisted they both apply since it would be the best thing for their futures to get – essentially – a free advanced degree. Catra reluctantly applied just for the four-year version of a paralegal degree, but Adora enrolled in the masters' program to become a veterinarian.

The downside of the combined bachelor's and master's program was that it was only available across Bright Moon Bay, at BMU. In their final conversation, when Adora tried to

apologize for missing their date, Catra accused her of never being satisfied with anything less than perfection. Anything Catra could offer her would never be enough, because Adora wanted everything: the perfect career, the perfect life, the perfect *girlfriend*, and Catra would never be those things, too riddled with mediocrity and flaws and a willingness to settle for the things that made her happy.

It was painful to hear how deep the words that had been spat at her growing up had sunk into Catra's skin, but she didn't stick around to let Adora convince her otherwise. Adora was always satisfied, if not overjoyed, with anything Catra could give her, no matter how *mediocre* Catra felt it was. The thing Adora needed to be perfect was herself, and in her quest to be everything that she thought she should, trying not to let down anyone's *possible* expectations of her, she failed the person most important to her.

Adora realizes she has sat in silence for far too long, but it doesn't matter. Catra fell asleep while she was having her internal crisis. Adora should do anything other than what she does, but her heart is hammering in her chest and when her emotions are running high, it's hardest to maintain She-ra.

Gold flaring and dying doesn't cause Catra's eyelids to even flutter, but the moment Adora is sitting on her floor as herself, inches from Catra for the first time in so long, she nearly has a panic attack. Being alone in Catra's space is too much – means too much – and Adora can't let herself fall into the fantasy of this being allowed. If Catra's eyes opened right now, she would find one last reserve of energy to be furious and kick her out.

Adora hurries to her feet, holding her breath as she shuffles some of Catra's things around and stacks the papers from the couch cushions carefully to move them to the coffee table. She moves to the other end of the room to grab the pillow from Catra's bed and finds herself able to breathe again safely once she is several feet from Catra.

She takes a few steadying breaths before returning, carefully laying the pillow on the side of the couch cushions that she thinks Catra is going to slump onto in a few minutes. She grabs a blanket, too, only able to loosely throw it over Catra's lap due to her precarious position and a fear of waking her. When she doesn't stir, Adora risks a careful pet over Catra's short hair and only gets an ear twitch in response, but it does something to her heart extremely disproportional to the reaction. Couch cleared, she casts her gaze over the room one last time before reluctantly leaving. She turns the lock on the inside of the doorknob and flicks off the light switch, finally closing the door behind her.

It's probably for the best. Her heart is hammering still. She needs to process.

Besides, now she has a reason to come back. She never did look at Catra's ankle.

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Catra wakes up on her couch, curled on her side. Despite her attempts to stay uncomfortable last night, staying in her suit and contorting her position, she fell asleep. Somehow her head is resting on a pillow and she's tucked warmly beneath a blanket. It takes her several minutes to even remember She-ra's visit.

She bolts upright, but upon casting her gaze around, the only thing she finds out of place is her notes. The couch has been cleared and everything is neatly ordered on her coffee table. The sun has risen, but Catra was warm all night thanks to the She-ra apparently getting her a blanket and *tucking her in*.

Catra groans, falling back against the couch and throwing an arm over her eyes. Oh, she is so fucked. She can't believe she even managed to fall asleep with She-ra around. She doesn't trust like that, no matter how exhausted she was. She's going to need to do a sweep of her apartment to make sure She-ra didn't fuck with anything other than her bed – *bad thought*, she can't stop having those when it comes to She-ra – but she's already pretty certain she isn't going to find anything. Peaking out from under her arm reveals She-ra even locked the door behind her, at least the doorknob.

Reluctantly, Catra goes digging around the couch cushions and turns up her phone after a minute. She quickly shoots off a text to the Super Pal Trio group chat, proposing a movie night this weekend to celebrate when her presentation is over. She immediately gets a message back from Scorpia bursting with excitement. At this time of day, Entrapta is probably sleeping, so Catra takes that as effective confirmation they're on and drops her phone onto her stomach.

She needs fucking advice. She feels like she's going insane.

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Adora can't find the time to slip away the next day, so she reluctantly waits until two days later to make her way back to Catra's apartment. When Catra answers the door, she looks like herself again, in an oversized hoodie Adora can't help but suspect used to be hers and a pair of joggers. Once again, she isn't using her crutch, and this time her foot isn't even properly wrapped despite how she clearly puts all her weight on one ankle as she leans out into the hall to look around.

"You'd better not get caught. Someone is going to come shake me down for information if they see you visiting," Catra says, carefully stepping back and shuffling her feet so she doesn't put too much weight on her foot. Adora suppresses the urge to wince.

"I'll be careful. *You* should be careful with your foot. Where's your crutch?" Adora asks as she enters. Catra rolls her eyes, locking the door behind her.

"I'm doing better and I'm still using it when I leave the house, calm down," Catra replies, her tone dry. Despite her words, she shuffles with a telling amount of caution as she crosses her

small apartment and flops back in her desk chair. She has notes spread across it and a textbook open, clearly studying again. Adora spots her crutch leaned up against the kitchen counter.

“I’ll be the judge of that,” she decides, moving across the space to kneel before Catra. Catra’s ears twitch and she rolls her eyes up to the ceiling, keeping her gaze fixed up there *definitely* out of pure exasperation. Adora isn’t falling for it and she smiles to herself as she goes to carefully roll down the plain black stirrup sock Catra is wearing in lieu of a wrap. She doesn’t know if Catra has just gotten worse at hiding her tells or she’s relying on She-ra not being able to understand them, but her fluster is clear to Adora.

Catra turns out to have been telling the truth when Adora unveils her ankle. The bruising is starting to fade beneath her fur and there’s only a few small scabs left from the shrapnel. Adora takes a few seconds to compare both her ankles, but it doesn’t look swollen anymore either.

“It looks a lot better. It still hurts when you walk on it?” she asks, looking up. Catra looks back down at her, shrugging, but the flicking of her tail gives away that she isn’t as casual about this as she would like to appear.

“Not too bad. My boss has been giving me a stool at work, so I mostly use the crutch just to go to there or school,” she says. Adora frowns, but she nods, carefully rolling Catra’s sock back up. “Aw, you don’t have to look so disappointed, princess. You can still try to kiss it better if you want to,” Catra drawls, her teasing voice sending a jolt straight through Adora’s spine.

“Sorry, I don’t have a foot fetish, but let’s see about your tail and maybe the offer will still be open,” Adora replies. She doesn’t know how obvious She-ra’s scent signal are or if she can even really get turned on – it has never been on her mind while transformed before – but she can’t risk lingering on that tease. Catra’s voice has always done a lot for her and, kink or not, Adora would gladly lavish any inch of Catra in attention. Catra’s ears pin back, but her pupils dilate and follow Adora’s movements closely, so she knows it isn’t a *bad* reaction.

The tip of her tail flicks erratically as Adora reaches for it, pausing to see if it will still or Catra will give her clear permission. Catra has always been touchy about her tail, and though Adora was a noted exception to that, she knows She-ra probably isn’t. She glances up to meet Catra’s eyes. Catra immediately huffs and looks away, but the next flick is a large arc and lands Catra’s tail on her hand. Adora twists her fingers around it, reaching for the tail sock Catra is at least still wearing.

The burn mark is now some fresh, pink skin and a decent amount of scabbing. It has a ways to go, but it’s clearly healing fine. Her ankle is healing over too, unlikely to be fractured or have any other underlying issue. It’s good news, but it’s also disappointing. Adora could be sick with herself for the disappointment she feels when she should be overjoyed.

If she truly was coming just to check on Catra, this would be the last visit. This probably *is* her last visit.

“Everything looks like it’s healing well. Just keep covering this when out of the house to make sure it doesn’t get infected, and don’t work your ankle too hard,” Adora instructs, taking far more care than necessary to make sure Catra’s fur doesn’t get mussed or pinched beneath the sock as she re-covers her tail. It buys her maybe twenty more seconds of touching Catra. When she finishes, she looks up to find Catra watching her.

Neither of them says anything. Catra doesn’t look weirded out, but Adora can’t tell what she *is*. It feels like they’re both waiting for something. In Adora’s case, it’s more like dreading. She doesn’t want to leave, but there isn’t much else for her to do now.

Catra isn’t kicking her out, though, just watching her.

“I’m not a princess, you know,” Adora says. Acknowledging any part of Catra’s *kiss it better* statement feels dangerous, but it’s pretty much the only thing she can think to say that isn’t *well, it’s been nice knowing you*. Catra shifts in her chair, settling back almost like she’s relaxing.

“Duh, this is a democracy. I know the whole story, though, they read it to us in elementary school,” Catra responds, falling into the conversation with ease. Adora feels a smile tug at her lips. The history is taught in school, but she knows Catra heard more of it from Adora reading her books aloud as a kid than from their teachers. She always loved the stories of the princesses, even if there were only a few active on the superhero scene at the time.

“Okay, but She-ra was *never* a princess. Everyone else had their powers follow a royal family line before they branched off to some worthier heir, but I don’t think She-ra has ever been nobility,” Adora explains, barely resisting the urge to reach for Catra’s tail when it twitches. If she was here as Adora – and they were still friends – she could easily pick it up and start petting it. She has no idea what Catra would allow from She-ra, though. She’s pretty confident she wouldn’t be comfortable with that.

“What’s the ‘Power Princess’ thing, then?” Catra asks, tilting her chin with defiance, like she thinks she has cornered Adora. The spark in her eyes shows a side of her Adora desperately misses, challenging and ready to chase down any contradictory answer.

“You’re going to be a great lawyer,” she says without thinking. Catra’s tail immediately starts lashing and her ears pin back. Any potential worry Adora feels evaporates before it can form. She grins up at Catra’s flustered expression. “If you can control your tail in the court room, anyway,” she teases. Catra is definitely blushing now. She releases a noise caught between a growl and a purr, a flustered intersection that makes Adora’s heart flutter just to hear.

“Shut up. That’s offensive,” Catra mutters as she tucks her knees up to her chest and wraps her arms around them, but her reaction isn’t *bad*. Adora snorts.

“Sure, it’s definitely that and not that you just don’t want to admit how much you like praise,” she returns, too bold and too teasing, but Catra is too *flustered* to do much more than hiss at her. Adora grins, but she decides to ease off, mostly because she doesn’t know where Catra’s lines are with She-ra.

“To answer your question, she’s called the Princess of Power because she was closely associated with the other princesses as their leader. With the titles sticking around to distinguish us from the average magic-user even after we split from the royal lines, She-ra got a moniker too. But I’m not a princess,” Adora explains, waving her hand vaguely around. Catra sniffs, but her tail isn’t lashing quite so fast, so her fluster seems to be easing.

“I’m still calling you princess. She-ra is weird to say all the time, anyway, and *goddess* is off the table. I don’t simper like that,” Catra decides. For some reason, the words make Adora’s heart trip. There’s an implication there, like she thinks she’s going to keep talking to Adora long enough for a nickname to be necessary – or to make sense at all.

“You can call me whatever you want, kitty,” Adora returns, throwing Catra a smile that she hopes comes across as flirtatious without leering. To her surprise, Catra’s ears pin back and this time Adora knows it’s bad from the tension that gathers around her eyes.

“And you *can’t* call me that,” Catra returns, a sharp edge to her voice. Adora’s heartrate speeds up with worry, but she quickly nods.

“Sorry,” she rushes out. She forgot *Adora* was allowed to say that, but Catra isn’t talking to Adora right now. “Sorry, I know some people are okay with it, but others aren’t and I shouldn’t have assumed,” she tacks on, hoping Catra doesn’t decide She-ra is a creep. At least it wasn’t kitten. That one is even more of a minefield. Catra sniffs, her tail flicking once, then twice, as she glares She-ra down. The intimidation works. Adora has everything – namely, Catra – to lose if she fucks this up.

“I just don’t like it,” Catra says, an air of finality to her voice. Adora nods mutely, wondering if this is because they don’t know each other like that or if she *never* liked it. Catra looks at her, appraising. Adora doesn’t really know what to say or how to move past that awkwardness, all she knows is that she doesn’t want to leave, especially on that note. While she is struggling, Catra inclines her head slightly, clearing thinking.

“Why do you keep coming to visit?” Catra asks. Adora stills, trying to come up with something. She doesn’t have an answer to that, at least not one that she can say to Catra.

“To make sure you’re okay.” It’s half-true, only small a part of her motivation but still there. Catra raises a brow at her.

“I told you I could see a doctor if I had to on the second day. You saw me walking around without my crutch two days ago,” Catra returns. Adora is lucky that being She-ra seems to mute her physical reactions. It’s easier to hold back her wince like this, her body hardened so it can always be ready in battle.

“I could still help,” she says softly. Because her voice is a fucking traitor, a few layers fall away in it. She hates how that gives her away as surely as Catra’s tail does for her. Catra’s ears prick forward.

“And now there’s nothing to help. But you’re still here,” Catra returns. She has that look in her eye, like she’s trying to crack Adora. Whether it’s Adora’s secrets or Adora’s resolve remains to be seen, but she feels like this is a test.

She failed just a moment ago. She can't fail now. It will be the last time she sees Catra if she does.

"I like talking to you," is all she can come up with. Honest about her intentions, but also a bit pathetic. Catra's ears twitch and the tip of her tail flicks – probably a good sign – but her face doesn't change.

"You don't even know my name," she points out. Adora is so, so grateful for the mask.

She forgot She-ra doesn't know Catra's name. She never even thought about asking, the name always right there in the back of her mind. She needs to get her story straight if they're going to keep doing this. She has to put together a list of the things She-ra knows, and maybe some very important things that she *doesn't*.

"Am I allowed to know your name?" she asks. Catra's ears both twitch, trained forward, like if she listens hard enough she'll find an explanation in the undercurrent of voices beneath Adora's own.

"Why wouldn't you be allowed? You already know where I live and tucked me into fucking bed," Catra returns. Despite the sarcastic bite in her words, her cheeks are warm as she finishes. Catra narrows her eyes, daring Adora to say anything about that last part. At least Adora knows the gesture was appreciated. She manages a smile around her anxiety.

"Stranger danger," she replies. Her smile only grows, relaxing as Catra rolls her eyes.

"Like I said, it's a little too late for that," Catra's tone is sarcastic and she's smiling too. After the tension from just a few moments ago, that feels incredible. For a moment, Adora just basks in it, but then Catra looks back to her and she remembers not to be weird. Gently, she nudges Catra's uninjured leg.

"So?" she prompts.

"So, what?" Catra says, just to be contrarian. Adora rolls her eyes.

"Do I get to know your name?" she reiterates. She kind of needs the answer to be yes or she's going to fuck it up in the future and it's going to be really suspicious.

Shit, when she went to get Catra's backpack, did Catra tell her what it looked like? No, she did, she said it was black. That wasn't a lot of direction for a stranger, but Adora didn't need even that much. The real problem was just turning it up in the damaged library.

"Hm, are you going to tell me yours?" Catra hums back, a sparkle dancing in her eyes. Adora sends her a look. The finer points will get lost beneath the mask, but she knows the intention doesn't from how Catra has to fight down a smile. They both know the answer to that.

"She-ra," Adora returns, her tone dry. The smile spreads across Catra's whole face, just enough deviousness to it to warn Adora to brace herself.

"Pretty sure that's your title, not your name. What, should I have you call me sir all the time to make it even? I don't like ma'am unless you say it *really* prettily," Catra asks. Oh, she's

playing *dirty*. Adora wonders how far her blush can extend. She is trying to suppress her reaction by holding her breath for some reason, a terrible instinct that is probably only making any potential blushing worse. The hint of laughter shaking at Catra's shoulders makes it clear that Adora isn't as unmoved as she would like to appear.

"It's Catra. Don't make any jokes, I'll kick your ass," Catra finally takes pity on her, having had her fun at Adora's expense. Adora lets out a breath of relief, but she can't help smirking at Catra.

"You'll kick She-ra's ass?" she challenges. A litany of supervillains has tried and failed, but Catra smirks right back at her, her tail curling with satisfaction.

"Yeah, I will. You won't fight back because you'll feel bad about hitting me and I'll have you on your knees in no time," she returns. Adora glances down, suddenly very aware she's still kneeling in front of Catra. She hurriedly stands, but somehow she feels like that was Catra's plan from how her eyes trail up from where Adora was crouching slowly, tracing up her thighs and then following her curves. The heat in her eyes feels like it has a physical effect on Adora. By the time Catra finally meets her gaze, Adora can't pretend she wouldn't let Catra tie her up with her own lasso. Trying to say anything to the contrary would only make it clear what a lie it is.

"Okay, fine, but just because I don't want to fight you," Adora huffs, crossing her arms. That small victory makes Catra's eyes *sparkle* and Adora already knows she needs to cut her off before she says something else to worsen the direction Adora's thoughts are trailing off towards.

Okay, so She-ra can probably get turned on. *Probably*.

"I think it's a pretty name, though," Adora says. It's true, no matter how uncreative the social workers were when they named Catra after she was dropped off. Catra scoffs, quickly looking away, but those ear and tail twitches are unmistakable. She's so *easy* to fluster these days.

Has it just been a long time since someone teased her like this, or is she reacting more strongly because it's She-ra? She barely knows her, but Adora knows She-ra is more attractive than her. She has better hair and bigger muscles. Does Catra like her better?

"Flattery won't make me go easy on you when we fight," she says. Adora rolls her eyes. Yeah, that's not happening *ever*. Catra looks back to her and Adora pointedly looks down at her – *down*, because with Catra sitting She-ra absolutely towers over her. It might normally be more awkward than sitting on the floor, but in this specific moment, her height lets her show Catra what a dumb idea that is. Her tail lashes and her eyes seem to drag down unconsciously.

Adora smirks. Catra catches the movement in the corner of her eye – has to, because she certainly isn't looking at her *face* – and her ears pin back. She whips her chair around, turning back to her desk so fast Adora is pretty sure she hits her knees on it. She releases a small hiss but still pulls her chair in closer to tuck under the desk.

“I have a presentation I have to study for. Your dumb face is distracting,” Catra accuses. Adora grins, excited. They’re at the *insults* phase. That means Catra likes her, at least when she says it like that.

“My face is distracting, huh?” she teases. Catra pulling her chair in tight under the desk can’t do much to hide the sound of her tail thumping against the filing drawers on her right.

“You forgot the *dumb* part,” she stresses, flipping her notebook to what Adora is sure is a random page. After a moment Catra flips it back to where it started. Adora grins, shaking her head fondly. She really, really wants to stay and tease her, but she doesn’t want to impact Catra’s studying.

She isn’t sure when she’s allowed to come back. She feels like Catra will let her – she probably would have shut her down when she asked her about her name if not – but without the excuse of checking on her, she’s not really sure what another visit would look like or when it would be reasonable. She doesn’t know how to ask about it either while being at all subtle.

If she was really on her fourth conversation with Catra, what would she do? It feels impossible to imagine with how well she knows her. She has seen plenty of glimpses of the old Catra she loves, so plenty to want to get to know more, but she would be calmer about it if they were strangers probably, less desperate and not coming over every few days. She couldn’t manage to see Catra even that often when they were regular friends.

“I’ll let you get back to it. Good luck on your presentation,” Adora settles on saying. Catra tilts her head back, watching Adora over her shoulder.

“Thanks. Lock the door behind you,” she says. Despite the dismissal, she keeps watching Adora. Probably just to make sure she locks it. Adora nods, turning before she can linger too awkwardly and heading for the door. Catra doesn’t call her back as she turns the lock on the knob and closes the door behind her.

Adora takes a few steps down the empty hall before she takes a deep breath. She lets She-ra go as she blows it out. Okay, she knows what she needs to do now. It isn’t exactly what she wants, but it’s still so much better than the last ten months. She missed how Catra’s mismatched eyes sparkle. None of her friendships, even with her fellow heroes who she should have so much in common with, can replace that. She’ll do what it takes.

Chapter End Notes

> In case you haven’t encountered them, combined bachelors and masters programs are a real thing. I know someone who applied to one but didn’t get in.

Chapter 4: Movie Night/Return

Chapter Notes

> It's the American drinking age because I already went with our terrible healthcare system LMAO

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra walks into Entrapta's apartment, distracted by planning what she will say during movie night, and ducks on instinct when she sees danger in the corner of her eye.

"Why do you have that pointed at the door?" she hisses, dropped to the side on all fours as she tries to get her fur to lie flat again. Entrapta looks up from the salvaged Horde laser she currently has a screwdriver in and just had aimed at Catra's chest. Hopefully the power is disconnected, but Catra's heartrate is still calming as she slinks around the edges of the room, circling around to the non-firing side of the laser.

"This is the optimal angle for achieving a balance between both light and leverage," Entrapta explains, gesturing vaguely at her work light and then immediately turning back to her project with her tongue stuck out between her teeth. Catra narrows her eyes at the laser, daring it to gain sentience like technology seems to do around Entrapta. At least Emily's laser was already missing when Entrapta recovered her and started making modifications.

"Having been on the receiving end of one of those, I recommend scrapping it unless you're intent on murder," Catra says, edging around to the far end of the workbench. She's right next to the laser now, but it can't hope to hit her. It doesn't seem to be hooked up to something that could be powering it, at least.

"Oh, but there's so many more possibilities! The Horde's lasers are the most advanced I've ever seen and this is the first time I've been able to recover one. Figuring out how they focus their power could lead to improvement of so many things. Sticking just to lasers is thinking too small!" Entrapta returns, pulling her screwdriver out of the metal shell to flail it around excitedly. Catra, for the second time, ducks. She sighs from under the table.

"Be *careful*," she chides. Entrapta really shouldn't have the damn thing in the first place, but she's fascinated with the tech the Horde utilizes and has been combing attack sites for a long time, usually only able to approach long after emergency services cleared the area of any Horde remnants. It's concerning that they missed a whole laser, even if the bot it was once attached to is long gone.

This might actually be something to bring up with She-ra. Catra doesn't know how the Alliance's relationship with the city works, but clearly someone isn't doing their job. Catra doesn't know how to bring it up without outing Entrapta, though, and she isn't about to bring

the Alliance down on her head. It would look really bad with all the Horde tech in her house, especially if they learned she's a technopath. Catra doubts She-ra likes her enough to take her word that Entrapta doesn't have any ill intent, especially when there's such a large difference between *bad intentions* and *harmless*.

Entrapta is never, in any situation, harmless. She proves this by laughing loudly at Catra's suggestion. Catra's ears pin back and she resigns herself to looking over her shoulder when she visits for the next few weeks. Maybe she can talk Scorpia into hosting movie night instead for a while. Her apartment is closer to Catra's and she actually has a decent television. She can probably imply some problems with her ankle and convince her.

"I'm going to get the living room set up," Catra tells Entrapta, slinking away as Entrapta calls a joyous *okay!* behind her. It gives her an excuse to get away from the laser and to pick the movie before Scorpia shows up and insists on a terrible comedy, or even worse, a decent – for the already terrible genre – romcom.

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Scorpia can be a bit slow on the uptake when it comes to social cues, but apparently Catra is too predictable.

"So…" *Here it goes*. They've barely even started the movie. "Anything new going on with you? That you might want to talk about with your best buds?" Scorpia asks. She's pretending to look at the TV, but *pretending* is about as far as it gets. Catra slumps in her seat, hoping to disappear into the couch cushions.

"You're talking over the movie," she mutters, as if there's even that much dialogue in the opening of Fury Road.

"We've seen this a dozen times. You always put it on when you need to talk," Scorpia says. Catra slinks lower and turns to curl into the arm of the couch, just getting comfortable and definitely not hiding. Entrapta turns her head from the armchair, blinking at Catra with her giant eyes that contain no judgement or preconceptions, but still get under her skin as effectively as Scorpia's puppy eyes can.

Catra huffs, looking back to the screen with her ears pinned back. Fine. She thought she had longer to prepare herself, but she's a big girl. She can do this.

"Remember when I said She-ra helped patch me up after the Horde attack?" she asks.

"Yes… Wait, are you okay?!" Scorpia asks, immediately twisting towards her and reaching her pincers out so she can lean closer as if to check Catra's injuries. Catra bats out blindly in her direction, too much distance between them to make contact, but the flash of claws is enough to send the message.

“I’m *fine*. Now you sound like her,” Catra returns. Scorpia eases off, but she doesn’t look back at the screen like Entrapta has. Catra shifts, tucking her tail under her leg so it can’t give her away. “She may have carried me home to do that,” she admits, begrudgingly. Scorpia gasps and Catra’s ears pin back.

“She *carried* you?” she asks. She sounds awestruck. This is so much worse than teasing. Catra doesn’t need Scorpia *proud* of her for accepting help. She balls up, leaning into the arm of the sofa, and sends a desperate glance to Entrapta, but she’s looking at the movie. Listening, definitely, but eye contact isn’t her thing on a good day, nor is picking up on subtle cries for help.

“She twisted my arm, okay? She wouldn’t let me walk home injured, so she said I could let the paramedics treat it or she would bring me home to my first-aid kit. And I wasn’t about to pay the hospital bill,” she explains, gesturing vaguely.

“Did she not treat it well? You’ve seemed to be feeling better this week,” Scorpia asks, clearly confused where Catra is going with this. Probably because she doesn’t want to say it.

“No, she took great care of it.” Catra resists the urge to pick at Entrapta’s couch with her claws, instead adding to the collection of small holes along the edge of her t-shirt by twisting it around her fingers and poking her claws through. “Such good care that she keeps coming back to check on it. She’s come back three times, and this last one we both knew was unnecessary. It was healing fine,” Catra explains.

“Do you have concerns for your privacy?” Entrapta asks, her voice unnecessarily loud compared to the rest of the conversation. Catra snorts, her gazed fixed down on her claw tips poking through the dark fabric.

“I mean, maybe, but the ship has sailed on that. She seems nice. The first time I kind of bought that she was just worried because I told her I don’t have health insurance, but then we ended up flirting and she keeps coming back. I don’t know what to think,” Catra explains. Entrapta nods but Scorpia has a strange look on her face in her periphery.

“She has been coming to your apartment to flirt with you? Isn’t that kind of…” Scorpia trails off, apparently too nice to say how douchey it sounds on the surface. Catra trills quietly to herself, a laugh and noise of affection in one. She isn’t even sure if it’s affection for Scorpia or *She-ra*.

“She’s not creepy about it. I started it, anyway, she’s just following my lead. That’s not the part that confuses me,” Catra says. She retracts her claws to admire the holes she has made – it feels good to leave a mark, even one that’s just going to make this shirt fall apart faster – and then slides them back in and extends the small pricks by a millimeter.

“What is it?” Scorpia asks. At least she sounds as confused as Catra is. Catra sighs, tilting her head back and looking at the ceiling.

“I just don’t know why she keeps coming back. She was worried about me at first, sure, but that’s definitely not why she’s doing it anymore. When I asked her about it she just said she

likes talking to me," Catra explains, gesturing vaguely with her mostly-free hand. Scorpia seems hesitant beside her.

"She's not bothering you?" she clarifies. Catra rolls her eyes, but she's smiling.

"No, she isn't. I… like her visits," she admits in a mutter. Her ears pin back and she *refuses* to look up at Scorpia makes a gasp that borders on a coo.

"Then it sounds like she likes her visits too!" Scorpia declares, ready to put her seal of approval on it just like that. Catra releases her shirt so she can curl up more fully, preparing to hide.

"But… why me, you know? She's fun, I'm sure she has plenty of friends in her personal life, not to mention the rest of the Alliance. Even if none of that holds up, she's *She-ra*. Half the city would trip over the chance to talk to her. I called her face dumb last time she was over," Catra points out. She expects some rush of affirmations she doesn't want and won't believe, but instead she gets silence – from Scorpia, at least. Entrapta hums loudly.

"Personal compatibly has little to do with perceived social status or preconceptions about who makes a fitting pair. Regardless of who she has contact with, it's possible she has never met someone like you and that intrigues her. She could also enjoy being called names. Given the weight you give her status as She-ra, it could be no one else has done that due to their own perception of her status," Entrapta muses.

Catra purrs softly to herself, soothing her anxiety around this conversation as much as she is just amused by Entrapta. She has been afraid to talk about this, part of her just waiting for her insecurities to be confirmed or afraid that it will stop the instant she speaks about it like the cosmic joke it clearly is, but she loves her friends and they instantly prove why.

"You've been insulting her?" Scorpia finally says from her left. Catra looks over and feels her fur fluff up at the *knowing* look on Scorpia's face. No, *no*. Sure, she already admitted to flirting, but sometimes she flirts with female customers just for tips – or fun. Juvenile insults are something else, and Scorpia knows her well enough to recognize the forms Catra's affection takes.

"No one has looked at the movie in like, ten minutes," Catra points out hurriedly, fixing her own eyes on the screen.

"Not true! I've been watching this entire time. Is the movie's inclusion in your avoidant talking ritual not to provide a distraction when necessary?" Entrapta replies, voice bright and happy while she's exposing Catra's constipated approach to emotions. True to her word, she's looking at the screen the whole time. Catra can't slink any lower without falling off the couch, but she sulks where she is slouched.

"I'm trying to distract *right now*," she clarifies in a petulant mutter. Entrapta makes a knowing *ahh* from her seat. Scorpia is still being suspiciously quiet. Catra braces herself and glances over. Scorpia still isn't looking at the screen – of course – instead sending Catra one of those soft expressions that still make Catra uncomfortable with their vulnerability

sometimes. She immediately snaps her eyes back to the screen, but she knows that won't deter Scorpia.

"I think Entrapta's right, Wildcat. It doesn't matter who she is: she didn't know *you* already and she recognized someone special when she met you," Scorpia says, her voice dripping with cloying sincerity. Okay, that is *not* what Entrapta said. Entrapta was a lot more realistic about it. Catra isn't someone who can catch someone's attention like that. More likely, She-ra's thirsty just like she is and having enough fun teasing each other to keep it up.

Catra's tail curls around her. She could accept that, maybe even thinks it's the best-case scenario – of the plausible options, not the insane shit Scorpia is saying – but as nice as the attention feels, she doesn't know if it is even genuine.

"Yeah, sure, whatever," Catra mutters back. Scorpia doesn't seem pleased with that answer, but she doesn't immediately launch into another speech. Scorpia settles back and looks to the TV.

Dammit, she's waiting her out. She's gotten better at dealing with Catra's moods over time. Their friendship wouldn't have survived the state Adora left her in otherwise. She was a mess, and in some ways, still is.

It's just so hard to believe a stranger wants her for anything but her body when the girl who loved her for her entire life couldn't even stomach her eventually.

"She called me kitty and I snapped at her," Catra eventually admits after several minutes of action have unfolded on the screen. She has her knees tucked up to her chest, but it's more of a comfort thing than an attempt to hide. Scorpia twitches, not quite startling, but it seems like she got absorbed in the movie enough to startle no matter how many times she has seen it.

"What's wrong with kitty?" she asks. Catra sends her a flat look. Scorpia waves her off. "I know people can be mean, but I assume she wasn't using it like that." Scorpia gasps with horror. "Was she? Is She-ra secretly awful? Oh, no. Wildcat, I know you're lonely, but you shouldn't put up with that," Scorpia rambles. Catra snorts.

"No, she wasn't, she was just joking around," Catra says, trailing off by the end. She's *pretty* sure that it was innocent, but she barely knows She-ra despite how easy it has been to fall into joking with her. She just has a certain warmth Catra had been missing from her life for months. "She's just been really flirty and you know people can be… weird about it," she elaborates eventually, waving her hand vaguely. She doesn't really think She-ra just sees her as some fetish, she would be way grosser if she did, but she's worried.

How did she get invested enough to want She-ra to want *her* and not some fantasy about taming or trailing claws? She's not an idiot, she knows they're just flirting and she's not expecting anything to really come from it, but if She-ra did want to follow through on her talk, is it too clingy to want it to be about *her* and not what she is, or is that just how hook-ups work? She wouldn't know, she never paid attention to that kind of stuff growing up emotionally married to her best friend.

“I think you’re a good judge of people and you wouldn’t have defended her like that if you really thought she only saw you like that,” Scorpia offers. Catra’s ears twitch and she ducks her head.

“Yeah…” Scorpia’s probably right, but that doesn’t stop her insecurity. She clears her throat. “Thanks for listening to me,” she adds, because she’s trying to be better about not being a raging bitch to her friends and she thinks she has gotten as much reasoning out of this conversation as she can given the two very unreasonable people she’s having it with. *She recognized someone special*, her ass.

“Of course! It’s so cool that you’re friends with She-ra now,” Scorpia gushes. Catra can’t fully suppress the smile pulling at her lips as she wriggles in her seat and to get comfortable for movie-watching rather than defending herself from vulnerability.

“Yeah, it’s pretty cool,” she agrees. She doesn’t give half a shit about the fact she’s She-ra – honestly, that’s more likely to make Catra resistant than anything else – but the person She-ra is beneath the glow? That might be cool. She doesn’t know her well enough to say, but she’s willing to look past the unfortunate magic to find out. She’s in too deep to walk away now. She needs to know what She-ra really wants from her.

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The Horde has been quiet ever since the attack on Harbor University – maybe in part due to the rampage Adora went on after she got Catra to safety, making quick work of the squad they sent out – so of course it’s time for them to come crawling out of whatever dark corners they hide in. Adora has been busy with school and trying to convince herself to back off, but just over a week since she last saw Catra, she finds herself back in the Fright Zone with the rest of the Alliance.

Well, most of them. Bow is in class, Frosta is in *high school* – which is worse than just class – and Netossa is working. The rest of them is more than enough to deal with the latest Force Captain terrorizing what appears to be a regular neighborhood block. The Horde probably has beef with someone there, maybe someone who refused to join up or who has been unwittingly getting in their way, but dissecting the Horde’s motivations is beyond her. She’s pretty sure they attack at random just for the hell of it sometimes. Mermista is the one who wants to style herself as a detective and crack the case. Adora just shows up to put a stop to the terrorism.

It doesn’t take too long. Her team is obviously suspicious when Adora dips early saying she wants to spend some time in the city and she’ll get home herself, but none of them can interrogate her with the gathering EMS personnel just barely out of earshot. They definitely don’t suspect the truth anyway, so they reluctantly let her go. They’re actually worryingly close to Catra’s building, so Adora uses a few jumps to make her way there as She-ra, startling a handful of citizens in the process. She arrives at Catra’s doorstep with adrenaline

still buzzing in her blood and beams at her when she answers the door with a wary expression.

“Hey. Can I come in?” Adora asks. She shouldn’t get breathless this easily as She-ra, but she sounds it as she takes in Catra after such a gap. Catra opens her mouth, but her ears pricking forward and then pinning back interrupts what she was going to say. Before Adora can react, Catra reaches out for her arm and yanks her into the apartment. Adora stumbles, barely registering the sound of a door out in the hall opening before Catra slams the door shut and locks it behind her for good measure.

“You’re going to get *caught*,” Catra admonishes, turning on Adora and narrowing her eyes at her. Adora throws her a sheepish smile, barely repressing the urge to rub at the back of her neck self-consciously. Too recognizable.

“Sorry, I always check there isn’t anyone around first, but I can’t really do anything about people leaving,” Adora admits. Catra has been clear about worrying her visits will bring trouble and Adora can’t blame her. Catra would be screwed if the Horde decided to kidnap her for information or something. She doesn’t know *anything*, much less that she could easily call She-ra for help if she just dialed the number that she seems to have done her best to forget.

Catra hisses an admonishment at her and stalks away, hopping up on her counter and scowling down at her feet. At least she seems to be walking normally, now. The tail sock is gone too, though her fur hasn’t regrown at all around the burn.

“I haven’t seen you in a week. I can take care of myself, but only when someone else doesn’t fuck it up for me first. I could have been dead a hundred times over if anyone had caught you leaving before. *Careful* doesn’t cut it,” Catra bites back. Adora winces. Catra is right, but Adora doesn’t know what she can do other than stay away. She really doesn’t want to do that, and before this moment, she didn’t think Catra wanted her too either, but her expression is dark as she glares down at the floor.

“I’m sorry. You’re right. I wanted to see you, not endanger you, but it’s hard for me to guarantee that,” Adora says. Catra scoffs, seeming unmoved, and turns her head to look out the window. Adora’s heart sinks. Catra is clearly unhappy with her and she doesn’t know how to fix it. Maybe staying away for a week was a mistake, but then again, maybe ever coming back was.

“Think you can jump on the roof without shaking the whole building?” Catra asks. Adora pauses in the middle of her spiral.

“What?” she questions. Catra remains facing the window, but she slides her gaze over to Adora and sends her the *you’re being an idiot* look. Adora doesn’t know how the hell she’s supposed to intuit what Catra means, but she decides to play along. “Probably. Magic cushions my jumps. Otherwise I would leave craters everywhere I go. Actually, I still do that sometimes, but the building isn’t that tall. Whoever is top floor would probably be annoyed by a thud, but I think that would be about it, especially if I jumped from the shorter building next door,” Adora decides. Catra sniffs and looks back to the window.

“We’re not allowed on the roof, but there’s a door up there and I have a general disrespect for authority,” Catra says, still ostensibly looking out the window, but Adora can tell she is watching her reaction out of the corner of her eye. Adora snorts. Yeah, she didn’t need to be told that, but Catra was probably testing She-ra. A smile twitches at the corner of Catra’s mouth. “We could meet up there. If someone sees you coming, they at least won’t know it’s me that you’re meeting up there,” Catra offers.

Adora pauses, blinking at her. It’s actually a solid plan, if they fill in some of flaws.

“Are you sure that’s not going to cause you trouble?” she asks. Catra rolls her eyes, her tail beginning to flick lazily.

“I’ve been sneaking up there when I need some air for months. No one has ever noticed. I’m a lot less worried about me getting caught than you,” Catra returns. Yeah, okay, that’s fair. Adora frowns, thinking, and then crosses over to the window that Catra has been pretending is interesting. There’s a wide alley between the window and the building next door. Its roof is half a floor up from Catra’s window, just barely blocking her view. Adora has never counted how many stories Catra’s building is, but it should be easy for She-ra to jump next door and then onto her roof without causing more than some thudding. If she turns her sword into a grapple, it will be even quieter.

“I can make visual flares with my sword. I could send one to your window when I come over and if you come wave back then I’ll know to meet you on the roof?” Adora proposes, turning around and hoping she doesn’t seem too eager. Catra was the one who brought this up, she reminds herself. No matter how closed off she seems, she’s offering a way for Adora to meet her. Adora’s words open her up, too. The tension in her shoulders eases and she lounges back on the counter.

She looks so good like this, so beautiful at ease under the kitchen light. Adora wants to cross the room, crowd her in, and kiss her.

Even for the brief week between Adora’s stumbling confession and their first date, Adora wasn’t allowed to do that, and now she’s *definitely* not allowed to as a half-stranger.

“What kind of superpower is sparkles?” Catra drawls, watching Adora as she snaps out of her reverie and huffs. That wasn’t a *yes*, but it wasn’t a *no*, and with how much Catra likes to say that word even when it doesn’t apply, a lack of rejection is probably agreement.

“Don’t let Moonstone hear you say that, but that’s not what I meant by flares,” Adora returns, reaching her hand out and pulling on the connection in her heart that calls out her runestone. With this much practice, it comes to her with ease, the sword materializing in her hand. Truth be told, she thinks her weapon could default to any form she wanted, but when she found the runestone it had been caged in a sword hilt for so long that it still feels like its natural form.

Adora points her sword towards the other end of the apartment, noticing the way Catra’s hands tighten on the edge of the counter, but Adora aims closer to the living room than to her, and the flares are harmless anyway. She pulls on the invisible threads of magic in her mind until they solidify into real threads of gold, wrapping around the sword and shooting along its blade to fire from its tip. The ball of magic fires across the room and bursts like a mini-

firework, leaving a shimmering impression of the sword hanging in the air a few feet above Catra's living room floor.

Adora looks to Catra, already grinning with excitement. Her smile only widens when she sees the awed look on Catra's face, her pupils round as she watches the sword glitter, the threads of magic twisted like line art. Adora realizes her tail is twitching and Catra isn't looking away, transfixed the same way she sometimes gets with Winterfest lights. It's so cute Adora wants to coo, and given how her innocent *kitty* comment went, she doesn't think that would be a good idea.

"I use it to signal the Alliance when we get separated and checking our trackers isn't practical," Adora explains. Catra flicks her tail in her direction. Probably. She is just kind of flicking it in general, but Adora is pretty sure that was the most acknowledgement she's getting while Catra is still watching the lights. Adora isn't exactly *maintaining* them, but a soft push is all it takes to make the flare dissolve into winking lights, like fireflies taking off.

Catra leans forward, slightly, watching avidly until the lights die out and she's left staring at her living room. Adora barely holds her tongue as Catra blinks – cutely, Adora might add – seemingly clearing her vision and then looking over at Adora.

"Trackers?" Catra asks. She sounds like she's catching her bearings again. Adora resists the urge to bite her lip. It won't actually help her hold in her laugh and Catra might recognize the movement. Instead, she reaches up and pulls out the small comm tucked into her ear. Catra blinks at it.

"It's off, right now, but these are how we communicate when we're out. They all have a tracker in them so Moonstone can come get us wherever we are," Adora explains. The comms aren't exactly a secret – they're visible even if they don't stick out much and it isn't hard to guess what they're for – but the others wouldn't like her sharing this much information. They wouldn't like her talking to Catra at all though, so they're obviously wrong.

"What, you're GPS tagged like an endangered shark?" she asks. Adora raises a brow at her as she puts the earbud back in, careful not to turn it on and immediately flag her location in the process.

"A shark?" she questions. It seems like an odd comparison. Catra's ears pin back and she looks away, gazing vaguely at the air where the flare once hung.

"My friend likes to watch shark week and correct all their inaccuracies," she mutters. If that was all it was, she wouldn't be embarrassed by it. Adora grins as she lets the sword – the real one – go, releasing the magic into the air and freeing her hands.

"And you just like to watch it," she finishes for Catra. Catra's ears pin tighter and her tail curls tightly around her knees like it does for all totally unbothered people.

"I like watching Scorpia *cry* when our spicy chip 'drinking game' brings her to her knees before we've even gotten through the first special," Catra shoots back with a glare. It's definitely a dare to challenge her, but to Adora it only means to push more. Adora sat down

and made her list of things she's allowed to know since they last spoke, though, and hearing a name immediately reminds her of it. She knows what Catra means, but She-ra doesn't.

"Scorpia?" she asks, finally moving back towards the kitchen so she can be closer to Catra as they talk. She's going to miss having these conversations in her space, but as long as they continue, that's enough.

"Oh, yeah. She's my best friend and her heat tolerance is *okay*, but nothing can hold up to Entrapta gushing about her special interest from elementary school, so she's usually suffering before we get very far. If we did a real drinking game, she would be *dead* by then though, so we just eat a ghost pepper chip for each inaccuracy Entrapta spots," Catra explains, waving her hand vaguely.

Adora can't help but smile. It seems like fun, and the confirmation that Scorpia is still in the *friend* category doesn't hurt her mood either. Catra befriended her at their university transfer orientation and Adora only met her once, but she got *vibes* from her. Then the *best friend* part registers and Adora remembers that title has passed to someone else.

"And you're totally cool and collected, I assume?" Adora asks, her voice thankfully coming across as teasing, no hint of emotion showing through. Catra rolls her eyes.

"There's no one on the planet that could be calm and collected playing with the rules we do. That's not weakness, it's a biological impossibility. I don't start crying into milk, though," Catra returns. Adora's smile returns, her happiness fizzling like bubbles as she looks at the woman before her.

She's falling in love all over again in a small kitchen, wearing a mask and always wanting things she can't have.

"It sounds like a lot of fun," she says, a voice or two missing from her own and softening the delivery. The words fluster Catra, but it's true. Adora didn't know about what is clearly shaping up to be a tradition for them, but they broke apart before Shark Week last year and Catra's friendship with the other two had only started the semester before, so it isn't a surprise.

"It is. Especially when Entrapta gets so frustrated with the supposed 'experts' that her robots come over to comfort her and the microwave starts beeping," Catra returns, smiling despite the shy blush on her cheeks. It surprises Adora to see her agree instead of wrapping herself in another layer of denial, but the words grab her attention.

"Robots?" she asks, because that part is truly new to her. She vaguely remembers Catra mentioning she had been hanging out with Scorpia's friend Entrapta near the end there, but she never said much about her.

"Oh, yeah, she's programmer and stuff. She's got this big robot she named Emily and I'm pretty sure she's going to build the world's most intense smart house as soon as she has, you know, a house," Catra says, waving vaguely. Her hand pauses before it falls back to the counter. "Actually, I kind of wanted to talk to you about that. She does a lot of parts

scrounging and she has noticed the city getting sloppy with cleaning up Horde tech," Catra adds, eyeing her.

"That's… not good." Catra snorts, which is fair, but Adora doesn't really have many more thoughts on it than that. "The Alliance doesn't exactly have contacts in the city, they barely tolerate our existence outside the system, but I can mention something the next time EMS shows up and hopefully they'll take it seriously," Adora adds. To her surprise, the corner of Catra's mouth curls up and she seems to relax.

"Oh, good. I would hate to have to kick you out for being a glorified cop," Catra quips back. Adora rolls her eyes.

"Please, if the police knew everything about us, they would hate us," she returns. Catra raises a brow at her and Adora realizes what she said. "Not that we're doing anything bad! It's just, you know, stuff like our comm system. It isn't hurting anyone, just probably not following any kind of regulations. And some of us are young. That kind of stuff," Adora hurries to assure. *She* knows Catra wouldn't have a problem with what the Alliance does, but Catra might not trust She-ra like that. Catra snorts at her rambling, eyeing her.

"Young, huh? I'm not cradle robbing, am I?" she asks, her words languid and teasing, but Adora would bet she's buying herself time to decide if she believes her or not. Adora rolls her eyes.

"As I recall, you haven't stolen anything yet," she returns, voice a little lower because it feels wrong to imply something so directly. A slow smirk pulls at Catra's lips and her eyes drag down Adora's body. Adora finds herself standing straighter, maybe flexing a little unnecessarily as Catra's eyes finally make their way back up to Adora's own.

"I like to take my time – make sure it's worth it in case I get caught," she returns, that smile still holding Adora at attention. The words drip with promise, exciting Adora more than any other comment that has passed between them. It's as close to a declaration of intent as Adora is ever going to get from Catra. These teases might actually be building to something.

Something Adora can't have, but *fuck* does she want it. She doesn't know how not to chase it, barely restraining herself from letting Catra's smile pull her in closer. She has had a lot of practice pushing down her responses to Catra over the years of convincing herself not to ruin their friendship with her crush, though.

"Anyone worth it knows how to wait," she responds, her voice soft. She hopes that's diplomatic and encouraging enough. She doesn't want to reject Catra – she doesn't know if she *can* – but she knows this is a bad idea. It seems to work for Catra, though, because her mood doesn't take a downturn as she roams her eyes over Adora.

"I bet I'm older than you," she decides, easing off the dangerous topic and going back to their conversation. Adora suppresses an affronted noise. Catra is three months older and she has never let Adora forget it. She doesn't want that to start up again with *She-ra*.

"I don't know how old you are," she responds. There, it's *impossible* for either of them to say.

Catra smirks.

“Twenty-two,” she tells her. Adora rolls her eyes. Yeah, so is she, that doesn’t tell them anything.

“I’m not telling you how old I am,” doesn’t seem to deter Catra at all.

“I bet you’re like twenty,” she decides, voice sing-songy. Adora makes an affronted noise before she can stop herself this time. Yes, Catra is older, but she isn’t letting her widen the gap. She-ra doesn’t look young, she doesn’t think, but maybe Catra is betting on She-ra aging her up.

“Please, I can buy my own alcohol. But that’s all you’re getting,” she returns, voice stern. Catra lets out a small, amused purr and any scolding Adora had prepared vanishes. She barely stops herself from stepping forward and putting her hand on Catra’s chest to feel the vibration directly. As She-ra, Catra would probably be more understanding of her feeling her up.

“I’ll figure it out. You’re not as subtle as you think,” Catra declares.

She’s actually a lot subtler than Catra has decided given that she isn’t onto her yet, but Adora isn’t about to tell her that.

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Catra makes it a policy not to be honest with herself, much less anyone else, but even she can admit her paranoia about being seen was only part of why she was sulking when She-ra finally turned up again.

The gap between visits was twice as long as any of her previous. Catra *thought* her fear that telling her friends would ruin everything was irrational, but the longer it took for She-ra to return, the more real it seemed. She-ra doesn’t try to explain her absence and Catra isn’t about to be clingy and ask. She-ra plans to come back, at least. She works with Catra to figure out logistics and it makes Catra feel better about where this is going. She-ra hangs out for a while, teasing and joking with Catra, before she eventually sighs and says she should get back. She pauses as she’s about to leave, glancing around the apartment.

“Want me to go out the window?” she asks. Catra stares at her and She-ra smiles. “So I don’t get caught out in the hall. The drop is nothing to me,” she explains, crossing over to the window and looking down. Catra is still processing She-ra volunteering to jump out a window for her when She-ra looks back to her. It takes her a second to convince her brain it will be fine.

“Alright, fuck it, sure,” she decides, hopping off the counter she has been lounging on to bring them a little closer together in height. She crosses over to the window, maturely

elbowing She-ra out of the way. The movement is light because she doesn't want to shatter her elbow on whatever She-ra is made out of – it certainly isn't regular muscle with the things she does– but She-ra still backs off with a chuckle and lets Catra open the window, sticking her head out and looking around.

No one within eyeshot. She steps back and gestures towards the window. She-ra will fit through it, but there isn't a lot of room to spare around her as she steps up to it. She braces herself on the window frame and then swings her legs through, sitting on the sill. Even knowing she'll be fine, Catra's stomach twists as She-ra glances back, throwing her a smirk before she pushes off and drops like a rock. Catra hurries to the window, her heartrate racing as she grabs the sill and leans her head out, looking down.

She-ra is in the process of standing from the crouch she landed in, right in the middle of the alley. She tilts her head up and gives Catra a cheeky salute, looking up at her for a long moment as the jolt of adrenaline slowly fades and Catra's heartrate calms.

"I'll see you next time I'm in the Fright Zone," She-ra promises, not bothering to call it up to her. Catra can make it out without help. She doubts the same could be said for She-ra, so she doesn't respond verbally, nodding and offering She-ra a wave she feels awkward for, but it seems to be enough. She-ra nods and turns away, taking a few steps before *jumping*.

Catra whips her head to follow her as She-ra clears the street, landing on the opposite sidewalk. She jumps again and disappears behind the next row of buildings. A moment later, Catra thinks she sees her head just barely pop up above the roof as she jumps another row, but then she stares into the skyline for several long moments and doesn't see anything again. Slowly, she leans back from the window and closes it.

When they're just joking and flirting in her kitchen, even with all the power that fills any room She-ra walks in, it's not too hard to push the whole *goddess* thing aside; then she sees She-ra flex her power and she remembers she isn't a typical magic-user like Entrapta. Her powers certainly aren't limited to a small set of abilities or spells. She's probably not invincible, but she's close.

She's also – probably – twenty-one. Somewhere around Catra's age, anyway, and a bit of a dork if the way she flirts is any indication. She's cocky until she isn't and Catra declaring her intent to pursue her left her seemingly shy. It's so strange, so different from how Catra always pictured her as a person when she gave her the curtesy of assuming there was one under all the glow.

Catra can't believe she has someone like this sneaking out her *window*. How did she end up here – and how does she make sure She-ra doesn't leave like Adora did?

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It’s dark, and cold, and lonely. They’ve always been surrounded by the crowds of people moving through the city. Down here in the dark, the only sign of life is the distant rumbling of trains that sometimes pass somewhere in the distance. Everything echoes in the cavernous room where they’ve been caged.

An entire life spent hiding, but what they could conceal from prying eyes they couldn’t conceal from magic. There’s no telling when their jailer will be back, just that no one will hear their cries from the underground.

Chapter End Notes

Entrapta is a technopath because… well you’ll see. In this world magic often manifests as specific power, but some people have a shallow access to magic in general and can channel it only through crafted spells (sorcerers/sorceresses).
The lightshow thing with her sword is whatever the fuck she did in Erelandia to project that symbol above the town. Magic lights is just on her list of powers, okay, She-ra doesn’t have limits.

Chapter 5: Rooftop

Chapter Notes

> This fic is named after an 8tracks playlist from 2014, but the name does have meaning outside of that. Have fun with that one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She-ra mentioned that she would see Catra the next time she was in the Fright Zone. Catra puts together her long absence with the lack of Horde activity and realizes she – probably – only drops by when it's convenient to. It makes sense if she doesn't live in the city, though it makes her feel a little less special. As soon as she feels the disappointment she hunts it down and tries to kill it with logic – She-ra is already going out of her way to visit her in a city where she apparently doesn't even live – but even if the nagging voice in the back of her mind wants to insist otherwise, she already decided she was going to be casual about whatever this thing with She-ra ends up being.

With her infrequent visits, She-ra doesn't take up a lot of her time, but wondering about her kind of does and Catra has a lot of work to do for her final semester. She relegates thoughts of She-ra to work hours, when she's either bored waiting for customers or dealing with them and in need of a distraction from the latest entitled asshole. The only problem with that is that a good half of her thoughts about She-ra aren't particularly PG. Catra prides herself on her ability to keep a straight face, but her tail isn't always as cooperative. She can't do anything about her scent signals either, so she mostly has to try to censor herself or hope that no one with increased senses comes in.

She doesn't think she can be blamed when She-ra looks like *that* and flirts so openly. Catra isn't sure if that's just how she is, but she is becoming increasingly convinced that She-ra's teasing offers are serious. Serious about sex and nothing more, probably – maybe she doesn't want even that much, Catra will take a make out on the roof – but she has a feeling She-ra is the type to follow through. She comes back, after all, startling Catra with a flare at her window when she's in the middle of studying. She heard a lot of sirens earlier, but she wasn't really paying attention. It's the Fright Zone. Sirens happen. Apparently the Horde was up to something.

Seeing She-ra smiling brightly from where she's half-crouched on the adjacent roof – a position that shows off her thighs – is a bizarre feeling, but Catra waves at her and She-ra waves back with seeming excitement before fixing her gaze up. One powerful jump and she vanishes from sight. Catra hurries to make her way up to the meeting point. It has been a week and a half since she saw She-ra and she was starting to worry again. Her irrational impulses are soothed as she climbs her way to the roof. This is just how it's going to be now and she is fine with that, knowing what to expect. She just needed another visit to convince herself they were still happening.

“What’s it like being a superhero? How’d that even happen? It doesn’t seem like it’s easy to pin down the Alliance and hand them your recruitment form,” Catra asks in a lull between She-ra’s pestering questions. Not that Catra minds talking about her classes and why she decided to become a lawyer, but it feels a bit too much like *first date* type questions, and that’s a dangerous rabbit hole to go down. She wants to get to know She-ra’s personality and that’s about it. Just enough to flirt for some fun and to decide if she trusts her for *more* fun. Anything more isn’t possible outside of brief delusions, and Catra prefers to keep those isolated to her bed.

“It’s… complicated,” She-ra offers, looking out at the darkened skyline. It’s not fair she’s so much taller. All she has to do is look straight ahead and suddenly they not only aren’t meeting eyes, Catra isn’t even at eye *level*.

“I’m not looking for more than the short version,” Catra replies, shrugging. She has told She-ra a lot about herself – surface level shit, yes, but even that is a big ask when it comes to Catra, she doesn’t like to give out so much as her LinkedIn information – and it seems fair that She-ra answer the kind of question Catra would expect a reporter to ask when they try to flag the Alliance down after a battle. She-ra seems to think for a moment.

“I don’t think I can tell you anything about how it happened, but long story short, the Alliance invited me in as soon as I learned how to use my powers,” She-ra explains. Catra nods. That’s all she was really expecting on that front. She-ra is clearly still thinking.

“As for what it’s like… Also complicated. It’s amazing, a lot of the time. I grew up watching the Horde terrorize the city and finally being able to fight back is incredible. I like being able to make a difference. It’s an adrenaline rush to fight and a relief just to be able to help when we’re dealing with a natural disaster. Stuff like that subway station collapse last winter. I didn’t go home from that feeling good, but the only way I slept that night was by counting the people I managed to pull out from the wreckage,” She-ra explains.

Catra swallows, her tail flicking as she nods. She remembers that collapse. She and Adora were supposed to meet up that day, but the entire public transit system was thrown off and Adora never made it over. Catra called her like twenty times before she even answered, apparently glued to the TV screen watching the whole thing and worrying.

Catra is so selfish. Here She-ra is talking about saving people – there Adora was worrying about them – and the first thing Catra thinks about is how the disaster affected her personally.

“I don’t know, disasters like that are hard. You see all the people you couldn’t save right next to the ones you could. It’s easier to just fight egotistic supervillains. I like problems I can punch,” She-ra settles on, shrugging. Catra purrs a quiet, soothing laugh to herself. She-ra gasps and Catra quickly looks away, ignoring her own twitching tail and ears.

“You know, I always thought superheroes were just jocks, but somehow I assumed She-ra would be the exception to that,” Catra teases, a good distraction if the smile playing at She-ra’s lips is any indication.

“Disappointed?” She-ra asks. Catra tilts her chin back, meeting She-ra’s gaze head-on.

“No. You’d be so insufferable if you were some all-knowing goddess convinced of her own self-importance. Punching the bad guys works just fine,” she returns. Truthfully, that’s about a third of why she didn’t trust the Alliance. They seemed like they would either be irresponsible with their power or convinced that they were the only ones who knew best. Maybe the rest of the Alliance is like that, she can’t really say, but She-ra seems okay.

She-ra shakes her head, seeming good natured at first, but slowly her smile fades.

“No… I feel like I barely know anything, to be honest. The rest of the Alliance all knew they were going to inherit their powers and could train even before they got them. I got thrown in the deep end with all of this. I don’t have anyone to teach me since there hasn’t been a She-ra in so long. I’m still learning my magic, much less balancing my duty with having a life,” She-ra explains. Her voice is quiet, a few layers dropped away from it, and it’s heavy with emotion.

Her face is tilted down, like her gaze is fixed on her feet, and Catra watches as the glow of her eyes dims. In battle, her entire body glowed subtly, but normally when they’re just talking her eyes still beam blue. Now the glow is dull, like a dying flame. Catra swallows, her hand twitching at her side, but she’s unsure how to reach out. She doesn’t comfort people a lot.

She-ra feels like she’s *not enough*. That’s a feeling Catra knows well, one she never expected someone like this to share with her.

“Hey, it doesn’t matter what you think you ‘don’t know,’ you’re doing more than anyone else ever has. I mean, Shadow Weaver terrorized this city for, what, twenty years? And then you took her down in one afternoon,” Catra says, settling for lightly nudging She-ra. Affectionate elbowing is a language she understands – a soft, comforting hand is not.

She-ra glances up and Catra feels her breath hitch when their eyes meet. *Meet*, because she can make out crystal blue eyes beneath the glow. Just barely, and they certainly aren’t natural in their size or color, but she can see the shadows of She-ra’s eyelids through the blue haze and how the outer corners are tight and turned down. Catra’s heart races and she can’t tell if it’s the familiar magic shivering through her or something even more dangerous.

“She got away, though. I broke her power conduit, but she could come back if she found another. She’s loose on the city right now, probably being a horrible person in her day-to-day life,” She-ra says, what little of her expression that Catra can see pained. The strongest of her voices, what Catra assumes is her own, is quietly controlled, but the undercurrent is rough from emotions she can’t hide.

Catra doesn’t know how to be soft and comforting, so she rolls her eyes and scoffs.

“You took away her ability to do more than yell at service workers, and if that’s a crime you’re punishing now, I work customer service and I can give you a *list*. Without her powers, any cop can handle her if she tries breaking the law again. She’s not your problem anymore,” Catra returns. She-ra gives a wet snort and tilts her head up to the sky. Catra thinks she might close her eyes, but she’s too tall for Catra to see them. The blue glow coming from them dims considerably, though.

She-ra tilts her head back down, definitely opening her eyes, and their gazes meet again. The light is brighter again, like there's more life in her, and it makes it harder to see her expression, but Catra still relaxes some.

"Thanks. I think it's probably an abuse of power if I take that list, though. Favoritism, if nothing else," she says, her tone soft. Her voice isn't isolated – Catra isn't sure it ever could be – but there are fewer layers to it. Catra sends her a smirk she almost feels.

"What's the point of all this power if you don't use it to act as a hero to those *really* in need: our city's poor, overworked baristas?" Catra jokes. It's actually nice to hear She-ra say that when it comes to Catra's general distrust of magic-users, but the fantasy of siccing She-ra on a rude customer is a nice one. She-ra laughs, the tones even and bright again, just like her eyes which have disappeared beneath blue glow.

"Tell me about your job. Maybe you do have a supervillain hiding in your customers," She-ra requests. She's clearly looking for a distraction and Catra doesn't mind giving it to her. Her job isn't exactly exciting, but She-ra seems to at least get a kick out of Catra complaining about how cutesy her uniform apron is.

In all the times she snidely thought about what annoying show-offs the city's heroes were, she never thought about how hard it must be to take the weight of the entire city's safety on their shoulders. It was easier to think they just showed up, flexed their power for kicks, and then went back to their normal lives thinking they were stronger than everybody else. That clearly isn't the case with She-ra.

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Catra had a stressful day. She has an easy way to deal with stress without needing to rely on anyone else outside of memory form, even if it's crass. It's not like She-ra will ever know the thoughts in her head – at least until she randomly gains telepathy as one of her powers – and it's nice to think about someone other than Adora when she does this now. For months, even when she was mad, she still defaulted to thinking about someone who didn't even *want* her.

She-ra is at least interested enough to be physically present in her life, and she had to go and be all *sensitive* and shit. Catra swears that isn't a thing for her, but it did make her trust her more. Trust goes a long way – it goes from *fantasy* to maybe something she would like to make *reality*. She-ra has largely seemed confident of herself, and that could easily translate to secretly being a self-centered asshole. Knowing otherwise makes it so easy to picture She-ra with her when she collapses in bed after class, squirming and getting comfortable as she sheds her layers and imagines She-ra tugging them off for her.

Until now, her fantasies about She-ra have been abstract. They were enough to get her off, but they didn't have the same satisfaction as her old fantasies of Adora. With Adora, she trusted her to give her what she needed and care about how she felt during it if by some miracle something ever did happen between them. Now she feels a bit safer with She-ra –

now she can picture her *eyes* softly glowing as she picks Catra up and pins her against the wall – Catra can just lose herself in excitement and fantasy.

She imagines sex with She-ra would be rough given all the strength at her disposal, and that excites her. Something base, instinctual, to satisfy the itch beneath Catra's fur without having to get into all those gross emotions that only ever betrayed her. It would just be exciting, strong hands on her and that warm aura that follows She-ra only making Catra feel even hotter, until she's burning from the inside out.

She whines quietly to herself, imagining scrabbling her claws down She-ra's back with no need to worry about hurting her invulnerable skin. She loses herself picturing the exchange, give and take, hot and panting until her mind is a bit too fuzzy to do much more than gasp, "*Princess*," to herself as her pleasure finally whites out.

In the comedown, her heart and endorphins pounding through her, she looks back at what she pictured. She is used to questioning herself, feeling bad about who she just pictured with her when that door closed a long time ago. This time, she knows that she wants it to become a reality.

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"Not that I don't love talking to you, princess, but it's going to have to be short. Midterms are kicking my ass," Catra greets as she shoves open the rooftop door. She was sprawled out on the couch in a halo of notes when She-ra's light at the window caught her eye. To her surprise, She-ra groans and tilts her head back.

"Ugh, tell me about it. I have so much more I need to study but my friends basically forced me to take a break. It's one of those weeks where I get serious about dropping out," She-ra complains. Catra's tail swings in arcs, surprised by the admittance. Well, it's nice to know She-ra isn't also a perfect student. That would be unfair. Catra suspected she was around her age, but that didn't necessarily mean she was in school, and she wasn't expecting She-ra to tell her that either way.

"Hey, next week will be baby mode, right? We just have to survive this one," Catra returns, swatting She-ra with her tail playfully. She-ra laughs, but she shakes her head.

"Easy for you to say. We'll see if you feel the same next year," She-ra says. Catra's ears flick forward.

"Grad student, huh?" she asks, not because she *cares* or anything, she's just pretty sure that's what She-ra is implying. She might even be implying she's in law specifically. She did mention it being hard, before, but she said it in such a theoretical way that Catra thought she was just assuming. Now she can't help but wonder if that was her trying to seem uninformed. She-ra freezes.

“I’m not at liberty to say,” she says, clearly trying to seem neutral, but there’s anxiety in the undercurrent beneath her voice. Catra frowns.

“Relax, princess, I’m not trying to deduce your identity, just commiserate. I really don’t care who you are,” Catra assures, her tone a little belittling, but it must get the point across because She-ra unfreezes and turns her head to focus on Catra’s face, looking at her long and considering.

“No?” she asks, very little tone in her voice, emotional or even questioning. Catra shrugs.

“No,” she affirms. “Why should I? Are people set on unmasking you or something?” she returns, flippant in her tone. She’s only downplaying how she feels in the sense that she actively cares about *not* finding out She-ra’s identity. What they have right now works. She likes the distance of a mask. There’s no reason for either of them to get too invested knowing this secretive layer is between them, so they can just focus on having fun. She thought She-ra was out of her league to start, but at least she’s out of *anyone’s* league and basically in her own special category. She doesn’t want to know where the person beneath the mask falls.

“I mean, kind of? There’s a reason the princesses decided to start keeping their identities secret, but I just thought… I don’t know, you aren’t curious?” she asks. With her eyes glowing as bright as usual, Catra can’t read her expression, but her voice quality is weird, almost hopeful. Maybe she’s just trying to get Catra to let her guard down.

“No. It’s not like you’re ever going to tell me either way, and clearly I don’t need to know to talk to you,” she returns. She thinks She-ra’s expression would have been unreadable to her a few visits ago, but now she sees a frown pulling at the edge of She-ra’s mouth. She thought She-ra would be *happy* that she didn’t want to know. She doesn’t want anything more from her than what she’s willing to give.

“Why do you care?” Catra questions, not quite distrustful, but *something*. Confused, if nothing else. It would only make things more complicated if Catra was yearning to know more, so all she can think is that She-ra likes the idea of Catra wanting her like that. Catra understands the desire to be wanted even when its destructive, but just because she would be a hypocrite to blame She-ra doesn’t stop it from being mean.

“I don’t, really, it’s just… hard to navigate having two lives. Our identities have to be secret – if not for us, then for the next runestone holder that might inherit an easily-outed identity – and it makes it hard to maintain relationships.” She-ra pauses, and her voice drops lower, layers falling away, “I disappoint people a lot. I have to drop my regular life the moment the city needs me, no matter how important something is to me. It’s hard to lie to people you love,” she admits, voice trailing off as she looks towards the skyline.

Oh. Okay, maybe Catra finally understands why She-ra keeps coming back to her. She has to hide She-ra from others. It might be a relief to instead be hiding *herself* when it comes to Catra. Maybe She-ra is worried about disappointing her in the opposite way than she does people in her daily life, but Catra knows what to expect on that front.

“I never thought about what the secret identity thing must be like,” Catra admits. It feels more appropriate to say than just *that sucks*. She peeks at She-ra, trying to read her

expression, but she seems largely blank beneath the mask. “Does the rest of the Alliance help, at least? They must have the same problem,” she asks. She isn’t built to comfort. They might be. She’s glad She-ra told her, though. Not knowing why She-ra would even want to talk to her has made it difficult to fight her insecurities.

“Some. My situation is more complicated, though,” she admits. It’s vague, but she has already told Catra a lot tonight. Catra nods, knowing when to back down. She can’t help but wonder, though.

“Do you think we would be friends if we met each other in our regular lives?” Catra asks before the realization hits her and her ears pin back. She doesn’t know if they are even friends *now*. She-ra doesn’t shift awkwardly like she’s trying to figure out how to let her down, though. She just looks at Catra for a long moment.

“Yeah, I think we would,” she finally offers, her voice soft.

Alright, that just isn’t fair. At least when She-ra normally makes her fur hot it’s because she just turned her on. Catra doesn’t know *what* this is, but it’s nothing deserving this reaction.

She thinks she might still be turned on, though. Apparently affirmation does it for her.

Gross.

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Catra can’t help but wonder if the Horde has enough younger members that they were also busy with finals, because she hears sirens multiple times over the weekend. A glance at the TV shows a laser light show taking place on the evening news. Catra can’t even blame them if they’re celebrating tests being over by blowing something up, it would just be nice if that *thing* wasn’t the leisure ferry across the bay. She-ra turns up again on Sunday night, apparently too busy dealing with the explosive weekend to stop by earlier. She seems lighter than she was for the last visit, though – from the adrenaline rush, probably.

“What’s with your hair?” Catra asks as she hops up on the retaining wall around the rooftop electrical unit. It’s probably a dangerous place to be, but she doesn’t feel like standing around and it brings them closer to the same eye level. She-ra pauses, cocking her head at Catra.

“What do you mean?” she asks, her words measured. Catra rolls her eyes. She isn’t trying to *insult* her or anything.

“It moves on its own,” she points out, gesturing at She-ra’s ponytail. It’s still for the moment, but it *wasn’t* back when the Horde attacked the university. She-ra’s mouth forms a silent *o*.

“That’s not my hair. The magic just kind of generates movement around me. It affects my skirt too, sometimes even people standing close. It only happens when I’m channeling a lot at once,” she explains. That’s not much of an explanation considering Catra didn’t feel a magic

wind when She-ra was carrying her, but whatever, she doubts She-ra is going to give her a better answer. Maybe that made perfect sense if you know more about magic than Catra ever wants to.

This is why she made it a policy to avoid superhero stuff until She-ra had to be all hot and caring and shit.

“It’s the texture too. It looks like hair when it’s underwater,” Catra points out. She-ra pauses, glancing back over her shoulder before realizing that causes her ponytail to also move, staying behind her head. She sighs and reaches back as Catra snickers, pulling her ponytail over her shoulder to glance down at it. Catra watches it spill down over her chest.

She-ra would look good with nothing to cover her but her hair.

“It just always looks like this when I transform,” She-ra decides, with a shrug. She glances up, but it takes Catra a minute to wander her eyes back up to She-ra’s face so they can meet eyes. She-ra has a slight smirk when she does so. “You want to touch it?” she asks, her tone making it clear she thinks the answer is yes. Catra hisses at her before remembering that She-ra doesn’t seem to have spent a lot of time with hybrids and might read too much into that, like finding it rude or thinking it means she’s *right*.

“No thanks, I hate water,” Catra says, curling her lip with disdain to drive it home. Sure, that’s probably not what She-ra’s hair actually feels like and Catra *is* kind of curious, but she’s not breaking that easily.

“Uh huh. Your pupils are blown out,” She-ra responds. This time it’s genuine when Catra hisses, her tail lashing and ears pinning back. Yeah, that has nothing to do with She-ra’s *hair*, but sure, she’ll let her think that.

“Fine. Can I?” she scoffs, too flustered to come up with any other excuse. She-ra grins, stepping closer until she can lean her hip against the wall. She looms over Catra, who considers hastily sitting up to gain a little more height over the way she’s languishing, but She-ra might consider that a personal victory, and she’s definitely not giving her that.

“Sure. Do I get a turn too?” She-ra asks. Catra feels her body heat at the idea of She-ra’s hands in her hair, or worse, *on her ears*.

She sits up hastily.

“You already touch me a lot. This is just making it even,” she returns, reaching out and running her fingertips down the gold draping over She-ra’s shoulder. Once again, it reminds her of water, not because it actually feels wet but because it is soft like her mane used to be beneath her fingers when she washed it out. “Huh.” Even though it feels exactly like she thought it looked, it still surprises her. She has never felt this kind of softness dry before.

“I touch you a lot?” She-ra asks. Catra glances up to find She-ra’s face way too close, a shiver running through her as their eyes meet. Her ears pin back and her tail waves slowly. Okay, She-ra doesn’t actually touch her that often, but when their relationship started with

She-ra checking over her injuries, there was a lot of vulnerable contact very quickly. Catra doesn't usually let people touch her at *all*.

"It's obvious you're one of those *touchy-feely* types, but by my standards, yes, you do," Catra says. Slowly, a smile begins to spread over She-ra's face. Absolutely not. Catra can't be blamed for what she will do if She-ra tries to make a joke about what Catra can touch and feel when she's already this close. "Fine, but be careful of my ears. I'll scratch you if you pull on anything," Catra distracts, telling herself it can't be worse than Scorpia's random hugs. She-ra's smile only spreads wider, but she presses her lips together and hums, politely not saying anything as she reaches up.

It has been so long since Catra has been pet. She doesn't know what she was expecting, but She-ra's touch is light, smoothing over her hair and stroking through it. Catra can feel the warmth of her hand and she isn't sure if that comes from magic bullshit or if it's just because her hair is shorter now. She-ra is careful to avoid her ears, but her touch is so steady, like one Catra has gone months without, that she almost wants her to start scratching her ears. She probably wouldn't do it right, but for a moment it feels like she would.

As quickly as it starts, She-ra's hand pulls away, and Catra barely keeps herself from leaning into it. At least she didn't *purr*. She sunk into the feeling and didn't realize what a give away her eyes falling closed was until she opens them again and sees She-ra grinning at her. Catra's ears pin back and she huffs, looking away.

"Shut up," Catra cuts her off.

"I didn't say anything." She-ra is still grinning.

"You're saying something right now. Shut up." She-ra really needs to step back if she's going to smirk at Catra like that. Catra knows exactly what she would rather She-ra be doing with her mouth right now.

"I like your hair. It's cute," She-ra says, her tone smug for no fucking reason, but maybe it's to match Catra's inexplicable blush. Her tail is going again.

"It's not *cute,* it's supposed to be punk and badass," Catra shoots back, sulking on the wall. She didn't realize how much the cut would make her ears stick out until she did it, so used to them being lost in the mass of her mane, and she would bet that's the part She-ra is referring to as *cute*. She has gotten used to the look over time, but She-ra is just being insulting.

"Punk?" She-ra questions. She looks like she's barely holding in laughter. Catra hisses at her again for good measure. Okay, not punk as in the style, but definitely as in the attitude.

"It was a breakup haircut," she elaborates, begrudgingly. She-ra's smile falls. Catra reminds herself that's what she wanted as She-ra's body language shifts towards caution.

"Breakup haircut?" she asks, like she thinks she misheard, or has maybe never heard of the idea.

“Yeah, you know, you’re going through a big change, emotions are running high, you want to be a new person and take control of your life, so you cut all your hair off in your bathroom at midnight?” Catra explains, waving her hand around vaguely. Her claws are out and she isn’t sure why, there’s just a lot going on between the petting, her desire, and the memories. She-ra nods, but it’s a little jerky.

“When, um- When was this?” she asks, haltingly, and Catra realizes her mistake. She rolls her eyes and braces her hand on the wall instead so she can lounge and showcase how unbothered she is.

“Almost a year ago. I’m over it, it’s just still short because I get frustrated every time I try to grow it out again and I end up trimming it,” Catra explains. Maybe there’s just too little expression visible for Catra to see any change, but She-ra’s caution doesn’t seem to ease. “I’m ready to be over it, you don’t have to worry.”

There, whether she means *worry about bringing up bad feelings* or *worry I’m still hung up on someone else* can be ambiguous. She-ra would be a rebound, she can’t lie about that – actually, she can, and she *will* if She-ra asks – but after this many weird hangouts, she would be interested in She-ra even if Adora hadn’t shattered her heart. She-ra is just *interesting*. She’s cocky and hot, and then gentle and emotional. A traitorous thought informs her those are the same traits she liked in Adora, but she does her best to beat it to death in the back of her mind as She-ra considers her.

“I’m sorry. It looks nice,” She-ra finally replies. Catra breathes out, straightening her hunching shoulders as she does so and trying to shake off the weird shame that talking about it makes her feel. “Do you want to talk about it?” She-ra offers, her voice soft, layers falling away. Catra’s ears twitch back. No, she doesn’t, but maybe she needs to if she’s going to convince She-ra that it’s fine.

“It wasn’t even a real breakup. Technically we were never more than friends, but *technically* didn’t make it hurt any less.” She-re just nods and Catra sighs. She-ra wants more. “Look, we had it rough growing up, okay? We were both foster kids. We were in a shitty group home, and then the ownership changed and it was less shitty, but we still didn’t have anything except each other. We built our lives around each other and planned a future together, but it wasn’t enough for her.”

To her surprise, She-ra doesn’t jump to the *poor you, that must have been hard* shit that most people pull when Catra mentions how she grew up. There’s a reason Catra has learned to edit out how abusive the home was until its owner “went missing” – or more likely, did what she wanted for two weeks to teach them self-reliance or some bullshit and returned to find the government could overlook abuse, but not neglect – and the state quietly replaced her, but She-ra just nods mutely, waiting for the rest. Catra sighs. She reminds herself she doesn’t want to talk about this as a tirade builds on the back of her tongue. She needs to edit it down.

“She moved to get her degree and started blowing me off. Eventually she asked me on a date just to stand me up. She made new friends and moved on, so I did too. Now she’s just an impulsive haircut I still have.” She’s lying through her fucking teeth, but she thinks she sounds convincing. She isn’t over it and she might never be, but she’s *trying*. She has fucking

ambitions now. Her entire life would be a void if she hadn't filled the space Adora left with something, but she's trying to be someone worth staying for, too.

"Why would someone ask you out to stand you up?" She-ra finally asks, her voice soft. Catra's brow furrows. She wasn't expecting that reaction. She could have answered anything else, but she never figured that out. It just seemed fucked up. Adora had never been cruel like that before. It didn't make sense, but if she really did just lose track of time, and get lost, and somehow have a dead phone all at once, then at best it showed that the day wasn't nearly as important to her as it was to Catra.

"You'd have to ask her. She made a lot of excuses, but I wasn't listening to them after months of being treated that way." *I'm very available, bitterness aside*, is the message she desperately hopes She-ra takes from all this. She never should have brought it up, really, but she wasn't expecting She-ra to ask for more details. She-ra is quiet for a long moment, just looking at her. Her gaze itches at Catra's fur, but she refuses to squirm.

"I'm sorry," She-ra finally says, her voice soft. The few voices lingering beneath it are rough with sadness. Catra's heart does something painful, but she shrugs it off. She doesn't need pity. Nothing to be sorry for – at least nothing that She-ra did.

"It's fine, princess. I'm ready to move on," she throws She-ra a meaningful look, hoping the *with you* is implied without being too desperate. She-ra offers her a small smile back, fleeting and a little unsure around the edges, but it's less of a rejection than Adora ever gave her, so Catra will take it after she just unloaded something emotional and dumb onto her.

"You deserve better," She-ra adds. The sincerity and quiet tone still in her voice *kill* Catra. Her fur fluffs up and her body feels hot. She ducks her head, ignoring the way her tail is lashing behind her. She has never known what she *deserves*, but she certainly knows what she wants, and hearing She-ra say that flusters her.

"Yeah, well, I don't get to choose what people give me, just what I'm willing to put up with," Catra says, eyeing her. She doesn't know yet what She-ra is going to give her, but she can hope that *you deserve better* means *I intend to give it to you*. She could be wrong, but the small smile She-ra gives her makes her hopeful.

"I admire that about you. It isn't easy to draw boundaries like that," She-ra says. Okay, too much sincerity is going to kill Catra, especially fucking *She-ra* saying she admires her. Catra manages to find enough bravado within herself to throw She-ra a smile.

"What, is that how the almighty She-ra ends up letting her friends bully her into taking breaks?" she asks. She's *really* done talking about Adora now. Luckily, She-ra takes the hint, letting out a shaky laugh and taking a half step back. They both have room to breathe again and it makes it easier to move on from the heavy conversation.

"Yeah, well, let's just say that I know it's worth admiring," she says. Catra purrs a quiet laugh, soothing herself as she pushes aside the thoughts of Adora. "How were your midterms, by the way?" Catra is glad for the subject change. It's easy to relax again while she's bitching about the bullshit test her least favorite professor threw at her.

Still, in the back of her mind, the quiet sincerity in She-ra's words plays over again. If Catra wants to force herself to be honest for once, she knew she was done for the second She-ra pet her like that. She isn't in love like she once was with Adora, but she doesn't want that again anyway. All that did was leave her open to being hurt. She wants She-ra and she trusts her enough by now to take a risk on her.

She'll just have to see what exactly it is that She-ra thinks she deserves.

Chapter End Notes

She-ra isn't actually invulnerable, that's just Catra's read from what she knows on the outside of the situation. Her understanding of She-ra's powers and the princesses in general is limited due to a combination of their secrecy and her apathy.

Chapter 6: Mistake

Chapter Notes

> I really love y'all's speculation comments I just can't reply to any of them because of spoilers.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Every part of their body hurts, drained and limp. Their jailer gave up on trying to extract information from them and just settled on taking their magic. Someone like that could never understand. It's dangerous, but that might be the key to their escape.

Take too much, give too much, and it could end in disaster. They can already feel one stirring in the streets above. Their only chance is channeling that trapped energy at the right moment. Until then, they have to fight. When the time comes, giving in will be a relief.

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Adora has never blown off Alliance work before, but sweeping the city for signs of who could be causing the spell-storm outside isn't in her skillset. They don't even know that it's someone breaking the law. It could be a sorcerer summoning it intentionally, but it could also just be someone struggling to control their powers, in which case Adora doesn't think a team of superheroes descending on them is going to help.

She still showed up and dispersed with the rest of the team, but it was only an excuse for Glimmer to drop her in the Fright Zone. After a cursory sweep of the streets, she's in Catra's apartment. Catra motioned for her to come in when Adora sent a flare to the window and Adora happily circled around to the apartment building's entrance. The rain is so torrential it has all but shut the city down, hence the Alliance's attempted intervention, but it means there's nobody out to spot Adora sneaking into Catra's apartment.

The rest of the Alliance is getting bruised by pouring rain and blinded by flashes of purple lightning while Adora sits on Catra's couch, flirting with enough shame to feel bad but not enough to stop.

Catra started it. Adora temporarily dropped the transformation out in the apartment stairwell, both so she could free herself of the rain and so she could slip her comm into her pocket to ensure they didn't get interrupted. She transformed back before making her way to the hall, but that gave Catra plenty of room to tease her about how she had to dry herself after seeing Catra through the window.

“I’m flattered you got so wet seeing me,” Catra purrs to her, because she’s *evil*. She’s certainly gotten closer to killing She-ra than any supervillain has ever managed, even if it is via heart palpitations. Catra invited her to sit on the couch when she let her in and then threw herself down beside her, closer than they’ve ever settled together before. Catra is sat sideways on the couch, facing her, and they’re so close that Catra’s legs would be in her lap if her knees weren’t tucked up to her chest.

“I’m supposed to be investigating who’s causing the spell-storm, actually, but She-ra’s magic is too strong for me to really pick up anyone else’s around it, so I decided coming over would be a better use of my time,” Adora explains, trying to focus on anything other than the woman in front of her. Something about the thunderstorm, or maybe the fact Adora is supposed to be somewhere else, makes the apartment feel like a liminal space. That transitory feeling is dangerous – it could tempt Adora into doing something she really shouldn’t.

“I can’t believe you’re skipping. That sounds like something *I* would do,” Catra returns with a playful smile. Her tail flicks beside her occasionally, giving away that she’s nowhere near done teasing.

“I can’t punch the weather sunny. I don’t know why they expected me to help,” Adora says. She does know actually, it’s because she’s the only member of the Alliance from the Fright Zone that was available, but she can’t tell Catra that. Knowing the city streets doesn’t make her able to hunt down magic anyway. Unless there was a sorcerer drawing glyphs in the streets, she wasn’t going to be able to do much. That could have been the case, but she didn’t see anything in her quick sweep.

Catra eyes her arms. Adora shouldn’t, but she flexes her muscles before reason reaches her conscious thought processes. Catra’s flirting has made her mood clear and Adora doesn’t need to bait her further. She *shouldn’t* bait her at all, but she doesn’t know how to not want to. The way Catra’s eyes dilate is too tempting.

“It’s okay, princess, some powers don’t need to do more than look good,” Catra teases, meeting Adora’s gaze with a glint in her eye that tells Adora she knows *exactly* what she’s doing.

“Hey, I can *use* this muscle, you know,” Adora returns, focusing on the slight because otherwise hearing Catra so openly appreciate her is just going to make Adora want to flex more. Catra’s eyes flick down for just a moment before locking onto hers again. A lazy grin spreads over Catra’s face.

“Prove it,” Catra challenges. In contrast to her relaxed expression, her tail is dancing beside her. Adora is trying to be good, but with Catra looking at her like that, she can’t quite remember why.

“I’ve picked you up before,” Adora manages to point out. It’s all she has. If Catra wants her to hold back, she needs to accept that answer.

Adora is pretty sure they passed Catra wanting her to hold back a while ago. It has been down to just Adora’s self-control since. That’s not much of a barrier. Her self-control has

always been awful. The only way the Alliance has kept her on rails is by appealing to her sense of duty and guilt complex.

Catra's eyes burn.

"Oh, I remember," Catra assures. She unfurls a little, sliding her legs to the side enough to lean in and purr to her, "You could always try that again, princess." She's close enough that Adora feels her breath ghost across her face.

This is a bad idea. She knows it's a bad idea as she fights for control of her body, but she's gazing into that sparkle in Catra's mismatched eyes and she can't hold back any longer. If she wants to do keep herself from doing something way harder to come back from, she has to give in to this. She knows Catra has something planned and she can't find it in herself to be anything but excited for it.

She stands with more power than necessary. Catra's grin widens and any vestiges of higher thinking left abandon Adora. Catra slowly turns to face her, her legs untucking and draping over the edge of the couch.

"We already know you can do princess carry, but I'm not magic or royalty, so let's try something different," Catra proposes. The way she says the words alone is enough to get Adora worked up. There's so much promise – *filthy* promise – in her tone.

"Firemen's carry," Adora replies, her tone about as dry as her mouth. Catra rolls her eyes and Adora flashes her a cheeky smile. Catra's plan is probably to say something dirty while Adora is carrying her and see if she can make her drop her. She can prepare for that. Probably. Depending on what she says.

"You did that too, when I first got hit," Catra reminds. Adora doesn't know what answer Catra is looking for, but she knows she wants to give it when Catra talks like that. She briefly considers just picking up the entire couch with Catra still on it to prove a point and maybe show off, but if Catra is planning to ambush her then that will just make it easier for Adora to break. She's a little beyond coming up with carry styles or even appropriate responses at this point, though, so she decides to just reach for Catra and see which way she moves.

The way she moves is she *doesn't*, not beyond shifting closer to the edge of the couch and reaching up to lay her hands on Adora's shoulders when she grabs her hips. She lifts Catra up with them face-to-face, realizing with every inch they grow closer that this was a *mistake*. Catra only shifts to spread her knees and wrap her legs around Adora's chest, a totally unnecessary anchoring given how meaningless Catra's weight is to She-ra, but it does give Catra leverage to push herself up and grin down at Adora.

Adora has faced supervillains, but she's never faced an onslaught like this before and it leaves her speechless. Adora fumbles adjusting her, but Catra tightens her legs and Adora manages to get through her flustered panicking to put her hands on Catra's ass and hold her up properly. Catra eases the squeeze of her thighs, letting her weight settle onto Adora's hands, but she keeps her legs wrapped around her. Only about half of Adora is paying attention to their positioning, though, because the other half is focused entirely on Catra's face.

Her expression is cast in shadows by the ceiling light behind her, but her eyes still smolder. Ever since they were little kids, Adora always thought the mismatched color was cool, but she was an *idiot* because they're so much beyond that. She would need to learn a few more languages before she had enough adjectives to describe them. The look in them is dark and full of promise. *Intent* curls at the smile tugging on Catra's lips, a ghost of smug victory that is slowly fading into something else.

Catra's eyes flick down. Adora's breath hitches and her hands tighten unconsciously. She should put her down. She should do *something*, but instead her tongue darts out to wet her lips and Catra's eyes flare. She doesn't look back up, her eyes just suddenly *are* locked on Adora's again and it's no safer than when she was looking at her lips. The air feels heavy, a crackle of anticipation muted beneath the heavy fog of unmet desire.

Catra sways forward. Despite some warning bell going off in the back of Adora's head, she doesn't move, doesn't put Catra down, doesn't even have to decency not to lean up to meet her when Catra slides a hand up her neck and guides her in to kiss her. The muggy haze clears in an instant, like a flash of the purple lightning outside hits them.

Her lips are soft. Adora is, maybe, a complete fucking loser who has kissed the back of her hand when she needed something tactile in the middle of a fantasy and was picturing Catra's face there instead. She never thought that's what kissing Catra would be like, of course, but it still surprises her how soft she is. The kiss isn't shy, but she's pretty sure it's the first for both of them, so it isn't as desperate as some of the ones she has imagined. It's still passionate, or at least it turns that way in the time it takes Adora to stop marveling at the plush feeling.

She never wants it to *stop*. She knows people in relationships, people with boyfriends and wives and shit. How do they ever leave the house? If she was allowed to kiss Catra all the time she *would*. It feels so good and yet it grows the hunger inside her. She wants to kiss more, push more, *have* more. Catra's hand has slid around to the back of her head. Her hand gripping at her hair, claws incidentally pricking at her scalp, just makes Adora want to have her hands all over Catra too, but they're a little occupied holding her up.

Adora barely knows her way around Catra's apartment, but she knows if she turns to the side and walks straight there's nothing between her and the door, so she does that as she experiments with nipping at Catra's bottom lip. Catra *moans* and it feels incredible between Adora's teeth, so it's probably the most successful moment of her life. It's immediately followed by abject failure when she reaches the door and accidentally shoves Catra against it with a loud thud.

"Fuck," Catra curses against her mouth, her claws tightening on the back of Adora's head. Adora still has to be the one to break the kiss so she can apologize.

"Sorry, I-" Catra doesn't let her get any further before she returns the favor and bites her lip, *tugging* on it and effectively ending all of Adora's thought processes beyond *more*.

"That meant do it again," Catra clarifies, her tone husky. Adora squeezes her eyes shut, the hungry need almost too much to contain. She doesn't even know what she wants or what would be enough, just that *more* and *Catra* are in there somewhere.

“Fuck,” she curses back. Catra grins.

“*Exactly*,” and then they’re kissing again, this time with Catra pressed tightly between Adora’s body and the wall. It’s almost not enough, but she doesn’t have the presence of mind left to map out a path to Catra’s bed so she can truly touch her. One hand will have to be enough. It’s not like she needs both to carry Catra’s weight, and the wall stabilizes her enough for Adora to slide one hand up over her side. Catra bites off a small whine in her throat, arching into the touch.

“*Princess*,” she sighs, pants, quietly whimpers. It doesn’t matter how small the sound is, it cuts through the pleasure-haze currently fogging over Adora’s brain. It’s the wrong word, the wrong *name*, the wrong person kissing Catra and definitely the wrong person Catra is arching into the touch of. Adora wanted too much and she forgot she *isn’t Adora* right now. Catra doesn’t want Adora anymore; she wants She-ra.

A lie.

Adora has been guilty and turned on before, but never like this. The incredible high is gone when Catra kisses her again. Catra is just as passionate, but Adora is slow beneath her. The endorphins are still there, but buried beneath how wrong it feels. She could cry. She wants this. She wants Catra. She wants to kiss and touch her and hear those soft little pants, but she wants them to be *her name*, and like this they never could be.

It doesn’t matter what she wants, anyway. This is wrong. She needs to figure out how to stop this without breaking Catra’s heart all over again. She thinks Catra notices the change in her because there’s a sound – tiny, desperate, and questioning – muted beneath the next kiss. Adora lets the slide of lips end and pulls back before Catra can start it again. Catra is still trapped between her and the door, and they’re both panting heavily. She looks as dazed as Adora feels.

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When She-ra picks her up, she brings Catra close enough for her to really, truly see her eyes for the first time ever. The glow has been dim pretty much since she arrived, and as She-ra lifts her up, she swears it darkens further. Catra finds herself caught in the unnatural crystal blue. Seeing it feels as intimate as their closeness, and she kind of mourns the loss of that soft blue when she sways forward and closes her own eyes, but then she’s kissing She-ra and nothing else fucking matters.

It’s exactly like she thought it would be, hot and passionate. She-ra’s grip on her is strong and when she shoves Catra against the wall, she’s pretty sure she gets wet enough to ruin her underwear, though it might have been a lost cause already. She-ra’s hands are so *big* as they run over her and she’s already thinking about what her fingers would feel like inside of her when she feels She-ra grow unresponsive beneath her. Immediate panic lights Catra’s blood.

No. This was supposed to be it. This *felt* like it. She wants it so fucking badly and for a minute, at least, She-ra wanted it too.

But she pulls back. Not far, but her lips leave Catra's and it's like swallowing ice water, a shock to her system compared to the desperate heat of the last few moments. Catra opens her eyes and finds She-ra's are unfocused and dark – truly dark, next to no glow around their edges. She-ra's lips are still parted, bitten, and Catra can see a flush creeping out from the edge of her mask. For a moment, She-ra's gaze lingers on Catra's lips again and she just *hopes*. Hopes She-ra liked it, that she'll want to do it again, maybe *right fucking now*.

The hand She-ra was just about to feel her up with slides back down to her thigh. She slowly pulls back from the wall, giving Catra time to adjust as she takes her weight back and carefully sets her down.

Catra is overreacting and she kind of wants to cry. She was cruising an endorphin high – felt *wanted* – for a few moments there and losing it makes her so emotional it's hard to think, which is stupid, because consent is fucking important and she's the one who kissed She-ra without even asking.

"I'm sorry," She-ra murmurs to her, reaching up and cupping Catra's cheek. Catra is caught between the instinct to lean into it or to claw it away, but she knows at least one of those would be completely unreasonable, so she gives into the first as she tries to remember how to think – and *feel* – rationally.

"It's fine." It's not, but this isn't just about her and she needs to remember that. "I should be saying that. Did you not want to?" her voice is so small and stupidly insecure in a way it *never* is. She feels like this all the time, but that's usually when she puffs up and gets angry. She can't do that now, not when there's the real fucking possibility that she just forced herself on She-ra. Sure, She-ra was definitely an active participant for a minute there, but Catra didn't ask and then She-ra stopped it.

She-ra lets out a soft snort. It's a little wet.

"No, I did. I do. That's not why. We just shouldn't," she explains, gently stroking her fingers just beneath Catra's ear. Catra blinks up at her, some of the wild emotions settling, but still there.

"Shouldn't?" she asks, her voice a lot less pathetic. There's a hard edge there that feels like strength and probably reads as annoyance, but it makes the words feel less flighty as she forces them from her chest.

She-ra's eyes aren't glowing. There's a hint of radiance to them, but Catra can clearly see enough of her expression through her eyeholes to tell her brows are pinching together under the mask. She chews on the inside of her cheek with the motion. The movement plucks at Catra's overstretched heartstrings. It's painfully familiar.

So is the rejection.

“You don’t know my identity,” She-ra says, her voice quiet, guilty. Catra stares up at her. Yeah, *duh*. Leaving the mask on in bed will be a little weird, sure, but she never asked and she made it clear she didn’t want an answer. She doesn’t know why it would even be a *problem* unless She-ra secretly has a girlfriend in her civilian life.

The thought should be sobering. Instead it makes her square her jaw and tilt her face up to look She-ra right in the eyes.

“Okay. When did I say I care?” she challenges. She-ra looks pained. She takes a step back, her aura retreating. It’s cold without it, the damp from the rain outside pressing in on Catra’s lungs like even the weather is trying to drown her.

“You know this wouldn’t work. I can’t settle,” She-ra says, her voice a soft plea. Catra’s jaw clenches. It hurts. It hurts so fucking much. She shoves past She-ra and her warmth, hoping there aren’t tears in her eyes as she stalks back towards the center of the living room.

“And I’m only good for a quick fuck. Got it,” she bites back. Why does it hurt? That’s what Catra told herself she wanted. She shouldn’t be upset that She-ra doesn’t want to ruin anything just for that. She hears She-ra cross over behind her, sensing her warmth in just enough time to duck away from the hand attempting to reach for her shoulder. She turns and hisses at She-ra, making it clear she *missed her fucking chance* to touch her at all. She-ra’s expression seems distraught.

“Catra, no, that’s the opposite-” She cuts off, looking down at the pain in Catra’s eyes. Slowly She-ra’s expression darkens, her jaw clenching. “Who said that to you?” She-ra asks, her voice low and dangerous. Catra laughs bitterly. What, she wants to reject her and then be mad when Catra calls it what it is?

“Nobody. They’ve made it clear with how they can’t stand sticking around long enough to even *get* to that part,” Catra returns, gesturing between them to make it clear it’s happening again right fucking now. She-ra makes a noise low in her throat.

“Catra, it’s because you’re too *important*. There’s no endgame for a secret relationship with a mask,” She-ra tries. It’s only a twist of the knife in Catra’s heart. She turns away. They’re pretty words. It’s a shame they’re not true. She wraps her arms around herself. She was so stupid to think someone was going to want her, to fucking *hold* her.

“I already said I don’t care about your fucking identity. Everyone in your life just gets half of you anyway, right? I’m happy with this half. Just say it if I can’t give you enough. Don’t do this to me.” *Again*. It’s the same fucking thing as with Adora, *I swear you’re important* as they walk out the door. She would have handled it better if She-ra told her to her face that she didn’t want her like this. This is so much worse.

She-ra is silent for a long moment behind her. Catra squeezes her eyes shut. Yeah, there it is. Of course She-ra doesn’t want her, *look* at her. She can’t take a rejection even when someone’s being nice about it. At least She-ra was willing to do it to her face instead of just abandoning her and promising she still cared. Catra has already ruined any chance of She-ra coming back with her fit, she doesn’t know why she can’t stop, but it’s catharsis, maybe, to be able to say how she feels for once. Adora never gave her that chance.

“It *is* enough. But you would care, if you knew, and I can’t do that to you. I don’t want to hurt you like that,” She-ra whispers, her voice low and distraught. It occurs to Catra that layers have fallen away ever since they kissed, narrowing down to just a few voices. She didn’t even notice with how familiar its tone has grown. Just hearing it makes her sick to her stomach. She growls, turning around.

“What do you think you’re doing right now?” Catra asks, her voice breaking halfway through.

“It- It would be worse. I’m trying to protect you,” She-ra pleads, reaching for her again, though this time she’s smart enough to go for her hand. Catra yanks back, but She-ra hangs on to her wrist, trapping her there beneath her pleading expression.

“Nothing is worse than fucking this. Just say you don’t want me. I can take that. I’ll be fucking reasonable about it, but not *this*. Don’t do this to me again.”

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Again. She-ra has never rejected Catra, never even paused before returning her flirtations. Catra isn’t talking about She-ra, though.

Catra doesn’t know. She can’t. She’s just upset and it’s too familiar. Adora should do what Catra wants and say she only wanted to be friends. She spent months lying to Catra before, it should be familiar at this point, but while Adora could lie and say she was busy with homework, or in class, or just forgot, she can’t say that she doesn’t want Catra. She can’t do that to her. She clearly ruined her once already.

“Catra, please, just *believe* me. I’m trying not to hurt you,” she begs, but she knows it’s pointless. There’s nothing she can do to fix this. She was trying to stop a moment like this but everything she has said has made it worse. As long as she’s lying to Catra, she’s going to keep hurting her. She should have just stayed away. She only knows one way to make it hurt less, and it wouldn’t make it *stop*. It wouldn’t fix anything, Catra would just finally understand instead of sitting there in her hurt, lashing out when Adora fails to explain the truth she can’t tell.

“I *don’t*,” Catra bites back, her gaze hard. She yanks her hand out of Adora’s grip and turns around, her shoulders beginning to shake. Adora’s heart breaks as she watches. This is probably what Catra looked like in front of the restaurant as she waited and waited for Adora to show up until she couldn’t stand to stay in public any longer. Adora never had to see it then, but she could tell Catra cried by the look the hostess gave her when she finally showed up.

They’re standing right next to the couch that Adora never should have risen from, and she sits down on it heavily, all the fight gone from her. She has nothing left she can say. Catra is never going to believe this is for her own good. If she thinks she hates her now, it would be

nothing compared to how she would feel if Adora let it keep going and she inevitably found out the truth.

Inevitably. Adora has two choices. She can walk out of this apartment and never see Catra again. Catra wouldn't want her to come back and it would only hurt her if she did. Catra would move on with her life, or she wouldn't. Adora thought she already had given the way she acted around She-ra, but it's clear now that Catra just shoved down how hurt she was and did her best to look like she was fine. That bullshit about *moving on* she spouted on the roof was probably in equal measures a lie to She-ra and a lie to herself.

Adora squeezes her eyes shut and she sees Catra sprawled across the lawn again, lifeless, only this time she gets the added effect of Catra's quiet sobs in the background to make it worse. She couldn't stay away. If she walked out that door, she would be back eventually. She can't just not know what's happening with Catra, if she's happy or even okay. She can't imagine a worse hell than spending the rest of her days wondering if Catra is even still alive.

So instead she's going to hurt her more and betray everyone in her life – even people who haven't even been *born* yet – in the process. Her emotions are so volatile, she's barely holding onto her magic. She wrestles for control, pulling it close to her chest so she can maintain it as she warps it. She opens her eyes to watch golden sparkles float away from her face, her mask dissolving but the transformation otherwise clinging on. Catra is still standing just a few feet from her, arms and tail wrapped tightly around herself as she tries to swallow down her tears.

"Catra," Adora whispers, and it's just that, *Adora*. No other She-ras are willing to bare witness to this moment, to even tacitly endorse it by contributing their voice. Catra stiffens where she stands, but she doesn't turn, at least not her body. Her ears swivel back, either pinning there or focusing in on Adora's voice.

"I'm sorry. All I wanted was to be with you," she whispers. She barely keeps from closing her eyes again as Catra rattles out a breath and turns around. She forces herself to watch as Catra's eyes widen, her gaze darting over Adora's face, taking it in. She struggles through the glamor for a moment, her expression folding in before it goes blank and Adora knows. For a moment, they stare at each other, Adora struggling to keep control of herself as she waits for Catra's reaction.

She breaks before Catra's expression does. Her magic is a painful crackle in her chest and she gasps out as it becomes too much and She-ra melts away in a shower of light.

Then it's just Adora, sitting on Catra's couch and still looking up at her. She's far too emotional to maintain enough control to keep her ponytail as she drops the transformation and her hair falls around her eyes, doing little to obscure how she's quietly crying. The blankness on Catra's face lasts only half a second more before rage washes over her.

"Get. *Out*," she grits out, more anger in her voice than Adora has ever heard as she points toward the door with a shaking finger. Adora is sure the feeling that washes through her is similar to what Catra felt when She-ra said she couldn't settle. It's the knowledge of a painful inevitably. She nods, standing on shaking legs.

“I always loved you. I never wanted to hurt you,” she whispers to her. She knows Catra doesn’t believe her, but she needs to leave her with that, to leave that *chance* that the words might sink in and mean something. Catra’s face warps further with rage.

“*Loved me*? You treated me like- You *tricked* me- And you lied to me. You’re still lying now,” Catra returns, so angry that she can’t form just one sentence why. Her voice breaks in the middle. The knife in Adora’s heart is what she deserves, but she can’t let that go.

“I wanted to tell you the truth, but I discovered I was She-ra and the runestone holders have to be secret. Every time I wasn’t there, it was just Alliance stuff. I wanted to be with you. I’ve *always* wanted to be with you,” Adora begs her to understand. Catra flinches, staring at her with the same kind of pain that broke Adora earlier and made her finally tell Catra the truth. Her hands flex at her sides as she readies her claws, but she doesn’t move, glaring at Adora and refusing to back down.

“Even if the other princesses told you to, you *chose* to lie. You chose them over me. I’m the one who went without you until I couldn’t take it anymore. *You did this*,” Catra snarls, baring her teeth at her. It wasn’t like that, but before Adora can plead with her further, Catra points to the door. She’s shaking. “Get out before I yell your fucking identity to the whole building,” she threatens, her voice trembling just like her stance. Adora opens her mouth, wanting to say something, but there’s nothing left.

She owes it to Catra to respect her wishes now. She tried. It’s not a surprise it wasn’t enough after how she made Catra feel.

“I’m *sorry*,” she whispers, too close to tears to say it louder. She finally turns away. She almost feels too lightheaded from emotion to make it to the door. As soon as she sees it, she feels sick thinking of how she had Catra against it just moments ago. She turns the knob with a shaking hand and stumbles out into the hall.

The door thuds shut behind her. For a moment she just stands there, trembling, before she forces herself to turn and stumble to the stairwell. She gets down one flight before she’s afraid she’ll fall if she takes another step. She drops down to sit on the stairs and buries her head in her hands, fisting her hair as she finally begins crying.

Chapter End Notes

For those up on my Tumblr lore: The Scene™

Chapter 7: Hindsight

Chapter Notes

Lost In The Citadel by Lil Nas X is on the Superzero playlist. That's all.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra can't tell if it was obvious or she just wants to have one more thing to hate herself for. She-ra looks different enough from Adora that she can give herself a pass on not realizing until they started talking, but there's a lot more than that. Her behavior, her voice when Catra started hearing enough of it, her fucking *friends* because now that Catra knows, it's easy to put together the identity of Moonstone and the archer. She's pretty sure she knows Pearl, too, though she only met Mermista once.

It's not hard to figure out who Adora made promises to, or why. They didn't want anyone to know their own identities so they told Adora to lie, and she *fucking did*, because no matter what she says now, they were more important than Catra. Now she has the gall to act like she's hurt by Catra's reaction, like she had any right to that even before she came crawling back via a lie.

Catra cries until the storm clears, replaced by cool moonlight. She goes through anger, and then grief, and then both of them again before the grief is finally so draining that she's just left numb. She's still sad and she's still pissed off, but she doesn't have enough left in her to think or feel much, her mind an echo chamber bouncing around the husks of the emotions she felt all day. She tries to think, sometimes, to make sense of it in her head, but she keeps getting caught in the same emotional cycles again.

Most pathetic is when a part of her says *but Adora came back*. She didn't, really, and she only made the lying worse when she did. Adora heard everything Catra said about their "breakup" up on the roof and she still led Catra on until the guilt was too much for *her*, never caring how Catra felt herself.

Why would someone ask you out just to stand you up? She knew the fucking answer. It takes Catra about five minutes after having the thought to see through the blind rage enough to consider the possibility that maybe Adora didn't just choose not to come so she didn't have to keep lying. Catra fumbles for her phone and mutely searches the Fright Zone's local news site for the date. She still knows it from memory. *April 26th*.

The Horde attacked a hospital in Bright Moon. Even after they were fought off, there was damage to the building and its utilities. The Alliance spent hours there between the fight and helping with emergency relocation of patients afterwards. She-ra is featured leaping through the air right on the article's heading image.

Catra drops the phone onto her chest, staring up at her ceiling. She should feel… something. Better, probably, that Adora didn't actually choose to stand her up. She didn't get lost with a dead phone battery like she claimed, but she – probably – intended to come.

Catra doesn't feel any better. It's just a reminder that Adora was lying to her constantly, probably with no plan to stop. She might have even lied to Catra her entire life about having powers, but Catra knows enough, however vaguely, about the princesses to know it's possible she only inherited them recently and had no idea.

Okay, fine. Catra isn't getting anywhere laying here and feeling like shit. It's time to research.

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Adora still has red rings under her eyes by the time Glimmer picks her up. She cried until her phone started buzzing, her absence noted enough for Glimmer to pop back to the hub and send an emergency alert to both her phone and comm. Her comm is slipped into its disguised earbud case in her pocket, but even with it inactive, Glimmer could text her and hope one of the two alerts went through.

Adora reluctantly makes her way to the sidewalk, not bothering to shield anything but the electronics in her pocket from the rain, and just stares at her feet until she sees sparkling in the corner of her eye to alert her that Glimmer has arrived. Adora knows she must look awful, so she isn't surprised when Glimmer looks horrified beneath her mask upon spotting her.

"What *happened*?" Glimmer asks, striding to her and grabbing her arm. She doesn't wait for a response before teleporting them back to the sanctum. It's cool down here most days and it makes Adora shiver, her teeth chattering. Before she can center herself enough to respond, she finds the world disappearing in sparkles again and they're back in their dorm, where the air is significantly warmer.

"Is your comm off?" Adora mumbles, not much of a question. She shivers again as Glimmer's expression pinches together, but she's a good friend, so she takes a step back and reaches up to her ear.

"We're back home now. Give us a second, guys," Glimmer says, and then she turns her comm off. Her mask and outfit melt away in a wash of sparkles, leaving just Glimmer staring back at her as Adora wraps her arms around herself. She's soaked like she just climbed out of a pool. "It is now. Adora, what happened?" Glimmer asks, her voice as distressed as her expression. Adora wishes she could stop hurting her friends.

Glimmer clearly didn't recognize the pickup location or she would have a few guesses. She probably only turned off her comm so she didn't have to worry about saying Adora's name. They have a rule against using identifying information over the comm system, even if it gets broken every other week. Adora opens her mouth, a labored breath coming out but no words. Where does she start?

“Why did you change back?” Glimmer prompts, her tone veering closer to coaxing. Adora tries to speak, but a shiver interrupts her. She wraps her arms tighter around herself. Glimmer quietly glances around and then darts to her laundry basket, pulling out a towel that is probably dirty – it’s hard to tell when Glimmer never puts away her clean laundry either – but it’s better than nothing. Adora takes it gratefully, wiping off her face and then wrapping it around her shoulders.

“I visited Catra,” she admits in a whisper. Glimmer’s eyes widen. Adora clutches the towel tighter around herself. She really needs to change out of her wet clothes, but this isn’t a conversation to have half-naked.

“Adora…” Oh, that hurts. It would have been easier if she was mad, if she hated Adora like Adora hates herself.

Like Catra hates her.

“I didn’t- Glimmer, she knows,” Adora admits, hugging the towel tightly. She almost tries to explain or justify it, but what’s the point? Why not cut to the part where she failed everyone? Glimmer’s mouth falls open and panic enters her eyes.

“Did she figure it out when you saved her? What did she say? Is she going to reveal it?” Glimmer asks, worried about the group like Adora should have been, but just can’t find it in herself after all this time of baring their secrets. Adora hangs her head.

“She won’t tell anyone,” she murmurs. She doesn’t know that, really. Catra threatened to already, but Adora hopes that she still knows her better than that. She doesn’t think Catra will tell anyone – except maybe her own best friend, like Adora *didn’t* when she was in that position – and if she does decide to tell someone dangerous, well, it’s too late to stop her.

“Adora, I’m sorry, I know you’re upset, but I need you to tell me what happened. This affects all of us,” Glimmer says behind her. Adora – kind of – growls, swallowing a distressed groan as she shivers again. All she has done until now is think about the others, never herself and not Catra either.

“I told her. I just told her, okay?” Adora bites out, finally looking up and letting go of the towel to gesture angrily at nothing. Glimmer’s mouth falls open as the towel pools around Adora’s feet. She’s shaking and she knows it only makes her look more unstable.

“You *told* her? Adora, you can’t-”

“Well, *too late*. You don’t even know how easy you have it, do you? You grew up with a parent that knows, that can *guide* you, and Bow found out before you ever had to make a habit of lying to him. I’ve never had anyone but her, and I *lost* her for you. I was about to lose her again if I didn’t say something,” Adora rants, reaching her hands up and burying them in her hair to keep from gesturing more and maybe accidentally hitting something. She knows she looks insane and Glimmer looks horrified at her statement, but she’s too far gone.

“I’ve been seeing her for weeks as She-ra because it’s the only way she could stand me anymore, but she wanted more and I had to reject her to keep *your* secret. I couldn’t keep

making her cry over me, so I told her, and even if she hates my guts, I wouldn't take it back. She doesn't deserve to think it's because no one could love her," Adora finishes, her voice trembling by the end. She squeezes her eyes shut and twists her hair in her fist, fighting the urge to punch the wall.

She did that once, when she and Catra were first fighting. That's when she found out that some of She-ra's power can be summoned without having to transform. She put her fist through the wall and back out the other side, buried up to her shoulder.

And it was *brick*.

"Adora, I know this has been hard but you have *us*-" Glimmer starts. It's the wrong thing to say, especially since she's clearly about to tell Adora she shouldn't have done it. Adora yanks her hand from her hair, glaring at Glimmer, and cuts her off before she can make Adora mad at her on top of herself.

"*Stop*. You aren't her. No one is ever going to be. Look me in the eye and tell me you wouldn't have told Bow by now. You're not that good of a liar. I've spent the last *year and a half* killing myself for you guys. Don't you dare tell me now that I failed you. You failed me when you made me lose her. I'm *not sorry*."

It's an utter lie. She's so sorry, so guilty, but she wouldn't undo it if she could and that amounts to the same thing no matter how awful she feels. She's crying again. She shouldn't be yelling, it's only making her feel sicker, and the dorm may be soundproofed enough to accommodate the basic needs of sensitive hybrid species, but it isn't good enough for them to be having a fight about *this* here.

Adora sidesteps Glimmer and her friend is smart enough not to try to get in her way, even if she reaches for her. It's easy to yank her arm away. Knocking Glimmer over would probably be the best outcome for any further intervention with how volatile her emotions – and thus her magic – are right now, and she doesn't need to feel even sicker than she already does.

"You can tell the others. I don't care. I'm not doing this," Adora says, and then she yanks the door open and slams it behind her. She's so busy being grateful that Glimmer didn't follow her it doesn't occur to her that she doesn't have anything but her phone until she's down in the lobby of their dorm, staring out at the spell-storm.

Purple lightning flashes, reminding her of the duty she shirked off just to break every promise she still had left. The rest of the Alliance is out there right now, looking for the lightning's source.

Adora squares her shoulders and turns away.

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There's a lot of information about She-ra online, but most of it was written before her reappearance a year and a half ago. After that it's just news articles that aren't useful to Catra right now. Information about the princesses that still exist is largely speculative and it only gets worse looking back at supposedly extinct ones. She-ra is often listed alongside Spirit Ember as a princess whose line died out hundreds of years ago – four hundred years ago, for them both – and Black Garnet as a more recent line lost. Neither of the other princesses has reappeared, but somehow She-ra found her home in Adora.

Trying to figure out how that works isn't very successful. It's just the same shit Catra already knew – a runestone passes down from holder to holder, usually mother to daughter, with little concrete knowledge of how or why. It's not strictly hereditary, but no one seems to have more than theories on how it works.

The only solid thing she really turns up is an article written after She-ra's first reappearance. It contains plenty of the speculation she has already dug through, acting as a summary of the last hour of her research, but the important part is the date. November 13th. Catra's call logs don't stretch back that far, but the text history on the messaging app they used does. She scrolls back a long ways and searches keywords. Between the messages and her memories, she knows Adora started missing calls at the end of October.

She's punishing herself – them both – so she starts plugging dates into the local news site. *December 5th*, Adora apologizes for missing a call and a Horde bot gets loose in downtown. *December 26th*, Catra checks in when Adora suddenly decides in the middle of Winterfest that she needs to go visit her friends in Bright Moon, *alone*, and Catra was left feeling hurt and confused as the Alliance dispatches some kind of worm monster summoned by Shadow Weaver. When Catra finds the first missed date after the initial gap that doesn't turn up anything noteworthy on the site, she stops.

It isn't actually obvious in hindsight, she doesn't think. How was she supposed to know Adora was magic this entire fucking time? She thought there would be some kind of *sign* when someone was secretly the avatar of a goddess. Everything falls into place now that she knows, though. She's pretty sure Adora told her intending to make the rejection better, to convince her it was just *duty* or whatever keeping them apart. She made it clear it weighed heavily on her during their rooftop visits.

It doesn't make it better. Maybe it will – some – when she's more settled and less blindingly angry, but now it just turns out that Adora was lying to her the whole time and didn't trust her. The part of Catra that has been so *broken* by the abandonment insists that's better, but the rest of her shouts it down. No matter why, Adora still chose strangers over her. She chose to break a promise to Catra in order to make a new one to them. She chose her fucking side, and Catra wasn't standing on it.

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Adora spends the weekend sick – from spending so much time wet and cold when she was refusing to go back to the dorm, or from stress, who knows, but sleeping in the communal lounge in soaking clothes definitely didn't help – and avoiding her friends whenever possible. Glimmer and Bow both try to talk to her about what happened and Adora only roughly explains how the visits started. When they try to bring up the final one or what she told Catra over the course of them, she shuts down. Glimmer tries to lecture her once about ever starting to visit Catra and Adora disappears for eight hours afterwards. Glimmer doesn't try again after that. By Monday, Adora is still waiting for the Alliance to call a meeting to decide her fate. After all, she proved she couldn't be trusted when she broke their one strict rule.

She understands the dangers, that's why she obeyed for so long, but it's such *bullshit*. She wishes she had just told Catra a year ago, but she couldn't bring herself to fail all the expectations on her. She tried to balance everything and in doing so failed *everyone*. She goes in circles in her head, mad at herself, mad at fate, and sometimes mad at the Alliance or even – completely unreasonably – at Catra for not being willing to wait or hear her out, but she knows she's ultimately the one who failed.

She's upset and doesn't want to go back to another interrogation in the dorm, so she heads down to the Alliance sanctum after class. There's a corner with a few spells set up to help with training. Beating up a magically-repairing dummy is what she needs right now. The sanctum looms around her, reminding her of her failures. Even when she tries to force her thoughts from the mess with Catra, there's always something else she fucked up waiting for her.

How is she worthy to be She-ra when she couldn't even manage something as simple as balancing her duties with school? All the rest of the Alliance has mastered it, but Adora is barely meeting the grade minimums for her aid with all the extra responsibility weighing on her. She's not the great mystical warrior She-ra is supposed to be, either, because she only notices she isn't alone anymore when she swings her entire body with an arc of her sword and catches something in the corner of her eye. She refuses to turn around to face her teammate, though. If she's lucky, Netossa was just coming by for something unrelated and doesn't want to talk to her. If she's unlucky, Netossa *does* and Adora is completely fucked.

Netossa could never hope to understand. She met Spinnerella young, the two heirs introduced via their mentors, and they fell in love. Netossa never had to hide anything from anyone important except maybe her parents, and even she has admitted that she's pretty sure they figured out who her aunt was and now know about her, they just never ask. Only Frosta and Perfuma can understand the *orphan* thing, and they at least have other family and had a mentor to talk with *once*.

"Are you going to talk about it before you manage to shatter Castaspella's glyphs?" Netossa asks from behind her. Adora lowers her sword arm to her side, panting heavily, and glances around her. Every dummy is in pieces and they are taking a concerning amount of time to stitch themselves back together. The Alliance is only going to be more upset with her if she makes Castaspella come down here. They hate bringing Glimmer's aunt in, even if she has known Angella's – and by extension, now Glimmer's – identity ever since Micah's death.

Just another person in Glimmer's life she gets to tell the truth to while Adora struggled in silence.

"Not if I can help it," Adora grunts back, picking up parts of the dummies and forcing them together again so they can knit together faster. Netossa barks a laugh.

"Hey, remember that I offered you the easy way," she says. Adora opens her mouth, about to say nothing about this is *easy*, when Netossa cuts her off by casting a net right at her without even transforming first.

Adora's hands are currently occupied with the dummies. She doesn't have time to get at a good angle to cut through the net when it flies at her, wrapping around the sword and dummies. Netossa raises an eyebrow as Adora scowls and yanks her hands out from the mess, setting to untangling them.

"Don't bother. Drop the goddess act. I need to talk to you like the dumb kid you are," Netossa says, her voice warm despite her words. If it were anyone else – well, anyone but Netossa or Angella – Adora would probably try to continue to ignore her, but she knows it's hopeless. She'll find herself in a dozen layers of nets if that's what it takes to have this conversation. With a frustrated huff, she releases the sword, watching it fade away in golden light. A moment later, She-ra disappears too, leaving just Adora in her place, feeling like she has shrunk much more than a foot and a half.

She shoves her hands in her pockets and turns to face Netossa, even if she doesn't look her in the eyes.

"Catra's never met you. You're safe," she mutters. The Alliance are all friends, but they try to avoid leaving much trace of their friendship online to make it harder to unmask them all, so the only people at risk now are the ones that she hangs out with enough for Catra to know and be able to match up their appearances.

"Adora, I'm not worried about me. I mean, you should have told us first, but I can guess that it was a spur-of the-moment-thing. It's hard to know when you don't *tell* us, though," Netossa returns. Adora almost asks who she's worried about, but she's sure the Alliance has put together a list of which members Catra has met by now. She has kind of been avoiding the group chat. When she glanced at it, she saw an angry message from Frosta and immediately decided to stop looking.

"I told Glimmer some stuff," Adora says, nudging the pile of dummies with her foot. It's too still, too quiet in here. She misses the sounds of fighting reflecting off the walls.

"Either it was barely anything or she didn't share a lot of it," Netossa returns, her tone dry. Adora sighs and looks up.

"Fine, what do you want to know?" she asks, already preparing for the worst. She wishes her team had picked anyone else for the interrogation.

"The parts you need to talk about," Netossa returns. Adora stares at her. Her mouth opens, then closes.

“I don’t want to talk about any of it,” she returns. Netossa rolls her eyes. Of course she isn’t settling for any of it.

“I said need, not want.” Yeah, okay, but Adora doesn’t need anything from the Alliance except for them to not kick her out. Netossa looks unimpressed with her silence. “You’ve always put She-ra above everything else, even your basic needs. If you broke that oath, you must have been doing bad, and you’re not going to become okay again by ignoring it. So I’m here, because I know I’m going to do a better job of this than Glimmer and we’re all worried about you,” Netossa says.

Adora’s breath hitches and her head raises without her own command.

“Oh,” she breathes. A smile twitches at Netossa’s lips. Adora squeezes her eyes shut against the tears pressing at the back of them. “Aren’t they mad?” she asks. She would be afraid of the answer if she hadn’t already known it for days. She peeks up and watches Netossa shrug.

“Annoyed, maybe. That’s mostly Mermista, now. Maybe Glimmer too at first, but it’s been obvious how bad you’ve been doing by how fast she changed her mind. And even if they were still annoyed, all of us were worried the moment we realized your comm went dark and we haven’t stopped being since,” Netossa returns. Adora swallows hard.

“Sorry,” she murmurs. Netossa looks at her for a long moment.

“Glimmer told us what you said about us failing you. You were right. We didn’t know you well enough at first to trust your judgement, but we should have by the time you needed to tell her. It was too late once we all knew that, though,” Netossa says. Adora’s definitely crying now.

“Thank you,” she gasps out. She needed *someone* to acknowledge how unfair it all was to them both. Netossa raises an arm and Adora doesn’t hesitate to stumble forward and hug her. Netossa throws an arm over her shoulders, hugging back.

“Just telling the truth,” she assures. Adora sniffles and pulls back, offering Netossa a small, grateful smile. “Now, what do we have to cover? I’ll admit there’s stuff I just want to know about, too,” Netossa prompts again, throwing Adora an easy smile to lighten the moment.

Adora doesn’t know where to even *start*.

--

Catra is standing on a subway platform, waiting for the next train, when she feels it. A familiar warmth, more electric and crackling than she’s used to, but it’s still the unmistakable aura of magic.

She whips her head around, but aside from a few other pedestrians waiting on the platform, there’s no one around. How pathetic is it that she’s hung around She-ra enough to start not

only recognizing the feeling of magic, but when the magic *isn't* hers?

How pathetic is it that she's fucking disappointed?

…In herself, she amends, because she does not want to see She-ra. Not now, not ever. She-ra was a lie, someone Catra thought might actually be interested in her, but it was just Adora all along, and Adora has proven who is more important to her. Catra is getting better at telling herself she doesn't want Adora back – better at remembering Adora doesn't want her the same way – but She-ra is a new, glaring blind spot.

She was- She was so *good*. Like Adora, but actually interested, going out of her way to be around. She was funny, and hot, and *sweet*, and did Catra mention actually there? Right now, she doesn't even want Adora back in the perfect fantasy where she apologizes for everything. It's clear she's not going to put Catra first. No, Catra wants She-ra back. She wants her to have been someone else the whole time so they can rewind back to the moment they kissed, only this time they have no reason to stop. She wants Adora to have never told her so she could – for once – get *something* she wants, but once again, Adora takes it away from her right on the precipice of her finally getting it.

If Adora had gone through with it only for Catra to find out the truth later, she might actually have joined the Horde for an excuse to shoot a laser at her ex, but right *now* Catra is just upset with Adora's assbackwards morals ruining what was apparently a fucking fantasy. It couldn't compare – yet – to twenty years with Adora, but things with She-ra felt so good, so fast, that Catra thought they could have had something special. She knows why that was *now*, but she misses when she didn't.

She's really fucked up, and she blames that for why she pulls out her phone. She's emotionally spiraling, and lonely, and she has a really awful idea. Maybe Adora will think she is fucking pathetic, but it's not like Catra is in her life to feel that judgement anyway, especially if she says *no*.

She just wants to go back to feeling like it's possible someone would make her a priority. She opens her stagnant text conversation with Adora.

--

I expect princess at my apartment at 9:30. And I don't want to fucking see you

You're inviting me but don't want to see me?

I'm inviting princess
Real fucking inconvenient for me that you happen to share a number

Okay

Adora’s hands shake as she types her response. She wasn’t expecting Catra to reach out and she definitely wasn’t expecting *this*. Somehow, she has a suspicion what Catra wants. Maybe it’s just that there aren’t a lot of options outside of reconnecting and it’s clearly not *that*. She is going to come, though. She’ll take anything Catra offers – any chance between them – now that she knows.

Catra doesn’t send her any further clarification, but Adora doesn’t need it.

Chapter End Notes

The Alliance were more reasonable than Adora ever gave them credit for, but she was so quick to take on responsibility and so loathe to admit when she needed something it was kind of impossible for her to know that. They had plenty of good reasons not to want Catra to know at first, but time has made a lot clear. As will the rest of this fic since there's more to explain lol.
Next chapter’s going to be fun 😊

Chapter 8: I Like the Idea of You

Chapter Notes

> I Like (the idea of) You is a song by Tessa Violet that honestly has little to do with this chapter, but the title fit.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra leaves her window open after she gets home and changes. She keeps a close eye on the time, unsure if she should expect Adora at all no matter what she said, but light flashes outside her window exactly one minute before she expected her. There's no flare hanging in the air there, but a moment later She-ra jumps down and stands on *something* that definitely shouldn't be there. Catra intended to be pretty dismissive, but she's curious, so she crosses the room without greeting and glances down. She-ra is standing on a crescent of rainbow light, watching her carefully.

"Since when can you make platforms?" Catra asks, keeping her tone of voice bored as she steps aside and jerks her head back to gesture for She-ra to come inside. She-ra hesitates, but she climbs through the window.

"Two months ago, maybe. They're pretty temporary and I can only make a few at once," she explains, pausing once again before she closes the window behind her and then turns to Catra.

Catra plans to play denial *hard* tonight, but for once she lets herself looks at She-ra and see Adora beneath her. Her body has become ridiculously ripped, and obviously there's the height thing, but she doesn't stand the same way either. She-ra's stance is solid and always has been, like she's ready to jump into battle at a moment's notice. Adora is clumsy, and though she can be cocky, she doesn't default to self-assured like She-ra does. Things Catra has said that she knows would fluster Adora have bounced right off She-ra, or she answered in kind. Maybe the anonymity gave her confidence, but Catra suspects she has more control of her reactions like this.

Tonight Catra can *feel* how nervous She-ra is, especially now she knows to look for Adora's tells, even if the differences are still there. She wanders her eyes back up to She-ra's face. The glow of her eyes is dim, letting Catra see her expression beneath and how she is watching her. Catra raises a brow at her, not enjoying She-ra's discomfort as much as she thought she would, but she does enjoy the way She-ra's eyes flick down before meeting Catra's again.

Catra is wearing a black satin bralette and a mesh crop top she bought on shopping therapy trip with Scorpia after the breakup. Her leggings are thin enough to be slightly see-through and she accentuated that with red underwear just to make sure She-ra caught it. It's an outfit

she bought intending to wear whenever she wanted to go out and break some hearts, but it turns out rebounding didn't hold much interest for her until She-ra came along.

It's still a *fuck me* outfit and she doesn't mind flaunting it in front of Adora. She-ra. Dammit.

"How was your week?" She-ra tries – actually, *Adora* tries, because that was way too pathetic for She-ra. Catra sends her an unimpressed look before trailing her eyes down her body. She would rather claw her own face than have a conversation with Adora right now.

"Awful. Now if we could skip the small talk, you ran out on something important last week that I'd like to pick back up," Catra keeps her gaze bored as she trails it back up to She-ra's glowing eyes. It's an open challenge, and she holds Ador- *She-ra's* gaze, waiting to see what she is going to do. If she's going to try to talk, or tell Catra to fuck off, or drop the disguise completely. If she does go along with it, there's no telling how *far* she'll be willing to go.

It's probably a cruel request, pretending Adora doesn't exist so Catra can go back to the fantasy where somebody else cares about her, but Adora was cruel to do all of this to her, so Catra can focus on her own hurt instead. She-ra doesn't look surprised. Catra is kind of impressed. She-ra does seem indecisive, though, glancing across the room – at the couch they were on before it all went wrong last week – and then back at Catra's outfit before she meets her gaze.

"Are you sure?" She-ra asks, her voice soft without many layers, like it was the first few times she opened up to Catra and made her feel stupid emotions for her. They only fucked her over, so she might as well *actually fuck her* this time. Catra scoffs, her tail dancing behind her, irritated.

"You've kept me waiting long enough," Catra replies and immediately clenches her jaw. Too real. If she can't keep up the act, Adora definitely won't be able to, and she needs to just have one fucking night where things are okay again. She was so *happy* when She-ra was around and she didn't even notice until she was gone. She has been utterly miserable and angry for the last week, barely able to force herself through school and work. Adora owes this to her just to give her some escape so she can put her life back on track.

The glow fades from She-ra's eyes, making the edge of sadness in them obvious, and she nods. For a moment, neither of them moves. Catra half expects Adora to call her an asshole, and the rest of her is questioning whether she even wants this if She-ra is going to be looking at her like that the entire time instead of, you know, being *actually interested* considering that was her whole appeal, but then She-ra reaches up and cups her cheek, fingers slotting in under her ear and stroking softly.

Oh. Now that Catra knows, Adora doesn't have to pretend to be an idiot about hybrids anymore. Catra can feel her fur fluffing up just at the careful touch, and with how revealing her outfit is, she knows it's obvious. She-ra's breath hitches and her eyes trail down Catra's shoulders. Catra flashes her claws and watches She-ra's eyes zero in on her hands.

She always thought Adora had a thing for her claws. As much as Catra wants to delude herself about everything tonight, it's also a test. Catra has spent the last year thinking that Adora lied to her and led her on, only saying she liked Catra because she knew a relationship

is the one thing that would make Catra stay because of how badly she wanted her. Then She-ra showed up and was clearly attracted to her. Now Catra knows they're the same person – now she knows why Adora really didn't show up, even if all the lying was shitty and she's never going to forgive her – she wants to see for herself which parts were true.

"Kind of had other places in mind for where your hands could be," Catra points out, her tone dry. A smile quirks She-ra's lips and she looks up to meet her eyes. She takes a single step forward, but with her long legs it's easy for that step to bring them chest-to-chest. Catra's tail lashes wildly as she tilts her head up, sending She-ra a defiant look in case she thinks that a little bit of height is going to give her the advantage.

Sliding her free hand around Catra's back and running her fingers down the base of her lashing tail just *might,* though. Catra shivers, involuntarily leaning into Adora's hand on her cheek as she does.

"Did I guess right?" She-ra asks, her tone low and cocky. The voices layering beneath hers all share the same intonation, making it feel more singular than usual. Catra can hear her smirk in her tone. She-ra's hand is still playing at the base of her tail. She runs her fingers down it, then raises them again and squeezes carefully. Warmth radiates from She-ra, flushing heat through Catra's body. Catra huffs, trying to seem dismissive and ending up far too flustered.

"No," she grits out, constraining her voice to keep any sign of *moaning* out of it. Is she really so pathetic that a hand on her tail is all it takes? She-ra being close enough that Catra practically has her face in her tits probably isn't helping either, but it's the intimacy that is getting to her. Adora used to pet her tail a lot, and She-ra has touched it too, but never *here* where it's most sensitive.

"Aw, damn, I thought I had it," She-ra says, her tone still cheeky. Catra pins her ears back and looks up to glare at She-ra. She smirks down at her. "Let me try something else," she says in the least innocent tone possible. Her hand slides down to grope Catra's ass, which is definitely closer to what Catra was thinking, but then She-ra's hand leaves her face to grab her on the other side and lift her *up*. Wrapping her legs around She-ra's waist is *exactly* what she wanted.

Catra genuinely smiles for the first time in a week, placing her hands on She-ra's shoulders. She digs her claws in with just enough force to remind She-ra who she's messing with before she tries to pull something. Their faces are now only inches apart. She-ra's eyes are dark with lust, fixed on Catra's mouth, and her lips are parted. *This* is what Catra wanted – what they almost had before Adora grew a conscience last time.

"You want this?" She-ra – Adora, because that's a question coming from her and the layers have fallen away from her voice to prove it – asks, glancing up to meet Catra's eyes. She already asked, earlier, but Catra suspects this check-in is for Adora, not her – so Adora can assure herself and take down that last barrier of guilt, just giving in to what they both want. Well, what Catra *hopes* they both want. The reserved sadness from earlier is at least gone.

"Just kiss me already, princess," Catra returns, rolling her eyes. She-ra's eyes waver, and then she tilts her face up. Catra lets out a relieved breath and leans in to meet her halfway. Her whole body relaxes when She-ra kisses her. It's not the desperate feeling from last time,

thrilling and hot with passion, but it still feels good even in its slower pace. She hopes they do this hard, nothing soft or potentially emotional about it, but she's willing to ease into kissing at the start.

She-ra's hands on her tighten, pulling Catra in against her as the caution of the kiss slowly fades. Catra purrs as she nips at She-ra's lip, tugging on it and drinking in the groan she gets in return. The next kiss is fiercer, She-ra giving as good as Catra gave.

She-ra *wants* her. Sure, there's a hundred different caveats on it, but Catra is finally getting what she fucking wants and she can forget everything else to just enjoy it. She whines in the back of her throat as she tries arching in She-ra's hands and gets rewarded with a little bit of pressure from She-ra's abs against her. She-ra holds her steady, meeting every one of Catra's quickly frenzying kisses without any difficulty. Catra is already worked up between anticipating She-ra's arrival, the tail fondling, and the not-enough pressure now teasing her.

"Bed?" She-ra manages to get out, her breath hot against Catra's mouth, before Catra kisses her again. There's an electric edge to her kiss, the same tingle of magic that Catra now realizes must cover Adora's familiar scent. There's no trace of it below She-ra's scent.

"Bed," Catra pants back in confirmation, cutting off that thought quickly and focusing on her excitement for what She-ra is about to do. In her old fantasies, the other woman was in charge because Catra couldn't imagine She-ra would let anyone else top her, but now Catra wants her above her just to see She-ra, Adora, *someone* want her.

She-ra pulls away from the kiss just long enough to glance down and step over to the bed. She places a knee on the edge of the mattress, leaning forward as she sets Catra down like she weighs nothing. Catra strains more dealing with her *backpack*. Her tail lashes as she stretches back onto the bed, digging her claws into She-ra's shoulders and trying to pull her in for another kiss. She-ra can't be moved a goddamn *inch* if she doesn't want to be, though, and instead she pulls back.

For half a second, Catra panics, but then she realizes She-ra is just swinging her other leg up onto the bed. The frame gives an ominous creak as She-ra straddles her thighs, causing her to drop the cocky smile she was in the middle of forming. She quickly glances down.

"Are you sure your bed can take this?" She-ra asks, looking back to Catra's face. Apparently the past She-ras aren't getting in bed with them, because their voices haven't really come back since they first fell away. There's still a rough quality to She-ra's voice like there could be layers to it, but mostly it's just Adora. Catra wriggles experimentally and the bed doesn't make another sound. She-ra doesn't look very assured, but it's good enough for Catra.

"The frame is metal, and if it doesn't hold up, I've always wanted to brag about breaking one anyway," she returns, making pointed eye contact with She-ra again as she adjusts her position and subtly arches her tits up. She-ra's eyes flick down just like Catra wanted. There's a soft glow to them, but they're far from beaming like they usually do and Catra can easily track her movements and expression.

"I'll try not to make any sudden movements," She-ra jokes – at least Catra *hopes* it's a joke, because she wants it hard and fast – and then she leans down and kisses Catra again. This one

is more languid and Catra lets it stay that way for a minute, sinking into She-ra's soft lips. As turned on as she is right now, even just kissing is incredible, especially when She-ra's hands slide up her sides, wrapping around her waist. They're so strong, not quite large enough to completely wrap around but feeling like they *could*.

She-ra pulls on her, forcing her back to arch, and Catra moans. She-ra doesn't let go as she presses her body down on her, pinning Catra and claiming her mouth. When Catra *gets* to breathe between the kisses, it's labored. She can feel how each of her breaths presses their chests together even more. She-ra is a lot more composed, but Catra is hoping that's magic bullshit and not from a lack of interest.

That won't stand. Catra slides one hand around the back of She-ra's head and massages her claws against her scalp, remembering how She-ra seemed to like claws in her hair before. She-ra moans, finally moving her hands again to run them down Catra's sides until they can slip beneath the hem of her mesh top. She-ra pushes it up and Catra immediately tries to arch to make it easier, but She-ra is so solid above her that she doesn't move either of them at all. *Fuck*. She's so lucky She-ra doesn't have magicat senses, because she can smell how turned on she is just from a little straining. There's a lot of pent-up desperation beneath her skin. The make out is letting out some of it, and if Adora randomly feels guilty again she can content herself with this, but she wants *more*.

Breathless from how stupidly horny she is, she tilts her head back so she can draw in a few pants.

"You've got my whole body to work with, princess," Catra reminds, her voice husky. She-ra pauses, looking up. Her luminescent eyes search Catra's before she nods, sitting back and pulling Catra's mesh shirt the rest of the way up. Catra quickly lifts her arms, letting She-ra remove the imaginary piece of clothing. She falls back into the sheets, tilting her head back and looking down at She-ra through her bottom lashes. Visually, it's not much of a difference from when the shirt was on, but it still feels like it. As little coverage as the top gave her, it at least felt like a shirt when it was on her.

Now she's topless with She-ra looming over her, eyes roaming over her body. The look is dark and makes Catra press her thighs together. She-ra's gaze flicks up for a moment, making burning eye contact before she descends. She ducks to Catra's jaw, kissing it once and then nudging under to press open-mouthed kisses down the line of her throat. The cool metal of She-ra's mask is a shocking contrast to the flush in Catra's face as the hunger within her grows, an incessant need that She-ra only teases higher with every filthy kiss to her neck.

She-ra pulls back and Catra growls, glaring at her as she shifts far enough back to reestablish eye contact.

"Can I take off my mask?" She-ra asks. Her voice and eyes don't give anything away, but Catra's tail does as it lashes beneath her. She wants to say no. She wants to make a painful comment about how she can't do that because it will reveal her identity, making it clear she isn't thinking about Adora at all while they do this.

It is kind of weird, though. She doesn't want to see more of her face – to see *Adora* – but she does want to feel her skin. Adora is already going along with this. Catra can let her have the

mask.

“Fine,” she bites out, making it clear it easily could have gone the other way. Now She-ra’s expression is clear relief as she nods and closes her eyes. Catra – apparently foolishly – thought She-ra would reach up and remove it, but instead it dissolves into weightless magic sparkles, warm lights dancing for a moment before they wink out again and She-ra opens her eyes.

Catra’s fur is standing on end. It’s Adora’s face, whatever distance she wants to create in her mind. A little bigger to go with her new proportions, sure, but it’s still her ex-best friend staring down at her with an edge of concern in those giant blue eyes. Catra growls and yanks Adora in, directing her straight down into her neck.

“*Bite*,” she instructs, and Adora does, nipping at her neck far softer than Catra wants. Catra gives a low growl as Adora presses an overly-sweet kiss against the same spot, but it turns into a gasp when she finally bites for *real*. Catra groans, her hips and tail shifting as she searches for friction, relief, *something*. She almost moans a please. Instead she turns it into a strangled *fuck* at the same time that She-ra’s hands roam over her chest to squeeze. She-ra bites her again as she slips her fingers beneath the edge of her bralette, toying with her nipple.

Catra is sensitive and the light touch immediately has her gasping and arching up. She isn’t sure if She-ra is taking her time, taking a *normal* amount of time, or just playing with her, but Catra is worked up enough that there’s nothing on her mind except the ache between her legs. That’s how she wants it, all the weighty emotions pushed aside so she can just feel good for once, if She-ra would *hurry up*.

“Take it off,” Catra instructs, voice breathy. Dammit. It’s hard to be composed when She-ra’s teeth are digging into her shoulder, though. She-ra presses a soft kiss to spot she just bit as she considers it. She pinches Catra’s nipple and speaks over Catra’s gasp.

“Take what off?” She-ra asks, innocently. Catra growls, her tail lashing as she arches up, trying to make her point clear. To make things worse, She-ra leans back and Catra has to watch Adora send her a smug smirk.

“Stop trying to be cute, it’s not working,” Catra returns, slipping her hands beneath her back to undo the damn clasp for herself. Adora’s gaze trails down to watch, her eyes bright.

“I don’t know, you seem pretty worked up right now,” she says. There’s a satisfied hum in her voice even though her real focus is clear as she watches Catra. Right as Catra has undone the small clasps, She-ra moves, her hands finding Catra’s wrists and tugging them away. Catra tries to fight it, briefly, but it doesn’t seem to make any difference as She-ra tugs her wrists above her head, gathering them in one hand and pinning them there.

Catra closes her eyes and growls. She hopes She-ra will take it as annoyance and not Catra being so turned on she doesn’t know how to deal with it. The urge to bite her is strong, but there’s nothing *to* bite with She-ra shifted back so she can watch.

"*Princess*," Catra groans, hoping She-ra will get the message and just fucking touch her. She-ra's free hand runs over her side before she hooks her fingers under Catra's shoulder strap. Catra opens her eyes to watch She-ra tug on the bralette, pulling it away from Catra's chest. She-ra's lust is obvious as she pulls the bralette up, only looking up to make heated eye contact with Catra after it passes over her face. She shoves it up to leave it wrapped around Catra's wrists, not releasing the pin to remove it fully. Somehow the thin clothing staying around her arms, half removed, only makes Catra's body feel hotter. She *needs* to be touched, but she's still fully dressed from the waist down.

"So impatient. I should drag this out and teach you to wait," She-re remarks with all the hot confidence that fueled Catra's first few fantasies. Catra feels a violent flush as her body temperature seemingly raises a few degrees, some growly kind of trill starting and then getting strangled in her throat as she tries not to be a bottom *mess*.

They need to do this again just so she can ruin Adora and put her in her place.

She-ra. Fuck. She's so turned she isn't thinking straight.

"Don't you fucking-" Catra cuts off with a moan as She-ra ducks and *kisses* the opposite nipple to the one she was toying with, immediately laving her tongue over it. Her thoughts reduce mostly to *fuck* and *more*.

"Oh, I'm sorry, were you going to tell me to stop?" She-ra returns, lifting her head to send Catra the most annoying smile ever. Catra growls and tugs at her wrists, but she only gets stupidly wet when She-ra doesn't budge at all.

"Stop making me *wait*," she growls back. She-ra's smile doesn't turn any less satisfied as she ducks her head, doing her best to keep eye contact as she sucks Catra's nipple into her mouth. Catra immediately cries out, apparently loud enough for concern because She-ra hurriedly pulls off and even her grip on Catra's wrists slackens, *finally* letting Catra pull them free.

"Was that okay?" Adora breathes, voice obviously worried, as Catra hisses and untangles the bralette from around her wrists. She helps even though Catra had it, tossing it aside without looking away from Catra with those too-big eyes. Catra growls low in the back of her throat and reaches up, wrapping her hand around the base of She-ra's dumb golden ponytail.

"It's fine, they're just sensitive. It doesn't feel as good as *some* places you could be touching right now," Catra instructs, pulling She-ra in for another kiss. She-ra's worry must ease because she smiles a little into it, parting her lips and letting Catra's tongue explore. Catra still has no clue when she's doing, she just has a desperate need and She-ra doesn't seem in a hurry to help. Any form of contact helps, and no matter what kind of *technique* Catra does or doesn't have, She-ra's tongue against hers is hot, sending sparks shivering down her spine.

She-ra pulls back and the look she gives Catra has her thighs squeezing again. She's wet enough her underwear is kind of uncomfortable at this point.

"Just another reason to take my time," She-ra intones, more infuriating than any of her previous statements despite how her tone is less smug, a softer edge beneath it. That might be why, actually; it's *sincere*. Catra growls back, but before she can reprimand her, She-ra ducks

down and kisses her other nipple. The sight alone makes Catra keen, dropping her head back so she doesn't have to see Adora's damn face looking up at her with those weird blue eyes.

She wants to go back to the pin, because at least that wasn't *sweet*, but Adora keeps dropping shit like that in when all Catra wants is to get fucked already. At least Catra's hands being free means She-ra's hands are too. She reaches up, playing with Catra's chest on the other side. Catra plays with her chest sometimes – duh, boobs are great – but her nipples are the kind of sensitive that veers towards painful and she doesn't mess with them often. She-ra's mouth is a different story.

Catra is losing her mind, but everything She-ra is doing only makes the hunger inside her grow stronger. She tries to shift her legs apart and finds them completely stopped by She-ra's thighs bracketing her own, but at least she draws She-ra's attention. She releases Catra's chest. When Catra looks down, a string of spit is still connecting Adora's lips and her nipple. Catra moans, her hips shifting involuntarily, as She-ra finishes rising, snapping it in the process.

"How about-" She-ra starts to propose, leaning in and nuzzling at Catra's cheek. At first Catra thinks she's trying to mark herself with her scent, and then she realizes she's doing that *and* positioning herself to whisper in Catra's ears, "-you occupy yourself with my thigh while I take my time appreciating you naked, and then I'll fuck you until you've lost count?" She-ra all but *purrs* to her.

Anything beyond basic instinct abandons Catra, she just gasps out a desperate "*Yes*," and then finds Adora's thigh shoved between her own. She pants out a moan as she shifts, rocking her hips until she manages to position herself so she can get some pressure. It's a false relief, not enough to get her off and definitely enough to drive her wild, but it's *something* after all the teasing and it's an excuse to finally release her sounds without feeling pathetic.

She should probably care more about being reserved with Adora openly watching her, expression caught between ravenous and *awestruck*, but right now she can't quite remember where her plan to fuck Adora over and get fucked at the same time was going, so she lets her eyes fall closed as she shamelessly rocks down on She-ra's thigh. A moment later, She-ra's hands are on her, petting and squeezing and feeling her up, so she really can't imagine she had anything better than this planned. The hands on her body and pressure between her thighs are incredible, so she lets herself sink down into the feeling of her own moans.

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After a few minutes of grinding, Catra is far gone enough to let Adora start murmuring how beautiful she is into her skin as her lips skim over it. Her chest is heaving beneath Adora as she presses kisses to the stripes on her ribs, lost in her own pleasure between the desperate sounds Catra is making and the sight of her writhing.

“So gorgeous, I never want to stop touching you,” Adora promises, her left hand finding where Catra has one fisted in the sheets and gently extracting it. Sure, she still hears fabric rip beneath Catra’s claws, but that would have happened anyway. Catra whines, her other hand coming up to cover her face so she can just barely peek out to watch as Adora kisses the base of each of her claws. Catra purrs, the sound uneven and rattling with her breathlessness, as Adora carefully sucks her index finger into her mouth. Her claws are out and Adora can feel the sharp edge against her tongue, but all it does is excite her.

“You can keep these out. I’ll heal anything you do to me,” Adora promises as she lets the digit slip back out past her lips. It felt so good to have her mouth wrapped around Catra, even just her finger, that she kind of wants to try eating her out, but that isn’t really a *first time* kind of thing. Besides, she’s very clear on what Catra wants from her.

It isn’t what she is going to give her, at least not if she can get away with it, but she’ll come close. Catra moans at her words, rocking her hips down onto Adora’s thigh.

“I was planning on it, princess,” Catra pants back, apparently still set on seeming in control despite how obviously *ruined* she is. Her fur is a mess from Adora’s explorations, her eyes are dilated, her entire body is flushed, and even through both of their clothes Adora can feel how wet she is on her thigh. Adora smiles to herself as she kisses Catra’s palm, and then the inside of her wrist, making her way up her arm.

“I love how cocky you are, too,” she pauses to look up and send her a look that conveys just how turned on she is, “even when you know you’ve lost,” she finishes in a low rumble. Catra growls back, but with the way her eyes squeeze shut – and her thighs *try* to around Adora’s own – she gets nowhere close to sounding like a threat. Adora was closer to it, and that was a *promise*.

“I don’t see your fingers in me yet,” Catra huffs back. She’s way too far gone to come up with anything better as she tries to wriggle her hips and get something out of Adora’s positioning. There have been a few moments where her shifting grew rapid enough, combined with increasingly desperate moans, that Adora thought she might get off, but every moment has been followed with Catra obviously being left unsatisfied, falling back with a growl as she lies still and pants to recover before starting her shifting again.

“I’m pretty sure that’s when you win,” Adora chuckles, but she decides to finally take pity on Catra and shifts back, hooking her fingers into Catra’s waistband. Catra releases the most relieved moan Adora has heard yet, her arm falling back to the mattress from her face as she goes limp. She purrs quietly as Adora peels her leggings down her thighs. It’s fucking cute, so Adora pauses in the middle of undressing her to lean up and kiss her.

Catra sighs into the kiss, soft, and lets Adora take a minute to just sink into her before a hand finds her ponytail and pointedly tugs *down*.

“Off,” she orders, breathless. Adora grins and does as she’s told. Catra’s underwear looks pretty, maybe even fancy, so Adora marks it as a shame she’s paying no attention to it, but it’s so ruined by this point it has to go along with her leggings without ever getting a chance to frame Catra like she clearly bought it to do. It’s not like she needs anything to help her appreciate Catra more, anyway.

The scent that hits the air when Catra's naked thighs shift apart fills Adora's nose and hits the back of her throat, making her mouth water. She instantly feels a *need* to taste Catra, so she lifts one of Catra's knees over her shoulder and busies her mouth with kissing and biting her thigh, holding eye contact with Catra as she works her way up.

"You're so *wet*. Can you even tell what you smell like when it's your own scent? I want to eat you alive. That's not what you want, though, is it?" she asks, her voice rough from her own desire. Catra whines, her thigh flexing as she seemingly kicks her feet behind Adora's head.

"I can ride She-ra's face *later*, just fuck me already," she returns, the embodiment of *bratty*. If Adora's voice is rough, Catra's is sandpaper, utterly strung out. Adora smiles as she kisses a point about halfway up Catra's thigh and finds it damp. She darts her tongue out to lick it and groans to herself. Yeah, definitely later – once Catra isn't sore anymore, anyway.

"So desperate, kitten. I'm not done appreciating you," Adora purrs back. Catra gasps out and arches her hips, trying to wrap her leg more around Adora's shoulders so she can pull her in closer, but she might as well kick a brick wall. Adora isn't budging. She does kiss her way higher, though, because even if she is going to fulfill Catra's request, she wants more of that intoxicating taste. Despite saying "She-ra" for her proposal, Catra knows she's with Adora now and she doesn't get offended by the use of *kitten*, instead straining for more.

Despite saying she only wanted the lie of She-ra like this, not Adora, that's something she wanted from Adora that she never liked from She-ra.

"Appreciate me while two fingers deep or I'm going to fuck my damn self," Catra threatens, voice shaking. She's so *gone*, Adora can't help but marvel at her. She felt a lot of conflicting emotions when she first arrived, but she can't think or care about much beyond the woman beneath her when Catra looks, sounds, *smells*, like this.

"I can do both," Adora promises before biting her inner thigh – hard – and being rewarded with Catra's voice breaking as she cries out. Adora moans herself, soaking in her own endorphins from every desperate sound Catra gives her. Finally, Adora reaches up the last few inches and cards her fingers through Catra's damp curls. They're trimmed decently short, but they were plastered against her from the grinding. It's so fucking hot just to be touching Catra's damp, and Catra must agree because she stops whining and purrs quietly to herself.

Adora runs her fingers over her slit, spreading her while she still has her hips pulled up so she can watch – and maybe assess, maybe form a battle plan, she really should have looked some things up before she came here because she doesn't know how reliable her experience with her own body will be when it comes to Catra – before she leans forward and kisses her clit softly. She wasn't exactly planning to do it, but the urge came over her and it was clearly a *good* one considering how incredible Catra tastes on her tongue and the way she cries out, jerking her hips up to try to get pressure.

"I thought you said later," Adora teases, pulling back and finally slipping Catra's thigh off her shoulder so she can settle her hips against the bed. Catra lets out a strangled and unintelligible *guh*. Her right hand twitches in the sheets and Adora has a feeling she was going to flip her off before she realized she didn't have the energy to disentangle her claws from the sheets. Catra is right where she wants her: a soaking wet *mess* too far gone to tell

Adora off when she enacts her real plan. She shifts up on the bed, getting in position so she can easily support her own weight while leaving her hands free to touch Catra. One she keeps on her thigh, ostensibly holding it open but really just letting her run her hand over it as she drags the fingers of her other over Catra's slit.

She's wet enough there isn't a sign of friction as Adora's fingers reach her entrance. Catra lets out a quiet moan in the back of her throat, her hips weakly twitching up, but she's spent from the earlier grinding.

"That's it, just let me take care of you," Adora murmurs to her, rubbing her fingers insistently but pulling them back before they can properly slide inside. Catra lets out a quiet, vulnerable sound, but it sounds affirmative. Adora drops a kiss to Catra's side.

"That's it. Let me know if anything's too much, okay?" Adora assures, keeping her voice low. Catra gasps out a clear *yes*, nodding frantically. Adora smiles as she finally presses one finger in. Catra is soaking and open, easily enveloping her finger down to the base. Aside from a hitch to her breathing, there's no obvious sign of relief, so Adora pulls back. When she adds a second finger, Catra moans, her hips twitching again, so Adora decides to start with that, gently thrusting into the warm heat of Catra's walls.

Adora has always liked fingering, even just doing it on herself, and maybe it's from the knowledge that she's inside *Catra*, but feeling her walls twitch down around her fingers is enough to have Adora biting back her own moans. Distantly, she decides sex might just be ecstasy, and then she corrects it to *sex with Catra* when she angles her hand just right and Catra lets out a purring trill. Compared to the desperate shifting of the last few minutes, Adora can tell she's doing it right because Catra goes *still*, finally getting enough pleasure from Adora that she doesn't have to work for it.

"Fuck, you're gorgeous. I can't imagine anything more beautiful than you like this," Adora breathes to her, rewarded with another small purr as Catra turns her head so she can rub her cheek against the pillow, her eyes closed. "You feel so good, like everything I imagined. I think I want to fuck you every day for the rest of my life," Adora promises her, leaning up and kissing her face. Catra lets out a soft gasp, nuzzling back as her tail begins to pick up speed to make up for the rest of her lying back.

"There you are," she breathes, mostly to herself, and it's stupid how a mostly meaningless statement is filled with so much emotion. She wants to blurt out how much she loves her, but even swimming in her own endorphins, she knows that would be a bad idea. She doesn't want to ruin this when Catra is finally letting go and just letting Adora take care of her.

Fuck, her mouth is *dry*.

"You're so incredible, Catra. I'm going to be thinking about this every time I get off for the rest of my *life*. You- fuck, your pussy feels so good," Adora growls out, stuttering when Catra twitches hard around her fingers. "Do you think you can take another finger? I want to hear you moaning again," Adora asks, breathless and greedy, but apparently so is Catra, because she nods desperately.

It's a little tight, but Catra's body allows Adora to slip in a third finger with only a rough moan that hardly counts as protest. When Adora begins to slowly rock her again, Catra's tail lashes wildly and she twitches down to meet each thrust, the movement small and weak but still obvious with Adora's fingers buried inside her.

"Good girl. You take it so well," Adora praises, utterly breathless, but she can't shut up. This was the whole plan, anyway. The moan that rips from Catra's throat is loud enough to rattle off the walls. Adora grins, pressing another kiss against Catra's chest. "Just like that. You're so good for me," Adora promises her. Catra's moans are wrecked, small and almost anguished, but Adora can tell it's from how badly she needs it. She still hasn't – really – touched her clit, but the way Catra's thighs are falling further open so she can angle into the thrusts makes it clear she doesn't want *this* to stop.

Her breaths are synced with each thrust, a moan tinging each. Adora feels ruined and desperate just from how badly she needs Catra and how stupidly in love with her she is. She can't *imagine* how Catra feels with all this. That's probably why she's letting Adora praise her without protest or any attempt to order her around. Adora anticipated that, though. That, combined with wanting to actually get to touch Catra like she has always dreamed, is why she took so long winding her up.

"Fuck, Catra, you're so amazing. You're *perfect*. I can't imagine ever wanting anyone more. I'm so lucky to get to see you like this." Adora has to pause in the middle of her speech for Catra to loudly moan, and she uses the opportunity to completely change the pattern of her thrusting, going for a few short, hard ones that have Catra giving a sustained cry, the sound rising with each until Adora eases off and returns to steady thrusts. Catra whines with frustration, absently hitting her fist on the mattress as she kicks her feet and throws the cutest tantrum in existence.

"*Please*, just let me come," she whines. It probably isn't supposed to be begging – or maybe her filter finally turned off – but it's still a desperate plea. Adora isn't more in control than she is, though, and her thrusts speed up without her ever commanding them to, sending Catra moaning again.

"Just a minute, kitten, I'm not done telling you how much I love you." Catra's noise of needy frustration is almost enough to make Adora break, but she isn't done. "I've wanted this as long as I've been able to want. You wouldn't take it from me, would you?" Adora asks. Catra releases a growling purr that is probably supposed to be a threat but just makes Adora grin. "I know. You would be the cruelest supervillain in existence," she drops her voice an octave, "but none of them will ever have anything worse to hold over me than taking this away. I want you like this more than I want anything in the world," Adora tells her, kissing Catra because her mouth desperately needs to be satisfied with her desire this strong. The words are too much for Catra, small cries ripping from her with every thrust and synced breath.

"*Adora*," she finally moans out, too lost for anything else, including her own denial. That's where Adora's own self-control *breaks*.

She finally got Catra to say her name. This is Catra and Adora, She-ra's additional size and stamina just a benefit. This is Catra being ruined for *her*. Adora's thrusts turn hard and fast, still varying them with slower patches so she can make sure she isn't hurting Catra – and to

drive her *wild* – as she finally shifts into a better position and drops her other hand to her clit. Just because it's a better angle than she was at before doesn't mean it's a *good* one for using both hands, but Catra is so far gone that finesse doesn't really matter. Adora is still trying to figure out what way Catra likes to be touched when Catra begins crying out, her legs twitching in and toes curling.

A few hard, short thrusts and some sustained pressure circling her clit later, Catra's single cry breaks into a bunch of small sobs and she drops back into the sheets, going limp. Adora shifts to slow, *slow* thrusts, dragging her fingers in and out and just pressing her palm broadly near her clit to give her enough pressure to work through it as Catra catches her breath in desperate gasps.

There aren't tears in her eyes yet. She isn't worked enough. Right when Catra begins purring, hopefully a signal that she's ready to sink into endorphins now, Adora begins experimenting with how to touch her clit again. Catra gasps and her eyes fly open, but the naked surprise on her face is *hopeful*, not pained, so Adora keeps going.

It takes some experimenting, but the earlier orgasm loosened her, and the second time she comes, Catra screams her name to the ceiling.

Adora always used to love when Catra would purr *hey Adora* to her, a subtle flirtation only they knew the depth of, but she thinks she might have just found a new favorite intonation for her name.

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It's three or four orgasms. Or five. Fuck, she doesn't know, she just knows the next time Adora tries to slowly work her through it, Catra reaches down and weakly pushes her hand away, too breathless to tell her that she can't take another. She feels incredible but she's fucking *ruined*. Adora immediately slides her hands away, though, pressing a kiss against the crease of her thigh and hips, and then into her curls, without any seeming disappointment. Then again, Catra has her face half-buried into the pillow where she's gasping and recovering, so opening her eyes and checking on Adora's expression is kind of beyond her.

Her purr and own heartbeat are pretty much all she hears, but Adora's fingers are so soaked from *Catra* being soaked that she still hears a slick sound as Adora slides them into her mouth and licks them clean. A moment later, there's a flash of warmth and light. A body falls beside her own with the same kind of spent sigh as Catra gave a moment before.

The body is the same size as her own. In the back of her mind, something reminds Catra that she should reprimand Adora, but her thoughts are mostly reduced to static and endorphins, so instead she nuzzles closer. Adora gasps either because she needs to anyway or because Catra didn't reject her outright, and then she reaches for her. Catra's purr doesn't pause as Adora gathers her in her arms and pulls her close so they can cuddle. Catra rubs her cheek against

everything she can reach, which is definitely intended to be the pillow and Adora just happens to get in the way.

The last time she was in Adora's presence, she was way too fucked up to pay attention to much of anything aside from her own hurt, but now Adora's scent – with an extra layer of desire and satisfaction, which is a good thing because Catra is too spent to switch positions – fills her noses and she begins to knead as she nuzzles into a comfortable spot along Adora's neck. Adora appears to have been wearing regular clothes under her spandex, tank top straps grazing past Catra's cheek as she scent marks her. Catra shifts her legs and feels denim rub against her.

"Pants off. No jeans in the bed," Catra mumbles. She sounds *drunk* and having her face pressed into Adora certainly isn't helping, but Adora doesn't laugh at her, instead humming softly and kissing the top of her head. She started kissing her a *lot* on round two, after she switched positions to make it easy. She kissed around her face, too, but Catra thinks she was enjoying how Catra was so far gone that she could hardly kiss back between the panting and moaning.

Adora certainly got her pliant and wanting, but that is *not* how Catra imagined She-ra going about it. She's floating on so many endorphins she can't find it in herself to have a problem with it, though. She makes no move to leave as Adora shifts down and tries to wrestle her jeans off without disturbing Catra. It's hard when she's half on top of her, but after a minute Catra hears the jeans get tossed over her and crumple on the floor. Adora wraps her up in her arms, settling them into another warm cuddle, but this one is better because they can tangle their legs together and just feel skin-on-skin.

Catra sighs, her purr rattling as she sinks into the embrace. She's rubbing her face all over Adora, marking her and rolling in her scent in equal measure, but she doesn't give a shit about affection or her rules right now. She hasn't been this content in years, maybe *ever*, and she's exhausted. She floats away on endorphins and into sleep, sinking into Adora's comfort like she never left her arms.

Chapter End Notes

If you thought this was going to be anything less than intense repression, you forgot how much these two love bad ideas.

Chapter 9: Ripples

Chapter Notes

We're on a run of monster chapters so I've been cutting it close on updates lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wakes up with Catra curled up on her chest, purring as she does her best to ball up there and crush Adora's ribs with all her weight. Waking up *cuddling* – Catra's version of cuddling, anyway – is a dream Adora didn't dare have even as they were falling asleep last night. Apparently orgasm four is Catra's off-switch. Adora really hopes she'll invite her back to abuse that knowledge. Catra's invitation was painful – and surely designed to be – but this felt like *progress*. Sure, Adora had to endure a drop in her stomach a few times when she would remember that Catra wanted the lie of She-ra over her, but those moments became more disparate as they went on.

By the second round, *princess* might as well have just been Adora's nickname. Catra wasn't pretending anymore, even if it was just because she didn't have the presence of mind to. However it started – and Adora is pretty fucking clear on how it started – where it ended was somewhere decidedly more emotional and personal than Catra's initial invitation allowed for. She let Adora take off the mask, and from that moment on it seemed like things had changed.

Adora still expects Catra to reject her in the light of day, but unless how emotional that got completely scares Catra off, she's pretty sure Catra is going to be calling her back, even if it's just because she can't resist the endorphins. They both know *Adora* is the one who gave those to her – the one who touched her, the one who loves her, the one who knows her well enough to make her feel good even in this previously-uncharted territory – no matter what Catra says when she wakes up.

One glance at the clock tells Adora that she needs to leap up and call Glimmer for a teleport *now* if she wants any chance of making her morning class, but she isn't moving. She is not missing a second of Catra time. She can't see her face – she has it tucked into her arm and Adora is mostly looking at the top of her head – but from the gentle rumbles on her breath, she can tell she's still asleep. Catra wouldn't purr like that for Adora anymore. She only let it out "for She-ra" when she had the immediate endorphins from an orgasm pouring through her.

Adora shifts carefully to free one of her arms, first pushing her hair out of her face – no ponytail, again, though she isn't complaining this time – and then lightly petting over Catra's hair. She doesn't stir. Adora grins at the ceiling, settling in to pet her freely. She never got to really pet Catra when she was here as She-ra. She was pretty confident that Catra wouldn't allow it, and even if she did, it felt like it would give her away somehow. It has been a year since she could relax into just petting Catra and enjoying a quite moment with her.

Catra's ears flick a few times as Adora pets, brushing her chin. She really wants to kiss them, but Catra's rumbles have petered out. She's probably at least partially awake. Kissing them could shatter Catra's complacency with the morning-after air, and Adora would feel weird about doing it, no matter how innocent it was, while she was unconscious and they were on bad terms. Adora settles for massaging the base of her ear.

Catra rumbles slightly and then she shifts, half-rousing. She stretches out, her limbs shaking and Adora groaning as her ribs protest double now that some of the weight has lifted and she can feel more of the damage. Catra drops to the bed again, limp, this time draped over Adora's chest at a haphazard angle. The bed is supporting a lot more of her weight, but it also hurts way more.

"I'm going to die," Adora strains out, perhaps too dramatic, but Catra's little answering snort is cute. She must not hate her *that* much, at least not when she's half asleep, because she lazily rolls to the side and drops off Adora's chest. Adora spends several moments basically blacked out as she wheezes and reacquaints her body to breathing without the world's largest cat crushing her lungs.

"Baby," Catra accuses, lifting her head to yawn and then dropping it back down to rub her cheek against the pillow, which she somehow managed to steal most of while Adora was recovering from her assassination attempt via slow oxygen deprivation.

"She-ra's the invulnerable one, not me," Adora returns, her words still a little strained. She turns her head to the side so she can look at Catra and finds her lazily blinking at her.

"I distinctly remember her bleeding last night," she returns, still sounding half asleep. She would probably have to be to not hiss at the reminder that it's currently Adora in her bed. Adora pauses.

"Semi-invulnerable," she amends. She-ra can take more, feels less pain, and heals to some degree, but when they switched positions Catra could wrap her arms around Adora's back and her claws ended up dragging down it, leaving deep scratches. Catra's claws are tough and the fact that Adora wasn't sliced to ribbons only proves how much She-ra can take. Adora flexes her shoulders absently and feels the familiar gentle burn left behind by her healing factor. Good. She *wants* to feel it. These scratches are a reminder of an incredible night, no matter what was hanging over it.

Catra snorts and then buries her face into the pillow, sleepily scent marking it for several long moments. She's showing a shocking number of signs of contentment. Adora knows Catra likes to sleep in and spend mornings dozing when she can, but she thought her presence alone would wake Catra up enough to have her spitting vitriol.

"I have a morning class. You should go," Catra says into her pillow. When she finishes marking it, she drops her head onto it again, blinking lazily at Adora. Adora hesitates, but things have been pretty good and she doesn't want to ruin it.

"I do too," she admits, reluctantly.

“Do you even have time to get there?” Catra asks, her tone unconvincingly casual as she glances at the clock, like she doesn’t care about the answer at all and is just making small talk. Catra hates small talk. It’s a fair question considering it just passed ten and the only time slot left that could still be considered a morning class is an hour from now. Taking the train across the bay from here, all the way to campus, would take up enough of that time to cut it close.

“Considering it started five minutes ago? No, not even Moonstone’s teleporting can help me,” Adora tells her, sending Catra a hopeful smile that quickly falls. Catra’s expression is sour.

“You can just call her Glimmer, I know who she is,” Catra mutters. She turns away, sitting up and looking around. Adora is greeted with the sight of her bare back as the blanket falls away.

“I wasn’t sure. There’s a glamor that can make it harder to recognize us,” Adora explains, sitting up for herself and taking a risk on reaching out and petting flat the mussed fur on Catra’s back. Catra growls, but she also arches her back slightly into Adora’s touch, so Adora keeps petting her.

“Well that makes me feel better, but you’re still an asshole,” Catra returns, awake enough for her words to bite now. Adora winces, her hand pausing for a moment before she resumes petting again.

“I know. It was stupid, I just missed you so much that I couldn’t stay away after I ran into you,” Adora returns, her voice soft. Even from over her shoulder, she sees Catra’s jaw clench.

“Stop,” she orders, standing and walking away, towards the closet. Adora quickly averts her eyes from Catra’s naked ass and nods, knowing Catra can probably see it in the edge of her vision. *Right*.

“Who else did you recognize?” Adora changes the subject, sliding out of bed herself and keeping her gaze fixed down as she looks around for her jeans. She wasn’t really paying attention when she tossed them last night, but she finds them and gathers them up.

“Mermista is Pearl, right?” Catra returns, a drawling quality to her voice that is probably supposed to show how little she cares, but she also lowers her voice, almost like she’s worried about her neighbor somehow hearing through the wall. Adora’s heart fizzles in her chest like a sparkler as she pulls on her pants. She knew Catra wouldn’t tell.

“Yeah,” she agrees, her voice soft. She probably should stick to her rules from when she was visiting as She-ra and say she isn’t free to say, but what’s the point now?

“And Bow is obvious,” Catra mutters, her voice strangely resentful. Adora looks up to send her a curious look, finding Catra has pulled on a dress shirt she’s still buttoning up. The lack of boobs makes it at least 50% easier to think. Being malevolent against Bow sounds impossible to Adora and he didn’t do anything to Catra, at least not that the rest of the Alliance didn’t also do. Catra catches her look and turns around to pull a pair of pants out of the closet.

“How come he’s allowed to know? Allowed *in*? You can’t tell me he’s anything more than Glimmer’s human boyfriend,” Catra asks, venom in her voice. Ah. Okay, not actually mad at Bow, then. Adora takes a deep breath, sitting back down on the edge of her bed and watching Catra as she lays out the rest of her clothes but doesn’t put them on, probably waiting to go to the bathroom. Okay, so they’re having this conversation with her pants-less. At least the dress shirt mostly covers her. From the front. Catra is partially showing Adora her back right now.

“Only three people who aren’t current or past runestone holders really know anyone in the Alliance’s identity,” Adora says, slowly. Catra pauses, her shoulders tensing, and then she reluctantly turns around to face Adora. Her expression is wary as she puts one hand on her hip, but as tacit as it is, she *is* listening.

“One is Mermista’s dad, and he doesn’t count considering he was there when her mom transferred the runestone right before she died.” Catra’s jaw clenches and she gives a jerky nod. “The second is Glimmer’s aunt. Glimmer’s mom was the last Moonstone. When the Horde attacked near her work, Angella’s husband came trying to make sure she was safe. Micah was a powerful sorcerer and he thought he could protect his wife if she was in danger. The Horde was using dark magic and he ended up being the only civilian casualty of the attack.” Catra’s ears pin back. Adora takes a deep breath and continues.

“Angella blames herself for it. If she had just told him, he wouldn’t have been worried enough to come, that kind of thing. I think she told his sister because the other princesses didn’t blame her and she wanted someone else to hate her as much as she hated herself. Casta wasn’t happy with her at first, so I guess it kind of worked, but she came around,” Adora explains. Catra looks uncomfortable, crossing her arms and looking away.

“What does this have to do with Bow?” she asks, but there’s less bite to her words now.

“I’m just trying to show you how secretive it is. The rules let us tell our spouses *now*, but that’s only an *after marriage* kind of thing, and it’s supposed to be with approval from everyone else. Mermista has had the same boyfriend off and on since middle school and he still doesn’t know. Bow only found out on accident. He was so used to coming to their house unannounced, he walked in on Angella hugging Glimmer while she was still transformed,” Adora takes a breath, tries to stop herself, and ends up adding on bitterly, “Everyone important in Glimmer’s life knows. She doesn’t understand what it’s like to have to lie. And half of the princesses still have their mentors to talk with.”

She looks at the floor. She tells herself she does it because Catra crossing her arms caused her shirt to lift, but mostly she’s just ashamed of herself for being bitter. Frosta and Perfuma don’t have anybody either. No parents, no partners even if they would have to lie to them. They once had a better support system, but they’re alone now except for the extended family they have to dodge and lie to. Everything isn’t about her, it was just such a shock to be thrust into this world of magic and then an even worse one to lose Catra.

“Fine. It’s a secret. You still could have told me. I would have kept it. The Alliance never had to know,” Catra returns, her voice bitter again. Adora’s chest hurts, she looks up to find Catra glaring indistinctly at her knees. A moment of heavy silence hangs in the air.

“I know,” Adora finally admits, quietly. Catra’s eyes snap to hers. “If it had just been me, I would have told you in an instant no matter what they said. Knowing about me gave away Glimmer and Bow’s identities too, though, and I didn’t have a right to do that. It wasn’t just my secret. I was going to tell you, eventually, but I was trying to get permission for it.” Catra scoffs, happy to keep her bitterness. Adora tightens her hands by her sides. It’s *true*.

“I’m sorry. I lied knowing that I could trust you, but it was because the Alliance didn’t know *us*. They thought I just wanted to tell my crush or something and I was going to be a big security risk if I couldn’t keep my mouth shut. I was waiting until they trusted me so I could tell you without betraying anyone,” she explains, pleading for Catra to understand. She should have known they didn’t have that kind of time – at the end there, she *did* know it – but she still held pattern, unable to admit that she had failed. She wishes she had done so many things differently, but after what she *did* do, she doesn’t really expect the plea to work, and it doesn’t. Catra growls under her breath and turns away.

“Instead you just betrayed *me*. I’m going to the bathroom. I don’t want to see you here when I get out,” Catra snaps back, stalking across the room before Adora can try something else. Her heart falls as she watches the bathroom door snap shut.

She suspects that if she stayed, Catra would just remain lurking behind the bathroom door until she was absolutely forced to leave for her class. Adora sighs, standing and checking her pockets to make sure her phone and keycard didn’t fall out. She just has to hope that something she said today made a difference. It’s a slow game with Catra. She’s really hurt and Adora doesn’t expect it to change overnight. The fact she isn’t spitting vitriol at the sight of her face is an improvement.

She hesitates as she passes by Catra’s bathroom door.

“I hope you have a good class,” she murmurs, knowing Catra can hear her and is probably listening attentively to Adora’s movements. The water immediately turns on to drown out anything further. Adora sighs and turns towards the front door, letting herself out. As she heads down the stairwell, she texts Glimmer asking if she’s free for a teleport so she can at least make the second half of her class.

She’s a diligent student and that’s the only reason. It has nothing to do with not wanting to be alone with her thoughts.

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Okay, so her grand plan didn’t go how she wanted. Sure, the sex was *incredible*, but it was supposed to be some distanced thing that helped her get over She-ra and gain clarity. Instead she spends the next two days desperately wanting to call Adora back so she can come like that again or just be *cuddled*. Inviting her back is bad idea when things got as emotional as they did, both during – the praise was a *lot* – and after, but if the point was to prove that Adora at least wanted her, she certainly did that. Catra always pictured sex with She-ra as

something wild, fun, and *meaningless*, but it ended up being so caring that Adora barreled through her walls before she had the time to put them up. She wasn't supposed to still have an afterglow the next day, but even with Adora's attempts to talk in the morning, Catra feels better than she has since finding out.

It felt so good to forget it all and just enjoy something physical after the turmoil, but Adora's words dig under her skin as much as she doesn't want to let them to. Anger is familiar, but it's comforting and exhausting in equal measure. No matter how tired she is of it, she doesn't *want* to not be angry. She could maybe understand Adora taking a few days to tell her, but after six months of lying – after it *tore them apart* and Adora still didn't come clean – she can't. That feels like Adora chose keeping her new friends happy over keeping Catra at all.

It still hurts, even if it's a different kind of hurt from before when she thought she was just done with her. She tells herself to put it all aside and ignore it with finality, but then five minutes later her stupid, wrung out heart whispers *at least she loves you*. She thought – stupidly – that the night with She-ra would make it easier to push all these thoughts to the back of her mind, but in the end it just made her want her back more. She treated her so well. Catra wants to believe it could be like that if they tried again, but there's a wall in her mind built over ten lonely months.

She tries to bury herself in her work just like she did before, and she's more successful this time, but she still can't do much for when she has moments of downtime and the thoughts incessantly come bubbling back up. She knows she has to do something drastic or she's going to call Adora again and she's keeping that as her nuclear option now that she's able to almost function. She abuses her best friend privileges just like she did when she got her job in the first place – alright, Scorpia offered because she knew Catra hated her boss at the retail job she had at the time and she accepted – and she texts Linda that she has a dip in schoolwork before things get busy again and would like extra shifts to balance it out.

School is *not* dipping, but the amount of free time she wants to have is, so it works out, even if the slow shifts are dangerous. Right as her shift on her third day in a row is ending, something like an earthquake hits and knocks over everything on the counter, not to mention half the people in the shop who don't manage to grab something up. A massive sound echoes in the distance, like they demolished a building or something, but Catra can guess who *they* is and she doubts it's the city.

She curses in her head as she spends the next fifteen minutes cleaning everything up. It's time for Catra to clock out, but She-ra used to swing by after Alliance business brought her to the Fright Zone. If she heads home now, is there a chance Adora will try her luck and show up? She shouldn't want that, but if Adora showed up under the ruse first, she isn't sure she would be able to resist.

She lingers, hoping her reliever for the evening shift won't show up and she'll be stuck here, but the Fright Zone doesn't stop for supervillainy and he shows up only two minutes late thanks to the explosion. It was something massive that sent chunks flying over roofs. Great. Maybe it will just be a gas main bursting or something and the Horde didn't actually try to plant a bomb in the middle of town.

Catra isn't a fucking coward and she refuses to hang around like she's worried about going home. She clocks out, trading her apron for a flannel to guard against the spring wind. Reluctantly, she heads out. From her coworker's description, she's pretty sure she's heading towards whatever the disaster of the day is, but probably not straight for it, and that's good enough. Her apartment block better not be damaged. It's already going to be enough of a pain to clean up everything that got knocked over.

There's a lot of noise in the distance, but like Catra said, she's not a coward. She makes it close enough to see her – intact – block before anything even startles her, and that's just because she wasn't expecting anyone to call her. She isn't surprised when she checks and sees that it's Scorpia, though. Of course she would be worried. She has probably been making her way down her contacts list in alphabetical order.

"Hey, Scorpia. I'm fine and so is the shop," Catra greets, already rolling her eyes. Her tail sways behind her, a little fond of her overbearing friend.

"Oh! Great, that's great. Um, we have a problem, though," Scorpia returns. Catra's tail slows, falling still.

"What's wrong?"

"Entrapta texted me instructions for taking care of Emily 'in case she gets arrested or burnt beyond repair,'" Scorpia reads off. Catra stops in the middle of the sidewalk, staring straight ahead.

"*What?*"

"I already called her. She said she was going to the crater to see if she could salvage tech before the EMS arrives and cleans it up. She's hoping one of the Horde workshops blew," Scorpia rushes out. Catra's heart drops.

"*Shit*. She wants to go *near* that thing?" Catra asks, turning and looking in the general direction of the commotion. As she looks, she hears an obvious explosion, though it is much smaller than the first. The ground doesn't shake, just her eardrums.

"I tried to talk her down and she just said 'gotta go!' and hung up on me. I'm heading that way now, but you're a lot closer," Scorpia tells her, voice strained with anxiety. Catra's heart feels about the same. Unlike Entrapta, she has survival instincts and doesn't want to go near the explosion, but *unlike Entrapta, she has survival instincts* so she has to be there to pull her dumb ass out of the fire before she runs into it chasing after something shiny.

She growls under her breath. Sometimes she *hates* having friends.

"Don't bother, I've got this. She-ra connection, remember? Just… head to her house, or something. She's going to need babysitting until this has all blown over," Catra returns, and then she hangs up before Scorpia can protest. She checks the news widget on her phone – maybe she added it back when she was looking forward to every visit from She-ra and then kept it just because it's useful for shit like *this* – to get the actual address of the explosion.

Uncomfortably close to her apartment. Great. Hopefully just far enough that the quake didn't damage the foundation. Graduation can't come soon enough. She really needs to move with how close she often is to Horde activity. Bright Moon is a lot safer. The Horde still attacks it, but not as often. It's not their territory. It only takes her a minute to get close enough to see the damage. Chunks of pavement, *cars*, and general random crap litter the streets as she grows closer, along with craters that the sources of are a mystery. There were some peopling milling on the sidewalk in case of another quake as she walked here, but now people rush past her, fleeing to safety. Some of them are coated in dust or have minor injuries. When she finally sees the source of it all, she stops in her tracks.

There was a photo on the news feed, but it didn't convey the devastation of an entire intersection blow to bits, a gaping hole down to *hell* replacing it. Catra's best guess is that the Horde blew a subway station, because she can't even see the bottom from here. The streets are filled with rubble, the windows have been shattered in all the nearby buildings, and chunks are missing from many of them. People are still in process of evacuating. Catra is the only one stupid enough to walk towards the crater that robots are swarming around. There actually aren't too many – probably because the Alliance is leaping around the crater and picking them off before they can make the damage worse – but something about it pings in the back of Catra's mind as she watches one descend into the crater for cover, a laser firing out a moment later that Fractal Flake catches with a spike of ice.

There's too much chaos to really tell what's going on, superheroes and robots flying through the air as civilians flee on the ground. Catra's best idea is to circle the thing until she identifies Entrapta. First, though, she needs to edge closer to make sure Entrapta hasn't gone down *into* it. Approaching the explosions and lasers spikes her heartrate, but she pins her ears back against the sounds of chaos and marches on, sliding her claws out just in case as she shoulders past fleeing civilians.

A robot thunders past the street opening onto the destruction and Catra crouches down instinctively, readying to run on all fours and leap at it if necessary, but it's busy tracking Pearl and doesn't turn. Suddenly Catra feels a lot less passive about Emily. *This* is what she was designed for before Entrapta got her hands on her. Catra forces herself to stand and continue on, but she lowers herself again when she gets near the edge of the crater, ready to catch herself as she looks down.

Definitely the ruined remains of a subway station, though there don't seem to be any people or turnstiles inside. A bunch of shit that has fallen into it, from cars to twisted hunks of metal to *furniture* Catra can't guess the source of. A half dozen robots are swarming over it, too. She grits her teeth, looking up at the other streets opening onto the disaster now that she's close enough to see them. She only winces a little when lasers shoot off across her view. She still has that bald spot on her tail.

She's just about to ease back, find the next cross street, and approach from a different angle when she spots purple hair. It's across the crater at an angle, but with some squinting she can spot Entrapta at the edge of the hole, trying to *climb down into it*. Catra's heart leaps into her throat. She looks up, darting her eyes around the clearing looking for anything to help, and unfortunately all she spots are the Alliance.

“Hey! Arrow boy!” Catra calls, straightening and waving up at the building where she can see him perched. He’s the only one who might be close enough to hear her, even if she’s not sure what his codename is. Sometimes people call him Cupid, but she’s pretty sure that’s something Twitter made up. He turns, looking around the area. He clearly spots her when he gives a full body cringe and then reaches to his belt, pulling off what Catra always thought was a spare mini crossbow or something, but no, apparently it’s a grappling hook he just made to *look* that way, because he fires it at a building between the two of them and leaps off the roof, swinging in a practiced arc across the corner of the crater.

Not for the first time, Catra feels jealous as he lands beside her.

“You shouldn’t be here! Are you okay?” he greets, already reaching for her and trying to run a hand down her arm as if to check for injuries. Catra hisses and ducks away.

“I’m *fine*, but she-” she points across the crater towards at where Entrapta has managed to climb down past the lip. Bow follows the point, his mouth falling open beneath his half-mask as he spots her, “-has no sense of danger. She’s trying to investigate the robots. She’s going to get killed if someone doesn’t drop her far away from here,” Catra tells him. She takes a deep breath, swallows her pride for her friend’s sake, and adds, “Please.”

“Of course, that’s what we’re here for,” Bow returns without a moment’s hesitation. He reaches up to his ear. “Moonstone, I’m shooting a flare arrow so you can find a civilian. Teleport them over to the bay,” he says, turning to glance at Catra as he talks. Catra immediately nods. The bay is perfect. Maybe twenty-five minutes away on a good day, probably thirty or forty right now. The Alliance will have dealt with the danger by then and hopefully EMS will have established a perimeter. It’s closer to Scorpia, too, so hopefully Catra can send her over there to intercept Entrapta.

Bow must get an affirmative, but the fighting is way too loud for Catra to be able to eavesdrop on their comms right now, so she doesn’t hear anything as he raises his bow, reaches into his quiver, and fires an arrow off in a perfect arc across the crater. It lands beside Entrapta and she startles, turning towards it and reaching for it with *no* sense of preservation before it flares to life and shoots red sparks up into the air.

“Get to safety!” Bow tells Catra, throwing her what is probably supposed to be an assuring smile, and then he pulls out his grapple again and leaps away. Right before an explosion cuts everything off, Catra hears him say, “Not now, She-ra.”

She probably overheard Catra, then, or maybe spotted her. Catra keeps her eyes locked on the red sparking beside Entrapta that she at least has the sense not to touch *now*. A moment later, pink sparkling signals Moonstone’s arrival. She materializes long enough to grab Entrapta, the girl barely beginning to flail, and then they pop out of existence, leaving only the burning of the red arrow to signal that they were ever there. Catra breathes a sigh of relief, but she barely gets to let it out before she hears the thudding and whirring of a robot approaching. She turns her head and finds one coming to a halt just feet away, within the lip of the crater. It swivel swivels its body and its laser eye lands on her.

She doesn’t know if it is locking its targeting system onto her, but she isn’t waiting around to find out. She throws herself backwards, using her flexibility to do a cartwheel back so she

can twist midair without having to slow down to turn, and she takes off down the street. She can still hear the thudding, like it might be following her, but it could even be one of the *other* robots. She jumps to the right when a side alley appears and runs down it instead. She pins her ears back, listening, but after turning another corner she doesn't hear any more thudding, at least not close by. She turns down a street and then ducks into another alley to be sure before she slows to a stop, leaning against the side of a building and panting heavily.

She isn't sure where she is. If she has been here before, it looks unfamiliar with all the chaos around. She gained a little distance away from the crater, but in her quest to turn corners before she could be hunted down, she thinks she ended up partially circling it. Before she can pull her phone out to check her GPS, it rings.

"Catra! Did you abuse your She-ra privileges? I was right there. I'm never going to make it back in time now!" Entrapta says, her voice shrill. She doesn't sound mad, but Entrapta never sounds mad. Some of the adrenaline dissipates just like that, replaced by relief. Entrapta is safe, at least. Catra is more questionable, but she thinks that she's fine now.

"No, I didn't, I just yelled that there was a civilian who needed help from the sidelines. You were going to get *shot*, Entrapta. Take it from someone who has been hit by one of those lasers, they *hurt*," Catra replies, pulling her phone partially away from her ear so she can text Scorpia. With all the noise, she still needs to keep it close to hear, so she ends up awkwardly texting about an inch from her face. "Where did they drop you?"

"I'm at the *ferry*. I have no chance of getting back in time to find out what was calling the robots down there. It could have been valuable tech! What else would robots need?" Entrapta complains. She is forgetting most robots aren't anywhere near sentient, so they could have just as easily been seeking out a bank vault the Horde was after, but that *prick* in the back of Catra's mind from earlier finally draws blood. Entrapta's right. Catra didn't see when they first arrived, but the robots were heading *into* the destruction, not climbing out of it. She doesn't know what they were looking for, but she doesn't like it.

"I'm sending Scorpia your way. Once everything is cleared, she'll take you over to see if anything got left behind, okay? And I'll ask She-ra if she knows anything. Just stay in safety until then. *Please*," Catra tries to negotiate. Entrapta is a hard person to bargain with and she whines loudly, but after a minute of drawing out the sound, she finally *hmphs*.

"Fine. I expect answers!" Entrapta responds. She probably only agrees because she knows she isn't getting there in time, but Catra will take it.

"If there was anything, you'll be the first to know. Share your location with Scorpia," Catra promises even though that means talking to Adora. One problem at a time. Entrapta mutters something, but she hangs up, and a moment later a notification for her phone's location pops up in the Super Pal Trio group chat. Not even a minute later a message with the dictation symbol beside it pops up from Scorpia saying she's on her way.

Just as Catra is pulling up the maps app to try to figure out where she is – definitely circled partially around the crater, that much is sure – she hears the sound of something heavy hitting the street nearby, like something else went sailing out of the crater. It's immediately followed by a much *closer* sound like a metal drum being hit. She jerks her head up, but the alley is

empty aside from her and a large green dumpster. It's metal and could have made the sound, but she doesn't see anything to cause it. She doesn't trust it with this much adrenaline pounding through her blood. Slowly, she crouches.

A pair of blue eyes blinks back at her, wide and scared. They're surrounded by shadow, but is that… a cat?

As they make eye contact, the eyes take on a threatening blue glow, a warning they have magic and aren't afraid to use it. Okay, not a *normal* cat.

"Hey, uh, it's okay. I'm only here to make sure my friend is safe," Catra tells them. She doesn't know if they're a threat, but clearly they feel *threatened* and she doesn't want them to take that out on her. The blue glow softens slightly.

"There you go. Don't scratch me and I won't scratch you, deal?" she asks, reaching out and retracting her claws to show she means it. The cat-shape stays in place but stretches its neck out and sniffs the air. She can see their head more clearly now it isn't enveloped in shadow. It has some kind of translucent shroud around its neck, solidly proving that whatever it is, it isn't natural.

Another explosion echoes from a few streets over and the cat quickly skitters back, making the dumpster produce that same metallic thud again as it hides. Catra, for her part, pins her ears back and whips around, but there's no sign of the destruction coming for them.

Okay, so they're not a normal cat, but they certainly scare like one. Catra looks back at them to find that soft blue staring at her with a wide-eyed fear that makes her heart clench. What is with those eyes? Why do they have to be so much like Adora's – She-ra's – and make her want to help? That kind of association should fill her with rage.

"It's okay, She-ra's out there. She won't let the Horde hurt anyone else. And just between you and me, she kind of likes me, so she's not going to let anything happen to you if you're with me," Catra promises, quietly. She isn't exactly eager to go around advertising her connection to She-ra, but now that she knows how to call her, she's a little less worried about it. The cat shifts close enough to become visible again, but another explosion sends them skittering back and they seem to disappear completely in the shadows. Like, Catra doesn't see *anything*.

"Are you scared of the noises?" she asks. She hates them too, but she has a sinking feeling as she watches the empty air. "Or… who's making them?" she asks instead. A small, sad mew answers her a moment later. Slowly, she watches the cat melt back into existence, looking up at her again with a fearful expression.

"Yeah, the Horde fucking blows, but I'm not going to let them hurt you, okay? I can get you out of here if you come out," she offers. She doesn't know what exactly she's going to do with them since leading them to her house sounds like a bad idea, but what if they are someone's magical pet who got out in the damage? She can't just walk away. She can probably call animal control or something once they're somewhere safe and they can at least tell her what she's looking at.

The cat watches her, wary, but it slinks closer. She offers her hand with the palm up and slowly the cat approaches, sniffing it carefully. After a moment of inspecting her fingers, they nuzzle her hand.

Light overtakes her mind, everything blacking out for several seconds as her hearing turns to static. Then, just as suddenly as it started, she's back in her own body, gasping and blinking down at them. They stare up at her.

They're worried about her. It has been a long time since they've tried that.

"I- Yeah, give me minute," she assures them, internally panicking at the new stream open in the back of her mind. Another explosion echoes. *Fear. They're going to be captured again*. "No, we're not letting that happen. It was probably a robot blowing up. Less Horde is always a good thing. Come here," she assures, reaching out. They don't dodge her hands like they might have a moment ago, letting her lift them up and curl them into her arms.

They're too drained to cloak for more than a few seconds. That's why they were hiding. Okay. This whole thing is *new*, but at least she doesn't have to play translator. Small victories keep her sane. She can freak out about this *later*. For now, she shrugs out of her flannel, wrapping it around them to hide them from view.

"If anyone asks what I'm carrying, mew and pretend to be a regular cat I'm evacuating, alright?" she tells them as she stands from her crouch and glances out around the corner. The remains of a robot have left a small crater in the street. Well, that explains that tremor. It seems to have come sailing in from where the main action is. In her arms, Melog mews.

"Good- uh… Let's do this," she cuts herself off, tucking them close into her chest and then heading down the street away from the crater.

Entrapta is *so* on her shit list.

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Their name is Melog, and it turns out she *can* close them off from her head now they've opened a mental bond – it's some kind of extended telepathy they can *unextend* – it just takes a little concentration and neither of them are focused enough for that right now, especially when being able to communicate is helpful. She has decided to blame Adora for this whole thing, actually, because magic was never a problem in her life until she had to go become a goddess somehow.

"Sorry it's… small," Catra says, vaguely, as she sets Melog down on the floor of her apartment and shakes out her flannel. It's covered in dust, like the rest of Melog. After they've had a look around, they're getting a bath. They're clearly *not* a cat and are actually looking forward to that idea as they pad after her, cautiously sniffing while she picks up everything that fell over from the tremors.

The apartment is big enough to breathe, small enough to see every corner and be sure they're safe. She gets that. They've clearly been through some *shit*. She's only getting the thoughts as they come, but they're enough to get a sketch of the context lurking behind it. The explosion was them, in a way. Their jailer couldn't control their magic when they willingly flowed some their way. With how weak they feel now, they weren't expecting the effects to be so devastating.

"It's okay, it was an accident," Catra murmurs, distracted, as she gathers up the last of the dishes that broke and carefully throws them away. She glances down to find Melog standing next to her ankle, blinking up at her with big eyes. They want to be bigger, but they don't have the energy for that right now, and the sorceress kept them in too small of a cage for them to change. They've been stuck like this for a while.

"Hey, you'd be too big to fit in the bathtub, then," Catra tells them. She gets an echoing purr in response, so humor seems to be the way to go. She dusts her hands off and heads to the bathroom to open the door for them. Her pocket buzzes as she is holding it open, Melog slinking past her.

She pulls it out and frowns when she sees Adora texted her. Catra growls under her breath, but she reluctantly texts back.

> I know you don't want to talk to me, but I just want to make sure you and your friend are okay
>
> We're fine
> Thanks
>
> Always. You're welcome

She doesn't mention Melog, instead texting Scorpia to make sure she found Entrapta okay as she gets the water running. Luckily, it works, so at least the pipes weren't affected by the disaster.

Scorpia assures her that she just found Entrapta at the pier and they're heading back to her house now to wait out the emergency responders. It will be hours before Entrapta can hope to access the crater, but Catra texts her she's only going to find standard Horde equipment, if anything at all. Entrapta texts back with a list of questions to ask She-ra, but Catra's information isn't coming from her fucking ex.

She looks down at Melog, happily swimming in loose circles in the tub as it fills up. They're still shaken, but they feel safe with Catra. It's easy to when they're *reading her fucking mind*. At least their particular brand of telepathy mandates it be a two-way street. If they had just invaded her head with no recourse, she would be panicking a lot more.

“We’ll… figure it out,” Catra tells them, standing and reaching for her towel hung up on the wall. She lays it out on the floor for Melog whenever they decide they’re done. She retreats to her living room and decides to ignore the parts of her apartment that are still a mess, pulling out her laptop instead. She googles *extinct magic species* because she didn’t get a name from Melog, but she picked up them worrying about humans finding out they survived.

She has stepped in so much shit. Why couldn’t Entrapta just stay home?

Chapter End Notes

I have some pre-established krytian lore (dating all the way back to SLAS, wow) that has taken a few forms in my various fics and is going to be reappearing here. Details always change to match the story/setting, but potato Melog will live on.

Chapter 10: Cause and Effect

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra zips her hoodie up around Melog as they curl into her chest. They don't seem to be afraid of Entrapta, but they clearly prefer the dark safety of Catra's arms. Entrapta just *had* to go and use the word dissect when Catra asked if she could help her figure some things out about Melog. Catra pets them over the hoodie as Entrapta continues on. They should know it's safe because Catra knows it is and animal instinct works like that, but they still prefer to hide. They aren't used to people seeing them. They've lived most of their life cloaked.

Krytians are, it turns out, *not* extinct, they just decided to live in secret after being hunted a few centuries ago. They can't see each other without a pre-established psychic connection, though. There probably aren't many left, but Melog doesn't know much. They haven't seen any others since they were small.

"I'd love a new project. It has been a long time since I researched an anthropology topic, and I've never been able to verify information with someone firsthand before!" Entrapta agrees to help with her usual excitement. Against Catra's chest, Melog seems to wilt. The connection is thin at the moment, just enough for either of them to force it open if they need to talk without words – well, Catra's words – but Catra knows that Melog doesn't have as many answers as Entrapta wishes they did.

"I'll answer what I can, but they really need room to breathe, now," Catra promises, awkwardly sticking her fingers down the neck of her hoodie so she can pet the top of Melog's head. They lean into the touch. Catra offers them a soft purr and Melog goes boneless in her hoodie. They like purring. They like cats in general, that's why their form began to mirror their stray friends as they grew up.

"I'll have questions ready whenever they are!" Entrapta pauses, seeming to think, and then suddenly slams her hands on the table so she can lean over Catra and get in her face with the usual manic excitement that comes to her when she has just had a new idea. "What's it like? It's not normal telepathy, right? Oo, do you think it's like the connection I have with Emily?" Entrapta asks, leaning in way too close. Catra stops petting Melog so she can put a hand on Entrapta's shoulder and gently – okay, never mind, *firmly* since Entrapta didn't respond to gently – push her back. After a few seconds Entrapta seems to realize what she is doing and remembers Catra's personal space mandate, reluctantly leaning back and sending Catra a pout.

"It's important data! No one has recorded it in modern history. Please?" Entrapta asks. Melog shifts in Catra's hoodie and Catra puts a hand over them, thinking it over. It's a hard question and even harder to answer in a way that Entrapta will understand. Catra has no idea what Entrapta's connection with technology is like, just that long term exposure to her thoughts can change the tech she's communicating with. Whether it's magic shit or as simple as reprogramming, Entrapta's microwave is surprisingly "dumb" for a piece of tech she owns and it still sings little songs to her when she uses it, apparently out of affection.

“It’s like a window into their thoughts. I don’t hear every detail, but I get the overview, maybe even see flashes of it if there’s a visual. I don’t get a voice in my head, it’s more like ideas being passed back and forth and not words. I think they get something similar, but I can also talk aloud to them to help,” Catra tries to explain. Telepathy is apparently way more complicated than she ever gave it credit for. She always thought it was unfettered access to someone else’s mind, but Melog’s powers are very different. They can only mentally communicate with someone they’ve bonded with, and even then it’s just their current thoughts. It’s not the mindreading Catra would have feared if Melog was capable of asking her permission before they bonded.

“Oh, so it’s like how I can feel Emily’s general presence, but when I actually enter her, I can read all her processes going on their usual routines, and then they all change as she starts communicating directly!” Entrapta replies. Catra has no fucking clue if it’s like that, but honestly she’s just glad Entrapta didn’t make it sound weirdly sexual when she talked about her technopathy this time, so she just nods.

“Right, well, Melog is having a little trouble shutting the window, but they want to respect my privacy and shit and get better at it, so we need anything you can turn up on the bond,” Catra continues. Against her chest, Melog mews. “And krytians in general to make sure there isn’t a way to magically track them,” she tacks on. Melog quiets.

The Horde captured them while they were “running the paths” before, some kind of invisible roads through the city created by the natural flow of magic over the landscape. They aren’t actual roads, but the power in them lets Melog manipulate their relativity to objects around them, crossing large distances impossibly fast and sometimes even crossing into spaces that exist only in the paths, like the well of magic where their old den is hidden.

They’re afraid to return to it now, or even to step on the paths again. They’re pretty sure the Horde consulted an old map of the paths in Harbor University’s archive and they walked into an ambush, so being actively tracked *shouldn’t* be an issue, but Melog wants to feel safe again and that will only start to happen once they know it was a lucky ambush. Even then, it won’t really happen until Shadow Weaver is behind bars.

Catra lays a calming hand on top of Melog. She may have met the bastard *yesterday*, but she’s fond of them. Magic bond and all that shit. She’s going to make sure they’re okay. They don’t have to go back to their den if they don’t want to.

“It will be a good test of my reasoning capabilities! I can put together information ranked by my confidence in its plausibility and Melog can help me distinguish blind spots in my logic if anything turns out to be false!” Entrapta agrees, nodding her head and smiling brightly. A smile twitches at the corner of Catra’s mouth. When the day comes, Entrapta will probably talk for hours and it will be exhausting, but there’s something endearing about her friend’s eagerness to find out how *wrong* she is.

As weird as Entrapta is, there’s a reason they are friends, and it’s not just because of Scorpia. Melog kind of likes her too, even if she’s a little *much* for their nerves right now. There’s just something about Entrapta that you can’t be mad at.

For long, anyway. Catra stopped talking to her for half an hour when she pointed out the bald spot on her tail and how it wasn't going to heal. Entrapta was just stating *facts*, but the day Catra stops being petty is the day she calls Adora back, so it hasn't come yet.

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So Catra has a cat now. A cat she's pretty sure knows secrets about one of the most dangerous groups on Etheria after being their prisoner for a month or two, but there's understandable trauma there, so Catra isn't asking yet. It's probably not urgent, so she can wait to call Adora until Melog's ready to volunteer it. In the meantime, Melog is working on easing back on the bond because they don't want to upset her or make her uncomfortable, but that's only a *most of the time* thing.

Melog is a pretty effective distraction in general, but whenever Catra starts brooding over the situation with Adora – like she has been for weeks – they're vocal with their thoughts. If Catra doesn't let them into her head, they just meow incessantly at her until she breaks, and then she immediately wants to kick them out again when they ask her why she can't just go back to her lover since that's clearly where she wants to be.

Catra tries to explain the lying and broken trust thing – both pretty abstract concepts to a being who can only really communicate mentally, where all attempted dishonesty is very obvious and exact words aren't passed back and forth – and Melog reminds her that Adora apologized and Catra hasn't given her a chance to do better. Yeah, well, what's the point in just getting disappointed again? A second heartbreak might kill her. Melog doesn't get it. They're starved for contact and their perspective is skewed.

She is too, but she's handling it. She only spent *one* entire day's earnings on a cat tower for Melog. That's self-control. She's a paragon of mental health. Melog lounges on the top of it, *judging* her as if they aren't profiting off of her gay drama.

Catra is having another day where she's yearning for something she can't have. Her better judgement is apparently taking a vacation and telling her that calling Adora is a good idea. Melog is great, but as much as they keep her company, sometimes she feels a sharp pang at how different the company is to what Adora used to give her – what she got glimpses of again with She-ra. Or maybe she just needs to make out. That's kind of hard to do with Melog around, though.

For one, it would be weird in front of them, and for another, they're judging her for just *thinking* about it. She flips them off and they come running across the room to jump onto her stomach. They ignore how she wheezes as they knock the air out of her in favor of batting at her finger like she's trying to play. Melog is in her head right now; they damn well know what it means.

"How about I don't make her pretend to be her alter ego this time? That's progress!" Catra offers, petting Melog because then they'll at least stop hitting her. Melog doesn't look

impressed. Catra thinks they should give her concession more credit. She's pretty sure Adora would let her invite princess over again, so being willing to fuck *Adora* and admit it to her face is a big step.

Melog sneezes.

"Yeah, yeah, *judgy*. You could just mind your own business, you know," Catra tells them, poking their side. They're having trouble with that again tonight, but Catra could *clearly* use the privacy. Krytians only reproduce via some form of magic sharing Catra isn't clear on and Melog would like her to keep this side of her to herself, which she would *love* to do if some asshole wasn't blue balling her. She hasn't even gotten off since finding them because she has been so busy '*keeping it to herself.'*

Melog wrinkles their nose, sneezes, and then jumps away to climb up their cat tower and sulk high above her, as if physically elevating themselves will help them avoid Catra's gay thoughts. Catra wishes it were that easy. She's tried every damn thing she could think of to stop thinking about Adora, including *fucking* her, and she still takes up space in her thoughts.

At this point she knows the truth: Adora is never going away, because Catra doesn't want her to. She wants her back, not gone, and she has too much hope that's a possibility now for her to ever fully turn away. It's hard, though, when a voice in the back of her head still tells her that no matter how sweet Adora is or how she says she loves her as she touches her, she chose them both being alone over just telling Catra the truth. Maybe she didn't know if Catra would forgive her, but this would have been a lot easier to forgive last year when it happened. She never changed her mind, the truth was just forced out.

Okay, only kind of forced. Adora could have just said it was a bad idea to have a relationship with a mask and walked away. She did finally tell Catra. It doesn't feel like she should get credit for deciding to stop lying, but Catra is to the point where she can look back on that conversation and know that Adora finally told her because she really didn't want to hurt her *again*. That still leaves the first time, maybe, but Adora did decide to tell her. Eventually.

She feels herself getting caught in the familiar cycle – *she cares, she lied, she wants you* – so she growls and sits up, yanking her desk chair out and throwing herself in front of her schoolwork for a distraction. Melog lifts up their head, looking towards her and trying to share calm with her, but Catra is frustrated. She wants things to be good again. The only way to get that back is to open herself up to breaking in half again. She's barely staying on top of her work when she's just conflicted. If Adora hurt her again, she would bomb every one of her finals and maybe fuck up her chance at law school.

Melog would be here if her heart broke. They wouldn't let her be alone, and they wouldn't let her isolate like she tried to do when Adora hurt her before. That's… *something*, but there's a gap between her and Adora that she's not sure they can cross with or without the help of a magic cat. She doesn't want to stand alone on the other side anymore, though.

Melog seems to think that's her answer. Catra growls at them and opens her casebook. Just push the thoughts of Adora aside like she's pushing *Melog's* thoughts out of her head. It's simple.

Nothing between them has ever been simple.

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Eventually, Catra asks Melog what the Horde wanted them for. She knows the rough shape of their captivity from the thoughts they have had about it – *their body, compromised of magic, feeling like it's tearing apart as the jailer drains it from them and then cradles her storage crystal like it's precious, ignoring the creature panting pained sounds on the floor of their tiny cage* – but that much power must have a use.

Melog isn't sure. They saw their jailer – from the flashes of memories Catra has seen, it was Shadow Weaver, even if Melog never knew her name – perform some spells with it, but mostly she was stockpiling. Their best guess was that she wanted to repair her mask. The crystal in its forehead had a subtle aura of power that promised an immense depth, but it was cracked.

Melog asks, and it could be important, so Catra says yes, closing her eyes and letting the images wash over her. The abandoned subway – a old maintenance station, maybe, but it's hard to tell with the sorcery equipment and makeshift bedchamber that fill the space – is as dark and dusty as always, but the sorceress has an unusual call on her terminal. It's hidden from Melog's view, but Melog listens to a man berate Shadow Weaver from it, saying they need magic support *now* and he would find someone else to take over the '*project*' if she couldn't.

When the sorceress turns on them to drain their magic again afterwards, she is angry and she takes too much, too fast. Melog knows they might not survive this so it's now or never. They finally willingly flow their magic – their very lifeforce – towards Shadow Weaver hoping to overload the crystal in the center of the room she uses to store it. It's too much. She tries to control it, and the best she has is sending it up instead of *out*.

It flattens everything in the room, bursting the cage and blowing back the furniture, but that's nothing compared to the force shot straight up towards the street. Rubble rains down as Melog struggles free from the mangled remains of their cage. As they run towards the sunshine, they see a dark shape out past the platform, on the unused subway tracks.

It's Shadow Weaver, thrown free of the rubble but still hardly moving thanks to the hard fall. Her mask has finally cracked in two, one half near her and the other half lost. Catra's mind fills in details that are missing, and then when her heart *stops*, she pushes towards Melog, searching for the full memory, for the right details to fill in and overwrite what she saw.

But nothing fills in. Because it's the same.

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Adora checks her phone as soon as she gets out of class despite knowing she would have felt it vibrate if anything had happened. She has a really bad habit of pulling it out for every notification, hoping that Catra has texted her again. She's trying to wait, mostly because she thinks reaching out early would just undo any progress Catra is making on her own towards not being angry, but sometimes she questions herself. Maybe Catra *does* need to hear from her, to know she's thinking about her and be reminded that Adora loves her, however bad she is at showing it.

Before she can start convincing herself it *has* been long enough to reach out, Bow calls her name and Adora looks up to find him standing with Glimmer by the building atrium. She smiles and waves, trying to push her worries aside as she puts away her phone.

"Relax, Adora, you need to stop checking that thing so much. You know you wouldn't miss an emergency alert," Glimmer says as Adora walks up. Adora quickly pulls her hand away from her pocket, feeling caught, and the spark in Glimmer's eyes tells her she's onto her. Adora has been a superhero for a year and a half, after all, but her attachment to her phone is *new*.

Glimmer had some *things* to say after picking her up from Catra's. Adora running to class didn't save her, just delaying the lecture. Said things ranged from *I'm not Uber, especially not for hookups* in an exasperated tone to *you hooked up with her?* delivered in a quiet shriek. Adora didn't tell her that, but it wasn't hard to figure out with the note she left telling Glimmer not to worry if she doesn't come back until late, followed by a pickup at the address Glimmer has now noted as Catra's.

Adora is never, ever revealing how or *who* Catra invited over, not when she's already being judged enough under their current assumptions. Probably half the Alliance knows about Adora's questionable decision-making, but Adora is pretty sure it *helped*, and it was kind of incredible after they got going, so she doesn't care. If nothing else, the Alliance seems less worried about Catra spitefully revealing their identities now.

"Just checking Twitter," Adora lies, flashing Glimmer a bright smile when she sends her an unimpressed look. The look in Bow's eyes tells Adora that he doesn't believe her either, but he helps her out anyway by changing the subject to what they should watch tonight. They fall into easy conversation about their days as they start walking back towards the dorms.

Adora's phone vibrates. Her hand immediately twitches, not helped by already being with the two people most likely to text her walking beside her, but she tries to remind herself to play it cool. She keeps talking as she reaches into her pocket and pulls her phone out, intending to casually glance at it and then put it away again when it's just an email notification or something. Instead, her step falters and she furrows her brow.

"Okay, what's going on?" Glimmer asks, squinting at her reaction. Adora hesitates, but she texts back.

"Catra is asking where I am," Adora replies, texting back *BMU* as Glimmer and Bow exchange a glance in her periphery. Next thing she knows, her friends are on either side of

her, trying to peer at her screen, but there's nothing that Adora didn't already read off.

"I am *not* being your ride for another hookup, Adora. That was a terrible idea," Glimmer says, as if that is somehow going to stop Adora from going.

"Hey, we know where she's at now, don't we? Don't tell me you wouldn't still be worrying if I hadn't gone," Adora points out. There's no way for them to do anything but worry about what Catra will do if they don't talk to her.

"We *barely* know, because you won't tell us anything. I know you're trying to fix things, but you can't let her string you along with a text every few weeks! Also, that's a really suspicious question," Glimmer protests, pointing at Adora's screen where Catra has asked her for an exact location. Adora ducks away from her friends, quickly texting before they can stop her that she's heading back towards her dorm but can be free for the rest of the evening if Catra wants.

"Adora, come on, we're just worried about you. And her. And what she's going to do," Glimmer tries. Adora rolls her eyes, locking her phone but keeping it out so she can see any reply on her lock screen.

"Glimmer, if she was going to do anything, she would have by now. She's not nearly as mad as she used to be. It's fine," Adora tells her. She knows Glimmer has never had to worry about her identity before, but Catra isn't going to call the newspaper on them or anything. Bow's hand lands on her shoulder, squeezing to get her attention.

"We know. We're not worried about us. You were really lost without her. I don't want to see you like that again, Adora," Bow offers.

"That, too," Glimmer agrees, pointing at Bow and proving that wasn't *all* she was worried about. Adora rolls her eyes, starting to walk again and forcing her two friends to follow her if they want to lecture her. Really she just wants to get back to the dorm so she can get ready to leave should she need to.

"By that logic, I'm still lost. It can only go up from here," Adora replies. Glimmer's expression could peel paint. It goes beyond unimpressed. Adora is pretty sure she has only ever seen that look once before, and it was on Angella's face. If she makes the observation out loud, she will definitely distract her friends from their current course, but it is guaranteed to end up worse for her. She can only imagine how Glimmer would react to the implication she acts like her mother.

"That's, uh, positive thinking!" Bow takes a few long strides so he can get just ahead of her and turn to make eye contact as they walk. "*But Adora, it can get so much worse again*," he says, the same edge of anxiety in his voice that crops up whenever one of his brothers comes back to town and he's anticipating the aggressive amount of family time and friendly little brother taunting to come.

Adora knows he has a point – she *was* a lot lower back when they first fell apart, too defeated to even properly try to fix it – but she really doesn't think that is going to happen again. If Catra never reached out again, it would be a lot slower and gentler of a heartbreak.

She also really, really hopes that she's going to reach out again.

"Listen, she texts back or she doesn't, but if she wants to meet, I'm going whether or not you help me or disapprove," Adora tells them. She glances down to check her phone screen, but there's still no reply. It hasn't been that long since she sent the message, though, and she would guess Catra wants to text back slowly right now to make it seem like she isn't that invested. Pretending to be detached seems to be her plan right now. They're only just now reaching the dorm. She should probably wait another ten minutes before she sends a follow-up asking why Catra wanted to know, gently prompting her to *just ask*.

"You have a morning class again tomorrow," Glimmer reminds. Adora has a morning class *every* day, actually, it's just smart when supervillainy seems to lean towards the afternoon, but even if she can't really afford to miss another, she would, for Catra.

"Don't care," Adora replies, flashing Glimmer a wide smile to project confidence in her answer. That's what She-ra would do – what Adora would do if she were She-ra right now – so she goes with the impulse.

"Adora, you were crying about your grades two weeks ago," Bow points out, which is an unusually low blow for him no matter how genuine his worry sounds. Adora scowls.

"There were extenuating circumstances."

"Yeah, those circumstances were *Catra*," Glimmer returns. Adora opens her mouth to protest – it's true, but it was Adora's own fault for putting them in that situation and every day between Catra kicking her out and inviting her back was rough – but a familiar voice cuts her off.

"Aw, busy thinking of me?" The tone is coy and playful, causing Adora to jerk her head up and stare. Catra is standing only a few feet away at the point where their current path crosses over the one that continues on to the dorm building. Catra is dressed in a tight shirt and leggings – all of it *opaque* this time, thankfully, but not leaving too much to the imagination – with a large tote bag thrown over her shoulder.

She's smirking at Adora, a flash of fangs in her smile as her tail flicks back and forth, satisfied with the blank wall Adora's brain has hit after it ran out of new things about Catra to register and just defaulted to staring.

"Catra! Hi, long time no see!" Bow greets, too loud from nerves. Catra's gaze flicks to him momentarily, and then it returns to Adora.

"Yeah, can't imagine why that would be," she drawls. Adora opens her mouth, then closes it, trying to find something to say and mostly getting back static.

"You're here," she says, intelligently. The smirk returns for a moment, ghosting over Catra's face, but then her face sets.

"I need to talk to you and your friends," Catra tells her, making pointed eye contact. Adora blinks at her as Glimmer straightens beside her.

“We’re right here,” Glimmer says, but even as she does, she glances around, probably counting who is within earshot. Adora is still just watching Catra as exasperation crosses her face.

“*All* of your friends. Somewhere private. *Now*,” Catra clarifies, her eyes locked on Adora’s.

“It doesn’t work like that,” Glimmer starts, but Adora holds up her hand. “*Adora*,” Glimmer warns, her voice low. Adora ignores her, taking a few steps towards Catra to close the gap between them. Catra pulls her bag closer to her, but other than that she doesn’t give away any nerves, her tail even remaining still as she tilts her chin up and holds Adora’s gaze.

“Why?” Adora asks, her voice quiet. Catra, like Glimmer, glances around for other eavesdroppers. There’s plenty of people walking around, even on the same paths they’re standing at the intersection of, but none of them are too close at this second. Adora would do a lot of things for Catra, but she has to give her something if she really wants her to call an emergency meeting.

“There’s something you need to know. About someone you all have *unfinished business* with,” Catra says, pointedly. Adora’s mouth falls open, but she doesn’t have a reply.

She- wasn’t expecting that.

“And how would you know?” she hears Glimmer say from behind her shoulder. Catra tightens her grip on her bag, defensive, but she’s still only looking at Adora.

“Trust me, you’ll want to hear that too,” she promises. Adora draws in a sharp breath. There’s such *weight* in Catra’s words, her gaze, that Adora immediately believes her, even if she has no clue how Catra could have found something out, or even what *exactly* she’s implying. She was near the site of the attack last week. It’s possible she saw something, though the delay is strange.

“Adora?” Bow questions from Adora’s other shoulder. Adora picks up her jaw.

“Come on,” she decides, turning towards the path Catra must have come down, the quickest route to the library from here.

“*Adora*,” Glimmer hisses, but Bow is already pulling out his phone.

“What, you want to talk about this in the dorm?” Adora asks, already reaching a hand to Catra’s lower back to guide her along beside her. Catra sidesteps the touch. Adora feels her heart fall, but she quickly straightens her shoulders and looks forward again. Catra seems to pick up on her disappointment, because she drifts a little closer to walk by her side, just barely not touching her. Adora takes it, not trying to cross the gap, though Catra dodging her touch probably isn’t *helping* Adora’s friends trust her.

“No, but we can’t take her there! Are you seriously calling a meeting, Bow?” Glimmer starts, cutting herself off when her and Adora’s phones chime in unison. Bow looks up, shrugging, as Catra shoots them all an amused look, still walking in step with Adora.

“They should meet Catra anyway, don’t you think?” Bow asks. A sideways smile pulls at Catra’s lips, revealing fangs. Glimmer huffs as the library looms in the distance.

“My mom’s going to kill all *three* of us if we let someone unapproved in. Let’s just… meet in one of the back rooms first,” Glimmer says. Catra turns, angling her body to face Adora. Adora immediately turns to meet her, finding Catra’s gaze hot where it holds her own.

“On the roof, you told me about her. She’s doing worse than terrorizing baristas,” Catra says. Adora’s stomach drops. When she reaches out this time, she grabs Catra’s hand, and Catra lets her.

“Make sure everybody is ready to gather ASAP. Glimmer, you’re going to get all of them as soon as they’re available,” Adora orders, turning back down the path and beginning the march to the sanctum again.

“Adora!” Glimmer tries to protest, but Adora isn’t listening. That wasn’t an order from Adora – that was She-ra, and Glimmer is going to follow it no matter how unhappy she is with it.

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The sanctum is hidden behind a vault door, behind a bookcase, behind a locked room that only opens for a shortlist of keycards in the already-exclusive back archive. Adora swipes them in, Glimmer still unhappy, but the shift in Adora when Catra said those words was obvious and her friends are letting this happen begrudgingly.

“We are *so* dead,” Glimmer reminds as they descend the staircase. Adora is sure that Angella will be mad, but this room is theirs as much as hers – and at this point, her main claim to it is as the dean – and they need privacy for this.

“Welcome to the Alliance sanctum. The runestone holders have been meeting here for… a hundred and sixty years, I think,” Adora says, ignoring Glimmer and sweeping her hand out at the main sanctum chamber as they reach the bottom of the stairs. There are still two smaller rooms off to each side of the stairs, mirrored architecturally with one set up as a changing room and the other as an emergency medical station, but there’s no reason to give Catra a tour right now. The main chamber is much more impressive, anyway.

Catra eyes it as Adora slides her backpack off her shoulder, dropping it on the stand beside the entrance. Catra doesn’t do the same with her tote, her eyes tracing up the columns on the walls to the vaulted ceiling, dragging back down the thick central pillar and then darting around the space, taking in the comms hub in one corner, the training space in the opposite one, and the display of relics on the wall.

“Strangely catholic,” Catra comments, dryly. Adora snorts, hurrying to cover her mouth and nose. Catra snickers, but with the sparkle in her eyes, it isn’t a mean sound. Glimmer, for the

first time, seems a *little* less keyed up, so she probably decided that was more funny than insulting.

“Okay, we’re here. Why were you being so cryptic?” Glimmer asks as Catra takes a few wandering steps into the chamber. She slowly turns on her heel, finally glancing back towards them to raise a brow at Glimmer.

“I figured you didn’t want me to shout across campus that I have information about Shadow Weaver for the Alliance. Kind of thought it was a bad idea to text it, too,” she says, casually. Glimmer’s mouth falls open. Adora already knew that, but she couldn’t explain it either.

“How? What happened?” she asks, stepping forward from her friends to get closer to Catra again.

“I’ll tell you when the rest are here. This is complicated enough to explain once. But it’s because I followed my friend towards that attack,” Catra explains, confirming Adora’s suspicions. She nods, glancing back over her shoulder at Bow.

“ETA?” she asks. He glances down at his phone.

“Mermista is walking over so she’ll be a few minutes. Netossa is a no-go and Frosta hasn’t replied, but I think she’s in her after-school piano lessons right now. Perfuma is ready for a teleport and Spinnerella will be in a minute,” he lists off.

“Bow! Codenames!” Glimmer hisses. The closer they’ve gotten to the sanctum the higher her anxiety levels have gotten. It’s fair considering they’re all definitely getting yelled at. Bow sends her a sheepish smile.

“Oh. Oops,” he says. He only sounds half sorry.

“Wow,” Catra comments, her tone dry and the look she sends Adora amused. Adora rolls her eyes.

“You’re about to meet them anyway and it’s not like they’re going to be transformed. Bow, can you just pull up the trackers for Glimmer?” Adora says. Bow nods, striding over to the comm hubs, and after a moment Glimmer groans and follows him, sending Catra a warning glance before she turns her attention to the giant screen stretching above Bow’s main monitor, dumping her backpack beside it. At a keystroke, it jumps to life, displaying a map of both boroughs with labels for the location of all their comms. Catra takes it in, her gaze flicking around the map. Adora sidles up beside her on her free side and takes it as a victory that she doesn’t shift away again.

“So. It’s cool, right?” Adora asks, jerking her head out towards the sanctum in general because she knows Catra would deem the map creepy no matter how useful it is.

“It’s okay. I would have thought it was cooler if you showed it to me a year ago,” she returns, voice low to keep the conversation between them. Not that Glimmer and Bow can’t hear it, but it’s very like Catra to project every clue she can for other people to butt out.

“Yeah. I’m glad I can show you now, though, even if I’m terrified at the idea of you crossing paths with Shadow Weaver,” Adora agrees, keeping her voice soft too. Catra releases a twisted chuckle.

“Oh, princess, you have *no* idea,” she returns. If Adora were in her right mind, she would ask what that means, but instead she’s a little caught up on the nickname. *She’s princess*. Adora is, not just She-ra, and Catra came to *her*. Sure, she has an reason to, but a few weeks ago she would have avoided her anyway. Besides, she could have called Adora over and just told her at her apartment. Adora’s honestly confused about why she wants to call a meeting instead of making Adora retell it to them later, but she can guess Catra wants to get a feel for the Alliance, if not test them outright.

Glimmer pops out of existence, drawing Adora’s attention back to the moment. Catra’s ears twitch back at the sparkling sound. She sighs and turns to Adora, making eye contact. Adora is immediately standing at attention.

“Listen, Adora, there’s something you should probably know first. It’s going to be a shock-”

“Oh, wow, you were serious,” Mermista drawls from across the room. Catra cuts off with a hiss, turning to face the intrusion. Mermista stands at the bottom of the stairs, looking as bored as ever, but she’s watching Catra despite her blank appearance.

“Um, Mermista, meet Catra. Again,” Adora introduces, waving between them and trying to hurry the greetings up so they can get back to that *shock* thing. If Catra wants to say it just to Adora, it might not have anything to do with the Alliance. It might have something to do with them and just act as context for whatever Catra wants to tell them.

Adora has an intense vision of Catra confessing that she dated in the time apart and the person turned out to be a Horde officer. In the week since spotting them at the crater, she reached out and somehow picked up information about Shadow Weaver along the way-

Glimmer pops back into existence a few feet away with Perfuma on her arm. Catra’s ears pin back and her gaze darts between Mermista, Perfuma, and now Glimmer. Adora reaches out, taking Catra’s hand and focusing her attention back to her.

“Come on, we can talk in the changing room,” she offers. Catra nods, but when Adora takes a step away to lead her over, Catra hesitates.

“One second, I need to let them out,” she says, dropping Adora’s hand and taking a step back. Adora’s brow furrows as Catra slips her bag off her shoulder and lowers it to the ground.

“Huh?” Adora questions, intelligently, but Catra’s statement doesn’t make sense. Catra smirks as she places the bag on the ground and straightens back up. Her gaze, however, stays fixed down on the bag. For a moment, the sides mostly stay up, and then the entire bag shifts and crumples to the ground, empty except for Catra’s keys and phone, half-buried in the corner.

Something brushes Adora’s ankle and she jumps back with a yelp, equally startled by a strong hand on her waist as Catra catches her. Adora stares at her, blinking at Catra’s satisfied smile

just inches from her face as Catra pulls her back to her feet. She doesn't move back away.

"*Careful*. Don't step on them," Catra chastises, glancing down towards the empty air behind Adora.

"*Them?* Catra, what's going on?" Glimmer asks from behind them, caught on to *something* happening in the middle of the room. Something is rubbing against Adora's ankle. She can't tell what it is through her pants and that sends a crawling sensation up through her skin. She looks down, gritting her teeth to avoid the urge to step away again, but there's nothing there. Catra rolls her eyes and releases Adora's waist. She takes a large step back and squats down, holding her hand out to the thin air.

"Come on, it's just Adora's friends. No one's going to hurt you," Catra promises, *clearly* not talking to Glimmer anymore. A moment later, a small smile plays at her lips. Adora has no idea what Catra let loose in the sanctum, but *something* twines between her feet and then the sensation disappears.

"There you go," Catra murmurs as the air begins shimmering in front of her hand. The rough shape of a cat, distorted like a mirage, becomes visible, its nose nuzzled into Catra's hand, but then it *grows*, the shape solidifying and colors bleeding in as it expands. Adora takes a hasty step back to give room to the cougar-sized animal morphing into existence in the middle of the room. Her jaw drops as she takes in the large cat now nuzzling Catra's cheek and trying to lick her. Catra gives the cutest squeak of indignation. It's almost enough to distract Adora from the purple and blue creature she has definitely never seen before, but somehow feels familiar.

"Stop it! Fine, you're on your own," Catra protests, standing up and sending the creature a firm look like they're a toddler she's telling off. She finally looks up, a smile quirking her lips as she takes in Adora's expression, and then the shock on everyone else's face. Adora is sure it mirrors her own. "Guys, this is Melog. They're a krytian, if any of you know what that is, and they've spent the last several weeks locked up in Shadow Weaver's basement, so *be nice* to them. I'll translate for them when me and Adora are done. Come on," Catra says, reaching for Adora's hand.

Adora has too many questions to count or form an orderly queue, but she lets Catra lead her away even as she turns her head back to look at Melog. So that's why they look familiar. Adora was into magical creatures as a kid – mostly unicorns, now extinct like almost all the others – and she remembers coming across the eradication of the krytians. Even if she hasn't seen *this* krytian before, the purple and blue physiology is pretty distinctive.

"I thought they were dead," Mermista says in the same tone as always.

"That's rude!" Catra calls over her shoulder as they reach the base of the stairs. She pauses and glances at Adora. Right. Adora takes her hand and pulls her to the side, pushing open the door into the changing room. She hesitates before closing it behind her.

"Where did they come from?" Adora asks, still reeling from the *invisible extinct species in Catra's bag* thing. Catra looks exasperated.

“I already said I’m only explaining that once. This is more important. I thought it would take longer to get everyone together and I’d have time to tell you alone first,” Catra replies. Adora can’t *imagine* what is more important than the magical cat Catra snuck into the sanctum, but she closes her mouth and nods mutely. Catra blows out a breath, reaching her hand up to run through her hair, clearly gathering herself.

“Melog saw Shadow Weaver’s face when they were her captive,” Catra says, watching Adora carefully. Adora blinks.

“That’s… good. Although identifying her will still be hard,” Adora replies, cautiously. Catra shakes her head, her gaze burning where it holds Adora’s.

“I’ve *already identified* her. We know her, Adora. You and me,” Catra says. Adora feels a drop in her stomach at the vehement tone as much as Catra’s words. From the way she’s talking, it was someone *important*.

“Who?” Adora asks. Catra takes a deep breath, straightening out her shoulders as she collects herself. Then her lip curls in a sneer.

“*Madam Spinner*,” she says, her tone twisted into the same one their old “guardian” used to use when she corrected anyone for not addressing her with the proper reverence. Adora’s heart and mind stop.

“How?” Adora whispers, even though the appearance – alright, the hair and the voice, that’s about all the identifying information that has ever come from Shadow Weaver, and even her voice she would twist with illusions, often mirroring the Alliance’s own voices back at them mockingly – is matching up now that she knows to draw the connection. It has been nearly ten years since she last saw the woman, and that’s a big jump to make.

Especially because Shadow Weaver was already terrorizing the city when they were children.

“I don’t know for sure, but I’ve tried to put together a timeline and I have a theory. I’ll explain it when we’re talking to the group,” Catra says. She’s watching Adora carefully. Adora opens and closes her mouth again before deciding that processing this is going to take longer than this conversation can last.

“Okay. Let’s just… do this,” she agrees, reaching for Catra’s hand again. Catra takes hers, squeezing softly. The gesture is small and the pressure gentle, but it stops Adora in the middle of her thoughts. She’s doing that thing again, the thing she did a year ago that lost her Catra, where she pushes aside her emotions and tries to just work, doing whatever is best for as many people as possible, not including herself in the count.

Catra has always been a part of herself. She didn’t realize until the breakup how intertwined they were. Everything she wanted was with Catra, so ignoring herself was ignoring Catra’s needs on top of her own. She stops, looking at Catra’s face and searching it for a sign of how she feels about this. Catra has had time to process and prepare, though, and all Adora gets back is the same searching look.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks, her voice low. She’s reeling, but Catra is the one who often got the brunt of the madam’s displeasure. Adora knows, now, how much her cruel words sunk into Catra’s skin. Catra’s ears twitch back, but she grunts an affirmation.

“It’s fitting, isn’t it?” she says, her tone edged with bitterness. Adora can’t help it; she gives a rueful laugh, shaking her head a little.

“She… was evil enough, yeah,” she agrees, her words a little distracted as a vision comes, unbidden, of the first time Madam Spinner caught a younger Catra – a *far* too young Catra, still a kitten in Adora’s mind – scratching the furniture and the way she struck out at her. Someone like that could definitely be Shadow Weaver, but it’s a past connection that Adora never thought would return. She hasn’t even thought about the first warden of their group home in years.

“We can talk after?” Adora asks, sending Catra a hopeful look. It’s a lot. Maybe she’ll be willing to discuss at least this, and that feels like a good first step. Catra hesitates, but she nods.

“Everyone who’s going to come is here. We should go out before they think I’ve killed you in a fit of passion or something,” Catra says, her tone wary, apparently not willing to acknowledge her agreement out loud. Adora peers at her, surprised she could hear all that while maintaining the conversation. Catra’s confidence returns to her and she throws Adora a satisfied smile. “Melog. I’ll explain once we’re out there,” she answers, which isn’t an answer at all, but Adora reluctantly nods.

She squeezes her hand one last time and turns towards the door. This is going to be a *lot*.

Chapter End Notes

I have to stop the chapter here just because it’s so long jfc. Don’t worry fellas it gets gay again soon.

Chapter 11: Peace Talks

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Melog comes running up to Catra as soon as they emerge from the room, circling her and forcing Adora to step to the side as they meow insistently at her. Catra rolls her eyes, smiling as she reaches down.

“It was a few minutes,” she tells them. Adora watches the exchange a little confused. They didn’t even *touch* on the krytian thing. Catra looks up to Adora as she pets Melog’s head. Adora jolts into action again, nodding to her and then looking out at her team. Just Netossa – at work, probably – and Frosta are missing, but Spinnerella can catch her wife up, and given the frequency with which Catra tends to make dirty jokes, maybe it’s for the best that Frosta isn’t here.

Adora looks back to Catra, offering her hand, and Catra reluctantly takes it, letting Adora lead her to the middle of the room. Melog sticks close by her other side, apparently attached.

“Everybody, this is Catra. Catra, that’s Spinnerella,” the princess offers her a warm smile and Catra nods back, more business-like, “and Perfuma. You, um, can guess who they are. Or don’t. They’ll probably be less mad at me if you don’t, actually,” Adora finishes as Perfuma waves.

“We’re only mad if this turns out to be stupid. We don’t need an emergency meeting to meet your not-girlfriend,” Mermista drawls, inspecting her nails where she is leaned against the central column. After she finishes speaking, though, she glances at Melog. This is *clearly* important.

“She snuck an invisible creature in here!” Glimmer points out, apparently mad anyway. She… has a point, krytians aren’t just animals, but when Adora glances down at Melog, they blink back up at her with an innocence that doesn’t worry her.

“I wasn’t trying to sneak them in, I didn’t know where we were *going*. They’re in hiding after the whole Horde thing, I wasn’t going to take them out until we were somewhere private. Besides, we’re psychically bonded. I know they wouldn’t tell anybody, even if they could,” Catra shoots back, rolling her eyes, but her tail is swishing tensely behind her and Adora can see her stance tightening. She quickly steps between the two.

“Glimmer, it turns out I was raised by a supervillain, so maybe let’s just hear Catra out,” Adora says, sending her a firm look.

“*What?!*” Glimmer – along with a few others – startles. Everybody jerks up, staring at Adora as she cringes a little. Catra snickers, petting Melog beside her, apparently content with the reaction. Adora takes a breath and waves vaguely at Catra, taking a step back to give her the floor. Glimmer has a point about the Melog thing, but so does Catra, and she doesn’t want a fight to break out.

She sees a line of tension enter Catra's shoulders as she becomes the center of attention, but she's pretty sure she's the only one who can tell Catra's amused smile has turned false. Melog sits down by her side, drawing up to their full height. Her hand falls to rest lightly over the blue membrane of their mane, looking down to them for a moment before looking back up and facing the group.

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Catra almost wishes the whole Alliance was here so she could get meeting them over with, but every extra person is another one to be anxious about – except Glimmer and Bow, she knows their deal – so this is probably for the best. She has had plenty of practice being on the spot in her pre-law classes and it's only the *Adora* factor that's causing her problems now.

"I don't know how much any of you know about the krytians-" she starts, pausing for a moment that is quickly filled.

"A lot!" from Bow, who shoots his hand up as if being called on in class. At the same time, Perfuma says, "Krytians?" so that makes the knowledge range pretty clear. Knowing what she needs to say makes everything easier, breaking down the task into smaller parts to cover.

"Ancient telepathic race heavily based on magic. They were the victims of a religious war a few centuries ago that nearly eradicated them. The few survivors went into hiding. Rumors some lived pop up whenever someone happens to spot one, but eventually it's always dismissed. Unless you're Shadow Weaver, anyway," she summarizes from the information she and Entrapta have found, glancing between the members of the Alliance pointedly. Glimmer is worried about her precious sanctum, but in order for Melog to tell somebody, they would have to reveal their own existence first.

"Mutual receipts, everyone keep their mouth shut. Got it," Mermista says from her pillar. Catra snorts at the same time that Adora does and she glances to the side. They exchange an amused glance before she realizes the pattern that they just fell back into without even trying. She quickly looks back to the group, ignoring the heat in her face and refocusing.

"Krytians have a lot of magic, but they mostly just use it for manipulating their form. Apparently it makes them a good magic battery if you're a psychopath, though. A few weeks ago, Shadow Weaver managed to capture Melog. She has had them caged up in an old subway maintenance station since," Catra explains, pausing to lift her hand to Melog's head when their ears pin back. They're bad memories. Catra looks up to find Adora wincing.

"Yeah, if you think being her legal ward was bad, being her captive was way worse," she mutters. They weren't safe from *anything*, but at least they didn't get their bodies ripped apart and drained daily. Adora looks a bit sick as she nods.

"*Shadow Weaver* was your guardian?" Mermista asks, her tone containing an emotion beyond boredom and annoyance for the first time ever, even if that emotion is incredulity. Catra

glances at Adora, unsure what is known and what she *wants* known. Adora hesitates, holding Catra's gaze for a moment, and then she looks to her friend.

"Until we were fourteen and she vanished, yeah, apparently she ran our group home. Madam Spinner was…" Adora trails off for a moment, but Catra fills in the blanks for her.

"A manipulative psychopath who turned into a completely different person whenever a social worker came to drop off another kid? And then she would turn around and call us ungrateful for not singing her praises enough in front of someone important?" she tries, what was supposed to be a joke stirring agitation in her chest as the memories resurface in the back of her mind.

Adora's eyes find her face at the same time as her hand takes Catra's. Catra's instinct is to pull away, but there's an immediate relief to Adora's gentleness, a sharp contrast to the woman in Catra's memories. Adora was the only thing that got her through that period.

"Someone I'm not surprised was capable of being a terrorist in her spare time. It's mostly a surprise she had any time left with all the children she had to traumatize in a day," Adora finishes for herself. It's enough to get Catra to quirk a smile. It's definitely one of those things that is only a shock until you start thinking about it. Then it makes too much sense. She sighs, looking back down at Melog.

"That intersection explosion happened when Shadow Weaver tried to take too much from Melog. She accidentally blew up everything she had stored from them. It broke Melog's cage along with everything else, though, and they escaped," Catra explains, waving her hand vaguely as she tries to move past the horrors. Mermista whistles lowly.

"That must have taken a *lot* of magic," Glimmers says, almost to herself, sounding caught between impressed and horrified as she looks down at Melog. Catra shrugs vaguely. Shadow Weaver had been taking from Melog for a long time and the storage crystal she had was huge. It doesn't surprise her, but she doesn't know shit about magic.

"Melog saw her without the mask as they were escaping. She has scars now, but I recognized her when Melog showed me the memory. That bitch loomed over me my entire childhood. It would be pretty hard to mistake her," Catra finishes, muttering bitterly by the end. Melog didn't get a great look, but Catra knows what she saw. She glances over to find Adora's expression unsure.

"Scars?" Adora asks. Catra pauses, trying to figure out how to explain it.

"Really big ones across her face. I did some digging and found an article from around when Spinner vanished asking the public to keep an eye out for women matching Shadow Weaver's description showing signs of curses. There weren't a lot of details, just that dark magic backfired in one of her ploys to take over the city. I'd guess she couldn't make her way back before someone noticed her absence and they replaced her," Catra explains. It's a guess, but the timelines match up and it would explain something that never made sense before. Adora's expression is sour. Catra's chest doesn't feel much better.

“And here I spent the last eight years hoping she just got stuck in a gutter,” Catra adds in a mutter, somewhere between bitter and joking. Adora cracks a smile at least, elbowing Catra as if she actually cares about her insulting *Shadow Weaver*. Catra elbows her back and then flushes when Adora steps closer to wrap her arm around the inside of Catra’s and hold her hand, making it a lot harder to get any leverage to elbow effectively.

“I can ask my mom. She might have been there, or heard about it,” Glimmer says, making an *incredibly* mature face at the affection. Adora probably has her fooled into thinking she’s sweet and this isn’t just a defensive measure.

Melog thinks she and her lover are being ridiculous. Melog can *stuff it*.

“Anyway, I found Melog hiding when I was leaving the intersection. When I tried to coax them out, they used what magic they had left to bond with me so they would know if I could be trusted. It took them a while to work through everything and show me that memory,” Catra tacks on. She didn’t tell Adora about Melog right away, but that was because Melog needed time to process and she wasn’t exactly talking to Adora anyway. She still planned to tell her if Melog could give her anything, and the Shadow Weaver revelation was something she needed to know right away. Catra spent last night researching and then came to Adora like *Adora* should have done with Catra when the whole She-ra thing happened.

“Bonded?” Adora asks. She looks concerned – maybe more than she was about the Shadow Weaver thing. Catra glances down, looking at Melog. They hold her gaze. Catra places a hand on top of Melog’s head and they close their eyes, both of them shimmering and turning translucent. Oh. Okay. So that’s what the cloak looks like when you’re *in* it. Melog senses her thoughts and drops the cloak, looking back up at her again as she drops her hand.

When she glances up, the entire Alliance is staring at her, but Adora most of all.

“We can pass thoughts back and forth. Memories too, when we want. When they cloak, I can tell where they are even when I’m not in it with them. Aside from that, we’re still figuring it out,” she explains. Adora looks down, and then she squeezes Catra’s hand and sends her a hopeful look. Catra knows what she’s asking without the need for words or a psychic bond and she rolls her eyes, nodding to Melog.

Adora reaches her hand out, offering it to Melog. Melog sniffs it as if they didn’t try to scent mark her ankles when they first met. Melog can’t even scent mark, it was just pure transfer affection. After a moment Melog bonks their head forward, trilling as they demand a pet Adora is more than happy to give, a smile blooming on her face.

“Nice to meet you, Melog. Be nice to Catra, okay? And the rest of us want to help you, too. It’s our mission to fight the Horde,” Adora promises them. Catra feels stupidly warm and quickly reminds herself that *fighting the Horde* means having no time left for *her*.

“Knowing who Shadow Weaver really is *feels* like it should help with that, but what can we do, actually? We can’t exactly tell the police. They’re really unhappy with us after the Swift Wind incident and we can’t tell them our evidence without compromising Adora’s identity,” Perfuma speaks up from the side lines. Catra shoots Adora a questioning look. Adora offers her a sheepish smile, her hand leaving Melog’s head to rub at the back of her neck instead.

“Um, I may have discovered another She-ra power a few months ago and accidentally transformed one of the police horses into a unicorn. That talks. And hates the police for enslaving animals to do their bidding. He has been running around trying to break free the other horses and K-9 dogs ever since. It’s a whole… thing,” Adora explains, waving her hand. Catra *stares* at her, but no one laughs like it’s a joke.

“You made a horse *sentient*?” she asks, incredulous. Half the Alliance snickers and the other half nods.

“And a communist,” Bow adds, helpfully. Catra is suddenly struck with the revelation that as weird as her last week has been, their lives are *always* like this. It must be, for them to be reacting like it’s just this funny, embarrassing thing Adora did. Adora looks chagrinned, but she just shrugs.

“They’ve asked me to take care of him a few times after we’ve cleared a scene, but what am I going to do, track him down and make him *un*sentient? I don’t know how, and clearly he enjoys having freewill!” Adora explains, gesturing vaguely with her free hand. This is clearly a justification she has given before, probably *to* the police. Catra psychically bonding to a random magic cat has nothing on this.

“Is this what you were talking about when you said the police don’t like the Alliance?” Catra asks. Adora relaxes, her smile softening now, like just the memory of their old conversations, back when things were uncomplicated, is enough to ground her.

It occurs to Catra for the first time that maybe Adora misses being just She-ra to her too. It was so easy then, so fun.

Fuck.

“Yeah. And the usual vigilante stuff I’ve already told you about. They were never going to like us even before Swift Wind,” Adora says with a shrug. There are a few looks of agreement between the Alliance that turn amused when Glimmer mutters *but definitely not now*. Adora huffs as Catra actually cracks a smile. Okay, so this is group is lot friendlier than Adora made it seem in her justifications. From their reaction to the absolutely *insane* horse thing, they’re just a bunch of magic weirdos.

Melog feels more at ease knowing that, the thought coming through in the back of Catra’s mind, but it just means they fit in, so of course they would like it.

Melog turns invisible so the rest of the group can’t see them attempting to trip Catra in retaliation for that thought, but she’s standing still and it doesn’t work very well, so she just looks down at the air they’re roughly occupying and sends them an unimpressed look. Adora – who definitely got brushed against as Melog tried to wind around Catra’s legs – snickers at the exchange.

“If you can write down all of the information you have on Shadow Weaver’s real identity, I can try to find her. Call it my P.I. agency’s first case. It’s more than we had before,” Mermista says from the pillar she’s leaning against. Catra looks up, blinking at her, and then shoots Adora a questioning look.

“Mermista wants to be an independent investigator after she graduates,” Adora leans in and tells her in a low voice, like she’s trying to secretly fill her in. Absolutely everyone can hear them. Mermista points at Adora.

“The system doesn’t work, so I work outside of the system. I *will* bust the Horde before the police does,” she says, like a catchphrase she plans to put on the front door. Her statement has such force behind it Catra almost believes it. Being a princess kind of gives her a leg up, but the Alliance hasn’t managed it with their combined forces in all these years, either, so Catra has her doubts.

“Normally we just… show up and fight and then turn the rest over to the cops, but Mermista wants to do more,” Adora explains further, gesturing at Mermista as she preens under what she clearly considers a compliment. Glimmer straightens up, indignant.

“Hey, I tried! But *nooo*, Mom said we have to let the police do their job. They’ve only ever arrested individual squads, they’re clearly never going to get there! The Horde will always terrorize the city if we don’t do *something*,” Glimmer protests, an impassioned rant she has clearly made before. Catra doesn’t blame her, though. Maybe she has more motivation than ever to want the Horde gone – there’s a lot animosity knowing what Shadow Weaver has done both to Melog and to *her* over the years – and she wants to see them taken down, but there’s another thing. An Adora-shaped thing, so something she isn’t addressing right now.

“I would love to take the fight to them! We just don’t know how to do that any more than the police do,” Adora responds, taking a step forward as the conversation shifts into a debate, but before Glimmer can shoot back *whatever* she is drawing in breath to prepare for, Catra places her hand on Adora’s chest, drawing the attention of both of them when she breaks their line of sight with each other. Catra gently pushes Adora back to stand beside her. Adora looks to her, relaxing beneath her touch so easily it makes Catra’s breath hitch.

“So how about *we*,” Catra says pointedly, holding eye contact with Adora, “put together what new information we have to see if it helps,” Catra jerks her head towards the stairs. Adora sends a glance out to the Alliance, gets a few nods back, and then immediately looks back to Catra with a wide grin. She squeezes Catra’s hand, lacing their fingers togethers.

“Yeah, sounds great,” she agrees, going from an argument to smiling just like that. Catra rolls her eyes. This is ridiculous. Catra suggested they talk about one of the worst times in their life, but she knows that Adora is smiling because no matter why, they are *talking*.

“I need to get back before my next appointment,” Spinnerella volunteers from the back of the group. When she says it, Perfuma nods vaguely in a way that Catra takes to mean she also has stuff to do. Clearly the meeting is adjourning, which Catra is fine with. This has been *enlightening*, but she has things she wants to ask just Adora. Glimmer jumps to her feet.

“I’ll take you,” Glimmer promises, teleporting all of *three feet* over to Spinnerella and grabbing her arm. Spinnerella smiles, surprising Catra by looking at her and waving.

“Bye, it was nice to meet you!” she says, voice warm and genuine. Catra’s tail twitches, uncomfortable, but Spinnerella quickly looks over at Adora and spares Catra the pain of responding. “I’ll fill Netossa in tonight,” she promises. Adora gives her a firm nod – the kind

of nod Catra has seen from She-ra in news clips before, a commander addressing their soldier despite Spinnerella looking like she could be Adora's mom. No one questions it, though, and it just serves as a reminder to Catra there's still a lot she doesn't know about all this. Shit like the *sanctum* looming around them.

Twinkling crawls in the back of Catra's hearing as Glimmer summons her sparkles and then she and Spinnerella disappear in a shower of them. Catra twitches each of her ears, shaking the sound away, as Mermista pushes off her column.

"Yeah, I've got a date, so just get that to me whenever," she says, her voice bored again. The contrast only makes Catra more aware of how impassioned – for her, anyway – Mermista got when talking about the Horde. Adora steps aside, pulling Catra with her, which makes Catra equally aware of the fact they were in between Mermista and the stairs as it does that they're still holding hands. She waits until Mermista has walked past them and made her way up the stairs before she turns to Adora with a sigh.

"Can we talk?" she asks. Adora looks like she has just been offered a puppy and she's expecting Catra to yank it away.

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Adora takes them back to the changing room again. The main space is a little *austere* and the changing room had some comfortable-looking seating. Also, Bow and Perfuma are still out there, not to mention Glimmer whenever she gets back, and right now Catra wants privacy from Melog too. They're far apart enough that it's easy to silence the bond as she settles on a sofa beside the footrest bench Adora has laid across, propped up on one arm. Catra is pretty sure she laid like that because it makes her shirt ride up a little so she can flex her abs. Or maybe Catra is the only one whose thoughts go in that direction the moment they're alone, but they definitely aren't here to put together that list for Mermista, at least not yet.

Catra doesn't really know where to start. For a long moment, they just look at each other, taking in the other. There are so many things they need to cover and so many things Catra doesn't *want* to, but – stupidly – the conversation with the Alliance felt… not as bad as it could have. Yeah. It could have been awful and it… wasn't that, despite the subject matter.

Fuck, okay, she found it kind of fun. She liked falling into her old patterns with Adora and she liked hearing about the stupid shit she has been up to. She's supposed to hate the Alliance for taking Adora away from her, but for the last year she has hated *herself* just as much as Adora for not being lovable. All she had was some weird kind of revenge fantasy about becoming a lawyer and one day – maybe – having the opportunity to brush Adora off completely so she finally saw what she lost, ruining Adora like she ruined her.

Catra doesn't want that anymore. She doesn't know that she ever did, it was just the only thing she could imagine getting that was satisfying for even a moment. She sighs and then she nudges Adora's bench, just a few inches away, with her foot.

“Tell me how the She-ra thing happened,” she says. Adora blinks at her, her mouth forming an *o* shape, clearly surprised by Catra’s request. It’s stupid that Catra finds that cute. The thought that she wants to bite Adora’s bottom lip is more acceptable, but it’s still all dumb.

“Okay!” Adora suddenly nods vehemently, clearly pausing for a moment to think. Catra raises a brow at her, but she waits. “Remember how Bow’s dads are historians? George teaches here?” Adora says. Catra rolls her eyes, but she nods. She doesn’t forget things and they both know it. It’s more likely that Adora forgets whether she mentioned it before.

“Well, they collect artifacts. Some are at their house, some are here at the university, and then there’s the artifacts Lance works with at the museum, too. I visited their house for an early Halloween party and I started feeling weird. Honestly, I thought I was getting sick, which seems stupid now considering the ‘symptoms,’ but I thought I was hallucinating or something because I was seeing these lights in the corners of my eyes, and I felt like something was *pulling* me towards them,” Adora explains.

“Adora, tell me you didn’t follow them. That’s how people get cursed,” Catra cuts in, but she already knows the answer before Adora sends her the worst attempt at an innocent smile in history. It’s far too chagrinned to pass.

“I just thought I needed some time away from the crowd. I ducked into a backroom they used for storing their private collection. They had a broken sword that they were restoring sitting on a table. It felt like it was calling to me, which was stupid *at the time* and makes sense now, but before I knew it, I was reaching for the handle. I had it in my hand before I realized what I was doing, so I freaked out and hurried to put it back down, but my hand brushed against the jewel set in the hilt.”

Adora sits up, reaching out into the air and concentrating. Light forms beneath her fingers and She-ra’s sword snaps into existence in her hand. She tilts the sword, showing off the blue gem set in its hilt to Catra. Catra hesitates, and then she reaches out. She sends Adora a questioning look, but Adora just nods, still holding the sword out, so Catra cautiously runs her fingers over it. She swears the jewel flashes when her fingers brush it. The rest of the sword is surprisingly cold for something seemingly made of light.

“Glimmer and Bow had come looking for me. They saw the flash of light from under the door. When they ran inside, I was standing there as She-ra, freaking out. There was a lot of whisper-shouting; it was a disaster. I tried to put the sword back in its case, and when I let go it was like a flashbang. When we could see again, the sword was lying there with the jewel missing completely from its hilt. Bow was freaking out about how his dads were going to kill us and Glimmer was freaking out about the princess I turned into for five seconds,” Adora explains, laughing a little at the end, but she seems nervous.

Catra *really* wishes she had witnessed that, because it sounds hilarious, but she would have been freaking out in the moment too. She just nods. Adora seems a little disappointed, releasing the sword and letting it disintegrate into light.

“Bow ended up taking us to his room so we could freak out somewhere a little more private. Glimmer thought she had figured out *something* about what happened, so she gave me a very confusing peptalk, but she managed to talk me through transforming. That’s how I found out

Glimmer was Moonstone and she and Bow were in the Alliance. We had to go to her mom and do some research to confirm it, but the runestone in the sword's hilt was She-ra's," Adora explains. Catra's face scrunches.

"How? How does any of that work?" she asks, thinking back to those *lost princesses* she read about. Adora blows out a steadying breath, her expression confusingly nervous.

"You know how I said all of this is a really big secret?" Adora says, keeping her voice low like she's afraid of setting Catra off again. Okay, *not* confusing then. Catra reluctantly nods. "Usually when we pass on the runestones, we… Glimmer calls it producing them from our heart. They're a part of us, and we manifest them as a physical runestone we pass onto the next person, who then takes it into their heart, passing on the powers and title. That's how the runestone vanished from the hilt as soon as I touched it. It became a part of me," Adora explains, waving her hand vaguely.

Catra *knew* Adora hadn't been lying about her powers this entire time, but it's still a relief to hear that she really didn't have them. Somehow it's not surprising how touchy-feely she manages to make something magically latching onto her soul sound.

"How do you know who the next She-ra is supposed to be? Surely it isn't just whoever touched it, someone else must have done it by then," Catra asks. Adora's expression makes it clear she's not confident in her answer before she even begins speaking.

"There are people who are worthy, and the current runestone holder can usually tell when someone like that comes along. I don't think I'm the only person who could have become She-ra, I'm just… the only one who did, you know? The only person close enough for the runestone to call, who was worthy of it, who *listened* to it. Or maybe I was born for it and its fate. I don't know. Runestones usually run in families, it's just easier to find and mentor someone that way, I guess, but Spinnerella's mentor started as her neighbor and somehow recognized a spark in her," Adora explains.

That finally explains the *princesses* thing and the last lingering questions from Catra's research. Of course a royal bloodline would want to hang onto that power once they had it, but eventually they all diverged once there wasn't someone worthy enough. That still leaves a more recent question, though.

"What does that have to do with the secrecy?" Catra asks. Adora nods, taking a deep breath.

"Hundreds of years ago, there was this cult. Now the princesses fight the Horde, but back then they fought that cult. It managed to capture one of them, Spirit Ember, and killed her. When we die, the runestones come out if we haven't passed them on, and they *shattered* hers. They killed not only the girl, but Spirit Ember itself. It sent the princesses into a panic, and then the cult captured She-ra also. For the last four hundred years, all the princesses thought she was dead, too. Forever."

Oh. Oh, it isn't just some bullshit paranoia thing.

"But… that cult isn't around anymore, is it?" Catra asks, slowly, resisting the urge to bury her claws in the couch. It's so stupid to want to protect Adora. She's fucking *She-ra*. She doesn't

need Catra.

“Not really. It was large, but it died out eventually. No one knew a runestone could be shattered before that, though. A few of the ‘princesses’ had already become anonymous over the years as the runestones passed on to nobodies, but they all decided that their identities should be secret from then on. Even doing that – even with the cult gone – they think another runestone got destroyed a few decades ago. She vanished without a trace and has never turned up again, anyway. But they thought the same thing and were wrong about She-ra, so maybe the runestone is still out there in someone’s ring or something,” Adora says. Catra feels uncomfortable and she doesn’t like it.

She doesn’t want to understand the dumb rule at *all*, but she can see why they’re scared. Ancient religions say the runestones were a gift from the goddess who created Etheria. At the end of creation – or after humans really fucked up, depending on who wrote the story – she divided herself into the runestones, creating She-ra as her avatar and leaving the runestone holders as the defenders and peacekeepers of Etheria.

No matter where they came from, it’s a fact that no one knows how to make *more*. Losing a runestone is losing a princess, forever. Keeping their identities secret so they can’t be hit by a car on their way to work makes sense. Catra thinks saying that she understands the theory but it was stupid for Adora to lie to her – on Adora’s part, and on the Alliance’s for insisting on it instead of just trusting someone they already knew was worthy – is as reasonable as she is going to get.

Worthy isn’t the same thing as *smart*, though, Adora already proved that.

“What *did* happen to She-ra?” Catra asks, because she doesn’t want to say any of that. Adora looks down at her own hands, flexing them for a moment.

“Either they couldn’t destroy her runestone or they wanted to keep it for its power. The sword Bow’s dads had was a style known to be used by that cult in ceremonies. She-ra has probably been trapped in the hilt for four hundred years. It’s not surprising no one in the cult was worthy of her, and apparently no one else who found the sword since was worthy either. It was just… dumb luck that I eventually found it,” Adora explains, looking at her hands like they’re not even her own. She doesn’t look up when she finishes, her expression tense.

Catra twitches her tail forward. Another flick and it lands squarely in Adora’s hands. She startles, but after blinking for a moment, her fingers close around Catra’s tail and she smiles. Catra feels her breath hitch, the soft expression such a *relief* after the sick look in Adora’s eyes. For a moment, Adora just pets her tail, her touch gentle.

“It was a lot to discover. I suddenly had responsibilities I never imagined on me, not to mention living up to She-ra after *four hundred years* of everyone building her up as this lost goddess. I just… really didn’t want to fuck it up, and it was the first time a stranger had ever inherited a runestone, so the Alliance was nervous. They tried to put me through this crash course and drill all these rules into me, and then a year later it turns out none of them are as harsh and world-ending as I thought early on, but even if the Alliance didn’t care once they trusted me, I’d already failed and lost everything, so all I could do was focus on being She-ra, because it was the only thing I hadn’t fucked up yet,” Adora says, her voice low and gaze still

fixed on Catra's tail as she passes her hands over it rhythmically. Catra's heart feels like a live wire, so she can only imagine what Adora is feeling. For a moment, they both just look down at Adora's hands.

"You weren't supposed to make me feel sorry for you," Catra finally whispers. It's mostly a joke, and it manages to earn a heavy chuckle from Adora. She looks up, a wry smile on her lips.

"Hey, I'll take pity sex if that's what it takes," she says, the look in her eyes lending more sincerity to it than her joking tone implies she was going for. Catra gives a short, amused purr. She scoots closer to perch on the edge of the couch, reaching her arm up as she does so to drape over Adora's shoulders.

"That's not what it takes," Catra murmurs to her. When her gaze drops down, Adora takes it as the permission it is and leans in along with her. They meet in the middle, one of Adora's hands coming up to cradle Catra's cheek. The kiss is slow, soft in a way that none of the ones before have been. It's also just *different*, and it takes Catra a second to realize it's because it's their first one.

She has only kissed She-ra before. The thought sparks something in her chest and then she's half standing, kissing Adora insistently when it seems like she might pull back because they do *not* need to part for Catra to slide her knee onto the bench beside Adora, the rest of her following a moment later as she straddles Adora's lap.

Adora's hand that was on her tail is at the perfect height to wrap around her hip, guiding her in as Catra settles her weight on her. The kiss has taken on a new life, but it still doesn't feel filthy like the ones they shared on their night together and Catra doesn't want it to be. She just wants to kiss Adora, and feel her body against her, and ride this high where she momentarily doesn't really feel mad at anybody and feels like – maybe – things could get better.

"Catra, I-" Adora gasps when they briefly part, and then kisses her again. Catra growls into the kiss, not quite playful, but definitely not *mad*. Horny. She's horny. "I've missed you so much," Adora manages in the next breath, both of her hands coming up to frame Catra's face as she pulls her into the next kiss. Catra whines quietly into it, unsure if she likes this better than before, but on the next breath Adora chooses to say, "I love you so much, I can't believe you're *here*," and Catra nearly melts in her hands.

Adora seems satisfied with that, tilting her head and kissing her how she wants as Catra stutters a rough purr. It's a little whimpering – partially self-soothing – but Adora drinks it down, especially when Catra presses her body closer and arches to press their chests together.

"We are *not* having sex in the sanctum," Adora pulls away from the kiss just long enough to breathe, her tone is rueful. Catra finds herself laughing, which turns the kiss into a *mess*, but Adora doesn't seem to have any problem shifting to kiss around Catra's face instead. Catra tilts her head back, letting Adora's lips trail down to her jaw while Catra is still getting her smile under control.

“Princess, it would *definitely* not be the first time,” she says. She didn’t clock a straight person in that room, and with the tensions of this job? Yeah, if it wasn’t the current princesses, then it was someone in the past. Adora chuckles as her lips trail down Catra’s neck.

“No, but Glimmer and Bow are still in there,” Adora points out. She then undermines everything she just said by nipping at Catra’s neck and making her moan, her eyes fluttering closed and breathing stuttering. “Sorry, it’s just-” Adora kisses the spot she bit, “-so tempting,” this time she kisses the corner of Catra’s jaw and Catra decides to take matters into her own hands, sliding her hand up to hook around the base of Adora’s head and pull her up into a proper kiss again.

“Shut up,” she murmurs into it. It’s hard to kiss around a smile, but they manage it, this time a little less frantic. Catra raised up on her knees at some point in the shifting to be closer and now she lowers herself back down, the kiss finally ending in a soft slide before they rest their foreheads together, just holding each other and breathing in each other’s air.

“Catra, are we…” Adora struggles for a moment, “talking again?” she settles on, voice slightly strained. Catra can’t help but laugh, leaning back enough to get a look at Adora’s pout. Adora’s eyes are soft and she smiles a moment later, the laugh answer enough. Catra leans in closer again.

“Well…” she drawls, experimentally dragging her fingertips down the side of Adora’s neck as she drops her hand from the back of Adora’s head. She’s rewarded with a slight shiver and Adora’s eyes dilating. Catra smirks. “I kind of got saddled with this *magic cat* business, and unfortunately I think they’ve already decided they like you. If you think meowing can get annoying, imagine how bad it is when they can get in your *thoughts* too,” Catra says, as if Melog doesn’t like Adora because *Catra* likes Adora. They have their own opinions, but they wouldn’t be rubbing around her ankles yet without the weight of Catra’s emotions behind it. Melog deciding they like the rest of the Alliance is all on them, though. Catra had nothing to do with that.

Adora rolls her eyes, but she’s smiling as her hands settle on Catra’s hips, just holding her close.

“I’ll be sure to thank them later,” she says, ducking in to kiss Catra’s cheek again. It surprises Catra and she squeaks, her hands weirdly flexing in what she only realizes a moment later was an aggressive and brief knead. Her face feels warm and her tail swishes behind her, giving her away. She tilts her chin back, looking out at the superhero locker room over Adora’s shoulder like she has developed a sudden interest in the furniture.

“Everything isn’t… fixed,” she adds. It needs to be said. This moment feels great – *is* great – but she’s probably going to be angry again at some point, and there’s so much shit for them to say, so much shit they made each other feel. Adora’s hands flex on her hips, squeezing gently.

“I know. But I really want to try, if you’ll let me,” Adora says, her voice soft. Catra reluctantly meets her eyes and finds only searing sincerity there.

“I’m going to be at BMU in three months anyway. It would be awkward if I was still dodging you,” she says, like she doesn’t desperately want more moments like this in her life. Maybe Adora is the love of her damn life, though, because the soft smile that twitches at her lips tells Catra she knows what Catra isn’t willing to say.

“We wouldn’t want you to have to duck into bushes when you’re wearing one of your fancy outfits,” Adora agrees, nodding seriously. Catra snorts.

“They’re *suits*, you uncultured swine. It’s called looking professional. It’s just for my law classes,” she returns. Adora grins, the insult bouncing right off her. She sways forward slightly, like she’s *thinking* of kissing her, but unfortunately she manages to hold herself back.

“Of course. You’re going to be the hottest lawyer,” Adora returns. Catra rolls her eyes because that *so* isn’t the point, but her tail has ideas of its own and is swaying excitedly behind her.

“Whatever, idiot. Your friends are going to *think* we’re having sex if we stay in here much longer,” Catra says. Adora predictably pouts, her hands running over Catra’s side one last time. Whether she’s making sure she’s real or considering pulling her in for more kisses is up for debate. After a moment, Adora hesitates.

“If we’re… *talking*,” she says slowly, with as much caution as loaded meaning, “does that mean we’re doing this stuff too?” she settles on, hands pointedly squeezing Catra’s hips. Catra chuckles inelegantly, almost snorting.

“Try to stop me,” she returns, ducking in and kissing Adora before she can make a smartass comment. Adora melts beneath her lips, kissing back slowly. It’s so easy to sink into Adora, Catra could easily make out with her for another ten minutes, and only when she realizes that does she reluctantly pull back, dropping her head onto Adora’s shoulder so she has an excuse not only to hide her face, but also to nose at her pulse point and maybe rub her cheek against her shoulder too. Alright, it’s affectionate nuzzling, but *Adora* doesn’t have to know that.

“Alright, come on, sleepy. If you manage the walk into the sanctum I can take you back to the dorm for a nap,” Adora says, dropping a kiss against the side of Catra’s head. Catra isn’t *sleepy*, but she doesn’t correct Adora. She is known for her unusual sleep schedule. Curse of being a magicat.

“Hey, Adora?” Catra speaks up from her shoulder, still not moving. Adora sucks in a breath, stilling beneath her.

“Yeah?” she replies, a hopeful lilt to her voice, though Catra doesn’t know what she is hoping *for*. She doubts Adora does, either. Maybe an undying love confession. Yeah, she’s at least a few months of not being an asshole away from that.

“What did you tell Bow’s dads?” Catra asks, turning her head to speak more clearly and coincidentally rubbing her cheek along Adora’s shoulder in the process. A huffing laugh breaks the anticipation in Adora’s body. One of her arms winds around Catra’s lower back, hugging her close.

“We kind of gaslighted them. Bow pretended he didn’t remember there being a runestone in the sword when they showed it to him, but they had pictures from when they bought it with the stone there, so they ended up arguing about if the stone was in the sword when it arrived, and if it *was*, when it fell out and who was handling the sword when it did. I think they’re still convinced it’s rolled under a display case or something in that room. They mentioned *maybe* someone stole it at the party, but there were no signs of it being pried out, so it seemed like it was just loose enough to fall,” Adora explains, kissing Catra’s hair again as she talks. When Adora chuckles at the end, her breath puffs hot against Catra’s ear. Her nerve endings immediately light up and she reminds them to calm back *down*.

She fully plans to fuck Adora again before they talk about the breakup or any of the shit since, but now isn’t the time for that. Now that Adora has suggested leaving, she can feel Melog getting stressed in the back of her mind, waiting for them to come back. They relax a little just at the brush of their minds, knowing Catra is okay and coming back for them soon. They weren’t entirely comfortable with Catra leaving them alone with strangers, but they both knew that they could be trusted and Catra could use a *little* time without them. Besides, it’s healthy or something to be able to handle separation.

Catra sighs and reluctantly sits up. She really doesn’t want to, but she slides out of Adora’s lap. They still have to talk about the Shadow Weaver shit, but after a conversation like that, Catra needs a rest period before anyone makes her feel emotions again.

“Come on, we should go,” she says, pretending she can’t hear how disappointed her own voice is. Adora stands quickly, taking Catra’s hand when she does. Catra feels a smile pull at her face as she glances down at Adora lacing their fingers together. This is nice. As long as Catra doesn’t get too hung up on the past again, this doesn’t have to be the only time she experiences it. She has tried so hard to be determined and cling onto her anger, but as soon as she’s in Adora’s presence again, it all melts away.

She’s annoying like that.

Chapter End Notes

I said the Swift Wind thing as a joke in the comments a while ago and then I had to work it into the lore somehow because I found it too funny

Chapter 12: Movie Night?

Chapter Notes

> Wassup a capacitor blew at my house and I couldn't really use my computer for two days ✌ Definitely didn't help me get back on track but I've got another update at least.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When they walk back into the main chamber of the sanctum, they find most of the Alliance gone, just Glimmer and Bow waiting with Melog. Melog comes running up to Catra just like they did before, twining around her like Adora is pretty sure they tried in the middle of their meeting about the Horde situation. Catra smiles just like that, easy and affectionate, as she bends to pet them. She has clearly taken to them quickly, but the mental bond probably helps. Adora is going to have to do some research on that. They have had *so much* to cover – and still have more to go – that the krytian thing is really having to take a backseat. She can't believe she's even thinking that, but she can see why Catra was focusing on other things when she first got here, even if she definitely enjoyed the chaos of revealing Melog.

"Alright, go run some laps and get your energy out. It's time to shrink down and get back," Catra tells them, tousling their ears. Melog *mrow*s and it manages to sound petulant. Catra rolls her eyes, shooing them out towards the chamber at large. "Yeah, well, only animals that can fit in bags are allowed on the train," she returns. Melog slinks down, but they reluctantly turn and run off deeper into the sanctum. Catra looks up to find Adora – and from the way her eyes dart off to the side, Glimmer and Bow too from where they're sitting – watching her. She quickly looks away, her tail lashing behind her.

"They've been stuck in their smaller form for a while. They're still recovering their magic after everything and there isn't really room for a cat that big in my apartment anyway," Catra explains, clearly trying to offer a distraction. Adora just nods, but she's still smiling, which makes Catra huff when she looks over and sees it.

"Well, now that you *know*, I don't see why you can't bring them over to run around sometimes. Maybe practice their magic somewhere private, I don't know how that works for krytians," Adora offers.

"Adora, do you actually want Mom to kill you?" Glimmer calls from the couch where she's leaning against Bow, half in his lap. She isn't nearly as wound up as she was at the beginning, though. She has probably accepted her fate.

"Ignore her," Adora says without even looking away from Catra. Catra snickers as Glimmer makes an indignant sound in her throat and Bow quietly murmurs something to her. Adora doesn't hear it, but Catra's ear flicks so she does. Her expression doesn't shift though, so it's probably not exciting.

“We’ll see. As I’m *sure* you’ve learned, finding time to get on that train is a pain, especially with finals about to fucking choke me,” Catra says, her voice only a little bitter when she mentions the train. Adora, in turn, only winces a little.

“It’s almost summer,” Adora whispers back, a hopeful lilt to her words. Summer is still technically a few weeks away, but school will be out soon. BMU runs a week longer than Harbor University, but either one of them having more free time helps, at least as long as they’re equally willing to meet in the middle. Adora knows that should be on her, though, at least at first. She sucked at it before.

“Yeah, it turns out adopting a magic cat during the pre-finals crunch isn’t *great* for time management, but I’ll be glad when it’s over,” Catra says, tone sarcastic and not addressing Adora’s underlying question. She can’t avoid Adora’s puppy eyes, though, and after a minute she breaks. She scoffs, looking away, but Adora knows she has won from the way Catra’s tail twitches.

“My lease is up in June. I already had a place near BMU I was talking to, but it’s not going to work with Melog, so I’m going to have start looking again after finals. I’ll still be visiting the Fright Zone a lot over the summer for work, so don’t think I’ll just be waiting around for you to call,” Catra mutters. Adora feels something in her chest that has been knotted for months – a *year* now, actually – finally, finally release. She had to step back while Melog was greeting Catra, but now she reaches for her hand, smiling despite Catra’s reluctance.

“You won’t have to. I’m going to be *annoying*,” she promises. Catra’s lips twitch.

“That was already guaranteed, princess,” she returns.

“Is it… a problem for her to call you that?” Glimmer says slowly from the bench where she and Bow are curled up, like she’s trying to decide for herself. Adora feels weirdly embarrassed as Catra turns to face Glimmer, throwing Adora a wink right before she looks away from her.

“What, you’re going to kinkshame her?” she asks. Okay, now Adora feels *very justifiably* embarrassed. It’s not even a thing for her – mostly it just happens to act as a reminder that Catra is aware of and *kind of* accepting both sides of her – but she knows she can’t protest that without looking guilty. Bow quickly looks away at the same time as Glimmer *twitches*. She looks from Catra to Adora, who is doing her best to avoid her gaze.

“I do *not* need to know this about you. Just keep it out of the sanctum and don’t be obvious about it,” Glimmer decides with a grunt of disgust as she slides off the bench. Adora is pretty sure just picturing the acts that could happen on it has made her want to leave. Bow shoots up behind her, clapping his hands together.

“Okay! Catra, do you want to join us for movie night? We were heading over to the dorm for it when you got here,” he asks, half positivity and half obviously moving on from *that*. Catra actually takes a half step back and might have taken more if it weren’t for Adora’s hand in her own leashing her close by.

“What? No. I don’t like any of you,” Catra says, quickly and reflexively. Adora rolls her eyes. That is *not* what Catra sounds like when she means something. Catra could have easily just let go of Adora’s hand if she actually wanted to get away. Bow turns the puppy eyes up to full force, which prompts a noise of disgust from Catra as if that will be enough to stop it from affecting her.

“Your finals are really soon. If you go back, you should probably study, right? So the longer you stay here, the longer you can avoid hunching over your couch,” Adora prods, lightly elbowing Catra when she scowls.

“I hate you,” Catra says, which is as good as a yes. Between his previous experience and Adora’s stories, Bow has picked up Catra-language fast. He cheers and turns away, hurrying over to the comms hub to lock it down and fetch his and Glimmer’s backpacks. Adora reluctantly drops Catra’s hand to get her own. It doesn’t occur to her that they left Glimmer and Catra alone at the entrance to the room until she turns to grab Catra’s tote, too, and sees them standing across from each other, sizing each other up.

“So, why was your friend at the explosion last week, anyway?” Glimmer asks. Her tone is trying for casual, though the *trying* part probably has more to do with how she and Catra didn’t get along before than the question itself. There was a clear jealousy issue mixed with both of them being unable to back down from a challenge.

“The dumbass is a technopath and forgot robots usually aren’t sentient. She tried to climb into the crater because she wanted to know what the robots were looking for. I think she has replaced so many broken parts she forgot humans don’t work like that and dying is kind of permanent. I followed her to make sure she was safe,” Catra explains. That surprises Adora given the general impression she was under that Catra wasn’t a fan of magic *anything*.

“Technopath?” Adora asks as she walks back over. Catra’s eyes slide from Glimmer to her, but her expression doesn’t shift even as Glimmer shoots Adora some kind of *I told you so* look that Adora doesn’t understand. Maybe it has something to do with her general caution around trusting Catra.

“Entrapta. She thought there must have been some amazing tech there because ‘what else would robots want?’ I don’t know, maybe to make sure their master isn’t dead?” Catra explains, making air-quotes as she talks. Knowing Entrapta is a technopath contextualizes a *lot* of Catra’s casual comments about her, but Adora is kind of surprised she didn’t know that before. Catra eyes her, looking wary. “She’s the one who noticed the city getting sloppy with cleaning up after the Horde. She found an entire fucking laser, just like, on the street,” Catra adds.

“That’s… bad. We should do something about that, right? A civilian shouldn’t have a laser,” Glimmer asks, glancing between the two of them, but she’s briefly distracted by Melog shouldering between her and Adora to slink up to Catra for pets. Catra looks amused as she meets their demands, ruffling their ears as she pets them.

“Entrapta’s harmless to others unless she accidentally blows her apartment up experimenting on something. I’m pretty sure she mostly uses her technopathy to dirty talk with her server rack. There’s a reason it took me months to figure out she had powers and wasn’t just a

weirdo," Catra says. Oh. Well, that explains why Adora didn't know. Catra probably didn't find out until their relationship was already heavily strained, if not *over*. By that point, it felt like she only ever brought up her friends trying to make Adora jealous like she was jealous of Glimmer and Bow. She isn't surprised this wasn't something Catra thought worth mentioning at the time.

"That still feels illegal," Glimmer says, but she seems kind of amused watching Catra pet Melog. It is *really* cute.

"Vigilantism is illegal," Catra deadpans. Glimmer huffs, rolling her eyes, but they're saved from further discussion by Bow finishing up with the comm hub and coming over with one backpack on each shoulder.

"Okay, Best Friend Squad ready to go!" Bow declares, beaming. Catra's ears twitch back and her tail jerks to the side. More concerningly, Melog's mane and tail darken in shade, the tail drooping from where it was happily waving. Adora feels her mouth fall open, looking between Melog and Catra, but Catra ignores her eyes, reaching out and taking the tote back from Adora, yanking it over her shoulder.

"Amazing how you have the ability to make me fourth wheel my own-" What was no doubt going to be a scathing comment cuts off as Catra's eyes go wide and her ears pin back, realization dawning on her face.

"Were you about to call me your girlfriend?" Adora asks, so shocked her tone just comes out sounding smug because she can't cover how badly she wants that in a moment like this. They have been talking for all of an hour, they're so far from being actual girlfriends it isn't funny, but it tells her that Catra's headspace could allow them to be, maybe.

"*No*, I just don't know what the fuck to call you, because we're not even friends," Catra hurries out, growling the words like that will dissuade Adora. Whatever just happened with Melog has passed and now they're looking between the two of them with curiosity.

"No, because we're *more* than fri-" Adora starts to tease, and Catra cuts her off by pouncing at her.

For the record, Adora thinks it should be noted she had one hand busy with her backpack strap, not to mention having to balance the weight of the bag itself, and Catra had the element of surprise, which can turn the tide in any fight. Also, Adora trains more as *She-ra* than herself, so it means absolutely nothing that Catra manages to wrestle her to the ground before Adora has finished laughing at how easy it is to rile her up. Catra pins her on her stomach with her arms behind her back.

"Finish that thought," Catra hisses into her ear, breath hot, "and you'll have a new supervillain to fight. And I know *all* your weaknesses." Adora is so, so lucky none of her other friends are hybrids or have some kind of supersense amongst their powers. She breathlessly nods, afraid to make a sound for fear of a moan slipping out. Catra holds her in that position for just a moment more before releasing her, straightening up and stepping back as Adora is still regaining control of her body on the floor.

"*Wow*," Glimmer says, because she's an awful friend who will point and laugh at you while you're down, just like Catra. Come to think of it, a lot of the Alliance would. Why does Adora attract these kinds of people?

Probably because she finds it an endearing quality, at least when she isn't standing up shame-faced, avoiding eye contact with her friends. Catra is smirking hard, her tail flicking behind her.

"Are you done rolling around on the floor yet? The train only runs so late," Catra comments, like it's *Adora's* fault she needed to gather herself before getting up. Adora flips her off, which only makes Catra smirk more. She drops her hand to pet Melog when they brush against her side and sniff her, as if worried she got hurt down there when their brat of an owner decided to push her.

"I'm fine, thanks for your concern. Are you ready to go now?" Adora asks, rolling her eyes. Catra looks down, exchanging a look with Melog.

"Yeah. They're just going to cloak and follow us. They want a little more time before they have to shrink down to fit on the train," Catra says, shoving her tote bag further up her shoulder after it got knocked loose in the scuffle. Adora nods, pretty sure Melog will at least *sort of* fit in their dorm. They at least shouldn't have problems getting inside. As they separate out to head up the stairs, too narrow to go in pairs, Bow ends up behind Catra and Melog, apparently with no fear for his life if the things he's willing to say to Catra at the top of a long drop are any indication.

"You're part of the Best Friends Squad too, you know. At least if you want to be," he says. Catra immediately hisses. Adora quickly looks over her shoulder to see Catra has turned to show Bow her teeth, but Melog seems unbothered, merely pausing along with Catra, so they at least don't register her agitation as too strong.

"As long as you stop leading Adora on," Glimmer stipulates, raising a finger in the air. It breaks Catra's attempted stare down, but when she turns forward again, she looks like she would storm on if Adora weren't in her way. Adora hurries to intervene before Catra's restraint breaks.

"Glimmer. I can handle my own relationship," Adora says, sending her a firm look. Glimmer's probably just trying to needle an admittance out of Catra that she'll talk to Adora again, but Adora already *got* that when they were in the changing room, so Glimmer isn't really helping anybody. Catra scoffs.

"Please, no one can handle me. The offer to kick She-ra's ass is still on the table," she says, flashing Adora one her self-assured smirks that never fails to bring Adora to attention even when she knows it's a distraction.

"Now you have access to the sanctum? I'd like to see you try," Adora returns. The look in Catra's eyes burns, telling Adora she plans to. Before either of them can totally forget where they are and drop their bags for round two, Melog sneezes from behind them. Catra's gaze darts away to glance at them and the moment is gone. A glance over Catra's shoulders tells

Adora her friends saw *exactly* what was going on there, so she turns forward again just to hide her face before her heating cheeks can confirm anything further.

They need to get away from here. There are too many tempting possibilities. They'll be better off somewhere they have to be more careful with their words – preferably somewhere *without* room for Catra to pin her to the floor.

Fuck.

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Catra seems undecided – or at least attempting to seem undecided – on if she's actually following them up until the moment they reach the dorm doors. She lingers an awkwardly long time within the doorway, and just when Adora is about to double back to prod her again, she feels something brush past her and realizes Catra was using her indecision to hold the door open for Melog to slip through.

Adora still hangs back to fall in step beside Catra as they pile into the elevator and slam the button to close the doors before anyone else can show up and possibly brush against Melog.

"What are you watching, anyway?" Catra asks, like she isn't included in *you*, as they stand in silence waiting to reach the fifth floor. Adora suddenly remembers, but Bow speaks up before she can cut him off with a cooler option like a horror movie.

"One of Adora's horse girl movies," he says, proudly. Yeah, the descriptor isn't necessary. He could have just said the title and Catra would have known what it was. She was there the first time Adora watched it.

"Only making me want to leave more, Crop Top," Catra replies even as they reach the fifth floor and she follows them out of the elevator. Adora has a feeling she's going to continue actively denying she's hanging out with them until the credits roll.

"It's so they can make fun of me. We have a bet about whether I was justified to cry during it," Adora reluctantly admits, mostly because Catra will probably stick around for a chance to laugh at her. Predictably, Catra snickers.

"I'll save you time: unless it's *Spirit*, then no, she wasn't," Catra says as they reach their door and Adora fumbles with her bag to produce her cardkey.

There's a half beat, and then, "You cried during *Spirit*, huh?" Glimmer asks, her tone smug. Catra's eyes immediately widen and her tail shoots out straight.

"*Shut up!*" she snaps, her voice high. Adora grins as she opens the door and ushers the group inside. She doesn't *stop* grinning as Glimmer singsongs *Catra has feelings* and Catra invents new forms of violent language to threaten her with. Adora has only seen interactions like this in her fever dreams. It's incredible to step back and just watch as Bow tries to genuinely

assure Catra that crying during movies is nothing to be ashamed of even as Glimmer continues to tease her about it.

By the time Adora has the movie pulled up, Bow has moved on from listing movies he cried about to listing movies *Glimmer* cried during, which, depending on the title, she is caught halfway between being unashamed of and being betrayed over his exposing of.

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Okay, so Adora kind of forgot how boring the movie got near the middle – or maybe anxiety really was that exhausting – because Glimmer has fallen asleep on Bow before the movie gets to the part that really had Adora crying, and Catra hasn't looked at the screen once since she draped herself on top of Adora and buried her face in her collar bones. She *isn't* asleep, but you wouldn't know that with how little she has moved in the last hour. Adora and Bow exchange a look and Adora wordlessly turns the TV down, all of them settling in for a college student's favorite pastime: napping.

Bow is out in another twenty minutes. Adora could be too, maybe, if it weren't for Catra gently purring on top of her, an almost silent vibration that Adora can still feel in her ribs as she slowly pets through Catra's hair. Melog seems sacked out too, sprawled on the floor and taking up most of the room between the two beds that the TV is angled towards. When Catra showed up earlier, she never thought that two hours later she would be purring in her arms. And she didn't even have to cheat with an orgasm!

She isn't quite sure where their relationship stands right now, just that she has permission to talk to Catra again and she doesn't want to ruin it with the *what are we* question when it has been all of an hour since they even got that far. They did make out, though. That was… a thing that they did, a thing that very nearly happened again when they were just trying to leave. And the *girlfriends* thing, which Adora is almost ninety percent sure Catra was about to call them before her brain caught up with her tongue.

It wasn't right, but it wasn't *wrong* either, because they sure as hell aren't available to anyone else.

Adora ducks forward and kisses the top of Catra's head before the next pet, rewarded with a gentle *mrrp* as Catra stirs slightly. Okay, maybe she was starting to doze and Adora shouldn't have done that, but the noise was cute, so she still smiles to herself as she returns to petting Catra's short hair, enjoying the feeling of it between her fingers and hoping it's enough to soothe Catra again.

Actually, maybe that was a very good idea, because Catra lifts her head and she's adorable with a crease from Adora's shirt pressed into her cheek. She doesn't look like she was just asleep, but there's a dark look in her eyes as their gazes meet. Maybe the room is just dark in general with only the quietly-playing TV to light it – Adora insisted they watch with the lights off since she thinks it ups the emotional impact and it was how she initially watched it

– but there's something perfectly still about this moment that feels as transitory as a shadow, like a mere flash of light could shatter it.

It feels like when they were in the apartment during the storm, before everything went wrong – or maybe went right, since it led her here, with Catra's gaze flicking down for a moment before they're kissing again. It's momentary, just long enough for Catra to decide this position doesn't work. She pulls back, shuffling up to a better spot and kissing Adora again. This time it's long and slow, Catra gently sighing against her lips as she settles back in. Adora's hands find Catra's hips, happy to hold her close as they kiss lazily. It's new for them, every embrace before now either desperate or groundbreaking. There's a forbidden thrill to it with the other people also in the room, capable of waking up and catching them at any moment, but Adora kind of loves just kissing Catra slow.

She feels a little separated from her body, aware that somewhere in her there's a nervous energy trapped, desperately asking *what is this and what are we, do you love me?* but most of her is blissed out between the long cuddle, the soft purr, and the slide of Catra's lips. The emotional turmoil of the earlier revelations helps keep her energy low – now languid – even as Catra breaks the kiss to rub their cheeks together and purr properly.

"You're so cute," Adora murmurs to her, because it's true and the way it makes Catra's tail swing only reinforces it. Catra ducks to bury in her neck again and Adora feels the scrape of teeth against her throat, her breath instantly hitching. Catra doesn't wait for further permission, biting down on the side of Adora's neck. Adora whines quietly and then gasps for breath as she tries to silence herself.

"Glimmer and Bow are right there," she reminds in a whisper. Catra's response to that is to drag her tongue slowly over the spot, causing Adora to strangle a sound in her throat almost painfully. She really, really wishes they were back at Catra's apartment right now.

"I don't see them complaining," Catra rumbles, pulling back just enough to show Adora her lazy smirk and bedroom eyes. Adora is lucky their bodies are still pressed together because she's pretty sure otherwise gravity would be giving her an eyeful down the front of Catra's shirt.

"If they wake up and catch us, we're dead, and I don't think you like me enough yet for me to live at your place when Glimmer kicks me out," Adora counters, reaching up to run her hands through Catra's hair. Catra's eyelids flutter and she leans into the attention, purring louder now. She has always purred for Adora, but never this *easily*. It's like she's starved for it.

"No, but you could try that, you know. Coming over. That was half of the problem before," Catra says, seeming to decide to close her eyes and fully lean into it. Adora did *not* know that, and despite the casual way Catra says it, she's pretty sure it wasn't even true two hours ago.

Apparently it is now, though.

"That was a symptom of the problem," Adora murmurs back, because she's aware *she* was the issue before. Catra doesn't say anything, unless the continued rumbling of her purr counts as an answer. It at least tells Adora that she isn't upset by the acknowledgement. She hopes

small things like that help – reminders that Adora understands what she put Catra through and what Catra lashed out with in return, no matter what her intentions were.

“I’m still mad at you,” Catra admits, her voice a quiet whisper as she leans into Adora’s hands. Adora’s touch doesn’t stop.

“I know.” She isn’t expecting things to be magically fixed, just hoping that they’ll *try*.

“You should have just told me,” Catra adds, in the exact same tone of voice with little emotion to give her away. Maybe she’s just reminding her to counterbalance all the softness, at least in her mind. If it’s the alternative to her pulling away again, Adora will take it.

“I know,” she replies again. Silence falls, except for the gentle rumble of Catra’s purr returning. It breaks again when Catra opens her mouth.

“Were you ever going to come back and tell me, or were we just over?” her voice is small and it doesn’t seem like it’s just to avoid waking Glimmer and Bow. Adora swallows, a shot of anxiety dropping into her stomach. She breathes for a second, gathering herself.

“We weren’t over, we never could be, but… I was. I gave up on being anything but She-ra after that. I didn’t really think I could have anything I wanted, but I did still think about you a lot. I had this idea to reach out again when I could actually balance things, but I never got there. It was more of a fantasy than anything. I don’t know how I could have stayed away forever, though,” Adora admits. It’s probably not the answer Catra wants, but after a moment, she nods.

She turns her head and presses a kiss against Adora’s palm, her eyes falling closed for a moment.

“I was right when we talked about being a hero back on the roof, you know. She-ra shouldn’t be your life. I’ll take down the whole fucking Horde myself to force you into having the free time if that’s what it takes,” Catra says, her voice low but genuine. Adora next breath is a little choked. It’s stupid how quickly she can be brought to tears. She forces them down with a few heavy breaths.

“There’s still just one She-ra. She’s always going to be needed,” she whispers back. She means it to be a joke, a stall until she has herself under enough control to continue, but Catra’s eyes burn as they hold hers instead.

“And there’s, what, six other princesses that have managed for hundreds of years? Pretty sure they can pick up the slack from a single She-ra,” Catra returns. Adora’s hearing feels a bit weird, staticky with a high whine in it. It’s not a revelation or anything, but it *is* a thought that has never occurred to her before. For a moment, she just breathes, anchoring herself on the yellow and blue of Catra’s eyes, so bright and soft. She slides a hand to cup her cheek, thumb gently rubbing her cheek, beneath her blue eye.

“I’ll, um, think about it. At first I had to train, too, which took up time even if I wasn’t dealing with some disaster. I have more time now than I did a year ago,” Adora explains, her

words feeling flighty from her irregular heartbeat. The arch of Catra's brow is soft, but skeptical.

"And what do you want to do with that time? Forget the She-ra shit for a second and what you think you've failed at; what do you fucking want? Because I've spent the last year thinking the answer to that question was *not me* when it turns out you weren't even thinking about it," Catra asks. Adora stares at her. Catra gazes back, unflinching. It's expectant and firm, something she can't dodge no matter how long she tries to wait her out.

Adora tips her head back and closes her eyes. After a moment she lets out a long, drawn-out breath, trying to gather her words and come up with an answer to that question.

When she starts, she doesn't know how long it goes. It's things like *running my hands through your hair* and *waking up together* and *all four of you guys making fun of my taste in movies*. It's stuff like picking Catra up and kissing her as She-ra, like wrestling down in the sanctum, or even finally being able to text her that she can't tonight because there's a bridge collapse and then making it up to her later. It's a small apartment with a view of the bay and big windows in the living room for when they're cuddling on the couch. It's studying together in the library, Catra making fun of her for falling asleep one day and then Adora taking a picture of Catra doing the same on another. It's fixing dinner while Catra turns the living room into a disaster zone of law notes-

"Absolutely not," Catra interrupts, the first thing she has said beyond a quiet noise of encouragement since she settled in against Adora's collarbones. Until now, she seemed content to just close her eyes and let the words wash over her, picturing it too.

"What?" Adora asks, incredibly thrown off by Catra interrupting her tirade. A slow tirade, maybe, but she has been going on for a while, reaching for any vision that makes her feel warmth when she considers it.

"You're not cooking. I remember Winterfest and I *know* you've been living off cafeteria food since then," Catra elaborates, her voice muffled by Adora's neck. Adora blinks up at the ceiling.

"I stayed with Glimmer over the summer and got a little better at it," she defends, but she has run out of energy – it turns out wanting things is *exhausting* – and her words are quiet.

"A little," Catra echoes back at her, unimpressed. Adora smiles, kissing her ear.

"Glimmer and her mom can't cook either. Angella pays a housekeeper to make meals, I just felt guilty taking them. I burned a lot of things, but I made progress. I promise not to set our imaginary apartment on fire," Adora elaborates, kissing the base of Catra's ear now despite the hair it gets in her mouth. Catra purrs her amusement, apparently beyond words now. After a few moments of kisses and soft purring, she yawns.

"Your presence in my real apartment over the summer is dependent on your ability to follow through on that," Catra tells her as she beds back down, burying her face in her neck. Adora's heart feels like pop rocks.

“Okay. Definitely,” she replies, intelligently. She gets another small purr.

“Wake me up when it’s time to make out again,” she says, her voice already drifting off. Before Adora can ask how she’ll know when that is, Catra adds, “And think more about that stuff. It’s the kind of shit Spinner never wanted us to have. Not fair she gets to take it twice.” Adora’s heart beats erratically.

“Okay,” she agrees, her voice soft. She doesn’t get a reply back. She’s not sure Catra even heard.

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Catra doesn’t know how she got here. She doesn’t know how she went from being mad at Adora to looking at her face and just wanting to hold her, but it *happened* in that dumb locker room with its basement air and she can’t walk back on it now, not after how good it felt to fall into her arms. She ends up staying for another hour, outlasting Bow when he wakes up and reluctantly heads back home after Catra and Adora both shoot down the idea of a Best Friends Squad sleepover night.

Adora sees him out – Catra recognizes the way she was shifting on her feet and she definitely just needed an excuse to go pee – leaving Catra to snuggle down into the warm spot she left behind and reluctantly gather herself to leave.

She feels… content, comfortable, warm, *weird*, and she needs to take a step back to process. She wasn’t ready to spend so much time together again like this. It has been fine – good, even – but there’s a part of her constantly on edge, waiting for the other shoe to drop. Going back home means losing the warmth of Adora’s presence, but it also means shaking the anxiety.

Melog is a little overwhelmed too, she thinks. They woke up while Catra was dozing on Adora’s chest, reluctantly shrinking down because the room was starting to feel claustrophobic. It’s helping her to wake up, some, which should make it easier to get up and head home, but she still finds herself nestled down in the sheets, opening her arms for Melog when they jump up to cuddle somewhere warm and safe. She has to wait for Adora to come back, anyway. She doesn’t *need* Adora to see her out, but she would like her to. Glimmer woke up first, causing the rest of them to stir, which meant no more secret making out.

Hopefully Adora will be willing to give her a few kisses in the elevator or something. It will certainly help her brain settle down overnight. She’s content to wait in the warmth of her sheets for her to come back, though, Melog a soothing weight on her chest.

Her comfortable silence is interrupted by Glimmer, who she has been doing her best to pretend doesn’t exist until now.

“Are you dating?” Glimmer asks, voice a little scratchy with sleep, but still smug. Catra huffs, her ears pinning back as she reluctantly slits an eye open to look over and see Glimmer

is sitting up on her bed. Her phone is out, but she's ignoring its screen, instead eyeing Catra across the room from her.

"Mind your business," Catra returns, closing her eyes again and pointedly wiggling back into the pillows. She tightens her arms around Melog, trying not to think about the questions that prompt brings up. Dating? No. Probably. Probably not, she means. They haven't been on a single date and they aren't planning any. Catra doesn't think she even wants Adora to ask her on one. She isn't ready to be disappointed if it doesn't go well.

"Listen, I still don't know that *any* of this is a good idea, but clearly that ship has sailed, so if you're going to stick around, we should learn to be friends," Glimmer continues, like Catra isn't trying to *sleep*. Well, pretending to try, which counts for the same thing when it comes to interruptions. How does Adora live with this woman? Catra would have changed roommates week one. She doesn't hate Glimmer like she once did, but she's still annoyed with the entire Alliance for their dumb fucking rules.

"This is a bad start," Catra returns, tucking Melog up under her chin so she can duck her face down into their weirdly smooth fur. She breathes them in, trying not to freak out too much about where she is and the conversation she's having.

"I won't pretend to understand what's going on with you two, but I'm willing to do the *incredibly* hard thing and be the bigger person to let all the old shit go," Glimmer continues, her tone sounding about as thrilled about it as Catra would be. It makes her lips quirk up.

"I guess being five-nothing does make that difficult for you," Catra chirps back. She isn't much taller than Glimmer, but she is still *taller*, and she learned that height jokes were something that annoyed Glimmer without getting too deep into an insecurity before. She doesn't actually want to start a fight right now, she just isn't ready to roll over and give up all her bitterness either. It's *hard* and she'd much rather spend that effort on Adora. Glimmer can get in line.

Glimmer makes an annoyed sound, but she doesn't get too affronted, just like Catra planned.

"Like I said, *incredibly hard*, but I'm willing to do it for Adora," Glimmer says. Oh, that's a low blow. Catra has spent a long time wallowing in her hurt, but there isn't anything she wouldn't do for Adora's attention, any bridge she wouldn't burn, or – apparently – *build*, even if it means making nice with her annoying friends so they can spend more time together. Glimmer hasn't been as awful as she remembers her today, anyway. Occasionally she even said something funny during the first half of the movie.

"I will tolerate your existence within proximity of me and Adora. Happy?" Catra returns, huffing and shifting her hold on Melog so she can cradle them as she sits up. She doesn't face Glimmer. This is the closest they're getting to a truce tonight. Catra needs at least twenty-four-hours before she can unpick this further. She's still working on Adora's explanation of the She-ra shit. Glimmer can get in line.

"Thrilled. We're besties now. I'll text you a cat meme every day," Glimmer returns, her tone bypassing sarcasm to go for the even more annoying sickeningly sincere. Catra sends her a

glare, to which Glimmer only smiles back. It's revenge for the short comment earlier, probably.

"Remind me to never give you my number," Catra mutters as she glances around for where Melog's bag ended up. Halfway under the bed is the answer.

"I'll just get it from Adora," Glimmer returns, her voice teasing now. That's… weird. They don't tease each other, they barely keep from going at each other's throats. This is going to take time to adjust to.

"If Adora gives you any means to contact me, I'm breaking up with her," Catra returns, already planning to tell Adora when they're walking through the hall and can't practically make out. She's definitely not wasting kissing time on Glimmer.

"So you *are* dating!" Glimmer declares with victory from the other side of the room. Catra's ears pin back and she chooses then to shut up since she doesn't really know the answer, instead setting the bag on the bed to transfer Melog into it. They reluctantly curl up at the bottom. They actually like being carried around, it's just a small space for such a long trip.

When she hooks the bag over her shoulder and reluctantly turns around, she finds Glimmer grinning at her. Being her friend might be more annoying than her rival. At least Adora finally comes back before Glimmer can tease her too much. She looks a little pouty when she sees Catra ready to go, but her eyes flare when Catra pointedly grabs her shirt and pulls her through the door.

Melog is so lucky the elevator stops one floor down and someone joins them, because otherwise they would be making out against the wall. As it is, Catra has to content herself with a relatively chaste goodbye kiss on the sidewalk. Well, several kisses, because Adora keeps trying to offer to walk her to the subway. It's sweet, maybe, but Catra can walk to the edge of campus herself.

It's Adora making an effort, though, and that's *something* even if Catra doesn't take her up on it. She'll just have to see where this goes.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter count is an **estimate** I can't stress enough what a disaster I am.

Chapter 13: Recalibrating

Chapter Notes

CW child abuse mention. It's Catradora, so it's there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora is just a part of Catra's life now, apparently. She texted Catra before she even got on the train home and she hasn't really stopped since. Part of Catra was expecting *one* of them to retreat, but apparently it is going to have to be her, and as unsure as she is about all of this… it's really nice to be able to text Adora again, to hear the way she talks about her day or the dumb comments she makes about Catra's. She's so sincere, asking Catra about what she has going on in school and texting her encouragement before her presentation.

It's kind of how Catra remembers that first month after Adora went to school, before she became good friends with Glimmer and Bow and would rather spend time with them. That's not what happened, really, but it's what it felt like. Really she just *made friends* and spent time with them too, but Catra was used to owning all of Adora's attention and that felt like being cast aside even before the She-ra stuff happened and made it a hundred times worse.

Now, she isn't ready to spend all her time with Adora again even if that were feasible, and she likes to think her perception of what's normal and healthy in friendships is a *little* better than it was before thanks to Scorpia and Entrapta, even with all the hurt. The texting is enough – *safe* enough – for now, even if Melog gets smug sometimes when her phone buzzes. They think they were right, but Catra would argue it hasn't been proven yet. It will take weeks to see if this was a mistake, but as much as Catra sometimes has the instinct to pull away before Adora can hurt her again, it's too late. Losing this now *would* hurt.

Adora comes over three days later, because they do need to put together that list for Mermista, but Catra had her presentation she needed to finish on top of her finals next week. It's kind of weird to have Adora, not She-ra in her apartment, and even weirder that *that's* weird, so Catra does her best to seem normal and unbothered, which lasts about as long as it takes for them to start talking about Spinner.

"I never realized how little we knew about the bitch until we had to write it down," Catra complains, dropping her head to the mattress. They sat on the bed because Melog decided to be big and stretch across the entire couch. Catra wasn't wasting her effort trying to kick them off. She feels Adora's hand enter her hair, ruffling it a little and then petting through it.

"I don't blame us for not wanting to know more about her. Mostly we just tried to avoid her noticing us enough to get mad," Adora points out, scratching lightly at the base of her ear. Catra makes a noise somewhere adjacent to a groan as she pushes up into the touch. Adora is

right, but it's weird to think how little she knew about a woman who hurt her – and was *responsible* for her – for so long.

They have a name, race, rough age, and her address for the eleven years they were in the home. That's really it. Things like "she's an alcoholic" and "she only considers music played on 'real instruments' acceptable" aren't a lot of help in tracking her down unless she has gone all *Phantom of the Opera* and is lurking under an orchestra pit somewhere. It was the discovery that they aren't even sure of her age that pushed Catra over the edge.

"I'm going to have Entrapta hack the DMV. She can probably come up with something better," Catra mutters, raising her head. Adora offers her a wavering smile, clearly unsure if she is joking, and if not, if she should intervene.

"How about we take a break?" she offers. It's in her "let's not be impulsive and get in trouble" voice. Catra rolls her eyes, but she's happy to sit up and move the notepad they've been writing their conclusions on aside. They can only scour their childhood memories for anything she let slip for so long. On the mental search, they started noticing odd comments, weird times she would seem like she just came home, and most damningly, a few injuries she tried to conceal that they never learned the source of.

"How about we never think about her again?" Catra counters. It's not an option – even if they never look at the list, the thought that they were raised by a *supervillain* keeps popping up in the back of Catra's head – but it would be nice. It's not fair that she gets to come back after all these years and ruin their lives again. Catra thought she was *free* of her, but thinking back on it has made her realize she's never free. That bitch is why she's so messed up – why *Adora* is, too.

"Yeah, I wish that was an option. *Supervillain mom* is a lot to handle," Adora mutters, apparently thinking along the same lines. Catra huffs, scooting closer on the bed so she can nudge Adora with her shoulder.

"The Alliance isn't giving you a hard time, is it?" she asks, using the opportunity to halfway crawl into Adora's lap while she's distracted. Adora quirks a smile, wrapping one arm around Catra's back.

"No. I mean, they're asking questions, but they aren't doubting me, or anything. After a year and a half, we all trust each other," Adora explains. Catra *hmphs* as she finds a comfortable spot tucked into her side. Part of her – an insecure part – *wants* the Alliance to have an issue with it. Adora has been insistent she only kept things secret because the Alliance wouldn't let her reveal the truth. Them just going along with something like this feels like it's contradictory no matter how much trust can be built in a year.

It can be lost in it, too.

"Most of them didn't know anything about how we grew up beyond 'group foster home.' I didn't really want to talk about it, especially when the worst days were so long ago. I've… told them some things, now, so they can get a picture of what she was like as a guardian," Adora explains. Catra's ears twitch back. She can only imagine what that conversation was like. She doesn't talk about it at all when she can help it.

“Even worse than she is as a supervillain?” Catra volunteers. Adora chuckles, turning to rest her forehead against the side of Catra’s head.

“Shadow Weaver has killed people, you know,” Adora says, in a low voice. Catra doesn’t think it’s what she intended to say, it just comes out.

“Yeah.” Catra knows. It’s a thought that occurred to her about twenty minutes after the initial revelation. Shadow Weaver’s MO isn’t murder, but she has killed and everyone knows it. It brings a whole new level of retroactive fear to every time they were caught breaking a rule, or *didn’t* but were punished anyway.

“Are you scared we’re not going to be able to do anything? That it won’t change anything?” Adora asks in a whisper, her eyes downcast. She looks haunted, so far from the confident goddess that once visited Catra. Catra remembers what she said up on the roof, about the guilt that she couldn’t do more to stop her. It must have gotten so much worse knowing not only who she is, but what she has done since.

Catra reaches up, using her fingertips and gentle pressure on Adora’s cheek to direct her gaze up. Adora’s gaze is hopeful when it meets hers, like she wants Catra to give her a good answer.

“If you’re talking ‘*we*’ as in the Alliance, eh, the odds are fifty-fifty. I’ll take care of it if you need the help, though,” Catra says, flashing Adora one of her trademark smirks.

It works. The anxiety on Adora’s face breaks as she gives a wet snort and then chuckles. She raises both her arms, wrapping them around Catra and hugging her close.

“Of course. I’ll let you know when we’ve given up so you can have your moment to shine,” Adora returns, in a similar tone to what Catra used, though she’s still working on pulling herself back up.

“Hey, I already unmasked her for you. At this point it’s just lazy to make me do all the work,” Catra continues, earning an affectionate eyeroll.

The thing Adora doesn’t seem to understand is Catra is only joking *now*, but Adora laughs, so Catra lets it go.

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After Adora leaves, Catra rewrites all the biographical information they gathered onto a separate sheet of paper. When she’s just about ready to tear her hair out studying, she goes to Entrapta’s. It’s not exactly a *break* to ask her friend about her shitty foster mom, but it isn’t memorizing legal precedents for another two hours, so it might as well be a tropical vacation. She brings Melog with her, because they haven’t really left the apartment since the trip to

Adora's. They cloaked and followed her to the grocery story once, but that was about it. It's good to get out even if they're still unsure in the presence of a former Horde bot.

Catra has gotten used to Emily, but she lets Melog hide behind her legs, assessing the bot moving around the room as she talks to Entrapta.

"Oh, if she's in the system that will definitely be enough to find her. I bet I can do it ten minutes!" Entrapta says, snatching the notepad from Catra and hurrying over to her computer with excitement. Catra trails after her, equal parts concerned and fond.

"Maybe take your time hacking a government database. I don't want you to get caught for me," Catra says, trying to frame it somewhat like a suggestion so Entrapta doesn't do the opposite and it like a challenge. Entrapta looks up, blinking wide eyes at Catra even as her hands pull up a program from muscle memory.

"I've never been caught before." Well. That's.

Not comforting.

Catra sighs and turns her attention towards gently introducing Melog and Emily. Last time they were here, Emily didn't make much of an appearance and Melog was mostly in her arms anyway. They don't really *get* robots – go figure, Catra doesn't either – but they seem to decide she's nice after a few moments of careful hiding and sniffing.

It takes Entrapta a worryingly small amount of time to declare "I've got it!" and pull Catra's attention away from Melog carefully batting at one of Emily's legs. Catra didn't expect Spinner to take long to find when they knew her name and a previous address, but she thought gaining access to government servers would take at least a few minutes more.

When she turns to the screen, that's her childhood tormenter staring down at her from the shitty license photo. The license has been reissued with a new address, but it looks like she didn't have to get her picture redone because there's no scars across her face. She looks the *exact* same, her photo imposing an eerie feeling like being watched on Catra.

"Is that her?" Entrapta asks, excited, as she turns to Catra. Catra swallows, quickly dropping her gaze from the photo to read the rest of the information on screen.

"Yeah, you did a good job," she praises, her voice a little hollow. This information doesn't tell her much. Spinner popped back up at some point after disappearing considering she got her license renewed on time and was never considered legally dead, and they have her exact age now, but the only thing Catra really expects to be useful is the address.

It's still a long shot considering Melog's memories showed her seemingly living down in the station with them for weeks, but it's something they can check instead of sitting around and worrying.

"Can you print this out for me?" Catra asks, gesturing at the screen.

“Sure!” Entrapta declares brightly, turning to the computer again and beginning to hit buttons like Catra didn’t just ask her to produce evidence of the federal crime she committed. “What is this for, anyway? Isn’t this the woman who ran your old home?” Entrapta asks, stopping Catra in her fucking tracks.

There are two possibilities. One, Entrapta remembered Catra saying the name Spinner when she casually traumadumped about a time Spinner locked her in her room during dinner as punishment for a fight in school. It was a clinical strike to get Scorpia to stop asking questions about her childhood and it fucking worked, but perhaps too well for Entrapta to still remember the name Catra mentioned *once* a year later.

The other option is Entrapta, after hearing that, did more research – likely similar to what she’s doing right now – and thus the name left a much bigger impression on her. Catra can easily see her pulling up Spinner’s profile in the foster system records to see if she’s still approved to work with kids. Entrapta’s moral foundation is shaky at best, but she’s still a good person, and she was upset by what little Catra did say.

Both scenarios are equally likely and leave her equally *caught* now. Catra panics.

“I reconnected with Adora,” she blurts out. Entrapta just blinks up at her.

“Did it bring up childhood memories you’re hoping to resolve?” she asks in the most Entrapta way possible. Catra manages a rueful laugh, reaching up to run her hand through her hair.

“Yeah, something like that.” It’s definitely not *wrong*. It doesn’t touch on the supervillain thing, but you know, the sentiment is the same. If things go well with Adora, Catra is going to have to eventually mention her to her friends anyway. She has been avoiding talking about it because she absolutely did *not* want advice.

“Well, let me know if you need anything else! I believe Scorpia would now praise you on personal growth,” Entrapta says, which is her way of saying that’s what she’s doing too. Catra chuckles, her mood picking up a little and then immediately dropping back down when Entrapta stands to head over to her printer for the print of Spinner’s license information.

“Thanks, Entrapta. For all of this,” she tells her. Entrapta whips the paper off the printer and holds it out to Catra with a bright smile.

“No problem!” Entrapta says, easy as that. Stuff like this is always simple with Entrapta. It’s a nice change of pace from the giant complicated mess this all has become otherwise. Catra just has to hope that somehow, this helps.

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Catra is still mad. It doesn't go away overnight, and today in particular she thinks Adora was a fucking idiot to keep her mouth shut like that. She has information for her, though, and she could use a destress after taking her first final, so she invites her over. They've already proven mad does *not* mean that they can't have some fun.

"What's that?" Adora asks as Catra, without explanation, opens her backpack and puts the folded piece of paper in it.

"An address for Mermista," Catra dismisses, straightening from the bag Adora dropped by the front door and doing her best to crowd Adora deeper into the apartment. It's kind of hard when Adora just tries to hug her instead, though. Catra huffs in her arms, trying to keep pushing with her body now so Adora will back up.

"Demanding. How'd you get that?" Adora asks, her tone fond. She doesn't even know how much is in the printout, but she looks suspicious. As suspicious as you can be while smiling, anyway. Catra did tell her what she was going to do last time she was over. Adora can guess.

"It's probably just a dead end, but I am *not* talking about Shadow Weaver right before we make out," Catra returns, pointedly pressing her body forward hard enough that Adora is forced to take a step back. Adora looks amused as she stumbles back, glancing back to see where Catra is directing her.

"Where's Melog?" Adora asks instead, but she lets Catra crowd her backwards towards the bed. Catra huffs.

"Locked in the bathroom," she says, *pointedly*. Both of Adora's eyebrows raise, but she lets Catra finally back her up to the edge of the bed. Catra stretches up on her toes, hoping Adora will give up on her questions and kiss her. Instead, Adora gives her false hope by threading her hands through her hair and, just when Catra has closed her eyes, *stopping*.

"That doesn't seem very nice," Adora comments, her voice smug when Catra opens her eyes to glare at her. Adora is smirking, apparently pleased to be delaying things. Catra huffs, dropping flat on her feet and crossing her arms to sulk.

"Yeah, well, they don't want to be out here when we're doing anything like this anyway. I'll make sure my next place has a bedroom," Catra huffs. She doesn't know why Adora finds it so damn funny to ignore her *very obvious* advances. Adora hums, scratching lightly at Catra's scalp. Catra hates how that instantly relaxes her some.

"Are you going to kiss me or do I have to kick you both out so I can get off?" Catra demands, refusing to look at the annoying smirk on Adora's face or acknowledge how she's leaning back into her touch. She just needs hands on her. Her hair isn't *ideal*, but it's better than nothing. Adora *hm*s. Annoyingly.

"Bossy," Adora comments. Just when Catra is about to bite back, Adora drops her hands from her. Before Catra's stomach can drop out, Adora's hands are on her hips. Adora swings her around as Catra hisses, scrambling to reach for Adora, claws out and instincts torn between pushing her away or pulling her close. Adora makes the decision for her, lifting her

up onto the bed with *way* more strength than Catra remembers her having. Catra blinks up at her, stunned, as Adora pushes on her shoulder.

Catra's tail lashes as she lets Adora encourage her to lie back so she can climb over her. This kind of confidence – and *manhandling* – is the kind of thing she used to fantasize about from She-ra. It's similar to what they *did* when she invited her over. Catra's tail speed picks up and she ignores it as Adora straddles over her hips. She reaches up, her claws still out after being caught off guard, and grabs Adora's shoulders carefully, remembering she does *not* have She-ra's ability to heal as she tugs her down.

"You really can't stand not being in charge for five seconds, can you?" Catra returns. Adora's smirk doesn't fade as she blankets over her, probably because Catra is still pulling her in for a kiss. Just because it's annoying doesn't mean Catra doesn't find it hot.

"Pretty sure you like that about me, brat," Adora returns before she finally kisses her. Catra makes an indignant sound into the kiss, but she still parts her lips for Adora, sighing as Adora braces herself with one arm and buries her other hand into Catra's hair. *Contact* is really what she wanted out of this. Maybe Adora being on top is better, anyway. It leaves Catra's hands free to roam over her.

Adora did her the decency of wearing shorts and a t-shirt today, leaving plenty for her to touch with ease. For the moment, Catra settles her hands on her thighs, kneading as they kiss slowly. Of course Adora does it slow, she's clearly in her own bratty mood tonight, but at least she's absolutely filthy about it, mouths open and tongues brushing. Purring is difficult while kissing like this, but the instinct is there, especially every time she squeezes Adora's thighs in her hands. They're a lot harder than they used to be, but thicker too, and it sends a shiver through her when Adora shifts back just enough to flex all the firm muscle beneath Catra's fingers.

She might have a thing for Adora's new strength. It's not something she would have expected, and when she trails her hands up she still quite likes the softness left on her curves, but having independently developed a thing for She-ra, feeling a bit of her strength in *her* Adora excites her. Adora doesn't seem content to let Catra have all the fun, tugging on her hair and pulling her head back. The moment their lips part, Catra gasps in and breathes out a purr.

"Fuck," Adora murmurs, ducking to nip at Catra's throat before Catra has time to open her eyes. She grips Adora's hips, hanging on as Adora softly kisses the same spot. It annoyed her when Adora tried to do soft shit like this the first time, but now it's just sweet, a moment of aftercare before she nuzzles down and bites Catra again just as hard. Catra strangles a sound into her next purr.

This is exactly what Catra needed after two hours of hunching over the exam table. She tips her head back, closing her eyes and sinking into the warm buzz each bite and kiss gives her. Running her hands over Adora's body excites her more, her tail beginning sway beneath her. She slips a hand beneath Adora's shirt, palming her abs and purring at what she feels.

Adora flexes them, because of course she does, soft stomach with an underlying core suddenly becoming hard planes. Adora can only hold it for so long while kissing and trying

to *breathe*, so Catra keeps tracing her fingers over her, smiling into the kiss as she waits for Adora to break. Smiling only makes it harder to maintain and after a surprisingly long stretch of seconds Adora pulls back just enough to puff out air, her stomach caving into softness again beneath Catra's fingers. Catra grins, nipping Adora's bottom lip and tugging as she continues her path upward, ghosting her fingers over Adora's ribs and earning a giggle like she suspected she might.

"Idiot," Catra murmurs into her mouth. Adora pulls back from the kiss, but she's smiling down at Catra as she catches her breath.

"You liked it," she accuses. Catra just shrugs.

"And?" Of course she did, at some point she fell for a fucking moron and dumb jock shit started turning her on. Adora chuckles, nuzzling in and rubbing her cheek against Catra's. Catra purrs, nuzzling back as Adora marks herself in her scent. Okay, so she's still an idiot, but she's an idiot that *knows* Catra – loves her, a memory she pretends not to cherish whispers in the back of her mind – and making out with her is infinitely better than it was ever going to be with She-ra if she had been a real stranger.

Adora understands her, knowing exactly what it will do to Catra when she tugs on the tip of her ear. Catra growls, her tail lashing as excitement shivers through her body. Sure, somebody else could have learned Catra like this, but she can't imagine how long it would take after everything she and Adora have had and done together.

Part of her mind says *and Adora threw that away* and the rest says *and you could have that again*. For a year, her dreams have been dead, all her plans surrounding her as ash. She can't just pick them up again like they were never damaged. The scorch marks are there – but the structure is too, evident in the way Adora trails her fingers down the side of her neck and then just holds them there. Just as Adora knows her, she knows Adora is feeling the vibration of her purr, appreciating it as the sound rattles louder around them.

"Adora," she murmurs, the words immediately catching in her throat, because what is she *doing*? Adora pulls back, eyes scanning her face and brows pinching together slightly as they find nothing but reluctance.

"I'm right here," she replies, voice soft as the hand that was playing with her ear easily shifts to petting over her hair instead, switching to a soothing touch just like that. It's only further feeding the voice in the back of her head making everything so damn complicated. Catra growls, mostly at herself, and grabs Adora with one hand on her hip and the other around the back of her head, kissing her demandingly.

Adora meets her, but it's different. There's a need to the kiss that isn't sexual, but *intimate*. She just needs Adora. It's all she has needed for the last year and a half. The difference is this time, she actually has her. Adora kisses her back, and arches into her touch when Catra runs it over her, and she *keeps* kissing her as Catra pulls her shirt over her head. She only pauses when – because she knows her – she senses Catra contemplating slicing through her bra band, pulling back and sending Catra a look.

"*No*," she intones, like you scold a fucking dog.

“Then get it *out of here*,” Catra hisses back, tugging on it again. Adora rolls her eyes, a fond smile on her face, but she leans back and pulls it over the top of her head. When she has no bracing and is an easy target, Catra grabs her and quickly wrestles them over until Adora is beneath her, laughing at… something. Catra’s fur brushing her, or the competitive little growl she gives, or maybe just her attacking in a moment of weakness, but it only makes it easier to pin her down and mark her collar bones.

Adora shivers when Catra trails her claws along the outside of her breast. *That’s* what she wants. She wants Adora reacting to her, showing that she wants Catra just like Catra wants her. She wants her drowning for her, begging, singing, *screaming*, anything as long as it’s gasping and desperate.

They don’t have that much time with Melog locked in the bathroom, but Catra *wants*. She can pare it down to what she needs, though. She-ra’s uniform ended up tattered before and Catra felt her up a lot, but she was never really topless beneath Catra.

And she wasn’t Adora.

Catra ducks down to kiss along Adora’s neck, biting and licking and sucking wherever she wants, earning gasps, giggles, and whines. When Catra reaches the top of her breast and bites hard, knowing the flesh will try to compress beneath her and escape, Adora’s moan is loud, drawn out and needy.

“Catra,” she breathes, voice soft and a little wrecked, everything Catra wanted. She growls, licking a long stripe and ending with Adora’s nipple in her mouth, making her squirm beneath her.

She needs this to belong to her. She needs Adora to need her back the same way she does her. She releases her, rising to brace over Adora’s head so they’re face-to-face as Catra pants, barely able to catch her breathing with the taste of Adora’s skin still on her tongue. Adora reaches up, threading her hands through Catra’s hair and settling her thumbs at the base of her ears so she can softly stroke them as they hold each other’s gazes. Adora’s eyes are soft and dark, meeting Catra’s with no challenge, just an edge of want lurking beneath the surface.

They’ve both wanted so fucking much. But right now is about need.

“Let me hear you,” Catra says, and then she ducks and makes that difficult be sealing her mouth over Adora’s, but Adora seems to understand, because she meets Catra’s frenzied kiss with passion and she lets soft pants and moans spill out of her as Catra roams her hands greedily over her body, no thoughts or purpose beyond *having*.

Adora gives it – gives herself – letting Catra shed the rest of her clothing and fold one thigh all the way up against her stomach just because she can do it. She lets Catra cover her inner thigh with bites and bruises despite how blatant they will be in her shorts and she whines her name as Catra touches her for the first time, watching eagerly as Adora falls apart beneath her. It’s so easy to get lost in Adora, to unmoor from the anchor of her anger and lose herself in the beauty of the small twitches on Adora’s face as Catra touches her just right.

There's a peace, strange in its sereneness, in watching Adora take down every wall and let Catra bring her to a shivering edge until she cries out, loud enough for the neighbors to hear, and goes limp beneath her. She's still twitching, especially when Catra pulls back to let her leg stretch out again. Catra knows it's stupid, but it's almost weird to her that Adora doesn't purr afterwards as Catra tucks herself in against her side and buries her nose against her pulse point. Every breath is laced with contentment, though, and her face is slack and relaxed in a way it isn't even in *sleep* when Catra glances up.

This is hers. This is Adora, at her most vulnerable, for *Catra*.

This means something. The quiet haze of the afterglow seems to silence the room, including Catra's insecure thoughts, nothing dark clawing at her as she just thinks about how nice it feels to be surrounded by Adora – again, and in a way she never was before.

At least, it's quiet until Melog starts batting under the door, making it clear it has been long enough that they think they should be let out. Adora laughs while Catra huffs, sitting up to straddle over her hips. Adora's smile is a little drunk, clearly still fueled by endorphins as she looks up at her.

"I think they just *might* want out," Adora says, smug like a fucking idiot. Catra narrows her eyes at her, pointedly rolling her hips.

"Then I guess you'd better hurry up," she says. Adora's lazy smile doesn't change as she drags her hands over Catra's thighs.

"Pretty sure I can manage that," she says.

Catra huffs, but unfortunately Adora is *right* and she learned enough in their night together to have Catra shuddering within five minutes. Melog has to wait longer than that, though, because Catra is getting at least a *few* minutes of naked cuddling in first.

Chapter End Notes

Writing near-smut, not at my desktop, with PEOPLE around felt like committing a crime so this is where I took it.

Chapter 14: Phantom

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra has been trying to focus on surviving her last two weeks of the semester, but even mostly limited to texts, things with Adora have been good. It's partly an excuse to be with her when she texts Adora that she needs access to her clubhouse to burn some energy. Only partly, because she's about to climb the *wall* after dealing with her third final. Adora invites her over that night and tells her it's *not* called the clubhouse, to which Catra asks if she really wants her to say the name over text and after ten minutes of silence Adora finally replies a reluctant *no*.

Melog could use the space to run too, so they accompany her in her bag even though it's a pretty intolerable way to ride the subway. They consider the paths, but even if they feel less afraid of them as time passes, they're still nervous, and it's easier to just deal with the train instead. Besides, Catra would rather take the train than be teleported, too. Melog might be confident in their abilities, but they've still never pulled anyone as big as her along. It has mostly been stray cats.

They're extra grateful for the space to run once they get there. Catra is wound tight and apparently the *no fucking in the sanctum* rule still applies even with no one else there – Catra can't help but wonder if they even know Adora let her in – so instead Adora lets her loose on what is apparently their magic training corner.

"When I first started, I had a lot of things to learn. Whenever I was busy and there wasn't a disaster, it was because I was down here training. She-ra's strength isn't very useful if you don't know how to use it," Adora explains as she shows Catra some of her early routines. Catra scowls at the mention, but it puts to ease one of the worries she has had since she first realized there were times when Adora being busy wasn't explained away with a disaster. She's still annoyed by that, but whatever, it turns out this shit is hard.

She can easily picture overachiever Adora spending hours on this every day, sure she has to effortlessly execute every move or she has failed She-ra's legacy. The other princesses had all their lives to train, but of *course* Adora had to catch up in just a few months. She was probably disappointed she didn't manage it in weeks and it's fucking exhausting. Just trying out all the stages to Adora's workout set is tiring and she gets a decent amount of cardio just walking everywhere.

"Has Mermista turned anything up yet?" Catra asks, partially in grunts, as she lets loose on the – magic, why does it have to be magic, this is so dumb – punching bag in the corner. It's cathartic. She knows a bit about how to throw a punch and Adora just showed her more, but mostly letting her body go wild on it is exactly what she needed. Melog agrees on the *wild* thing because they have been freerunning around the chamber, vertically dashing up the walls short distances before gravity takes over and they leap off to go bounding off again. Right now they're taking a momentary rest sprawled out on the cool floor, but they'll be back to their zoomies soon.

“Aside from the crime you probably committed? Not much useful. The contact information is a bust. Mermista staked out the address and never saw movement. Her online presence is only the few public records that are searchable,” Adora says. Catra grunts, ignoring the comment about the printout. That’s pretty much what she expected, but she hoped to be surprised. It seems like Shadow Weaver has given up putting on whatever front she was hoping to achieve with the group home.

Recruitment is Catra’s guess. A lot of disenfranchised young adults seem to end up in the Horde, hoping to make a name, if not some money, for themselves. Maybe in a few years Spinner would have pitched a *chance for a better future* or some shit to them after she thought she beat them down enough to agree.

“I think she’s mostly living as Shadow Weaver these days. She somehow managed to disappear into the sewer for a month without problems, anyway. She barely ever left. Doesn’t seem like she has a job,” Catra says in-between hits, getting in one last blow in with each fist before she steps back and just breathes, the endrophins soaking through her.

“Aside from renewing her license-” Adora pauses to give Catra a pointed look that she absorbs with a lopsided smile, “-it’s possible no one has really seen Spinner since we were teenagers. It definitely makes hunting her down harder. At least we have a photo now so the rest of the Alliance knows who to watch for.”

Catra nods, reaching up to push her hair off her forehead when it threatens to overheat her. Maybe it’s time for a break. Stretching will give her something to do without exhausting her. She moves to an open area of the floor and sits down, slowly setting to a circuit of whatever feels good. As she works on her first set, Adora falls quiet despite the *great* views Catra is giving her.

“I keep expecting to see her. Ever since I saw the photo again, I keep thinking she’ll be there when I walk to class or something,” Adora admits, her voice quiet. Catra looks up to find Adora standing over her, seemingly lost in thought. When Catra looks up at her, the movement draws Adora’s attention. She looks down, shrugging awkwardly. Catra unfortunately gets it. From across the room, even Melog agrees.

“When I took the subway yesterday, I saw a lady with black hair out of the corner of my eye and panicked for a second,” Catra reluctantly admits, turning back to stretching her legs. It was heart-pounding for half-second. She felt like an idiot afterwards – for so many reasons, but she especially couldn’t stop thinking *she’s not even tall enough* – and she was relieved to just go home and bury her face in the couch. It’s ordinarily not the type of thing she would admit easily, but they’re both dealing with the same demon they thought was *dead* right now.

“I know she’s not going to randomly find us when she doesn’t even know to *look*, but I still worry about it happening,” Adora agrees, a wry turn to her words. Catra could comment that Shadow Weaver probably *is* looking for Melog, but it’s unlikely she’ll find Melog with them almost entirely holing up in her apartment, so it shouldn’t bring any extra danger to them.

Shouldn’t.

She finishes her stretch and flops back on the floor, feeling the cool stones and taking a moment to breathe, much like Melog is doing across the room.

“Glimmer finally owned up to her mom about us letting you into the sanctum and asked Angella what happened with Shadow Weaver back when… Spinner left,” Adora says, hesitantly, drawing Catra’s attention. Uneasiness rises in her chest at the mention, but she reluctantly sits up and looks at Adora for her explanation.

“She got cornered. Dark magic wasn’t new for her, but she summoned too much to control. Her conduit was in her mask and it seemed to electrocute her or something. It nearly incapacitated her, but she summoned so many shades that they still stalled the Alliance long enough for her to get away. It probably left the scars on her face, but no one saw under it back then. Even when I cracked her mask, I never saw under it,” Adora explains, gesturing unnecessarily with her hands like she tends to when nervous.

“And all the cops knew to look out for was someone under the effects of dark magic,” Catra finishes for herself in a mutter, looking across the room at Melog, who looks back forlornly. Whatever happened to Shadow Weaver then, it isn’t fixed. Melog would witness times when her health seemed to worsen and she had to pull some magic from her stored supply to recover. It’s probably part of why she needed so much magic from them, and she did that to *herself*. It’s her own fault, but she tortured Melog for it.

“According to Glimmer, once you use dark magic, you stop generating any for yourself. It can have adverse effects outside of that, too. It’s powerful if you can find a way to fuel it, but that’s why she needed the conduit mask and why she needed…” Adora trails off, looking over to Melog too. Their ears pin back and they lower their head to the ground.

“Melog’s help to repair it,” Catra jumps in before Adora can say anything more to bring up the memories. To her surprise, Adora quickly turns her head to look at her with her brow furrowed. Catra shrugs. “What else would she be doing with all that magic? She was still storing it up when Melog escaped, but it’s the obvious answer. She couldn’t bring them on the go like she could with that mask. She probably misses the screams of civilians *desperately* by now. She doesn’t even have innocent children to satiate her in the meantime.”

The group home could have been just a front, or a recruitment effort, but it could have been because she’s sick and enjoyed it. Adora gets a dark look in her eye.

“Last summer, if I had just… We wouldn’t *be* here right now. Melog never would have been hurt, and everyone would be safe, and we wouldn’t have to be afraid,” Adora berates herself, the disappointment in her voice clear. Catra’s ears pin back. She remembers words like this, not from Adora, but from Spinner. *If you had just controlled her, I wouldn’t have to discipline her*. The blame was always simultaneously on them both.

“Say that to Angella,” Catra says, pushing herself up from the ground.

“What?” Adora sounds almost dazed in her confusion, completely thrown off. Catra rolls her eyes, stretching casually to make it clear there’s no place for Adora’s spiral.

“Tell Angella that it’s all her fault and if she had just caught Shadow Weaver eight years ago then none of this would have happened. You can’t, right? See, this is what I thought She-ra would be like before I met her. Self-righteous, sure she is the only one who can fix it. Shadow Weaver has a faceless fucking *Horde*, Adora, it’s right there in the name. One person can’t stop that, doesn’t matter how many fancy new powers you have,” Catra says. Adora gapes at her. Typical. Spinner fucked them up and Adora’s still playing by her rules.

Catra isn’t sure why her tone sounds like she’s threatening her, it’s just the only way she knows how to be when she’s scared. She wants things to be different this time. She wants to *believe* they’re different, because so far they have been, but she hates hearing Adora speak like this.

“Don’t make me lose you to this again,” Catra adds, her voice smaller. She hates it. She hates the way her voice sounds when it’s fragile. Before she can cover it up again with anger, Adora’s hands are on her shoulders and she’s pulling Catra close. Catra growls, but she lets herself be hugged.

“You won’t. I’m sorry. It feels like She-ra should be able to do more, so I must be doing something wrong, but you’re right. She got in my head a long time ago. I just got caught up in it again. I’m trying not to,” Adora promises, resting her forehead against the side of Catra’s head and holding her close. Catra drops her growl, though she still isn’t *happy*.

She might never get Adora the way she wants as long as the Horde is a looming threat, but Shadow Weaver is – surprise – really fucking them up. Things have been *good* with Adora coming over again, their text conversations having the same old spark they used to, but then moments like this come where the horror of their demons – and the weight Adora carries on her shoulders – come down on them again.

Catra joked about dealing with the Horde herself before, and she knows she *just* told Adora that one person can’t do it all on their own, but fuck, she just wants to silence it all. They shouldn’t be dealing with this. They’re twenty-fucking-two. They should be worrying about grad school and affording an apartment.

Adora pulls back after a few long moments of silence, their gazes meeting as she searches Catra’s eyes.

“I’ve been thinking about those things we talked about. The things that I want. It’s hard for me to think of anything I want as more important than the Horde, but you were right that they shouldn’t get to take it. The guilt doesn’t change overnight, but I just want to be with you now,” Adora says, her voice soft. Catra blows out a breath that ends up as a shaky laugh. That she knows how hard it is to change your mindset all too well. Their weeks of fighting prove it. She feels a little better, though.

“An apartment by the bay, right?” she asks, her voice as unstable as the foundation their dreams are standing on. Adora smiles softly, nodding. Catra might have, in a totally unrealistic and hazy late night googling session on her phone after four straight hours of studying, looked up apartments with bay views. Most of them aren’t cheap. They might manage something nearby, though.

“And plenty of room for your chaotic study habits,” Adora promises, leaning forward and pressing a kiss to her cheek. Catra manages a small smile. It’s nice. A nice dream.

If only the fucking Horde wasn’t in the way.

“I love you. I promise I’ve been thinking about it, this is just… backsliding,” Adora says, nuzzling her cheek now. It rubs Catra’s scent on her, appeasing her enough for a soft purr to start.

“If I still get to be mad sometimes, then you can be an idiot, you just have to let me call you that,” Catra tells her. It might freak her out sometimes, but it’s fair, or whatever. Adora chuckles.

“Deal,” she agrees. She nudges her nose against Catra’s and a moment later they’re kissing. It’s soft to start, their first kiss since Adora was last over at her apartment, but slowly it deepens as the knot in Catra’s chest unwinds. Adora wrapping her arms around her waist does a lot to help with that. Catra loves the way Adora holds her, strong arms that reassure her that Adora wants her here. The kiss isn’t chaste, but it’s still appropriately restrained given their audience. Melog is already annoyed by this much.

“You know-” a voice comes from the entrance, causing Catra to whirl around with a hiss and unsheathed claws as Adora jumps, “-I was going to say you’re good for her, but now you’re Frenching in the sanctum.” A new woman stands at the bottom of the steps, one hand on her hip and a smirk on her face. Catra hasn’t seen her before, but the white hair is pretty distinctive and she can guess she’s Star Sapphire.

“*Frenching*? How old are you, five hundred?” Catra demands, her anxiety raised up to ten. She isn’t used to be snuck up on. There has to be some kind of magic dampening spell around the door because it’s completely silent despite being big and heavy, but she was sure they were – relatively – alone and the shock makes her touchy. Adora hurries to move her body between them. She keeps her arm around Catra’s waist as she sends them both nervous, placating smiles.

“Catra, this is Netossa, Spinnerella’s wife,” Adora rushes to intervene. Netossa still looks way too smug to have caught them for Catra’s taste, but she nods to them so Catra reluctantly sheathes her claws again. That explains Spinnerella’s comment about catching her up. For all Catra knew Spinnerella was Fractal Flake’s babysitter or something.

“I’ve tried to be the one to talk some sense into Adora, but I think she only half listens to anyone when they tell her what she doesn’t want to hear. Seems like you have the best chance of success,” Netossa says. Adora pouts while Catra frowns. She doesn’t know how much Netossa heard or what she considers *sense*.

“She gives too much away. She always has. She really didn’t need this She-ra shit,” Catra says, because she’s not about to start heaping praise on Adora’s ego, but she wants to make what she was actually arguing against clear. She doesn’t know if it was the Alliance or just She-ra taking too much from Adora – she kind of assumed it was both – but she isn’t going to let it slide on her watch. Netossa nods, walking deeper into the sanctum.

“That’s why She-ra needed her, though, isn’t it? She-ra is a hell of a thing to be worthy of. It takes that kind of selflessness. But seriously, Adora, it’s kind of insulting how little you think we can handle,” Netossa says, her words casual in the same way Catra makes hers when she’s trying to show Adora she’s being dumb.

“I’m not-! That’s not what it’s about!” Adora tries to defend herself, immediately puffing up, but Netossa doesn’t let her, cutting her off with a dismissive wave of her hand.

“Yeah, yeah, it’s because you’d rather die than not contribute. Leave something for the rest of us, though. So many of us have to miss disasters all the time, but you never even consider taking one off just for you, do you? Listen to your girlfriend,” Netossa says. Catra’s tail sways. Fine, maybe this one is okay. She can’t be *sure*, but it’s the first time she has heard anyone else discourage Adora from becoming She-ra’s avatar full-time.

An alarm suddenly rings out through the chamber, loud and accompanied by a flashing light. Catra’s ears immediately pin back, cringing as they all turn towards the comm hub that has suddenly lit up and is ringing some kind of alarm.

“What is that?” Catra grits out. Melog buries their head under their own paws to block out the annoying sound. Adora hurries towards it, and the moment she hits the computer mouse, the alarm quiets to a polite-but-insistent beep.

“Our emergency alert system. Remember how I said the cops wouldn’t like us?” Adora explains as she pulls the computer up and clicks between a few feeds.

“Yeah?” Catra wanders closer now the alarm has been silenced. Netossa crosses the room in long strides to lean over the back of the computer chair Adora has dropped into, both of them following the events unfolding on the screen. From what Catra can see, it’s a combination of some kind of audio files, a map, and news feeds.

“It’s always listening for the police code for a Horde situation. Or magic. Or hostages. Or any infrastructure emergency. Basically any all-hands-on-deck situation the Alliance might be able to help with,” Adora explains. Catra is about to make a quip about Adora’s hypocrisy when it comes to Catra’s “own” hacking of government systems, but she cuts off when several of the audio feeds Adora has pulled up blare to life at once. They all wince, Melog hissing from across the room.

“Looks like Force Captains with some bots in uptown. One second,” Adora says, pulling up a text app to add onto the clutter on the screen now. “Sorry, I’m not usually the one doing this,” she adds, throwing Catra a sheepish smile as she types something out. A moment later, both Netossa and Adora’s phones start chiming. Netossa damn well knows what it is, so Catra is surprised to see her reach into her pocket, and even more surprised when she pulls out an AirPods case.

“Catra, can you hand me my bag?” Adora asks as she turns back to the screen and keeps doing… whatever the fuck she needs to do to call the Alliance together. Catra heads for their bags, leaned together and abandoned on a bench. By the time she has brought Adora’s over, Netossa has pulled her comms out of the case, and in a flash of light she transforms, confirming Catra’s suspicions about her identity.

“Guess I don’t need to train tonight anymore,” Netossa quips as Adora takes her bag from Catra and starts rifling through it. A moment later, she pulls out her own disguised earbuds case and puts in her comms. Adora pauses, glancing at Catra to send her an apologetic look.

“Glimmer just read the notification, so she’ll probably be here in a minute and can bring us out. We’ll come back as soon as we can,” Adora says. Apparently it’s too soon for her to be thinking about that *take one off* thing. Netossa is glancing between the two of them, *watching* in a way that tells Catra she’s expecting something to happen here. Probably for Catra to blow up. Apparently she has that reputation with the Alliance. The last time Catra got grumbly about them, Adora mentioned, sheepishly, that part of the reason they wanted her to keep the secret before was because they thought Catra might reveal the truth out of spite.

They only ever met her at her worst. Catra’s ears are still ringing and the jolt of adrenaline from the alarm is keeping her from accessing her bitterness for now. Besides, this isn’t an emergency interrupting something important like a date night. They’re just messing around in the basement. She makes a show of rolling her eyes and waving Adora off.

“I’ve got to get back anyway. I need to do some reviewing for my final tomorrow morning. Just call me or something,” she tells her. She doesn’t want to sit around in the sanctum wondering what’s happening and waiting for Adora to come back. The very idea makes her stomach knot. Adora hesitates a *lot* more, her expression in no way relieved. If anything, that makes her look more anxious, but they’re cut off by Glimmer sparkling into existence in the middle of the room.

“Who’s ready- What are you doing here?” Glimmer stops mid-sentence, staring at Catra with blatant surprise. Her tone is more bewildered than anything else, but it reinforces for Catra that she doesn’t want to hang around as Glimmer shuffles the rest of the Alliance through here. Or however they do it.

“Well I *was* making out with Adora until the alert went up, but now I’m heading home. See you later, Sparkles,” Catra tells her, rolling her eyes as she goes to grab Melog’s bag. Glimmer sounds exactly as affronted by that information as Catra wanted her to be and she smirks to herself as she grabs her bag. When she turns around, she’s surprised to see Adora crossing the room, Netossa having taken over her spot at the hub. Adora reaches out, catching her hand and looking at her beseechingly.

“Are you sure? You don’t have to go,” Adora asks, her voice quiet. For a moment, Catra hesitates looking into those blue eyes, but then Glimmer disappears in sparkles, probably to get someone else, and Catra is reminded that she’s definitely sure. Besides, even if it’s from pure spite, she’s determined to show she can be understanding when she’s given the *chance* to be.

“I’m sure. Just don’t get shot. Those lasers fucking hurt,” Catra tells her, squeezing Adora’s hand. She expects a laugh, but instead she gets a dark flash in Adora’s eyes.

“I won’t,” she says, her voice low, and then she leans forward and presses a kiss to Catra’s cheek. She lets go of Catra’s hand as she steps back, turning towards the comm hub in time for Glimmer to poof back into existence with Bow on her arm. Bow glances around the room,

does a double take at either Catra or the way Adora has her shoulders squared, and then rushes to take over monitoring the comms.

“Glimmer, drop me and Netossa on the closest roof to the scene so we can survey it while you’re getting everyone else. Bow, get everyone arranged for pickup,” Adora – *She-ra* – orders, striding across the room and reaching out. Gold washes over her and Catra feels herself take a breath as Adora swells with light, She-ra replacing her. The sword flickers between her fingers for a moment, but instead her empty hand lands on Glimmer’s shoulder, latching on firmly. Glimmer sparkles, her own transformation taking over her. Netossa puts her hand on her other shoulder and just when the shimmering has died down, all three of them disappear, twinkling echoing in Catra’s ears.

Catra swallows, shouldering her bag and jerking her head towards the stairs to signal Melog over. They walk to her side, wrapping a cloak around them both as they brush against her leg. Catra breathes easier in the privacy, turning and making her way towards the stairs as she listens to Bow tell *someone* that Moonstone can pick them up in five. He must already have his comm in. She could stay and listen now that her presence wouldn’t be obvious to anyone passing through, but something is knotting in her stomach and telling her to go.

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It’s fear, she realizes when she stops to pull up a map and instead feels herself drawn to the news widget on her phone. When She-ra was just She-ra and the Horde was some faceless villainy that has always run in the background for all her life, it was easy to assume that She-ra would handle it. She kind of thought She-ra was invulnerable and that has been proven false just by their night together. *Adora* is a whole different territory, and even though the feeds didn’t show or mention Shadow Weaver, her threat only makes Catra more uneasy.

Melog leans against her side, trying to silently assure her. They haven’t crawled back into the bag yet, the cloak affording them plenty of privacy to duck around a quiet corner when it’s time, but right now they both feel better with them at this size. Catra knows she’s being ridiculous – Adora has magic fucking powers, she isn’t the squishy human Catra grew up sheathing her claws from – but after a conversation like that, she’s unsettled.

They could go see. Wait, what?

Catra looks down at Melog. They look up at her more slowly, not shocked by what they suggested. Even if Catra *had* known the paths run through the university before now, she wouldn’t have expected the suggestion. Melog has been afraid of them ever since the ambush.

They’re far from their old territory. They’re in *Bright Moon*. The report didn’t show Shadow Weaver anyway, and they have Catra to keep them safe. That’s… a lot of faith to have in her, but she pets their head in appreciation anyway. Steeling herself, she turns to follow Melog. A

short walk to the edge of campus and they can look down the street in the direction of Uptown.

Melog gathers their magic within themself and then the world warps around them, the spot in the distance Melog chose as their first target magnifying like a fisheye lens. Everything grows distorted the further it stretches from their destination, invisible currents running against their bodies as corners turn with Catra's hand latching her to Melog. As they reach their destination, the warped lines straighten and the world in her periphery melts back into order. The heavy tides are replaced with calm water, and as Melog steps them out of the paths' magic stream, the sensation disappears entirely.

They're left standing on a rooftop looking over the battle, Catra's body settling down again after the uncontrollable forces washed over it.

"I would have called them the *rivers*, but whatever," Catra mutters to Melog, earning an amused trill. Both sounds are lost to the chaos below. There's only two Horde bots that Catra can see, but there are two or three squads clashing with the Alliance in the street. It's hard to tell with all the movement. She-ra, Star Sapphire, and Heart-Blossom are darting around taking them out, She-ra mostly focused on the robots and a Force Captain with a hand-cannon while her teammates use their powers to subdue the rest.

It's uptown, so there are always crowds around, and they flee where they can. Catra winces whenever she sees someone else get tagged with an errant laser. Her tail lashes and then wraps around her as she drops to a crouch at the corner of the roof. She feels her body straining every time a hit almost connects, instinctually wanting to block it or hit back despite being too far away to do anything. She has been in her share of fights at school, but nothing more than scraps. This is different.

Kind of. Given how easy they are to tangle in nets, Catra can guess the Horde doesn't give its members much in the way of training. It's not like they're a real army or anything, just a gang of armed supervillain-aspirants. Catra could probably take one or two – especially when they can't *see* her – but she's safe up on the roof.

She ignores all the people down on the street that are decidedly not safe. The Alliance is handling it. They've already taken out a good third of the combatants. Glimmer has only just joined the fighting herself. They seem more than capable of handling it with four members. Catra focuses on the people already trapped in nets and vines, struggling helplessly. Soon the rest will join them and Catra can go catch her train, going about her business like she always does when there's an attack no matter how close it comes to her.

One of them isn't struggling helplessly, she realizes as she watches. In the chaos, it's easy to miss, but someone in a Force Captain helmet still has a laser gun in their hand despite the vines wrapped around them – and they're taking aim. Catra can't tell where they're targeting from this angle, but the Alliance seems to be oblivious that the only Force Captain they've "taken out" so far is still a threat.

Catra and Melog are still standing in a path, even if they have stepped out of its current. Catra straightens, raising her hand to Melog's shoulder, and they follow her direction, everything

magnifying around the spot on the sidewalk where vines have busted through. The lines warp back into place as the currents leave them on the sidewalk, just feet from the Force Captain.

Catra couldn't tell where they were aiming because its constantly changing as they try to track Glimmer. All the vulnerable places Catra knows to look for are covered by their armor, but Catra ducks low, remembering the precise hit Adora showed her just an hour ago, and strikes the underside of their arm hard, where it is unguarded by their gauntlets. She tries to wrestle the gun from their weakened grip before they can recover. They cry out in pain and surprise, but by digging her claws in *deep* Catra manages to yank the gun from them without it going off and pulls it into the cloak as she and Melog retreat, carefully dodging another member of the Horde writhing on the ground.

They retreat until their backs press against a storefront, hopefully out of the way of being accidentally run into. The Force Captain is looking around, trying to figure out what happened, but they're smart enough not to yell and draw attention as Catra looks down at her hands. Her claws are wet, but she can't see the blood on them when her entire form is vague, rainbow shimmering. It's gross, and she can smell it along with the dust and ash raised by the fighting and lasers, but she swallows down the discomfort and turns the gun over in her hands.

Her claws left a deep scrape in the handle, but they mostly dug into the Force Captain and it seems otherwise undamaged. She's not stupid enough to run her hand over the end of the barrel, but as far as she can tell there's some kind of button on the back – above a port, probably power – and then the only other feature beside smooth metal is the trigger.

She looks up to see She-ra stabbing her sword through one of the Horde bots, crying out with effort as she drives it upward to cleave the bot in half. It slumps, twitching and whirring, but it's legs still move – and the laser lens remains intact. Catra raises the gun, does her best to sight down a transparent barrel, and fires.

She doesn't hit the laser squarely, but it turns out a few inches off is fine because the whole laser pops in a minature explosion, startling She-ra into turning her head. She just stares at it for a moment, a silent pause in battle, and then she flips her sword in her hands to drive it straight down into the remains of the bot, leveraging it again to slice through the bottom half. Its legs stop trying to flail for purchase.

That one's out of the picture. Catra turns her attention to the rest of the battlefield, trying to get a lay of the land and decide if now is a good time to melt back into the nearest alleyway.

She's not the only one with the idea, Melog points out. Catra turns her head to see one of the members of the Horde fleeing down the nearest street opening, either abandoning the lost cause or retreating temporarily to try again.

Catra isn't giving him that chance. She takes off, stuffing the laser into the tote still at her shoulder as she goes. She zips it halfway so it won't fall out as she runs to the corner with Melog hot on her heels. When she turns it, she finds the man is already almost at the next junction, causing civilians to scream and flee as they spot him.

Melog has this one. She keeps going, but she trusts them. As the man runs, Catra sees gold light gathering before her and then She-ra is standing there, looking down at the man with her sword thrown over her shoulders and a smirk on her face that clearly communicates how long she thinks this is going to take.

The man scrambles, trying to turn mid-run and stalling out. It gives Catra enough time to leap him from behind, flinging both her legs up to collide with his back and then use it for leverage, springing off of him as Catra twists to land on her hands, ending in a crouch facing the man now dizzied on the pavement.

She-ra rounds the corner – *actual* She-ra – and draws to a halt at the sight of herself. In an instant, Melog dismisses the illusion and Adora is left staring at empty air. She's actually staring right at Catra now, but she doesn't know that. The soldier struggles up on his hands and knees, unaware of She-ra "moving" while he was down, but Adora is still looking around, shocked by the sight of herself and looking for the source. Catra sighs, rolling her eyes as she stands and reaches back into her tote to pull out the laser gun. Pointedly, she fires it right at the soldier's feet as he stands, startling him back and making him fall on his ass. It didn't even hit him; he still has all his toes. At this point it's comical, but it finally startles She-ra into action, the sword transforming into a lasso she whips out as she runs forward, wrapping it around the soldier and forcibly dragging him back to the street entrance.

"Come on!" the man yells, and at this point it's sheer frustration as She-ra ties him up. When Adora finishes, though, she looks down the end of the street again at the space of air where her illusion was once standing.

Illusions are one of Shadow Weaver's abilities. Shit.

Melog brushes against Catra's leg, circling around in front of her. Their mane flares blue, the air shimmering just enough for the glow of their eyes, mane, and tail to show in a blue haze, the rest a rough outline giving little away. In all the chaos and fleeing, no one but She-ra notices the brief flash, her mouth falling open.

"Ca- Melog?" she says, which isn't really better than blurting out Catra's name, but at least Melog's name can't be googled. Catra doesn't give her voice away by responding, merely slinking to the side of the street in the safety of the cloak. After a moment of gazing back at them, there's a loud yell from the battle around the corner and She-ra startles back into action. She hoists the man over her shoulder, sending one last glance down the street as she turns the corner. The moment she disappears from view, she yells "Sapphire! Give me a net!"

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Catra lingers just long enough to see the fighting end, staying on the fringes as the last of the squads are swept up in nets, vines, and ice. At some point – probably when they were in the alley – Fractal Flake showed up and Catra missed it. She *doesn't* miss She-ra frequently

looking around once the fighting has settled down to pointless struggling, but Catra decides it's time to take her leave.

Melog has already risked a lot on the paths, so they shrink down as they walk back, using the cloak to hop the turnstiles at a subway a few blocks over. Catra is undecided on if she should head home or head to the university, but when her phone starts vibrating, she decides she has had enough fucking excitement for the day.

It's nearly impossible to read the screen in the cloak, so when they change trains Catra takes a moment to travel a few cars back until she finds one momentarily empty before someone else tries to hop in and nearly catches her. What he finds instead is a magicat curled up on the end of the bench seating, sending off a text to answer the two calls she has missed.

The message that she's on the train and she'll call when she gets home doesn't go down *great*, with Adora sending a barrage of messages back as Melog noses at her leg. She casually repositions so there's room in her lap for Melog to hop up and hopefully avoid brushes with strangers. They have plenty of room now, but it might be difficult later. Melog isn't ready to curl up in the bag with the fucking laser gun until they have to, though.

It's going to be a long train ride.

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For the third time – all of them related to Catra – Adora can barely wait for them to clear a scene. Last time she couldn't wait because she needed an explanation from Bow about what she thought she overheard. This time she doesn't know what happened, but she knows what she thinks she saw and it doesn't make sense. It was either Melog or it was Shadow Weaver, and neither possibility really makes sense.

Krytians have illusion abilities. Folktales say they used to use them to lure children away into the woods to never return. Adora is fairly confident that's bullshit, but it means they could have the power to do what Adora saw. Maybe that's even how they cloak in the first place. Adora hardly understands her own magic, much less another species'. Why – and how – Catra would have been there in the first place is a mystery, though. Adora doesn't see another sign of her while they clear up, which only makes her more concerned.

She's the last person Glimmer brings back to the sanctum, but she's the first to drop her disguise, hurrying over to her backpack, still leaned up against the comm hub.

"What happened over there? I thought I heard you say Melog," Bow asks, leaning back from the screen. Adora glances up at the screens showing the news feed of the police cleaning up after the fight.

"Yeah, I did too, but I heard you start to say your girl's name first. Does she need a codename at this point?" Netossa adds with a teasing lilt. Adora opens her mouth, about to defend

herself, and then stops.

Twice now she has had to say Catra's name on the field, once when she asked Bow if she heard her voice and again now. She kind of scrambled to say *anything* and shouldn't have really said Melog's name either, but it was at least marginally better than Catra's.

"Maybe. I turned a corner and saw… me. She-ra, I mean, standing over a Horde officer on the ground. And then she vanished and *something* sent the Horde officer flying back. I saw shimmering where 'She-ra' was. It looked like it could be Melog and Catra's outline. I don't know, it was only there for a moment and then it was all gone," Adora explains, hurriedly, as she calls Catra.

"There's no way. *I* didn't bring her, and she couldn't have gotten that far without help," Glimmer says, walking over as if to eavesdrop on the call, but Catra isn't *picking up*. The call goes all the way to voicemail as Adora lowers her phone, staring at the screen with panic in her throat. Glimmer places a hand on her shoulder, neglecting to say anything more.

They all know who it was if it wasn't Catra. No other illusionist has showed interest in the Horde's efforts to take over the city. Adora desperately calls again, this one going unanswered too as she feels her teammates looking on uneasily.

Just as Adora is about to call again, a text comes through and her building panic eases. She's still kind of freaking out, but Catra being on the subway right now makes sense. A lot more sense than what she saw out there, but it only calls it more into question.

She sends at least ten more messages trying to talk around what she saw without writing anything that could reveal the truth to a random stranger looking over Catra's shoulder. Catra's texts are slow and calm, but the message *I came to watch you work* seems to confirm that – somehow – she did see Catra at the fight.

"She was there. I don't know how, but she says she was there," Adora says, looking up to Netossa as Glimmer peers over her phone to narrow her eyes at Adora's rambling filling the screen.

"That settles it, she *definitely* needs a name," Netossa decides.

"Oo! Oo! Tiger's eye! That matches with our themes. It's a crystal that promotes vitality," Perfuma immediately volunteers, jumping a little with her excitement to talk about crystals. Adora is about to point out that already implies too much about who Catra is – for someone who can turn invisible, even the implication of a cat motif hints at her race – but she suddenly tunes out her friends when her phone starts to ring.

"I'm still on my way home, princess, so I'll be able to talk more when I get there," Catra's voice greets her, amused. Adora feels like she finally *breathes* hearing her voice. Sure, Shadow Weaver can imitate that too, but that's how Catra would greet her and Shadow Weaver wouldn't know *that*.

"Might want to make it quick. My friends are workshopping… nicknames for you," Adora says, talking around the subject as best as she can. She doesn't have the kind of wit for it, so

this conversation *will* have to be brief, but Catra definitely knows that too.

She called just to make Adora feel better. She still makes a noise of disgust, though.

“I’m not joining your Best Friend’s Squad,” she says. Adora hesitates, unsure if Catra is aware of *who* all is workshopping her name – Frosta just suggested Saber Cat which is… certainly a name – but Catra *does* have this kind of wit, so she probably gets the gist of what Adora is saying.

“No, but when I say your name and it… doesn’t match with the rest of us, it… stands out to anyone else who hears it.” Wow she’s bad at this. She talks slowly trying to say something semi-logical and Catra is already snickering by the end.

“Ghost.” Adora startles, turning around to blink at Netossa. She shrugs, but she seems confident in her suggestion.

“Maybe don’t lump me in with your squad, then,” Catra says, drawing Adora’s attention again. She really does need a name, though, and she’s probably going to come around to realizing that soon, if she doesn’t know it already and is just being contrarian.

“How do you feel about Ghost?” Adora returns, because that’s the only one so far that she can see Catra even accepting. Catra makes a noise of disgust again, but she doesn’t immediately say no.

“Phantom quartz represents clarity and helps with healing from trauma,” Perfuma puts in. Yeah, Adora isn’t relaying that, Catra is just going to feel talked down to. It’s a lot for Perfuma to assume when she barely knows Catra, but she knows some of what *Adora* has been through now, and that includes Catra by extension.

“Fine, whatever, just don’t go using it when you aren’t out with your friends,” Catra acquiesces. Adora turns, giving Netossa a smile and a thumbs up.

Netossa smirks as Frosta protests, “You didn’t even try mine!”

“I’ve got to change lines, I’ll call you what I get back home,” Catra says, her tone distracted as she no doubt gets ready to leave the car. Adora is settled again. She’s still confused, but she’s at least certain she really saw Catra and Shadow Weaver wasn’t just fucking with her by – somehow – knowing to project her outline to Adora. That would have been very, very bad.

“Okay, I’ll be waiting. I love you,” Adora tells her, brain catching up with her mouth too late. She has said it already, but it was always with *purpose*, something important and that Catra could have seen coming given the trajectory of their conversation. This time it just slipped out. It’s no less true, but it leaves an awkward beat of silence as Adora’s cheeks heat and she refuses to look up at her friends who she is *sure* noticed.

“I’ll call,” Catra promises, her voice soft and low as she hangs up, a weight to it that says as much – maybe more, given Adora’s casual tone – with fewer words. Different words. Specifically not saying she loves her but *affection* at least present and obvious.

Adora would love if Catra said it too, but she knows she has to earn it after making Catra feel unlovable. Catra isn't the kind of person to say it all the time even if they had never fought. She's quickly distracted from even thinking about it when Frosta *boo*s and Perfuma asks, "Can you see if she would like Phantom? It's a little more cohesive."

Adora is in the middle of debating codenames with her friends – specifically how little Catra wants one, and then Frosta getting excited thinking about what her name would be if she actually got to choose it, and then everyone devolves into coming up with their own – when she gets another text from Catra that makes her laugh out loud when she reads it.

"What is it?" Glimmer – or as she's now called, Cosmic Star – asks.

"Melog is offended we didn't think about a name for them, too. They want to be Mercury," Adora relays. The image of Melog getting huffy while Catra carries them around in a tote bag is very cute to her.

It's the same kind of affection she feels for Catra – not as strong, but still there. Melog is cute when they aren't an awkward presence while they're trying to make out. Given what she has seen today, though, she thinks all of them – including the Alliance – are going to spend a lot more time together than she first thought.

Chapter End Notes

Perfuma's just happy for an opportunity to talk about crystals lol
Happy Catradora day! I'll be honest, I'm still behind on this fic due to a combination of long chapters/life/blown capacitors, but when my schedule fell on this day it was too perfect and I just couldn't push it back. Next chapter (maybe next two, unsure) might take an extra day or two, though. I don't want to rush the ending(?). If it ever ends.

Chapter 15: Pew Pew (I'm Bad at Naming Things)

Chapter Notes

> As is tradition, the temp joke title became the title. I should know better. I DO know better. But I keep making dumb joke names anyway

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra likes not changing her mind. It's comfortable. Changing her mind might mean inviting *actual change*, and that's dangerous. Just because Spinner has been gone from her life for years doesn't mean her conditioning is, and sometimes it gets *reinforced,* like when Adora moved to Bright Moon and her entire life fell apart.

Also she's petty.

Change has come for her about six different ways in the last few weeks, though, and she has mostly been doing her best to ignore the shifts that have had to take place in the back of her mind, if not her life, as it happened. Getting a fucking superhero name changes that. Ignoring it isn't an option anymore.

Especially because she likes it.

Not having a name, to be clear, but she refuses to indulge too much in the exercise to choose something else given it's *just* so Adora doesn't blurt her name out in the field. What she liked was the feeling of – maybe, she *can* teleport – saving Glimmer, and the satisfaction of stopping the officer running away.

She liked what she always assumed was the only reason anyone was a superhero – what she looked down on the Alliance for before she even met She-ra. She assumed they were a bunch of showoffs, flexing their powers how they're allowed to. Catra doesn't have any powers, but she was able to work in tandem with Melog to use theirs like they were her own, and she doesn't have much of a justification for why. She was worried, and she had an inherent desire to stop the Horde that she wasn't expecting, but they were already *being* stopped, and by people with their own fucking powers, too. It didn't make a lot of sense for her to step it.

Melog thinks she's being dumb, that she stepped in because it was the right thing, the same way Adora did a year and a half ago. The feelings she had in in this encounter with the Horde were wildly different than when they attacked the university because the situations were, too. In the library, she was a hostage. In uptown she was an observer with Melog's abilities at the tip of her fingers, not to mention a fucking laser gun. She probably wouldn't have stepped in if it weren't for their invisibility, knowing the Alliance could handle it without her, but she had the ability to *help* them handle it. To help the Alliance.

Just this one time.

Maybe it's so eye-opening it makes her a little more accepting of Adora's – still shitty! – decision making, but there's only so much personal growth she can go through in two days. After her last final, she naps for sixteen hours as is tradition, only waking occasionally to use the bathroom, drink, or text Adora that she's still – debatably – alive. When she finally rises for the last time, now caught up on the toll from the last week of *bullshit* but feeling a bit like a slug after the coma, she goes to Entrapta's.

Catra isn't a hero, but she can do more than punch the Horde out in the street, or at least get the ball rolling on it.

She texts Entrapta before coming over, but she still feels like she walked in on something when she lets herself in via Entrapta's new thumbprint lock – which *somehow* already has her thumbprint despite not existing the last time she was here, probably best not to think about that – to find Entrapta basically riding Emily around as she fixes… something, somewhere on the top of her. There's a lot of *sounds* going on, from Entrapta's orders to hold still so she can *take care of her* to Emily's weird whirring sounds. Her footsteps thump as she slowly stumbles around with her rider and Entrapta is *grunting* as she hangs on and cranks her wrench. Catra chooses to interrupt just so she doesn't have to keep experiencing it.

"I've got a new toy for you," Catra calls. Emily stops staggering around and collapses all her legs into herself, which you would think would help with the stumbling, only she apparently does it so she can rotate her "head" a hundred and eighty degrees to look at Catra, which makes Entrapta slide off of her entirely. She catches her own fall, but still ends up lying on the floor, pouting for a moment before she looks up and sees what Catra is pulling out of her bag.

Superspeed might be another one of Entrapta's powers. Catra has never seen someone move so fast, Entrapta gasping as she scrambles over and flails her hands excitedly. Her gasp is drawn out and loud enough for Catra to pin her ears back before Entrapta breaks and gushes.

"Ohhh, *tell* me I get to take it apart!" Entrapta shouts, practically vibrating in place. She doesn't snatch the gun from Catra's hands, though, either waiting permission or too excited to release the fists her hands have curled into.

Catra is *so* going to regret this.

"Yes, but *carefully*. I want you to put it back together when you're done. Figure out how it works, how to charge it, if it has an exploitable weakness, that kind of thing. I don't trust these things to not be a ticking bomb or explode if you charge them wrong," Catra cautions. She mostly wants Entrapta to put it back together because that *requires* not getting reckless enough to break it. She did okay with the last laser she found, but while it was a lot bigger, it was also already inactive and damaged. Catra has no idea how many shots are left in this thing, but she can guess the answer is *at least one*.

"Oh, yes, I promise! Please, can I have it, please?" Entrapta gushes out, reaching for the gun now. She has surprising trigger discipline and doesn't risk trying to take it, though. Catra relinquishes it hesitantly and Entrapta immediately squeals again, cradling the gun with excitement and then holding it out at length as she inspects it carefully.

“It’s larger than I thought it would be, but I supposed all the footage of them has captains in armor wielding them. I'm sure there’s room for improvement here,” Entrapta says, pulling the gun close and inspecting the small seams in the casing.

“Let’s not make it more deadly, okay?” Catra asks, knowing it’s a fruitless suggestion. Either Entrapta is going to do it or she won’t. Catra just has to hope something good comes out of it too.

“There’s so much more to improvement than making it hit harder! Maybe it could be more energy efficient, or have a better user interface. I don’t see any passive feedback for charge levels. It’s probably this light on the side, but that should be on unless you’ve used all the shots!” Entrapta suddenly draws in a halt in the middle of her rant about *supervillain weapon design*. She looks up, blinking at Catra.

“How’d you get this? Oo, is this a present from She-ra? This totally makes up for sending me to the ferry!” Entrapta asks. Catra considers telling the truth for a split second, and then she remembers how complicated the truth is and how she can’t talk about *half* of it, so she just nods rather than come up with anything for herself.

“I’m giving it to you on the condition you try to learn something useful from it for the Alliance. They aren’t thrilled about you having Horde tech, but anything you can find helps,” Catra explains. Entrapta nods eagerly.

“I’ll take so many notes! Ohh, I bet I could make a presentation! Charts!” Catra is already very aware of how Entrapta feels about her charts, but she just nods, not wanting to spoil her fun. She might have to later when Entrapta wants to do something dangerous and she needs that for when it’s important so Entrapta will actually listen to her.

Hopefully this doesn’t result in a phone call to the fire department later.

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Adora is either cuddling Catra or holding her back. It’s kind of hard to tell, but it might be earned with the way Catra is *almost* growling here and there. She is in Adora’s lap, her back pressed against Adora’s chest as they sit on her dorm bed. The way Adora is holding her ensures Catra keeps her own arms tucked against her chest, but there’s also a lot of nuzzling going on. Catra hangs onto Adora’s arms, claws out but barely brushing against her skin. Her displeasure isn’t aimed at Adora, who keeps kissing her ears whenever she tenses up so Bow doesn’t feel threatened or something by her growling as Catra watches him messing with her phone intently.

She doesn’t even have anything on it. Nothing to worry about Bow finding, anyway, and her most precious files are probably just dumb photos she has taken of Adora for blackmail. She’s just touchy about people messing with her things after growing up knowing anything could be taken away at any time. She doesn’t know how sideloading apps works or how

badly Bow could fuck up her phone with it. Maybe the encrypted channel Bow is adding will corrupt everything in a week. That isn't worth being added to the Alliance's communications system.

She agreed to it, though. It's just so she will know what the fuck is going on. If she had access to it after the fight in uptown, they could have spoken openly without an issue. Adora was the one worried then, but if Adora goes dark and Catra doesn't know of an emergency from the news, then she can check or reach out to the others. She likes the idea of being able to see what the Alliance are saying. If she's going to trust them, this will go a long way to help.

It just requires trusting Bow a little first. Surprisingly, she does – the guy just oozes earnestness, it's kind of annoying – but she'll take Adora's comforting either way.

"Okay, almost done, just doing the final set up. I'm disabling notifications because there's no way to turn off just the high priority alerts right now and I don't think you want an Alliance mission waking you up. I'll see about adding that in later. There's never been someone who didn't need the emergency alerts in our channels before. There's only an off option for when one of us leaves town or something and knows there's no way we can help," Bow explains, glancing up to throw Catra an apologetic smile as he hunches over her phone. Catra's tail flicks and she nods. That's trust, right? The Alliance trusting her just like she's trusting them?

"Are you going with Ghost or Phantom?" Bow asks, startling Catra from her thoughts. She blinks at him.

"What?"

"For your name in the system. It's the one place where we can talk about both halves of our lives openly, but our profiles are kind of hard-coded so I need to know what you want your alias to be in the system," Bow explains, gesturing towards the screen. Catra continues to stare at him. She knows how this thing works – well, kind of – but she doesn't know where the Phantom thing came from.

"Perfuma thought Phantom would fit more because there's a phantom crystal or something. Ghost was Netossa's suggestion," Adora puts in from behind her. Oh. That explains it. She didn't hear all their – undoubtedly awful – suggestions as they worked on it. Phantom actually sounds cooler than Ghost, but she isn't part of their runestone squad and she doesn't want them to pretend she is. That's kind of what she liked about Ghost.

Besides, the only other thing she came up with in the few seconds before Adora – or Netossa, apparently – suggested it was *Wildcat* and she would rather burn another bald spot into her tail than give Scorpia that. It would out her, anyway. She has thought a bit more about what she would choose if – hypothetically – it *mattered* at all, but nothing was ever enough of an improvement on Ghost to be worth changing it even before it was part of a profile.

"Just Ghost," she tells him. He nods, turning back to her phone and continuing to type. She watches him, a thought slowly occurring to her.

“What’s your codename, anyway?” she asks, because if she opens the app and sees Cupid on the group members list she’s going to be disappointed in him.

“Oh, it’s Sagittarius! The constellation is an archer, and it’s Glimmer’s zodiac. Since I mostly coordinate from the hub and work on our systems, it doesn’t come up a lot, but I needed something,” Bow says, smiling way too much as he says it.

“That’s disgusting,” Catra tells him. If Glimmer weren’t in class she would probably protest Catra’s reaction to something sweet, but it’s *because* it’s sweet that she says it. Adora snickers as Bow laughs, unphased.

“Melog’s name matches our themes, actually, since Mercury is a planet and an element. Not quite a stone, but close enough, right?” Bow says. Catra is so glad Melog isn’t here. They would be so smug about any praise for their chosen codename. She just grunts an affirmative. That leaves her the only odd one out and she likes that. She does her own thing. She isn’t part of this squad no matter what Melog has been trying to talk her into.

They aren’t obvious about it, but she can tell what they want. They liked getting to use their magic, and striking back, and they felt braver with Catra beside them as backup. It works for them both, but even Melog is a little nervous about the idea of inserting themselves in battle when they don’t need to. They *aren’t* going to be superheroes. They’re just… around them a lot.

When She-ra showed up at her door three months ago, she *never* would have pictured it leading here. It’s kind of nice, though. Mostly the cuddles. Cuddles are always nice. Catra tips her head back and purrs, earning a soft gasp and immediate nuzzling. Too easy. She knew it would get her the attention she wanted. Adora’s kisses against the side of her face are just what she needs. She still has an apartment and new job in Bright Moon to look for, not to mention working her old one, so she keeps busy enough, but when she *isn’t,* the impulse to be with Adora is always there.

She has missed her so fucking much and buried it beneath hurt and anger.

“Okay, you’re all set up!” Bow says, unplugging her phone from his computer and making his way over to the bed. Adora starts shuffling over so Catra reluctantly shifts too, partially unfurling to take her phone back as Bow sits down beside them and points at different parts of the screen.

“The general channel is where we chat about anything. The automated alerts channel sends out anything the comm hub picks up for us to check out. You can’t send messages in that one. The emergency alerts channel is manually triggered when we’ve confirmed a disaster or need to call a meeting. That’s the only one that can send high priority notifications to break through silencing. The schedule channel is where we share our work and school schedules or any other times we won’t be available to answer alerts. Oh, and then the gym channel is for talking about training,” Bow says, pointing to each name as he goes.

Catra immediately opens the gym channel. She finds what she expected: Adora goading Glimmer into a competition to see who can take out the most training dummies. Scrolling through the channel, the whole thing is like that, occasionally interspersed with new workout

routines or arranging to meet up to train *without* turning it into a massive competition. Catra snorts.

“Jock,” she accuses. Adora isn’t the only one doing it, and damn near everyone is rising to it, but this is about what she expected. Adora chuckles and shrugs, unashamed.

“You like it,” she accuses, kissing under Catra’s ear. Catra ignores her, clicking back to the main feed and looking up at Bow.

“Thanks for not bricking my phone,” she says. Bow laughs good-naturedly.

“You’re welcome,” he says, and its obvious he’s saying it for more than just that, but *Catra* wasn’t the one who said it. Bow has picked up on her brand of communications easily. Well, fairly easily, because he doesn’t seem to notice, or at least understand, Catra side eying his backpack now. She appreciates the help or whatever, but she was also cagey about it on every level, so she’s kind of *done* with interaction now.

Also, there’s a reason she left Melog at home.

“Proud of you,” Adora murmurs in her ear as she kisses it again. Catra leans her head back, purring as she does her best to scent mark Adora’s face from the bad backwards angle. Adora hums and nuzzles back, helping Catra along.

Now Bow clears his throat, standing up.

“I think I’m going to go get food so I can meet Glimmer with it when she gets out of class,” Bow says as he puts away his laptop, hopefully a hint that neither of them will be back for a *while*.

“Okay! I’ll see you tomorrow,” Adora agrees brightly before kissing Catra again. Catra waves and wishes him a vague goodbye as he gathers his thing and leaves. Catra immediately twists around in Adora’s lap and pushes her back so she falls against the bed. Adora laughs as Catra crawls up her chest and kisses her. Adora bends her knees and wraps her arms around her, effectively continuing the cuddle even with Catra on top of her now.

Catra is purring too much to keep up the kiss, so she drops her head and nuzzles under Adora’s chin, breathing in her scent and marking her. Adora’s arms tighten around her and it feels *right*, safe and comfortable. She was a lot of things in the year apart, but comfortable wasn’t one of them. She absently licks Adora’s neck, causing her to gasp and giggle in a way that she knows means it tickled. She of course immediately does it again, laying claim to her…

Fuck it, her girlfriend. That’s what they are, right? If they aren’t anything else, that kind of just leaves girlfriends.

“You’re so cute,” Adora informs her, voice dripping with affection. Catra gives a warning growl that sounds far too playful and nips lightly at Adora’s neck, just a scrape of teeth. It makes Adora giggle again. She ducks her head, kissing Catra’s ear and immediately bringing back Catra’s purr. “I love you,” Adora murmurs, her voice soft and gentle.

It feels kind of like fireworks in Catra's chest, her ears pinning back from embarrassment and her tail swaying with stupid excitement behind her. Yeah, girlfriends alright. Her purr is like an engine as she responds by aggressively marking all over Adora's neck. Adora wheezes a little, but she lets Catra do it until her burst of affection has eased and she can settle back into her arms.

"So sweet," Adora murmurs one last time, sounding like she's talking to herself more than anything. Her voice is strained from how quiet she's trying to make it, as if that will save her from Catra's hearing. Alright, that's enough of that. Catra pounces. Adora laughs as Catra nips and kisses her, but she puts up no resistance. If anything, she pulls her in as Catra nips at her lip.

It effectively shuts her up from doing anything other than moaning. Good. Catra plans to use their alone time effectively.

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Catra gets a call from Entrapta where she's speaking so fast it's mostly jabbering, but it's the excited – probably – kind, and Catra can make out *come see this!* so she slips on the dumb tote she really needs to find a more permanent, cooler looking replacement for and heads out with Melog on her heels, cloaked. They only ride in the bag when it's crowded enough to force them, so mostly they just stick close to her in their smaller form until they arrive at Entrapta's.

The keypad looks different, sleeker but also bigger, like the last one was a prototype. When Catra tries her thumbprint, it still works. It feels *warm* this time and she swears her finger sticks to it for a moment, but the door still pops open as she hurriedly shoves her hands in her pockets. Catra slips through the door behind Melog, who shakes out their size just to be sure Emily doesn't accidentally crush them. Emily isn't anywhere in sight, though, just Entrapta. She jumps up from her workbench in excitement upon spotting them.

"Look at this!" she yells, brandishing what looks like the world's weirdest hairdryer in Catra's direction, though given when Catra can *guess* it is, she's glad Entrapta is holding it sideways with both her hands, the end of the barrel only pointed at the wall. Melog quickly darts to take cover under a table.

"How'd you manage that?" Catra asks, approaching slowly and eyeing the laser gun. It's at least half the size it was before, the barrel only two inches across at most. Entrapta has apparently scrapped the entire exterior, replacing the conical shape that flared out from the end of the gun with a smaller barrel that is straight down the entire way. It has a line of LEDs on the side, four of which are green with the final one yellow. She fixed the power readout that was bothering her, then.

"Oh, well, you did say it shouldn't be deadly and the space was already inefficiently used, so sacrificing the lethal levels meant it was very easy to rework the design to be more practical.

Now it's pocket-sized!" Entrapta explains, demonstrating this by pressing in a tiny circle at the base of the handle. The handle and its shielded trigger fold against the barrel, collapsing to fit easily in the front pocket of her overalls. "Tada!" Entrapta says, waving her hands on either side of her to demonstrate they're empty. The corner of Catra's mouth twitches. Melog cautiously peeks out to watch Entrapta's display.

"Impressive." She's pretty sure the *old* laser gun could have fit in Entrapta's pockets, but it fits normal-sized pockets now, even if the demonstration doesn't prove that. Entrapta grins as she pulls the gun out and presses the button again so she can flip the handle back out.

"I've added a safety, too. I accidentally shot it at the wall a few times while I was working on it. Did you know burning drywall doesn't smell very good?" Entrapta says, turning the gun to reveal the small inset switch on the back of the barrel, behind the port, which has completely changed shape since the last time Catra saw it.

"Weird," Catra returns, fighting to keep her tail from twitching.

"Not that strange given the chemical composition, actually! I looked it up. It's not something you should be breathing in." Catra knew the sarcasm would be lost on her friend, but it is kind of endearing the way Entrapta gets serious. Entrapta then seems to remember what she's holding and thrusts it in Catra's direction. Catra scrambles to take it, double checking the safety is on as she does. At least Entrapta labeled it. Granted, she used a full circle and a circle outline at each end, so it might not be Adora-proof, but Catra is eased at least.

"I made a case for it and a new charger. It has about thirty shots in it, so keep an eye on the display!" Entrapta says as she pulls said case – which is about the size the old gun was by itself – out from under her workbench and sets it on the table, flipping it open to reveal the removable charger nestled in beside the cutout for the gun. Catra carefully sets the gun inside. The gun now secured, Melog finally slinks out from their hiding spot to circle around Catra's side, posting up at her ankle.

"Hopefully I won't need to shoot anyone," Catra says. She's *absolutely* going to have to shoot someone at some point, but Entrapta doesn't know about Ghost and if Catra has things her way no one ever will. That would require her actually going out and fighting crime after dark or whatever.

Fine, she knows how it actually works now, but she's going to keep pretending she *doesn't* and it will save all of their identities or something.

"Maybe the Alliance, then! I have news and people that might need to be shot!" Entrapta says, causing Catra to do a double take as Entrapta runs off to her computer.

"*What did you do?*" Catra asks, hurrying after her. Melog comes running with her and jumps up on Entrapta's desk to stare up at her screens as they turn on. Before Catra even sees the monitor, she knows it's showing a map, but that doesn't tell her much.

"I have a lead on the Horde and it's quite annoying!" Entrapta says, her cheerful tone a bit pouty as she reaches into the big pocket she stuck the laser gun in and pulls out a… gear,

probably. It's a round metal bit with protrusions on one face, but it's so small Catra can't distinguish it even standing just to Entrapta's side.

"What did you find?" Catra asks, eying the gear as Melog carefully balances at the edge of the desk and stretches their neck out to sniff Entrapta's hand. Their efforts are immediately thwarted by Entrapta brandishing the gear up in the air, out of reach.

"This was inside the laser gun! It was a brilliant use, actually, it helped me figure out how they condense their energy so effectively – but now it means my favorite shop might be in danger!" She pauses, seeming to consider for a moment. "Or *a* danger. Hm. That would be bad. Where else am I going to get conductive tri-gears? They're a *trade secret!*"

Catra exchanges a glance with Melog, and then they both look up at the screen. Entrapta has a Maps page pulled up, opened on *Brother Electronics and Robotics*. Estimated time says it's an hour away.

And closing in twenty minutes.

"The gear, Entrapta?" Catra prompts.

"Oh! Right. These are machined specially by the proprietor at Brotherhood. He invented the machinery to make them. I used them when repairing the laser I recovered because they seemed like the perfect solution for tying together the parts I had, but now I suspect they were there to *start* with and because they're so small and fragile, they were just missing in the damaged piece I recovered," Entrapta explains, laying the gear flat in the palm of her hand and gesturing at it with her other hand, finally letting Catra get a look at it.

It sure is a gear. A weird one comprised of a flat disk and three spokes, but it doesn't look so special. Given how *small* it is, though, it's easy to believe it's hard to make.

"And you think that endangers the shop?" Catra asks, because that part doesn't track for her. Either the Horde is buying them like everyone else or they've cut a deal with the owner. Entrapta fervently nods.

"You have to special order these since they're so hard to make. If the Horde is using these in all their lasers, then they have to be placing large orders. The police either don't know their significance or haven't risked getting as deep into a laser assembly as I have to find them, but the moment they know they'll have something to trace back to the Horde and the Horde must know it. The shop is in constant danger," Entrapta explains. Catra can guess the scenario for the police is *both*, but she glances back up at the page again.

"Unless the shop is part of the Horde," she adds on. Entrapta lets out a distressed whine.

"But then they'll be shut down and I won't be able to get my gears anymore!" she protests. The thought has definitely occurred to her. "The guy who runs the shop is really sweet, but he's not the one who makes the gears. That's his brother. He works in the back, but I've run into him in the shop a few times and gotten into really interesting discussions! Maybe his brother got tricked into supplying the Horde and he doesn't know about it so I can keep my supplier," Entrapta speculates – fantasizes, more like.

Catra knows Entrapta likes to keep every possibility open, but this time it just seems like stretching for a solution that won't slow down her inventing process. Catra glances up at the screen – nineteen minutes – and then looks back at Entrapta. She sighs, reaching out and placing her hands on Entrapta's shoulders to force her to look at Catra so she can't get distracted by more possibilities or spontaneously inventing a new smart chip or something.

"Listen, I'll check it out, okay? If the shop is in the clear, we'll try to keep them from getting hit too hard." The chances the shop is completely unaware sound like they're about *zero* given how many lasers the Horde uses, but Entrapta brightens, nodding quickly. Catra lets her go, stepping back and eying the case on the table.

"I'll take Melog and investigate. I'll let you know anything we find," Catra says as she walks over and takes the case, slipping it into Melog's empty bag. Melog immediately jumps off the table and follows after her, their tail swaying. They're a little excited for the opportunity to use their powers, and especially to get a lead on the Horde that isn't Shadow Weaver related.

That goes for both of them.

"Okay! I'll be waiting! Don't get caught, but if you do, tell Kadroh I said hi, okay? He's nice," Entrapta says, waving. Catra snorts.

"Yeah, I'll let him know," she promises as she doubles back to check the map. Melog eyes it, marking in their mind where they can take shortcuts.

If they're going to get there before it closes, they have to leave now and take the paths where they can. Travel through the paths isn't instantaneous, but they might just make it. Closing time sounds like the perfect time to poke around. They'll hurry now and worry about contingencies later if they don't get there in time.

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Scorpia likes Bright Moon Bay at sunset. The oldest factories of the city crowd against the bank, spewing unhealthy clouds into the air, but the industry that drove Fright Zone's elites away to build up Bright Moon across the bay just tints the sky a bright pink that adds to the beauty of the sun on the water. And the clunky old factories keep rent in the nearby neighborhoods cheap! She's sure that a place this close to the water would cost thousands of dollars more over in Bright Moon. Sure, she has to walk past the factories to enjoy the sight since they block it from her place, but with the walk so short, that's not much of a hindrance.

"Oh! Yes!" she exclaims as she checks her phone and sees she has met her step goal for the day. Just another reason her apartment is perfect. The walk in the evenings is good for her. She knows her moms were worried when she moved out last semester, but it's working out great. Just when she is about to put her phone away again, she gets a call. Entrapta's name popping up is surprising since she usually prefers texting, but if she's really excited about something she might not be able to stand the delay it would take to type out.

“Hey, Bestie! What’s up?” Scorpia greets brightly as she turns the corner of her block.

“Unknown! Catra went to investigate something for me and she hasn’t responded for forty-eight minutes,” Entrapta says. Scorpia draws to a halt, anxiety immediately consuming her, but she hasn’t heard anything about a Horde attack.

“Investigate something? Where did she go?” Scorpia asks, glancing up for any signs of – not-factory-related – smoke rising above the city, but the night is quiet aside from the usual city noise. No distant screams echo. There’s a siren somewhere, but that’s not unusual, especially when it’s just one.

“To a mechanics shop that’s supplying the Horde. She was just trying to figure out if it was knowingly or not before they got swept up in any investigation,” Entrapta explains, her voice distressed. Scorpia’s heartrate skyrockets.

“You mean the Horde could have her right now?” she asks, looking around anxiously, but the empty street offers no answers.

“There are infinite possibilities! But that features in a number of them and has me worried, yes. I’m working on another contingency, but it will take time,” Entrapta says.

“Then I’m on it! I’ll head there right away,” Scorpia starts, turning towards the closest subway entrance and then pausing. “Oh, er, where is *there*?” she adds.

“I’ll text you the shop name and address. Keep in contact, okay? Catra brought Melog with her so you might not see her even if she’s there,” Entrapta says, her voice getting distant. That makes Scorpia feel a little better. She only met Melog once, at movie night right before finals hit, but the strange cat enjoyed making biscuits on her leg during it.

“Oh, Melog loves me! I’m sure one of them will let me know they’re there,” Scorpia says. Her confidence is a little false, but she *is* sure of that part, just not sure that they’re okay. Her phone buzzes as Entrapta’s text arrives. “I’ll keep you posted!” Scorpia promises, getting a goodbye before she pulls out her phone and checks the location. Her maps app says it’s close enough walking is faster than the subway. Still fifteen minutes, but Catra won’t have to wait much longer. Hopefully it isn’t already too late.

Chapter End Notes

I’ll be honest I’m this far in and I’m still not sure that’s the exact chapter count but it’ll be that or one more lol

Chapter 16: Jailbreak

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is stressing out about her finals even more than usual. She tends to become a ball of anxiety around exam season, but finals are even more important than usual for her this year. She might have been in worse shape academically last spring semester, but given it had only been a few weeks since she lost Catra, she was still in the depressed phase where flunking out almost felt like what she deserved or like it would somehow fix things.

The rough patch with Catra earlier in the semester – plus study time she blew off first as She-ra and more recently as herself to spend with Catra instead – means she needs to do really well on her tests, so she's doing her best to cram now it's on the horizon. She has had her head down for two hours, her neck aching as she hangs over her desk, when her phone starts buzzing and then ringing with the emergency alert sound that can break through all silencing settings.

She scrambles for her phone, already standing and trying to shove her shoes on before she realizes there was no warning buzz a few minutes ago to let her know the scanning system picked up an alert. Someone called the highest priority alert for something no other sources have picked up on

It gets more confusing when Adora opens the app and sees the message.

> **URGENT** Attention Alliance: I have hacked you because I need your help. I believe my friends' lives are in danger.
> Catra went dark nearly two hours ago and the friend I sent after her hasn't responded.
> Open broadcast channels. I'm already inside. This needs to be communicated faster than text allows.

Adora's stomach bottoms out, a high whine entering her ears. She feels weightless in a *really, really* bad way as her heartrate climbs. She fumbles for her bag, pulling out her earbud case quickly. In the chat, she sees Mermista send a *who the hell is this?* message, probably not able to hop on comms herself, but she is only half watching the text channel as she puts her comms in, too panicked to properly split her focus.

"Who is this?" she asks, aware this could be some kind of trap but incapable of not walking straight into it. If someone has hacked their channels, that means they're probably only a keystroke away of getting access to their trackers, if not already in. Their covers are already in danger and they somehow know about Catra. Her undisguised voice isn't going to do much.

“She-ra! She-ra, right? Your channel is labeled as She-ra. Catra needs your help. You owe it to her,” a bright voice says, loud and maybe even familiar. It isn’t some deep-pitched modulated voice threatening her now she has gotten on the line, but that means it’s likely the *worse* possibility: the message was true.

“Yeah, I’m She-ra. What happened?” Adora asks as she feverishly tags Moonstone and asks for a teleport from her home. Glimmer is at dinner with her mom and fucking *donors* right now, but her phone would have started ringing too. Hopefully she has at least glanced at what popped up on her screen by now and just hasn’t gotten somewhere private enough to respond yet. The moment she does, Adora needs Glimmer at her side, ready to respond to whatever this danger is.

“She went to investigate a shop with possible connections to the Horde and hasn’t responded to any attempts to contact her for over an hour. I sent another friend after her while I worked on hacking your communication, but she stopped responding after she arrived at the destination,” the voice lists off. Adora’s hands tremble slightly from adrenaline. Why the hell was Catra going off on her own? She has been pretty insistent she isn’t a superhero.

“What was the location and how do you know about it?” Adora asks, trying to steady her hands. She needs Glimmer to show up. She needs someone else-

“Alright, who the fuck are you?” Mermista’s voice breaks in, demanding in a way Adora can’t be right now.

“Entrapta! Catra has told you about my projects, yes? I found a trace in a Horde laser gun to Brotherhood Electronics. They were about to close, so Catra ran over and I haven’t heard from her since she left,” Entrapta says, and it all clicks for Adora. She never actually met Entrapta, but she has heard her voice in the background of calls and in a video or two Catra sent her before they fell apart. It’s a fucking *relief* to know who she’s talking to, even if Catra is still in danger. Catra trusts Entrapta, apparently enough to run off on her word alone.

And it might have gotten her killed.

“How did you find us?” Mermista asks next, the irate edge gone, even if it’s still an interrogation.

“Oh, I’ve known about your network for a long time. It wasn’t hard to figure out who it belonged to given it’s unique broadcasting patterns, but the security was well-done and I never had reason to break in until now. Who built this for you? Their design is elegant. These comms are so comfortable to be in.” Okay, Adora gets exactly what Catra was talking about with Entrapta being a weirdo about tech. The way Entrapta says it – from her words to the too-content turn of her voice – makes Adora feel like she has physically crawled inside the comm in her ear.

For all she knows, that’s an accurate summary of how her technopathy works.

“*What*,” Bow’s voice is too shocked to be a question as it joins the group.

"*Table it*. Where is this shop you sent Catra to?" Adora asks, focused enough now that she doesn't jump like she might have a minute ago when sparkles come to life beside her.

"I just sent the address. Hmm, I have access to your map now, *wonderful work*, really- Oh, I mean, I've pinned Catra and Scorpia's last known location on it," Entrapta rattles off as Glimmer solidifies beside Adora in a party dress, her lips already parted to ask questions. Adora cuts her off by grabbing her arm.

"Sanctum, now," she orders, and after a brief second of processing Glimmer complies. The world sparkles and the sanctum replaces the dorm when the lights fade. Adora points at the map, glancing at Glimmer's ear to verify she isn't on comms.

"Catra's technopath friend hacked us because Catra might have walked into a Horde den. We need to get to the pinned location," she lists off, glancing down at the chat to see Perfuma has also sent a question about what's going on in the chat. "Everyone on comms right now, sound off," Adora orders.

"Here!" Entrapta chimes brightly, over Perfuma's, "Just got here." There's a half-second of pause, but they have an established order for these things so when no one says anything, Mermista says, "Pearl here." Bow follows up with "Sagittarius still catching up," a moment later.

No Frosta, no Spinnerella or Netossa, and Glimmer is beside her. Great.

"Everyone, get in a position for pickup. Moonstone, get your comms and then grab Sagittarius and come back. Sagittarius, you'll coordinate from the hub-"

"No need! I have complete remote access now and can coordinate. I'm afraid I've already wasted too much time," Entrapta cuts in, her voice starting bright and then taking an uncertain turn. Glimmer doesn't hear *why* Adora cut off, though, so she sends her an uncertain look and then vanishes, used to reacting fast in these moments. Fine. That's fine. They'll still need Bow's backup since they're down three hands right now.

"I'm sorry, but we don't know your spirit yet. We trust Sagittarius," Perfuma puts in, her voice polite but layered. Oh right. Adora takes a moment to breathe, reaching out for She-ra and struggling for a moment before she finds that spark of connection and magic washes over her.

"Catra has vouched for Entrapta. We don't have time to debate this. Sagittarius, suit up when you get here. Entrapta, what can you tell us about the location?" Adora asks, not giving anyone time to question her.

"Brotherhood Electronics. They produce proprietary parts the Horde is using in their lasers. They either have records ultimately leading to the Horde's manufacturing or are a part of them. Catra was going to poke around invisibly as they closed to try to figure out which it was," Entrapta lists off. Adora swallows, flexing her hand out and pulling the sword from the air just to have something to hang onto.

“She took Melog?” she asks, because that’s *something*. Catra stands a much better chance with them than alone.

“And a laser gun! I only just refitted it to be nonlethal. It could have failed, or she might have gotten caught before she could use it. I don’t know, there are too many possibilities to narrow down. I only ever saw one or two staff in the shop at once, but it’s possible someone from the Horde came and was able to overwhelm her,” Entrapta says. The laser gun is a new factor to worry about, but Adora has to just hope that it helped Catra in any potential fight. Catra mentioned taking a gun off a Force Captain in uptown, but Adora didn’t realize that meant *taking and keeping* rather than just taking it from their hands during the fight.

Glimmer pops back into existence a few feet away, holding hands with Bow. Adora looks up and makes eye contact with Glimmer.

They can speculate on a lot, but right now Catra needs action.

--

Scorpia never thought she would be face-to-face with Shadow Weaver. She seemed too high up for Scorpia to ever cross paths with. Her anxiety has demanded that she worry about getting caught up in a Horde attack many times before, but she was never important enough even in her worst fears to be worth Shadow Weaver’s personal attentions. A chance accident was more likely to see her fleeing from a random Force Captain.

They’re here too, though, so it turns out everything her moms have ever said about not listening to her anxiety was wrong. She was underestimating how bad it could be, and she still doesn’t know what happened to Catra.

“This has been a very big misunderstanding, really. Clearly my friend isn’t here, I can just go and not tell anyone about this,” Scorpia says. She would gesture over her shoulder, but there’s the whole rope problem to deal with. She thinks she can break out of them between her strength and the rough spines of her chitin already starting to fray them, but right now she’s pretty deep in a Horde base. Her anxiety that she now believes in with renewed vigor tells her that she couldn’t fight her way out.

There’s also the dark shadows stirring occasionally around Shadow Weaver.

“Ah, yes, your friend… What was her name?” Shadow Weaver asks over her shoulder, a satisfied curl to her voice that sends a shiver down Scorpia’s spine despite how hot it is in the room. For a moment, Scorpia’s mind blanks.

“Elizabeth!” she remembers, voice a little too excited to have gotten it right. It seemed like a bad idea to give her or Catra’s real names to the strangers surrounding her when she circled completely around the shop twice and suddenly the two people smoking outside had become

four. Elizabeth was the first name she could think of. It was their class lizard when she was ten.

Shadow Weaver makes a *hm* sound, vaguely displeased, and returns to ignoring her. She stands with her back to Scorpia, examining the mask she took off only after turning around. A faint light is emitting from it, though it has gotten stronger with time. Shadow Weaver shifts, raising her hands, and Scorpia can tell she is putting on the mask again. Slowly, the sorceress turns to her.

The gem set into the center of her forehead crackles, the source of light coming from the small sparks dancing out of the crack down the center of it.

“Lauryn, you expect me to believe the next Black Garnet holder just wandered into my stronghold on accident?” Shadow Weaver asks, her voice icy. Scorpia swallows. Shadow Weaver falling for the fake name she gave doesn’t make the implied threat in her voice less scary.

“You forget whose house you’re in,” a sharp voice cuts through the room, causing Scorpia and Shadow Weaver both to jerk their heads up. The Force Captains flanking the door to the converted storage room both salute as a dark elf enters. When they led Scorpia through the workshop outside the sorceress’s room, he was busy welding and only yelled at them for disturbing his work, but now he has apparently taken notice of the disturbance. There’s way too many scary people with the power to kill her in this subway tunnel. She doesn’t really know what this place is, just that it’s definitely a hidden part of the subway the Horde managed to build an access into from the back of the electronics shop.

“Of course, Lord Hordak. I was merely saying, as a member of the Horde, she walked into a place where I hold more power than her,” Shadow Weaver replies, bowing her head, her tone entirely different than it was when she spoke to Scorpia. She still doesn’t sound *nice*, but she’s at least pretending to be polite. Hordak narrows his eyes at her for a long moment and then his gaze flicks down to Scorpia. Scorpia immediately freezes, trying to offer him a *please let me go* smile.

“No one should be here. Get rid of her,” Hordak orders, looking back at Shadow Weaver and ignoring Scorpia like she’s already dead. Scorpia swallows. She always thought Shadow Weaver was in charge of the Horde and it’s terrifying to realize there’s someone *worse* that even Shadow Weaver answers to. Shadow Weaver, snapped to attention, breaks her stance to sweep forward, placing a hand over her heart and gesturing to Scorpia with the other.

“But Lord Hordak, she could be useful, instrumental even, to restoring the power of the Garnet. The Horde has suffered swift defeats since I left the field-” she begins to pardon, but she’s cut off.

“And it suffered defeats before, too. Your schemes to establish a new source of magic have only been a colossal failure not worth the investment of resources. Take what you need from her and *dispose of her* before anyone notices she is missing. I want her gone before I finish this bot,” Hordak orders. Shadow Weaver’s fingers curl for a moment before the fist releases.

“I will see what I can pry from her in such time,” Shadow Weaver agrees. She is using the same tone she did when she first soothed Hordak’s displeasure, but this time it chills Scorpia to the bone.

Probably because they’re talking about torturing her over a rock she has never seen. Hoo boy. She thinks the fear has been extended enough at this point she’d becoming a little numb to it, feeling cold as she wonders almost distantly how she is going to get out of this.

She’s not sure anyone can, not even Catra with her ability to turn invisible. Hordak releases a noise of displeasure and turns with a curt, “dismissed,” the door shutting again behind him.

In his absence, that feeling like a cold fear-sweat is quickly replace with dangerous crackling, like any moment Shadow Weaver’s lightning powers are going to burst forth and level anyone in the room.

Shadow Weaver’s hands fall to her sides, curling in fists as she turns to Scorpia.

“Let’s see what your connection can do, hm, Lauryn? I suggest you cooperate. The only way he will consider keeping you alive is if you produce results,” Shadow Weaver says. Scorpia swallows.

She doesn’t know what *results* means, but she has a feeling it isn’t going to be much better than what Hordak wanted them to do with her. She leans back instinctively and one of the swirling shadows brushes against her arm, a reminder of what’s awaiting her.

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Glimmer drops Adora on a rooftop down the block from the shop so she can scout ahead as Glimmer teleports the rest of the team out. Adora checks the front of the store first. It’s dim, an anti-robbery grate pulled down over the glass. It appears no different than any other store after close. She tries to circle surreptitiously around the back, but She-ra isn’t built for stealth, and it’s hard for anyone to jump off a roof quietly. As soon as she lands in the back alley, a pair of humans loitering behind the shop spot her. Their eyes go wide and they both shout something indistinct, turning to run for the back door.

So she was right to be worried.

Adora leaps forward to close the distance as the two guys scramble through the doorway, barking out orders to storm the back as she does. She slams her forearm up, blocking the door from closing behind them with so much force she dents the metal. The men’s wide-eyed gaping is the last she sees of them conscious before a punch sends one flying into the wall and a kick sends the other *through* it just beside his slumped form.

She tries to hold back her strength whenever she’s fighting a person, but right now every one of her actions has an edge of fear to it. She scans the small room, but aside from stock for the

store, it's empty. By the time she has made her way to the door into the next room, Perfuma has arrived and Mermista is drawing water up from the storm grate outside. Adora slowly cracks the door into the next room open, but she sees no lights and hears no signs of activity.

Those men were trying to warn *someone*. Someone else is here, and that means Catra and Scorpia probably are too – or at least they *were*.

--

Overhead, there's a noise. It's muted through the layers of concrete, but it has to be loud to make it through at all and it makes Shadow Weaver jerk her head up from her work. After a moment, she turns her head to glare at one of the guards, letting Scorpia see her unmasked profile for the first time. Her powers appear to have left painful-looking scarring across her whole face, bold and distinctive. The reason for the mask is clear, but it is in her hands now as she hunches over it and tries to draw power from it.

"You, go see what that was," Shadow Weaver orders. The guard draws to attention, nodding curtly and then turning away. The door is open for only a brief moment to let them out. Scorpia's heart flutters, part of her mind telling her to run, but fear holds her back and then the door is closed again.

That sound could have been Catra, but now she's almost alone with Shadow Weaver. Only one guard is left. With the thick walls, it's possible she has a better a chance of stinging her way out of this now if she waits for the right opening. Shadow Weavers threats are terrifying, but right now she doesn't seem to be capable of much in the way of magic. Aside from some shifting shadows and the sparks that come from the mask with or without her input, she hasn't managed anything.

Scorpia is pretty sure Shadow Weaver will find a way to kill her either way, though. The sorceress turns back to the mask, positioning her hand over the gem and attempting a variety of hand movements to… draw energy from it, probably? Scorpia really can't tell. She's just trying to stay quiet and not irritate her captors too much. If Catra were here right now, she would probably make a joke about how hard that must be for Scorpia.

Scorpia manages one weak, soft *ha*. It's an attempt to comfort herself and more of breath than anything, but Shadow Weaver's head still jerks up as her enraged gaze focuses in on the prisoner laughing at her. In her moment of distraction, her hand shifts and a stray spark from the mask catches her finger.

She hisses, yanking back instinctively and dropping the mask. It clatters to the ground, rolling to a stop just before Scorpia's knees.

The sparking stops for a moment. Scorpia holds her breath, trying to shuffle back so it won't catch her pants on fire if it starts again. Up close, she can see the crack in the stone begin to glow, the air crackling around it, but no distinct sparks shoot out. It's kind of beautiful. As

beautiful as it is dangerous, anyway. She feels the urge to touch it, but she also feels the urge to touch lava when she sees it in pictures and she knows that's a really bad idea. Its dangerous light calls to her, though, especially as it glows even brighter.

An arc of sparks sprays just as Shadow Weaver reaches for the mask again, but it sprays towards Scorpia and Shadow Weaver is able to grab the sides of the mask. Scorpia yelps and leans back from it as far as she can. Shadow Weaver lifts the mask, holding it out in front of her so Scorpia is face-to-face with it.

"It's responding to you. You want to know what your powers could be, don't you?" Shadow Weaver asks her. Scorpia blinks at the mask, unnerved by the blank eyeholes.

"I don't want a mask, thank you," she says, trying to lean further back and realizing she has nowhere further she can go without falling. Is the mask cursed? Is that what's going on? Is Shadow Weaver trying to pass the curse on to her now?

"The mask is merely the home of your birthright. I've used the power of the Black Garnet for years. It could make you as powerful as any of the Alliance. Even She-ra is weak to lightning," Shadow Weaver says. Scorpia stares at it, a thought half-formed in the back of her mind and taunting her with the puzzle she can almost put together. She doesn't know what birthright Shadow Weaver is talking about – she's just *average* and certainly not a magic user – but now she has heard it enough, she swears the words *Black Garnet* mean something to her.

"It seeks you. Reach out for it," Shadow Weaver says. The glow of the stone is as mesmerizing as before, but Scorpia's shoulder jerking with she tries to move her pincers reminds her that she is tied.

"I can't, sorry," she says. She shouldn't be tired. She shouldn't want a curse. It's probably a curse, right?

"Not like that, *you*-" Shadow Weaver cuts off what was definitely going to be an insult, taking a deep breath. When she begins speaking again, her voice is calm again, almost encouraging except for the unnerving edge still present. "Call out to it. Pour your heart forward. Feed the connection. It's trying to heal but can't without you. Accept its power and make you both whole," Shadow Weaver coaches her.

Scorpia knows she's a little dim, never the first to pick up on a hint, but she can tell when someone's trying to trick her into letting a spooky mask suck out her soul.

"Uh, hi, rock, please fix yourself," she tries, hoping that's not enough to enter some kind of pact with a magic rock. Shadow Weaver hisses with frustration, but a muted commotion outside causes her to startle. She doesn't move much, but suddenly the mask flies out of her grip and hits Scorpia in the face. For a brief moment, she's looking through the eyeholes from the wrong side, the cool gem pressed against her forehead.

Then a flash of light overtakes the room. Power surges through her, whiting everything out but the sensation of gasping in a cold shot of air. The world comes back to life with a crackle

of light. Scorpia sees the tail end of the lightning shocks arcing out from her towards the others in the room, knocking back Shadow Weaver and the guard as they seize.

But there's a third cry, a third form flickering as it jerks back from beside Shadow Weaver. Scorpia sees a flash of Catra's face locked in a grimace before the distorted shape of a cat, small enough to have crouched beneath the arcs, circles her and they both disappear.

"Catra?!"

--

"Shut up, idiot!" Catra manages to grind out as she stumbles to her feet and retreats to the wall. Scorpia all… princessed out, is weird. Her eyes glow the same ominous color that Shadow Weaver's did. On her, it looked like red so bright it was mostly white. On Scorpia, it looks more like light pink, but it's still really weird. Her mask looks kind of like Shadow Weaver's on the top half, but the bottom half curls down her cheeks and hooks up, leaving her mouth free like the rest of the Alliance and softening her some.

"I've been so worried about you! Are you alright?" Scorpia rushes out, not listening at all as she hurries to her feet and reaches out in Catra's general direction. Her ropes fried and burned when she transformed, but sparks still dance across her pincers as she reaches out towards Catra. Catra, still feeling remarkably similar to how she did when she got tazed the *first* time, flattens herself back against the wall, her ears pinning flat to her head.

"We'll catch up later! I'm trying to maintain a cover here," Catra hisses back. Scorpia catches herself, glancing around at the devastation of the room. Shadow Weaver's new magic lab is still fairly bare, but Scorpia released a few large arcs of lightning as she transformed and they singed everything they touched. Catra is lucky one didn't shock her directly. The transfer shock from being near Shadow Weaver already feels like being temporarily set on fire.

It's actually way worse than the tase, but it's fine. She's fine. She probably doesn't have a burn this time. No new bald spots is her current criteria for fine after spending what feels like two hours locked in to this hideout. Watching Shadow Weaver threaten Scorpia was terrifying – both for Catra and for Melog. Holding back for a good opening was worse, not knowing if every moment she let slip by was the one and she had doomed them with her inaction. She picked up what Shadow Weaver wanted, though. If she thought she could use Scorpia's apparent connection to the Black Garnet to heal it, there was a good chance Catra might be able to interfere to ensure Scorpia inherited the runestone fully.

Melog mentally calls her. Catra looks down, following their gaze to the mask on the floor. The two halves have cracked apart again. It looks comically mundane with the remnants of glue showing along the inside of the crack, the gem inset now empty. It's in Scorpia's heart, or whatever, hopefully healed and at full power. The plan worked, at least the start of it.

Another crash rocks from outside, drawing their attention to the door. Catra stares at it, her heart too wrung out after the last hour of fear to know if investigating is a good idea. She thinks – hopes – she knows the source of it, but even her superior hearing can only pick up so much through concrete.

They have to get out of here soon, though. Shadow Weaver's breaths are rough rattles, but as long as she is still breathing, she's a threat. They need to escape before anyone wakes up. Catra reaches into the bag on her shoulder, relieved she can finally safely open the laser gun's case without worrying about the quiet clicking of the fastenings alerting anyone. She feels a bit better with the gun in her hand. All she could do this whole time was occasionally touch Scorpia and hope she understood the message that she wasn't alone.

"Alright, listen up," Catra says, edging around the outside of the room. "I'm staying behind you. Only aim that lightning in front of us and we'll be okay, alright? If Alliance is out there, maybe use your stinger instead unless you're confident in your aim," Catra says. Scorpia immediately ruins the plan by turning towards her voice, so Catra hisses at her.

"Face forward! I'm not talking again until we're out of here. Me and Melog are right behind you, so don't worry about us and *go*," Catra orders. She knows this is a lot for Scorpia – it's a lot for *her* and she's not the one who just found out she's a princess, just that she's apparently surrounded by them – but they need to get *anywhere else* as fast as they can.

"I don't know what I'm doing," Scorpia protests, anxious as she cautiously picks her way over to the door. The new voices layered beneath her own sound dissonant, like they haven't settled in yet. Yeah, Catra can't help with that part, but that's why she said to fall back on her stinger. Scorpia pauses by the door, reaching down and nudging the slumped guard. Even from behind, Catra sees the spark that arcs off Scorpia's touch and causes him to groan in pain in his sleep. Scorpia startles back, but Catra was expecting her to have a clumsy moment if nothing else and she's far enough back to not get taken down.

"*We need to go, Lauryn,"* Catra hisses pointedly, breaking her vow, but the whisper works. Scorpia straightens up again, taking a breath and steeling herself.

"Right. Just… hold it in," she murmurs to herself, and then she finally reaches for the door.

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Bow found the secret hatch right before someone opened it to investigate the sounds above. Bow punched him and sent him right back down the ladder he climbed up. The rest of them converge on the point immediately, Adora jumping in first just in case they have a laser aimed at the opening so the super healer can take the first hit.

The Horde doesn't, but they scramble to grab their weapons and fight back as Adora lands and calls the others after her. The room is probably similar to what Shadow Weaver's hideout looked like before blowing up, likely a disused part of the subway system that has been shut

away, only this one has been turned into a tech workshop. There aren't a lot of people inside, but a dozen combatants between both sides in an already small space makes the fight difficult. Workbenches, machinery, and half-built robots block lines of sight and offer cover. It's hard to strike out when you could easily accidentally hit a friend.

Even with the obstacles, Adora can tell Catra isn't here, nor is Scorpia. Catra could be invisible, but Scorpia is big and hard to miss. Scorpia got far enough to text Entrapta when she reached the location and let her know it seemed closed. There has to be a clue somewhere here, and if not, Adora is going to *make* the Horde tell her something.

A laser blast flies past Adora, letting her know that one of the cannons lying around the shop is operational even without an attached robot. When she turns towards the source, she sees a tall, broad elf with welding goggles hefting it up off a work bench to turn it towards her. For some reason, Catra complaining about the bald spot on her tail flashes before her eyes as she charges him. The cannon lights up, charging another shot, but he doesn't get it off in time, and he can't defend himself while trying to shoot.

Adora's fist connects with the side of his head, knocking the goggles out of place and almost off him entirely. The man drops to the floor, the cannon nearly falling as well before Adora catches it. It doesn't go off without his finger on the trigger, but the light at the end of the barrel is still blinding. Heat is coming off of it and it's probably best to *not* drop a primed laser on the floor. She sets the laser back down on the table it came from, movement at the edge of the room catching her eye.

A door she hadn't noticed earlier in the chaos opens and a woman stands inside of it, staring at the action in the room in seeming horror.

Scorpioni. Tall. White hair. *Wearing a mask with glowing eyes*. Adora's brain struggles to connect it for a moment, and that tells her two things: it's Scorpia, and she has a glamor to go along with the mask. That's too much for Adora to worry about right now, when a Horde officer has just gone flying past her and slumped unconscious on the floor. Mermista's *ha!* tells her who was responsible for that one. This fight needs to finish, because Scorpia is here and she might have answers about where Catra is.

Scorpia suddenly stumbles nervously out the door and it closes, seemingly unprompted, behind her. Scorpia holds her pincers in front of her and glances nervously between them and the Horde officer currently using what looks like a robot leg to block Bow's shots. Sparks dance across her chitin, but a blue blast fires from a seemingly random spot by Scorpia's side and knocks the man off his feet, giving Bow an opening to shoot a net arrow. Adora's heart leaps.

"Ghost?" she calls above the fighting, a desperate edge to her voice. She whispered it when they were up in the shop, hoping to get a whisper or brush back, but instead she was met with Bow quietly calling that he had found something and said *something* opening before she even reached him.

"Here!" Catra's voice hits her in a wave of relief, though it's short-lived when she registers how pained and breathless it sounds. Still, she's here *somewhere*.

Adora hasn't summoned the sword so far because they're fighting unarmored humans, but the knowledge Catra is nearby has it sparking to life in her hands. She turns on her heel, scanning the room and seeing glimpses of an officer moving between two machines. She raises the sword, waiting until she sees a flash of them again, and releases a blast from the runestone in the hilt. It shoots through the gap and the officer lets out a brief cry as they are knocked back against a shelf and fall motionless.

Even knocking them unconscious, it was probably a gentler hit than her punches have been. Adora can't see anyone else moving, though she can hear a grunt and a thump from the other side of a large machine near the front of the room.

"Who's still up?" she asks her comm. A straggled cry answers her and then cuts off. The next moment isn't silent – some of the machinery is humming loudly, and several people are breathing heavily – but it is in comparison to sounds of fighting.

"Nobody now," Perfuma replies, her voice very calm for having just lightly strangled someone with a root or something. She has been exuding manufactured peace as she tries to keep a grounded calm – probably for Adora's benefit – but this time it sounds more genuine. Adora immediately turns back to Scorpia, who notices her attention and hesitantly waves.

"Hi, I'm not with them, I promise. They kind of kidnapped me. I have no idea what's going on," she says, her voice unmistakably layered. It sounds discordant, like her ancestors are still trying to adjust for themselves. Several members of the Alliance make a confused exclamation, picking up on the unmistakable quality of the new voice in the room with them. Bow stares at Scorpia with his mouth open while Glimmer sparkles into existence beside him to join in. Mermista rounds the corner of a large shelf, coming to a halt when she sees Scorpia.

There's a lot of questions to ask, but Adora's first one is *is Catra okay*, so they need to get out of earshot of any half-conscious Horde members left. She raises a hand to her comm, pressing the small button that makes her channel a priority.

"We need an anonymous call to police for a Horde bust and thorough investigation of their workshop. We've got both missing persons secured," she relays to Entrapta, earning an excited gasp.

"I'm on it! Bring them back quickly," Entrapta replies. Adora moves to glance down an aisle in the shelves and finds Perfuma, who is busy staring at Scorpia with a... different energy, she would probably say, than Glimmer and Bow have. Different from Mermista, too, who seems vaguely impressed by what she's seeing rather than just surprised, but it's not the same *impressed* on Perfuma's face.

"Work with Sagittarius to secure everybody and then we'll work on leaving the scene in stages," Adora orders her. It roughly translates to *tie everyone up so we can make sure Catra and Scorpia are safe*, but she's pretty sure everybody understands that. Perfuma tears her eyes away from Scorpia to nod at Adora, but a moment later she's looking back at her. When she walks forwards, it's towards Bow, but that also brings her closer to Scorpia and she's sending her a bright smile.

“Hi, I’m Heart-Blossom. Who are you?” she asks with her generally friendly manner that has little place in a Horde workshop. Scorpia blinks down at her, opening her mouth to reply, but she’s cut off.

“Not now,” Catra’s voice grits out, to Adora’s left and *close*. Adora immediately turns towards it, gaze flitting over the empty air as if that will let her make out Catra’s shape. Perfuma dims a little, but she seems willing to accept Catra’s *later* and the implicit *we can trust her* within it, because she nods and turns to follow Adora’s orders about tying up anyone unsecured and merely unconscious.

Adora hasn’t taken her eyes off the empty air, and she’s rewarded with it warping. Catra fizzles into view. It’s not the elegant melting into reality Adora saw before and the difference is stark with Melog’s form warping into view much the same way at Catra’s feet. Catra is hunched, grimacing, and clutching what Adora assumes is a laser gun, aimed at the floor as she *twitches*.

Adora rushes forward in an instant, her hands running over Catra as carefully as she can and earning hissing when she touches *anything*. Catra’s expression is already tight, but she growls at Adora as Adora winces in response and pulls back to continue the desperate inspection visually.

“I’ll be fine. It’s not the first time I’ve been electrocuted,” Catra says, hissing with pain as she does. Adora’s hands twitch at her side, desperate to reach for her. She’s stopped by Glimmer teleporting right beside her, startling her. She raises her sword, dropping into a defensive stance before she realizes the person appearing isn’t a threat to Catra. Glimmer winces a little just *looking* at Catra.

She smells burnt. She isn’t – at least not visually, that would be very, *very* bad – but the scent clings to her. Glimmer extends a hand to Catra that she eyes warily. Adora watches it too, making sure she doesn’t try to touch Catra either.

“I’ll take you back to the sanctum,” Glimmer offers. Catra’s eyes flick to Adora’s. Adora takes a breath and nods. She doesn’t want to take her eyes off Catra, much less leave her *alone* when she’s hurt, but she wants her to get to safety even more. As soon as they’re done here, she can go back and assess her injuries. Catra doesn’t say anything, but on a silent signal Melog shakes their mane out, taking a few steps back to accommodate their growing size as they return to their preferred form.

“Bring her next,” Catra replies, jerking her head in Scorpia’s direction as she reaches down to place one hand on Melog’s head and reluctantly takes Glimmer’s hand with the other. Glimmer nods, her expression determined, and then all three of their forms turn to pink sparkles and disappear. Adora stares at the space where they were for a moment too long before she turns to Scorpia, who is looking down at her pincers again.

Adora remembers what it was like to turn into a princess and not have a clue what was going on. She doubts Catra has been able to tell her much. Glancing at the door they came through, it looks strong. That could have been some kind of cell they only just busted out of with Scorpia’s new magic.

Adora strides over to her, moving to place a hand on her shoulder before noticing the small shocks still traveling over her chitin seemingly at will. She drops her hand, instead doing her best to turn her head so it's clear she's establishing "eye contact" with Scorpia's own glowing eyes.

"Moonstone is going to take you back to our base where Ghost and Mercury are. Your technopath friend is on comms. You can listen in once you're back there. We'll explain everything once we've got this cleaned up," Adora tells her. Scorpia releases a loud sigh of relief.

"I don't really know what that means, but I guess I can guess – Heh, guessing all around- Um, anyway, thanks for storming in. I don't know how we would have gotten through all this on our own," Scorpia says, glancing around the room. Adora offers Scorpia her best reassuring smile.

"We'll figure it all out once we're somewhere private," she promises. She probably has as many questions as Scorpia does. Just a few more minutes and then she can go back to Catra.

Glimmer sparks back into existence a few feet from them. Adora steps back so there's room for Scorpia to nervously take her hand, seeming terrified of shocking the woman.

"It's instant, don't worry. Maybe steel your stomach, though," Glimmer assures, a warning that doesn't make sense to Adora given that none of them have ever had issues, but before she can ask, Scorpia nods and they both disappear. Adora takes a deep breath and turns back to the scene.

They just need a cover story and then she can probably leave dealing with the police to the rest of the Alliance.

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Catra lurches when they land in the sanctum, clutching her stomach. Melog props her up on one side while Glimmer steadies her with hands on her shoulders, which also sucks in an entirely different way than her stomach churning.

"Holy shit, you do that all the time? That fucking sucks," she gasps, looking up at Glimmer, who raises a brow at her. Melog silently agrees their method of travel is better, if more limited.

"Teleporting makes you nauseous? Really?" she asks, and she actually sounds disbelieving. Catra must look rough enough for Glimmer to believe she could be sick at her feet, because she hurries to point her towards the comm hub.

"Sit. If you pass out on my watch, She-ra's going to kill me," she orders. Catra huffs a painful laugh, but it still feels good to do after spending her last two hours on edge. She limps over to

the chair as Glimmer disappears again. The hub has the usual map pulled up, showing the Alliance – mostly – converging on the small shop in the Fright Zone. To the side, the text channels are open. After a moment, she realizes the audio waves in the bottom of the screen indicate activity on the comms.

By the time Glimmer has returned with Scorpia, Melog has curled up under the safety of the comm hub table and Catra has found the button to turn the speakers on, right beside a button with a microphone symbol on it.

“Whoa,” Scorpia breathes upon landing, but Catra isn’t paying attention to her because *Entrapta’s on comms*.

“-about fifteen minutes. I advise coming up with a cover story before then to minimize investigation into yourselves,” Entrapta is in the middle of saying. Catra so wants to be *done*, to curl up and just go to sleep, but Entrapta is right, and the work isn’t done now the fight is over. She reluctantly lifts her arm and presses the microphone button. Immediately, a new track labeled “HUB” appears on the audio feeds.

“Scorpia gave a fake name for us both, so the only way we’re compromised is if Shadow Weaver gives the police a sketch of Scorpia to try to track down the princesses’ real identities whenever Black Garnet debuts. You just need a bullshit reason for how the Alliance found the hideout without a connection to *Lauryn*,” Catra says. Her voice sounds exhausted even to her own ears.

“Black Garnet? Catra, do you know what’s going?” Scorpia asks, approaching the chair and putting a pincer on its back before seeming to remember her powers – or maybe just noticing Catra’s *state* again – and quickly flinching back. Catra slumps back in the chair, tilting her head back and closing her eyes, trying to force her muscles to relax so everything stops *hurting*.

“The gem in Shadow Weaver’s mask? It was a lost princess runestone. The Black Garnet. Runestones choose the worthy or some bullshit, so when you got close enough, you inherited it. That’s why she was spouting all that weird shit about letting it into your heart. She thought you bonding with it might repair it or something. Seems like it worked considering you’re-” she gestures at Scorpia’s everything. Scorpia looks down at her everything and then looks back up at Catra, her expression anxious. “Pretty sure her plan was for you to fix it so she could run off with it, but I stopped that,” Catra summarizes. She didn’t know if merely forcing Scorpia to make contact with the runestone would work, but it did for Adora, so she shoved the mask at Scorpia the first good opening she got.

“Also, I’m Ghost and Melog is Mercury because Adora couldn’t stop blurting out my name on the job. And Adora is She-ra. And we’re dating. Welcome to the Alliance,” Catra finishes, because at this point it seems best to get it all out there. Scorpia and Entrapta knew she was talking to Adora again, but she might have conveniently left out the dating thing. She was still feeling it out and she didn’t need Scorpia giving *advice*, not to mention she knew Catra had a thing for She-ra and there might have been questions.

Not that Scorpia ever would have put it together given the way she’s gaping at Catra now, but she would have questioned her judgement, probably, and honestly that would have been even

more annoying.

“Scorpia, breathe,” Catra instructs. Scorpia breathes *in*, but then she doesn’t let it out, seeming unable to process further. “Out and in. Try to… let it go, or something. You don’t need to be magic anymore,” Catra adds, gesturing at her outfit and then aborting the motion when it hurts to move. Scorpia looks down at herself again at Catra’s half-motion, seeming surprised to find her clothes different, as if she forgot she was a princess.

“Close your eyes and center yourself,” a voice interrupts them from the comms. “Picture a safe space, like you’re home or with family. It will help you balance. This confusion is transient. The challenges you face now will pass.” They must have a system for talking, because Flower Girl’s voice comes out clearly after being relegated to murmurs of logistics in the background until now.

Scorpia looks up at the screen, her brow suddenly setting determination.

“Right,” she agrees, receiving the words like war orders. She straightens up, taking a deep breath and closing her eyes. Catra leaves her to do her own thing, tuning her out as she focuses on not yelling from the pain. Her muscles are still twitching occasionally. She’s lucky to be conscious – or not burnt to a crisp. She knows a lot of explanations have to take place, but she’s exhausted and just wants to sleep. Adora’s hand in her hair would be nice. Cuddling is off the table with her body hurting like this, but some pets would be reassuring.

“Ghost?” She-ra’s layered voice prompts, cutting above the murmuring on the other channels again. Catra startles, hissing with pain from the slight movement. When she opens her eyes, Scorpia is back to normal, though she seems so concerned with Catra’s obvious pain – she did *cause* it after all – that she hasn’t reacted to her own change.

“Yeah,” is the best reply Catra manages, and even that comes out pained. With Adora’s channel prioritized – Catra can see it on the screen now, a small star next to both her name and “HUB” – she can hear Adora suck in a breath. Catra doesn’t have the bandwidth to reassure her right now, so she just waits for Adora’s question.

“We need to tell the police something without involving secret identities or conflicting with the Horde’s story,” Adora reminds her. The fact the Alliance has *no clue* what happened is obvious, and it’s hard for them to justify storming the base without mentioning their friends were kidnapped. Catra braces herself and turns her neck to look up at Scorpia.

“Scorpia, they grabbed you when you were just looking around outside, right? They didn’t actually catch you doing anything?” Catra asks. She picked up on it in vague terms when the Horde officers were talking to Shadow Weaver, but she didn’t see any of it happen. She had already been stuck inside for a while when she saw Scorpia being dragged into Shadow Weaver’s lab and her heart sank.

The longer she was down in Shadow Weaver’s chamber, listening for crumbs of information, the more she considered just bolting. It could give away that someone invisible was running around, but it would mean getting away from that monster. The stress was taking a toll on both her and Melog, who was starting to relive the fear they experienced at Shadow Weaver’s hands for weeks. Catra quickly regretted not taking the risk of slowing down and calling

Adora as she ran to the shop. She knew her friends had to be worrying, but she couldn't use her translucent phone screen while cloaked, so she couldn't even send a text that she was okay as she listened in.

"Yeah. I knew they were probably with the Horde, but that meant the Horde was *there* and you were in danger. I thought they might take me to you and I could sting us out of there, but then there was no sign of you and they thought I was lying about meeting up with a friend," Scorpia admits, reaching up to rub at the back of her head. It was unnecessary – as scared as Catra was of Shadow Weaver sensing her and Melog's presence, they remained undetected – but in the end the only price for a runestone being recovered was Catra getting electrocuted.

Okay, it's a pretty shitty price. She can feel every muscle in her body, and they all feel raw, like she has been run over a grater. Catra looks back to the monitor.

"They never knew I was there, so I don't have to be in the story. Tell the police you were investigating the Horde independently and found suspicious activity at the shop that indicated their robots could be coming from there. They kidnapped a woman off the street for seeing too much and you busted in to save her. You let her go before the police arrived because she didn't need an interrogation on top of her trauma. The police don't have to like your methods, right?" Catra says. It's not her best work, but it has to match up roughly with what the Horde will say when they wake up and she's fucking *tired*.

"Right. Good enough for me. Pearl, Moonstone, you're the best liars so I'm leaving the story up to you. Change parts if you have to, just make sure to let us know," Adora says, her channel dropping off in volume halfway through as the star disappears from her name.

"Aw, thanks," Mermista says immediately, causing Catra to snort and then hiss in pain from what that does to her ribs.

"I'm wounded," is Glimmer's response, her tone dry.

"I've watched you promise your mom that you're studying," Adora immediately refutes. Whatever response Glimmer gives, the muffled channels don't pick it up, but when Adora speaks again Catra can hear a smile in her voice. "Can you take me back?"

"Yeah, probably best you're *not* around when we get to the acting part. I can't believe you've kept a secret identity this long," Mermista comments. Catra snickers, but Adora doesn't seem to respond at all.

Then again, maybe pink sparkles forming in the middle of the room are her answer. Catra quickly pushes herself up from the chair to go greet Adora, but she ends up hunching over as soon as she's on her feet, growling her way through the spike of pain. Melog is at her side in an instant, strung out themselves from all the tension but still seeking to comfort her.

Adora's hands are gentle as they land on her upper arms, ready to catch her if it becomes too much to stand. When Catra looks up at her with watering eyes, she sees Adora's expression twisted by worry.

“What happened to you?” Adora asks, her voice low and strained, the layers fallen away despite She-ra’s mask standing between them. Vaguely, Catra is aware of Scorpia backing up to give them space and Melog slinking back under the safety of the table. Catra shakes her head and then hisses again. It’s so hard to be still when even being still hurts, just less.

“Nothing. I managed to get into the shop right before close and then followed an officer through the hatch. A few minutes later I got the opportunity to slip back into Shadow Weaver’s room with her and listen in. Once I was inside, I couldn’t get out without giving myself away until someone opened a door for me, and then Scorpia showed up and turned out to be a fucking princess. They never touched me, but I got a little too close to Scorpia’s lightning when she connected with the runestone,” Adora’s face twitches, so Catra offers her a watery smile. It doesn’t seem to help much given the way Adora’s hands flex on her arms, causing Catra to wince again. Adora immediately lets go, but her hands hover close.

“I’ll be fine. I’ve walked off electrocution before,” Catra add. Adora twitches a still-anxious smile at her.

“You had to be carried,” she reminds. Catra scowls.

“I didn’t *have* to be, you insisted. And that was mostly my ankle’s fault,” she retorts. That gets a real smile, however brief. It drops as Adora’s eyes roam over her again, looking for more injuries.

“I wish there was something I could do,” she breathes, and she really does sound like she would martyr herself to make Catra ache a little less. Catra manages a smirk, however twitching, cutting the mood with the wry grin.

“Are kisses still on the table from last time?” she asks, the memory of that first, similar injury fresh in her mind. Adora’s eyes soften, warm and fond regardless of the anxiety on the rest of her face as she holds Catra’s gaze.

“Always,” she promises, and then bends down, gently cradling Catra’s face before she kisses her even softer. Catra’s heart flutters almost painfully, because everything is painful right now. With her muscles still occasionally twitching, it doesn’t feel like she can keep something that feels so fragile safe.

“I was so worried,” Adora whispers to her before kissing her again, a little more firmly this time now Catra hasn’t cried out in pain. Kissing doesn’t hurt any more than talking. It actually feels better, but that might just be breathing in the warm crackle of the magic on She-ra’s breath. It’s soothing, the right kind of alive to chase away the last painful shocks and twitches.

It’s actually- Fuck, it feels like- Catra is breathing in *light* and she kind of feels like she’s floating. When she panics and opens her eyes, she sees gold everywhere, but she’s frozen beneath Adora a moment more before they’re both pulling apart and staring at each other. She-ra flickers for a moment, and then she’s gone, nothing but an afterimage of her golden outline left behind.

And Catra feels.

Okay.

“Uhh, what was that?” Scorpia asks. Catra takes a deep breath. The air is sharp, like on a cold night, but aside from that, it doesn’t hurt. Experimentally, Catra lifts her arms and loops them over Adora’s shoulders as Adora blinks at her. *It doesn’t hurt*.

“Pretty sure that was She-ra’s healing magic,” Catra says, watching Adora gape at her too, now. Adora glances down at her hands, still lightly resting over Catra’s arms, and then squeezes. Catra doesn’t react. Sure, she doesn’t feel *great*, but the pain is gone, replaced with just exhaustion and soreness. “Hey, you’re about due for a new power, right?” she teases.

It seems to click for Adora then, because she looks up and her eyes start sparkling when their gazes meet.

“I guess so,” she breathes, and then they’re kissing again.

“I’m just gonna… go over here and figure out this princess thing…” Scorpia says awkwardly in the background, backing away as Catra slumps into Adora’s arms with relief.

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Scorpia keeps giving herself small static shocks whenever she tries to touch something new around the sanctum. It’s kind of funny, honestly, and Catra’s allowed to laugh since she has felt the brunt of those shocks when they turn larger. Either the new powers need to settle in or the stone being cracked is making them unpredictable, but Catra is too tired to worry about it. If they can take a runestone out to pass it down then they can toss a problem gem if needed.

Okay, they’d probably put it in a glass case behind a laser grid, but as long as her friend is okay, Catra doesn’t really care what they do with it.

“Are you sure about this? I’m pretty sure I’m not descended from royalty,” Scorpia asks, anxiously. She’s asking Bow, because he made his way back before the police even arrived and has changed back to civilian clothes. Also, he isn’t in the middle of an intense cuddle session fueled by “I thought you could be dead” and “I just spent two hours trapped in a room with my childhood nightmare.” Their affection is only contained by the fact that they’re limited to the comm hub chair. It really wasn’t built for this. Melog has been forced to curl in a half circle near the chair’s base, but they would really like to be included.

“None of us are, but the runestone chose you as worthy of its power. Now you’re Black Garnet, you’re one of us. If you want to be, anyway. We can teach you all about being a hero and how to control your powers. Plus, Catra’s already here,” Bow says, throwing his arms out wide and then jerking his head back in Catra’s direction.

“I’m not part of your club,” Catra raises her voice to be heard, but no one seems to pay attention to her protest. The most she gets is Adora petting her ears.

“You have a name and went investigating the Horde. *On your own*,” Adora returns, her voice stern. Oops. Catra is definitely going to get a lecture for that. In her defense, she never dreamed that the shop could be the secret seat of the Horde’s leaders. She didn’t mean to be there that long.

“Yeah, well, now that the Horde’s top officers are in custody you probably won’t even need help dealing with the stragglers. You’re welcome,” Catra grumbles, sulking down in Adora’s arms.

“So there will be plenty of time for you two to train while they try to recover!” Bow responds brightly, as if Catra agreed to any of this. She groans, but that doesn’t mean she’s going to abandon Scorpia to do this gauntlet on her own. Maybe it will be good for her relationship with Adora to see what it was like to come into all this suddenly, too.

Scorpia isn’t nearly as much of a stranger and the Alliance has been through this once before – not to mention Scorpia having more support in her life than just one person – so it will be a softer version, but it will help with their growth, or something. Healing as a person isn’t on her list of priorities right now when she’s still working on *physically healing*.

“Ooo, are you training to be superheroes? That opens up so many new possibilities for gadgets I could build! Catra, how do you feel about thruster packs? They could give a little extra power to a jump or even a punch!” Entrapta babbles excitedly from the monitor. At this point Adora and Bow have taken out their earbuds since they can just listen to the speakers. The comm lines show Perfuma has put hers away too after she hastily had to head back for something related to her secret identity, but Glimmer and Mermista still have theirs in. They have finished giving their story, but haven’t left the scene yet. A moment later, however, Glimmer’s channel gets a star next to it.

“I don’t think I have to say how important it is that you keep everybody’s identities a secret. And that you patch up the vulnerability you used to hack into the channels before you get *out* of them,” Glimmer says. Catra can’t help but wonder if this is how she talked to Adora at first. Adora would have responded to it – badly. There were two options: keeling over beneath it or getting belligerent and digging her heels in. They’ve already seen which won.

Entrapta, on the other hand, is going to be another story.

“Oh, that’s not going to happen, but I’ll stop reading your message history now,” Entrapta offers, an innocence to the way she delivers it.

“You’re *what*?” Glimmer hisses, no longer speaking full volume, like someone came by. Catra snickers.

“Take what you can get. Compromise is important with Entrapta. She won’t tell anybody,” Catra says, sending Adora a glance that earns her a smile back. It’s the dazed kind that tells Catra that Adora is smiling just because *she’s* smiling.

“*You’re* compromising?” Glimmer asks. Catra doesn’t acknowledge how disbelieving she sounds.

“If it keeps a laser from blowing up? Yes. Entrapta, improve the security and you get to stay on the channels without having to build in a backdoor, okay?” Catra says, shifting her focus. Entrapta hums as she thinks that over.

“Okay! Taking extra time will let me come up with more new gadget ideas anyway,” Entrapta agrees. Bow moves closer, placing a hand on the edge of the table and leaning closer towards the general area of the microphone.

“I would love to brainstorm with you. It has been a while since I came up with a new arrow idea that worked *and* was useful,” Bow says, his voice genuinely excited. Catra sincerely hopes introducing them isn’t as much of a risk as handing over the laser gun was, but it’s too late now.

They’ve met. Entrapta is in the channels. She and Scorpia know everyone’s identity. Scorpia is a fucking princess now, and the bald spot on Catra’s tail is healed. Yes, that’s a priority. Adora noticed it immediately when Catra climbed into her lap. Maybe it’s not as important as the fact Shadow Weaver has been arrested, but the point is things have *changed*. Maybe drastically, depending how the remaining members handle the organization of the Horde going forward.

They’ll just have to see where this takes them, but at least they’ll have each other for it.

Chapter End Notes

This was so long it took forever but I had so many things I wanted to do I had to take the time

Chapter 17: Growth

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra reluctantly agreed to another nauseating teleport back home because she needs to curl up in her bed and sleep for ten hours. Melog is too stressed out from spending so long near their captor to feel confident taking all three of them back on the paths, and walking isn't any more of an option than leaving Adora behind is.

Catra is sure she hasn't heard the last of it yet for her snap decision that resulted in an evening of anxiety for all of them, but for now Adora has settled on not taking her eyes or hands off of her. She only leaves her alone long enough for Catra to shower the burnt smell out of her fur. Catra sprawls in Adora's lap afterwards, wriggling around to get comfortable before settling in to purr. Adora pets through her hair and occasionally over her healed tail where it is curled around them.

It's a moment to *breathe*. Sometimes Catra was afraid of doing even that down in the laboratory, sure someone would hear it and she would suddenly be at the mercy of Shadow Weaver's hand again. Her body is shaky from fatigue, as mental as it is physical. Occasionally she feels herself start to tense up again, so used to holding still that her brain suddenly tells her *you're slipping, they're going to find you* despite Adora's hands in her hair. The touch helps a lot, as does Melog sprawling across their feet. Mostly Adora's feet. Catra is kind of wrapped around Adora.

"We're going to have a talk about reckless behavior," Adora says, her voice quiet but stern even as she presses a kiss to Catra's ear.

"I didn't know they were there. I was just hoping to poke around and find an orders book or something," Catra replies, her voice quiet from how tired she is, but it's a token protest.

"I know, but you still went off on your own without even warning me. We're supposed to be a team now. Right?" Adora asks, a bit of a desperate edge to her voice. Catra's heart burns uncomfortably in her chest as she tips her face forward to bury it in Adora's shirt.

"We are. I was just… in a hurry. It was all an accident," she says, curling her fingers into Adora's shirt and hanging on. She knows Adora was just worried, but if she keeps scolding Catra for something she never meant to do and barely had any control over, this is going to escalate past. Adora makes a low sound that doesn't sound very assured, but she falls silent again, returning to petting Catra. She focuses on her ears this time and slowly Catra's fingers uncurl from her shirt, relaxing again as she sinks into the touch.

"At least I know I was meant to be She-ra, now," Adora eventually says, a wry turn to her voice, but it's weak, only an attempt at a joke rather than truly reaching it. Catra's ears twitch back as her brow furrows, confused. She manages a small *mrrp*? in response, too tired to properly ask what Adora is talking about.

“It has to be a destiny thing, because if it was just about someone who is worthy, it would have started reacting when you were trapped down there with it,” Adora explains, pressing a kiss to the top of her head as Catra’s heart rockets through her chest.

She wasn’t- she wasn’t *worried* about it, she doesn’t even want to be a fucking princess, but something in her chest felt dark as she watched the Alliance arrange for Scorpia to come back tomorrow for more information on the runestones and her newfound abilities. Part of it was jealousy, knowing how much it took for them to finally tell her anything, but the rest was triggered by the kind of thinking that only comes back when trapped in a room with someone who spent years convincing you that you were unlovable. She swallows, her ear flicking and brushing against Adora’s cheek, a reminder of how close she’s holding her.

“You don’t know that,” Catra whispers. They don’t. They didn’t and they never will, but it’s enough to know that Adora believes in her, even if her self-loathing still demands that she correct her.

There’s a moment of silence, and then, “Yes, I do.” It’s a whisper, but there’s an unshakable certainty in it that has Catra’s breaths turning fluttery in her chest. Slowly – suppressing a groan as she does because she forgot how sore she was – Catra lifts her head, meeting Adora’s gaze. Her gaze is soft and dark, holding Catra’s when their eyes meet.

Even with the cloak protecting her, she felt the memories coming back just being near Shadow Weaver and knowing who was beneath the mask. The ghost of her childhood fear possessed her bones once again and it’s hard to shake. Having Adora believe in her knocks the breath out of her lungs.

She purrs, loud and rattling, and butts her head forward to rub her cheek against Adora. Adora gasps and then laughs, her hand moving to the back of Catra’s head in quiet encouragement.

Catra is too strung out to say the words she really should in response to that – the ones that make her breath feel like it’s fluttering so much. She *wants* to say them, but she can’t, not when she feels this raw, so she settles for marking nearly every inch of Adora’s face as Adora giggles and whispers complaints that only sound delighted. When the affection in Catra’s chest finally feels satiated, she goes limp again, nuzzling into Adora’s neck and continuing to purr nestled in there.

Adora resettles her arms around Catra to hold her close, pressing a kiss against her ear but otherwise seeming content to cuddle.

Adora’s lips part and she draws in air, but a moment later her mouth closes without her saying anything. Catra can’t ask what she was going to say. She feels too fragile for it when part of her knows what it was and is too worn down to reciprocate in this moment.

She showed Adora. Adora enjoyed it, her laughter and smiling was enough to prove that. It has been too long of a day to worry about this. Right now, she just wants to fall asleep with her girlfriend, and it seems like Adora has decided the same thing.

This is enough. They’re safe now. Her fear can finally take a backseat.

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Catra does *not* remember signing up for superhero bootcamp, at most she just didn't say no very loudly, but here she is in the sanctum at ten in the morning. She doesn't even want to be awake at this hour on a non-workday, much less have hauled her ass across the bay with Melog in tow. She can't find a new apartment fast enough. She might have one lined up, but move-in wouldn't be for another two or three weeks probably and it's a long trip to be making for *morning training*.

Entrapta hacking her way into the police's investigation reports might have earned her a scolding, but finding out Shadow Weaver is claiming to be a victim of the Horde herself who was blackmailed and forced into working for them – something absolutely no one believes – seems to have lit a fire under the Alliance's asses. Knowing she claims not to remember much from the day of the ambush gives them confidence in their ability to add Black Garnet to their lineup without too much worry. They want to train Scorpia – and Catra and Melog too, apparently – over the next few weeks, maybe months, in case the Horde makes a comeback.

The training is needed given Scorpia's lack of control over her powers and Catra's lack of *any* powers – it isn't easy to adjust to being invisible, not the mention *aiming a laser gun* while invisible – but she never signed up for sit-ups.

"Come on, that's all you can do?" Adora teases when Catra leans back for a sit-up and doesn't come back up, sprawling back with her arms above her head. Adora is still going beside her, showing off as she flexes her abs. Scorpia's even worse, on the far side of Adora and doing sit-ups with a weight on her chest because regular ones are too easy for her. Somehow everyone in Catra's life is an annoying jock. Entrapta is her only solace, but she isn't an official part of the Alliance like Catra apparently is now and she certainly has no interest in "fieldwork." At least for herself. Catra gives it until the end of the summer before she's building a robot that she can pilot around.

"Not all of us have a goddess to increase our stamina," Catra shoots back, panting. She's in shape, she just doesn't work out and it's exhausting to dedicate time to *flexing muscles* and bullshit.

"She-ra's not here right now," Adora points out, still smug as she continues to match Scorpia. No one said it was a competition, but it's Adora, so of course it is.

If Catra had any chance of *winning*, she might be the same way, but instead she flips Adora off. Adora laughs when she sits up again and sees it.

"She-ra's always there," Catra returns, still winded. Adora's argument is horseshit since she has *told* Catra she can call on She-ra's strength without always having to transform. Sometimes Catra tastes the sparks of magic when they kiss, though at least that's usually

when Adora is about to transform or has just come down from it. Sometimes she just seems excited and it's there, though.

"Is that why I keep shocking myself?" Scorpia mutters to herself, causing Adora to snort, which fucks up her next sit-up. She sprawls back beside Catra. Before Catra can toss a jab at Adora for giving up herself, Adora totally derails her train of thought by finding Catra's hand and twining their fingers together. The angle is awkward with their arms above their heads and their fingers twisted up together, but Catra's tail sways beneath her nonetheless and her desire to mock Adora goes down a considerable degree.

"She brought us together, you know," Adora whispers, *way* too personal of a thing for her to say in front of Scorpia. Catra sits up quickly, getting a headrush as she pulls her hand away to cross her arms over her chest and resume doing sit-ups again.

"Only because someone was too caught up to just tell me the truth on her own," Catra points out. She doesn't want to have this conversation – again, now, take your pick – but She-ra didn't bring them together, Adora breaking down and being *honest* did. Adora never needed She-ra to get Catra back or tell her the truth. That was always down to Adora making her feel wanted again.

For a long moment Adora is silent, but then she shifts, sitting up and getting in position to resume the sit-ups again.

"Yeah. It's still the only Horde attack I've ever been grateful for, though," Adora acknowledges. Catra huffs something like a laugh on her next sit-up.

Now the bald spot on her tail is healed, she can say, "Me too," in a rush of breath as she does her next sit-up. It seems to be enough for Adora, because she doesn't pry further into the topic in front of their audience.

Said audience decides to put in, "I'm proud of you, Wildcat. Dating Adora is helping you open up!" Catra groans her way through her next sit-up. She would actually prefer Scorpia be less supportive of her relationship if she's going to start talking about her *emotional growth* or some shit.

"I don't know what you're talking about," she growls back. Before Scorpia can double down and make it mushier – see: objectively worse – Adora stands and says they should do laps. It derails any continued insistence Scorpia was thinking of doing, even if it isn't any better than sit-ups. At least this is an exercise Melog can suffer along with her in. They've spent too much of the morning lounging around and watching Catra do drills.

--

Catra is moving into her new place in a week and it can't come soon enough. She'll still have another two weeks of rent left on her old apartment, so she'll have plenty of time to move,

but she's ditching this location as soon as she can. She's still working at the tea shop for now, but she's spending half her time in Bright Moon and interviewing there too. It would just be more convenient to only leave it for work rather than leaving the Fright Zone for everything *else*.

Catra is trying to vaguely organize and pack things around her apartment in preparation when she's shocked by a light flashing outside her window. Turning towards it, she sees She-ra's familiar flare hanging in the air.

It has been weeks since she saw it and it stirs something in her chest. After a moment, she puts down the books she was stacking and walks to the window. From the roof next door, She-ra flashes her a smile and then leaps up, clearly moving to meet her on the apartment roof. Catra has no idea what Adora is doing, but her tail waves with interest as she turns towards her front door. She closes it behind her before Melog can think of following. Just in case.

When she gets on the roof, Adora throws her an almost shy smile. It looks out of place on She-ra, who Catra is used to always acting confident, if not outright cocky.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks, amused, as she glances around to make sure this isn't some weird superhero test and the Alliance isn't lurking in the area.

"Visiting. It's been a while," Adora replies. Catra raises a brow at her, walking over to the old retaining wall she used to sit on and leaning her hip against it.

"A while? Are we roleplaying?" she teases. Adora's cheeks heat as she rolls her eyes.

"No, I was just thinking about how you were moving soon, and even though I prefer what we have *now*, I still kind of missed this. It's our last chance to do this again, you know?" Adora explains, peering at Catra hopefully. Catra gets it, but only kind of. She prefers getting to make out with Adora in her bed, but those old meetups did have an excitement to them, a clandestine air mixed with the thrill of something new that had the potential to turn into everything she wanted. As good as their relationship is now, *knowing* it's good looses some of the excitement of what could be.

At least that's true for *her*. A small tingle of that excitement came back when she looked out her window and saw Adora. Adora knew the whole time, though. Even worse, she knew that the interactions would eventually end and it could only be *badly*. Catra isn't sure exactly what she's missing, but maybe Adora was better at forgetting the reality of the situation than she gives her credit for.

It doesn't really matter. They have a new world of infinite possibilities ahead of them they can talk about to tap into an ounce of that feeling without the need for roleplay.

"Alright, She-ra, you've got me alone," Catra replies, shrugging and throwing She-ra a leer just like she used to flirt with her when she was feeling bold. Adora rolls her eyes, but she smiles as she walks closer. When she leans against the wall, however, she does it perpendicular so she's facing Catra directly. Catra feels her cheeks heat, her tail swaying behind her. The desire She-ra can bring out in her still hasn't changed.

“You’re impossible,” Adora says. It has been a refrain Catra’s entire life, but She-ra said it more than ever. Maybe Adora didn’t know what else she could say in those moments that didn’t risk giving their history away. Catra grins, tilting her head back to make sure Adora sees the hint of fang in it.

“But you like to try, don’t you?” she returns. Turn her surprise, Adora gets a bit of a far away look in her eyes, like she’s remembering something.

“Yeah, I do,” she agrees, a little too genuinely. The tip of Catra’s tail flicks back and forth. Things really have changed. She-ra would have teased her for being a brat. She-ra wouldn’t have reached out and brushed her hand against her cheek, her gaze soft, so maybe they’ve changed for the better.

Probably. Being a brat isn’t nearly as fun when Adora doesn’t play along. Instead she’s being *sappy* and making Catra feel things. Gross.

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They lose track of time on the roof, talking about their plans for the summer, but every tease and obfuscated plan for a date just makes Adora more aware of the knot in her chest that spurred the impulse trip.

Catra really likes to flirt with She-ra, and sure, they’re making plans for this summer, but when Adora tries to subtly broach the topic of the apartment, Catra definitely doesn’t confirm how much time Adora can spend there. Maybe a bit of space is still needed for their relationship, but it has been weeks and Adora, at least, feels ready to be together more. They have logistical pressures too, with Adora’s only plan for the summer being crashing at Glimmer’s *again*, but Catra doesn’t seem to want to talk about it.

There’s so much Catra doesn’t want to talk about. Somehow, Adora thought it would be easier like this, or more accurately that it wouldn’t *matter* up on the roof, but now she is forced to acknowledge that there are things that bother her – things she has been trying to be understanding of, and that she should be still – but even though she knows a few weeks really isn’t a lot of time to get over a year of pain, she has a lot of *feelings* and they’re difficult to contain.

Catra figures out something is bothering her shortly before She-ra starts flickering, turning Catra’s gaze from wary to panicked.

“Adora, what’s wrong?” Catra asks, reaching a hand out uncertainly and hovering it in the air near Adora but not actually touching her. Adora breathes out, reluctantly letting She-ra go. She hoped that not trying to hold onto her would make it easier to stay steady, but she feels even more insecure as just herself, sitting on the roof with her back to the wall. She’s aware of all her flaws that She-ra doesn’t have, and that’s not counting the ones she *does* have.

Catra is still concerned where she is sat beside her, though she cautiously lays a hand on Adora's shoulder now in silent support. Adora doesn't want to burden Catra or ask too much of her before she's ready, especially when this anxiety is *pointless*, but she has been struggling with it for weeks and now it has bubbled up too far for her to swallow it back down.

It turns out she is a deeply insecure person. She didn't used to think of herself that way, but when her fear of failure burned down her entire life, she realized she has one or two problems with feeling any sense of worth or belonging. She used to *know* she belonged with Catra, but even though things feel good between them again, that foundational knowledge is gone.

She runs her hands through her hair as she tries to sort her thoughts out, separating the insecurity from what she actually needs to know so she can just *ask* before she holds it in too long and worries Catra more than the truth would just make her uncomfortable.

"We're planning for the summer, and it just makes me think about how I've said I love you a lot, but you've never said anything about where you stand. I *know* how you feel so it's dumb to worry about it, but also-" she takes a breath, rushing out as fast as she can, "-*I don't so can you please give me something to know for sure*," she says, having to gasp to catch her breath afterwards. For a moment, she breathes, her hands in her hair – this is the first time in a long time she has transformed back without the ponytail – as she waits for Catra to say something.

She doesn't. When Adora glances up, she finds Catra staring at her with her lips parted, seeming – rightfully – thrown off by Adora's outburst.

"I know you didn't believe me half the times I said it. I know I should give you more time. You don't have to say it back and I'm not expecting you to, but Catra, you've never even said you wanted to date me. The most you ever did was agreeing to my messy attempt to ask you out a year ago and then we were kissing when I… when *I* wasn't, and we haven't really stopped since," Adora elaborates, her words coming slow.

It's such a stupid thing to be worrying about when she *knows* Catra wants a future with her, but Catra insisting she stay as She-ra on their first night together is finally catching up to them. Adora knows Catra wants this with her, but she hasn't said it. She tried to assure herself it meant nothing that Catra wouldn't even admit they were dating until the Horde bust and that she hasn't said it again *since*, even denying it when Scorpia brought it up, but in truth she has been worrying about it since the moment they began this.

"And then you ran off on your own without even talking to me and… I'm just scared to lose you again," Adora finishes, more to that tangent and more she could say if her voice wasn't so small now.

For a moment longer, the silence hangs, and then Catra shifts. Adora blinks up at her as Catra moves to straddle her legs, settling into her lap facing her. She visibly struggles to speak even as she pulls Adora's hands from her hair and replaces them with her own, threading her fingers through it and petting her. Adora smiles as she leans into the touch, the air a bit easier to breathe even without Catra saying anything. The fact she's touching her so softly after Adora aired her fears is confirmation that Catra *does* want this, no matter her reluctance to saying it. She would have pulled away otherwise.

Adora reaches up, taking Catra's wrist gently in her hand so she can bring it down to her mouth and kiss it. When she glances up, Catra's eyes are blown out. It's a good look with her ears pinned back and tail lashing. Adora tilts her head back, leaning into Catra's hand that is still in her hair and trying to ground herself with the touch.

"I love you. There, now all you have to say is something like 'you too' or 'I could see feeling like that with you.' Hell, I'll take you just calling me your girlfriend. I'm not asking you to declare that you've been in love with me since high school, I just want to know that you want this with me and we're not just… experimenting because you liked She-ra, or something," Adora says, managing a joking tone. Catra is watching her with a darkened gaze, her usually-vibrant eyes dull with her back to the city lights and her head tilted down to watch Adora's expression. Finally, Catra speaks.

"Longer." Adora's brows draw together.

"What?" she asks. Catra shakes her head, leaning in and dropping her hand from Adora's hair to rest on her cheek.

"Longer than since high school. Maybe middle school. Or forever, since we were stupid kids," Catra says, knocking the breath out of Adora's chest. Adora gapes up at her, suddenly finding it difficult to breathe in a totally new way. Catra rolls her eyes, but there's a nervousness to her that the gesture can't hide. "Adora, I fell for She-ra because she's *you*. I've been calling us girlfriends for weeks, I guess I just didn't realize it was only in my head," she continues.

Adora whines. She doesn't mean to and she almost doesn't realize it was her until Catra's eyebrows shoot up and her pupils narrow in on the sound, her tail twitching with a familiar interest.

"Catra…" Adora breathes, not even caring how stupid her worry seems now because she's far too happy for it to matter. *Later* she can call herself an idiot, but it won't have the same kick it had before.

"We've been planning the place we want in the city together. I thought it was kind of obvious we were locked in. Do you think I would have been upset about everything that happened before if I hadn't wanted to spend the rest of my life with you?" Catra continues, seeming comfortable joking now. Adora feels her cheeks flush. Yeah, she feels stupid now.

"It could have been as friends. You never even said you *like* me, okay? I just… needed to hear it," Adora admits, her words a little sheepish now, but the relief is still much stronger than any embarrassment could be. Catra rolls her eyes, but her smile makes it feel fond. She reaches out with her free hand, poking a claw against Adora's forehead like she started doing when they were kids to annoy her. It stopped being annoying a long time ago despite the edge of pain inherent in brushes with her claws.

"Then you should have *asked*, dummy. How many times do I have to say that talking to me would fix things? Even when I was mad at you, I would have told you that you broke my heart, and that would have been your answer about what I wanted," Catra says. Adora suspected that, but the feelings still could have been *gone*. Even with the way Catra talked

about her with She-ra when she didn't know the truth, Catra could have gotten too jaded from those feelings to be sure of having them again.

"I wasn't ready to say it at first, and you know I'm still not the kind to blurt it out all the time, but I mean it now. We have a long way to go-" Catra pauses to find Adora's hand and lace their fingers together, "-but I want to get there. Together." Adora's breath catches. She lifts her hands, framing Catra's face with them and drawing her in. She just needs to be closer. Catra smiles as Adora pulls her in, nuzzling Adora's cheek.

"Do you think I would have joined your dumb superhero team if I didn't?" Catra asks, her tone joking. Adora laughs. Okay, that really should have been the dead giveaway. In answer, Adora kisses her. Catra purrs softly into it and Adora drinks it in gladly.

"I love you," she whispers when they part. They're too close for her eyes to focus when she opens them, but she can see the smile on Catra's face.

"You, too," Catra replies, her smile turning lopsided. Adora processes that for a second before she laughs, leaning in and kissing Catra again. That's what she expected. Despite the joke, it's genuine. That much is clear in Catra's thorough kiss and the way she arches closer against Adora as they embrace. When they part this time, the kiss got heavy enough that they're both panting.

"So I know the roof isn't the *best* place, but I've still got a week before I have a proper bedroom, so…" Catra says, trailing off and offering Adora a grin that is all fangs. Adora laughs, but she kisses Catra again and lets her make it exactly as filthy as she wants. Maybe just a *quick* one.

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The Horde is going through a power struggle that has them dropping like flies. The mechanic guy who came up with the gears, Hordak, seems to have been their ultimate leader, and with him arrested along with Shadow Weaver as the most publicly known leader, Force Captains are vying to take control of each other's squads and just taking each other out in the process. Things were quiet for maybe two weeks as they scrambled internally, but internal communication seems to be *shit* now that shop is gone, so the new method is trying to be the one to take over the city every few days as they fight to establish themselves as bad enough to fill Hordak's old role.

Catra watches with amusement from her invisible perch atop a light post as She-ra lassos the Force Captain of the day and then pulls them off their feet, swinging them into their own squad and knocking them all to the ground. She would be annoyed by the interruption to their date night, but it has been so brief that the rest of the group hasn't even gotten the chance to assemble. It's already all but over. It's going to take longer to wait for the police to arrive.

Not all of the squad was standing conveniently close together. Two stragglers are left, one trying to hit She-ra with a stun baton – yeah, good luck with that, even turned up to eleven that isn't going to stop her – and the other turning to run away. Catra takes aim, lining up the laser gun as best she can and firing. She's still learning – both aiming and timing her shots – but she tags him in the thigh and he cries out as he goes tumbling forward headfirst.

She might be learning, but she's gotten good enough that she's glad she was carrying the gun around in her bag, just in case. Melog gets great amusement from watching the person tumble over and then struggle to stand with his body still jerking. For all their intellect and powers, they're still a cat. To be fair, Catra would find it funnier if she hadn't experienced it herself a few times, but this is what he gets for trying to ruin her night in.

At the rate the Horde is going, they're going to all be arrested by the end of the summer. Only the smart ones that knew to bide their time will be left. It won't be the end of supervillains in the city – some will escape justice, and some will try to take their squads solo and start a new organization – but without the Horde and their weaponry to back them, it's going to be a lot harder to gain ground. They might be busy right now, but Catra predicts their lives will get a lot easier soon enough.

Good. It means fewer date nights will get interrupted.

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Catra's new place isn't perfect. It doesn't have a view of the bay, though it is close enough that walking there is feasible. It would be better for Melog if the living room was a little bigger, but there's still enough room for them to walk around in their full form and BMU isn't far for them, so they can run around the sanctum when they need to. The bathroom is just as small as the last one, but the proximity to the university combined with a real bedroom make it worth the move and coinciding uptick in rent.

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow all help her move, because as much as Catra hates going through Glimmer's teleporting, it is useful for moving furniture across the bay. It's certainly less work than Scorpia borrowing her mom's car – a mini SUV that can barely fit some of Catra's pieces of furniture, not to mention multiple ones at once – and driving back and forth a dozen times. She coordinates the moving of all the major furniture from her place before she steels herself for Glimmer to finally teleport her over at the end.

There's more to move, but it's stuff she can bring on the train after her shifts throughout the week and she doesn't like to ask people for help or accept help for too long when it's offered. She's working on it, but she still has that part of her mind that says not to show weakness or risk making people get tired of her. That's not what happened with Adora, but she still has to actively remind herself of that sometimes, so she isn't ready to start relying on Glitter and Crop Top so soon.

After thanking the couple – a little grumpily thanks to her face still being a little pale from the teleport, though it seems to amuse Glimmer regardless – and seeing them out, she surveys the place she has been watching shit disappear into all day. Melog has already made themselves comfortable on the couch, shrunk down to stay out of the way and dozing away. Her furniture isn't really in place, but it's all in the right rooms and she has a decent amount of her books and shit to make it livable until she brings the rest over.

"She-ra could probably get this all moved quickly," Adora points out as she wraps an arm around Catra's waist from behind and presses a kiss to the side of her head.

"You just want an excuse to flex," Catra accuses. Adora has a point, but when has Catra ever admitted that in her life? She prefers to tease her at any opportunity.

"Pretty sure you'd like an excuse to watch me do it," Adora returns, too smug for such a shit comeback, but again, *she's right*. Catra glances at her living room windows. There's two this time, both a bit smaller than her last one, but it's more light combined and given that they're on the fifth floor, she isn't expecting either of them to climb through them any time soon. She doesn't have curtains yet, but they're high up enough that she isn't really worried about anyone seeing She-ra through them.

"You're so annoying. Fine, I'll stroke your ego if it shuts you up," Catra says. Adora steps back and when Catra glances over her shoulder, she finds her smirking.

"Wow, that didn't take much convincing," she says. Before Catra can retort how annoying Adora is when she gets cocky like this, she transforms and suddenly Catra's talking to She-ra. Her face definitely has its healthy flush back as she turns back to look at her living room.

"I just want the bed in place." Before Adora can leer, Catra adds, "Moving is so *tiring*. I need a nap." Adora actually pouts at not getting her chance to make a joke. She seems to realize she has the opportunity to be of service, though, and brightens, tapping into that annoying *confident and ready to help* energy that drew Catra to She-ra in the first place, just an edge of cockiness to it still that tells Catra Adora will take the first opportunity she can to tease or flirt with her.

Catra toys with the idea of them breaking in the new bedroom, but she has boxes and bags everywhere and she can't deal with this organized mess. She needs true order or utter chaos and the barren feeling that surrounds the packed-up apartment doesn't exactly put her in the mood. This middle ground is unacceptable, so after She-ra hauls some of her furniture around and nearly puts a hole in her ceiling trying to show off by lifting Catra's desk over her shoulder, they settle in to unpack things. Sitting on the floor going through her things with Adora is almost disgustingly domestic.

Melog swats at flap of the cardboard box they have been unpacking, unimpressed with her internal denial. They have been here "supervising" – yeah, right – all afternoon. They don't have much to contribute to the move efforts, but Catra's chest squeezes as she watches Adora laugh and dance her fingers on her knee, trying to get Melog's attention. Melog is a sucker, so they fall for it, darting forward to bat at Adora's hand. It's adorable to watch Adora smiling down at them, sat on the floor surrounded by boxes of Catra's thing with one of her books in her free hand as she pets Melog.

This is kind of the only place Catra wants to be for the rest of her life, being gross and domestic with Adora in her apartment with her dumb cat who falls for tricks Catra outgrew at *least* eight years ago. Adora had her dream about a bay view and Catra turning the living room into a whirlwind, but Catra has *this*.

And it's real.

Wild.

"I love you," she blurts out. The smile on Adora's face freezes as her mouth becomes an *o*, eyes tearing from Melog to stare at Catra. Catra's tail waves behind her, amused with an edge of uncertainty. Melog crosses the few steps it takes to reach her and places a paw on her knee, a silent gesture of pride – with the unmistakable air of *finally, you dumbass* – before they turn and weave between the boxes they shrunk down to navigate, hopping up on the couch before Adora has managed to unfreeze.

"I love you, too," Adora suddenly blurts out, resuming moving and breathing and shit as she straightens up. Pretty much the only movement she made was blinking and slowly swaying forward as if she would eventually tip over. She blinks at Catra like she's trying to clear a mirage from her vision and then she finally turns *normal* again as a giant smile breaks on her face.

"You love me," she repeats dopily. Catra's tail is lashing now, but she rolls her eyes and pretends she can't feel her ears twitching back with embarrassment. She already *said* that a full week ago, she just didn't say all three of the words at once.

If she had known Adora would smile like this, she might have. Definitely would have. She's fucking beautiful beaming on Catra's living room floor.

"I'd hope so considering we're about to basically move in together," Catra says, rolling her eyes as she returns to sorting books. Adora is still beaming at her.

"We are?" she asks, a little breathless. Catra looks up and arches a brow at her.

"Do I have to spell everything out for you?" she asks, managing something approaching haughty despite how she explicitly avoided confirming something like this before when she was still unsure she could handle it.

"Yes," Adora immediately confirms, nodding emphatically. Her ponytail hits the back of her head. It's dorky and cute. Someone giggles, but it certainly isn't Catra. She shakes her head with a smile on her face as she moves a book into the *law school annoyance* pile.

"I'll still need space sometimes, but you can have the spare key," Catra says, shrugging like that cuts the seriousness of what she is suggesting. She's worried this is going to be too much for them, but she wants Adora here. Besides, it's *sad* to think of her sitting around the dean's house all summer. Melog could use someone else to bother anyway. Adora can be a giant cat toy in her down time.

“Okay. I don’t want to rush in too fast if it’s going to ruin things,” Adora agrees. Catra nods vaguely, ready to be done being emotionally vulnerable, but Adora reaches out and covers her hand with her own before Catra can grab another book. Reluctantly, she looks up, tail flicking back and forth. Adora is still smiling, though it has been toned back to match the tone of the conversation.

“I want to be here,” Adora assures, her voice soft and serious. Catra absorbs those words, lets them run down her spine and ignite a purr in her chest, running all the way down to her tail as it lashes back and forth.

Fuck books, she decides. She shoves the cardboard box between them aside, reaching for Adora and drawing her into a kiss before the smile of realization on her face can finish breaking. Stretching forward over the distance as they sit is a bit of an awkward angle, but they’ve done this enough that the kiss isn’t messy. It isn’t slow either, drinking each other down until Adora is sighing into her mouth. Usually Catra gets to that stage first. It feels like a victory.

Just before Catra can decide that actually, her bedroom *does* need breaking in, both their phones buzz at once. They pull back, blinking at each other as they get pulled back to reality.

Their phones buzz again.

Catra groans as she drops back to the floor and fishes her phone out of the mess on the floor around her. After the *incident* with the Horde workshop, Bow prioritized making it possible to mute high priority notifications – if she had them on then, she would have been given away and *fucked* – and finally she turned notifications on with that stipulation.

There was also the whole *apparently she’s part of the Alliance now* thing to factor in, but Catra still denies that when somebody mentions it despite how she’s standing right there in the meetings with them. She pulls her phone out of the mess and confirms what she already knew given the dual notifications: a news alert that a Force Captain group has popped up downtown. She looks up to find Adora sending her a sheepish smile.

“Welcome to Bright Moon,” she says. Catra rolls her eyes as she stands, Adora springing up a moment after to join her.

“Melog’s taking us,” Catra tells her, pointing a threatening finger at Adora. Adora rolls her eyes.

“I can’t believe you find that less nauseating than Glimmer’s powers,” she says, but it’s not a no. Melog sneezes, offended, as they jump off the couch and shake themselves out. They used the paths to take them to the last incident during their date night. Adora didn’t really have issues, but she certainly felt it.

“It’s like a roller coaster. Glimmer is just a ship in a whirlpool,” Catra argues as she digs around for her laser gun.

“It’s *instant*. It’s nothing,” Adora argues, though she still sounds amused. Apparently Catra is the only one who can actually feel the sensation of Glimmer’s teleport. She’s surrounded by a

bunch of idiot humans and Scorpia isn't any better even if she wasn't still learning how to control the strength of her lightning. She isn't going to scenes with them yet, but she has been teleported and barely noticed it.

By the time Catra has found her gun and her keys, Adora is waiting for her at the door with her comms in and the official priority alert has gone out in the channels. Catra texts that she and Adora will get there on their own before shoving her phone in her pocket and taking Adora's hand in her own. Adora beams as she takes it.

Sure, the interruptions can still get annoying, but Adora doesn't rush off on her own and leave Catra behind, hollow and wondering. They're in this together. They're *heroes* together. Whatever supervillain rises next, they'll face it as one.

And the rest of the Alliance will be there too, she guesses. They're alright.

Chapter End Notes

Fic notes will be up on my tumblr tomorrow! I'll edit them into this note when I've got them up or you can just join me over there. Thanks for reading!
Update: Fic notes are up.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!